Early Christianity

DIEGO KURILO

Early Christianity

History, Texts and Material Culture of Christian Origins

Sophia Lux Academic Editions

2026

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© 2026 this edition: Sophia Lux Academic Editions
Franklin 2054, 1st Floor, Apt. B, Autonomous City of Buenos Aires

First bilingual edition: 2026
Digital book, PDF · Digital file: download and online
ISBN 978-631-01-8779-2

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Typeset in EB Garamond.

Cataloguing-in-Publication data (as registered, in Spanish)

Kurilo, Diego
Cristianismo primitivo : historia, textos y cultura material de los orígenes cristianos / Diego Kurilo. - 1.ª edición bilingüe - Ciudad Autónoma de Buenos Aires : Diego Kurilo, 2026.
Libro digital, PDF
Archivo Digital: descarga y online
ISBN 978-631-01-8779-2
1. Cristianismo. I. Título.
CDD 200

ISBN 978-631-01-8779-2
9 786310 187792

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Prologue

This work begins from a simple but demanding premise: Christianity from the first to the fourth century cannot be reconstructed as a finished institution onto whose origins the doctrinal, legal and episcopal forms of Late Antiquity are projected back. It must instead be studied as a historical constellation of communities, texts, practices, objects, memories and conflicts whose configuration varied with period, language, city and networks of circulation.

The volume brings together literary, papyrological, epigraphic, numismatic, archaeological, iconographic and legal evidence under a single principle of critical scrutiny: no documentary series serves merely to embellish another. A codex has a material history distinct from the tradition it transmits; an inscription cannot be reduced to the doctrine a later reader recognises in it; an imperial law must be dated, situated and read within its legal genre before it can be used to describe a religious practice. This relative autonomy of the sources makes comparison possible without erasing their differences.

The research therefore adopts a deliberately cumulative structure. The main chapters reconstruct historical processes; documentary windows isolate evidence that requires closer examination; tables set out chronologies, attributions and degrees of certainty; and appendices provide prosopographies, networks, bilingual loci and reference materials. The apparatus does not seek to create an impression of absolute certainty. Its purpose is to distinguish firmly attested evidence from probable conclusions, reconstruction from direct observation, and matters still debated from established findings.

The reader will encounter divergent positions wherever the evidence does not permit the debate to be closed: manuscript chronologies, relationships between gospel traditions, the scope of categories such as "Gnosticism", the reconstruction of groups known chiefly through their opponents, the formation of ministries, the transformation of meeting spaces, and the interpretation of images and objects. In such cases, the work gives priority to making the problem explicit rather than offering false simplicity.

Early Christianity is thus offered both as a monograph in critical history and as a reference work. Its unity rests not on an all-encompassing thesis but on a delimited historical one—that later Christian unity was historically produced rather than given at the origins—and on a shared discipline applied to heterogeneous corpora: critically established chronology, a hierarchy of sources, analysis of transmission, attention to material culture, and a consistent distinction between evidence, inference and reception.

How to read this book

The book offers two complementary routes. It can be read continuously, following the transformation of Christian movements from the first to the fourth century, or consulted by topic, beginning with a particular problem, corpus, historical figure or body of material evidence. The contents, lists of figures and tables, Index locorum and specialised indexes support this second approach.

The codes for access to evidence indicate how sources have been consulted; they do not automatically establish their truth. [AUT] denotes direct physical examination; [IMG-HR], consultation of high-resolution digital images; [FAC], a facsimile or reproduction; [ED], a critical edition, catalogue or specialist description; and [LAB], published material analysis. [REC-GRAF] identifies a modern reconstruction or visualisation by third parties, and [REC-GRAF/IA] an original graphic reconstruction prepared for this edition. The historical value of a claim depends on the quality of its evidence and reasoning, rather than on a code taken in isolation.

Diplomatic transcriptions retain, where methodologically appropriate, the spellings and symbols of the source or the cited institutional edition. These should not be confused with a general typographic standardisation of the volume. Thus, the crescent-shaped sigma of certain papyri is retained when it forms part of the chosen mode of documentary representation, while Greek cited for philological purposes may be presented according to modern editorial conventions.

In historical social networks, metrics are read as properties of an explicit model, not as political or ecclesiastical hierarchies. High centrality may depend on the selection of the corpus; a regional aggregation, such as that used for certain African recipients of the Cyprianic dossier, is not directly comparable to an individual or a see. The book points out these asymmetries to prevent the visualisation from producing more precision than the data allow.

Images should be read together with their complete captions. For a reconstruction, a modern colour treatment or a reproduction of an ancient object, the status of the object is distinguished from that of the image. Licensing and provenance information belong to the editorial apparatus. For the print edition, reproductions lacking

documented commercial clearance have been removed or replaced, where analytically necessary, by original reconstructions explicitly labelled [REC-GRAF/IA].

Finally, dates and categories are used historically. A provision of 321 is not identified with a later norm of 386; a heresiological term does not in itself demonstrate the existence of a unitary organisation; a religious similarity does not prove dependence; and the late reception of a memory is not automatically projected onto the first century. This discipline of reading runs throughout the volume.

Editorial Note to the Present Edition

This monograph, Early Christianity: History, Texts, and Material Culture of Christian Origins, examines the emergence and transformation of Christian movements between the first and fourth centuries CE. Later literary testimonies, ecclesiastical catalogues, and retrospective traditions are used only where they illuminate the diachronic history of transmission, material reception, or the retrospective construction of institutional memory, and such use is explicitly signalled. The study integrates comparison of the canonical gospels, Christian apocalyptic literature in Jewish, Roman, and Iranian settings, asceticism and the formation of monasticism, protective and exorcistic practices, childhood and household organisation, and the imperial cult, together with the other historical, philological, social, and archaeological dossiers developed throughout the volume.

The volume is organised according to three principles of historical-critical discipline:

1. Exclusion of speculation unsupported by evidence. Numerological or gematric correspondences without documentary verification, esoteric genealogies and speculative Neoplatonic interpretations are excluded from the evidentiary apparatus. The ancient calculation in Rev 13:18 is a specific philological and historical problem involving manuscript variants; it does not serve as a universal hermeneutical key. Where Neoplatonism is relevant as a historical phenomenon of Late Antiquity, it is treated as a context that can be documented. Historical analysis rests on positive evidence, critically disciplined comparison and explicit chains of cultural transmission.

2. Hierarchy and traceability of primary sources. Ancient texts are cited by book, chapter, section, verse or document number; crucial loci are checked against standard modern critical editions. Before publication, secondary reproductions drawn from historical translations, digital databases or older series must be replaced or checked against Sources Chrétiennes (SC), Corpus Christianorum Series Latina (CCSL), Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum (CSEL), Die griechischen christlichen Schriftsteller (GCS), the Loeb Classical Library where appropriate, or individual critical editions such as Niese's edition of Flavius Josephus. An edition's

inclusion in the bibliography does not in itself demonstrate a comprehensive examination of its critical apparatus; the extent of consultation must be stated precisely.

3. The independent evidentiary status of material culture. Archaeological objects, inscriptions, papyri, codices, architectural spaces, and coin types are not decorative illustrations of conclusions already derived from literary sources. They constitute bodies of evidence with their own problems of dating, provenance, restoration, and interpretation. To specify how this evidence has been accessed, the edition uses [AUT] for direct physical examination, [IMG-HR] for high-resolution or multispectral digital images, [FAC] for conventional digital facsimiles, [ED] for critical editions, catalogues, or specialist descriptions, [LAB] for published archaeometric or physicochemical results, [REC-GRAF] for modern reconstructions or visualisations by third parties, and [REC-GRAF/IA] for original graphic reconstructions prepared for this edition. These codes record modes of access to evidence; they are not rhetorical scales of certainty.

Typography, pagination and indexing

The canonical pagination corresponds to the final printed PDF from Sophia Lux Ediciones Académicas. Internal references are organised by chapter, section, paragraph, and page of this work. The table of contents, analytical indexes, Index locorum, and page-dependent cross-references must match this same paginated matrix.

Chapter headings, major sections and appendices retain a stable hierarchy to facilitate cross-reference. The final PDF provides the reference pagination; the editable file is the medium of composition, not an alternative pagination.

In the composition, long tables continue over successive pages with their column headings repeated and no row divided, and headings and subheadings remain attached to the first paragraph or table they introduce.

Images, maps and reproduction rights

The images, drawings, plans, and reproductions included in this volume retain explanatory captions, provenance, identification of the repository or original publication, and copyright status. Any commercial reproduction requires authorisation, a licence, public domain status, or a duly documented applicable exception, with particular attention to the Dura-Europos plans and reconstructions and any identifiable author's drawings or photographs.

The historical maps produced for this edition are analytical schemes of location and networks, constructed from explicit documentary nodes. They do not attempt to reconstruct continuous routes, complete population densities, or exact political-administrative boundaries when the evidence does not permit it. The social network analysis (SNA) visualisations also distinguish between explicit links, strong inferences, and later traditions.

Access to the evidence

Access codes indicate how evidence has been consulted: [AUT], direct physical examination; [IMG-HR], high-resolution digital images; [FAC], facsimile reproductions; [ED], published editions; [LAB], documented material analysis; [REC-GRAF], a modern reconstruction or visualisation by third parties; and [REC-GRAF/IA], an original graphic reconstruction prepared for this edition. The absence of a code does not imply direct examination. Reproductions for which commercial rights could not be documented have been excluded or replaced by clearly labelled, non-facsimile original reconstructions.

Each reproduction has an editorial record stating its provenance and rights status—licence, permission, public domain or applicable exception; verification concentrates on archaeological photographs, the plans and reconstructions of Dura-Europos, coin types such as Iudaea capta and any identifiable author's or institutional image.

Academic status of the work

The work is presented as an interdisciplinary monograph grounded in historical, philological, and material criticism. It does not claim to provide a comprehensive critical edition of every ancient author cited, nor does it claim direct examination of every manuscript and object discussed. Its purpose is to reconstruct the emergence of early Christianity not as a linear or inevitable unfolding, but as a process of historical convergence among practices, texts, institutions, social networks, and material

archives across the Mediterranean and its adjoining regions. Where the evidence permits more than one reconstruction, historiographical disagreement forms part of the argument rather than being suppressed through retrospective harmonisation.

Abbreviations and conventions

Multilingual onomastic convention

Where a person has both a Greek name and a historically relevant Hebrew or Aramaic equivalent, the first occurrence in the chapter or specialist table gives both forms. A distinction is made between an attested form [A], a probable linguistic equivalent [B] and a disputed reconstruction [C]. Semitic forms are not invented for names that are Greek in origin, and no transliteration is presented as a surviving autograph.

Biblical and Jewish sources

Abbreviation	**Work or identification**
Gen; Exod	Genesis; Exodus.
Isa; Dan	Isaiah; Daniel.
Matt; Mark; Luke; John	Gospels of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John.
Acts	Acts of the Apostles.
Rom; 1–2 Cor; Gal	Romans; 1–2 Corinthians; Galatians.
Eph; Phil; Col	Ephesians; Philippians; Colossians.
1–2 Thess; 1–2 Tim; Titus; Phlm	1–2 Thessalonians; 1–2 Timothy; Titus; Philemon.
Heb; 1–2 Pet; Rev	Hebrews; 1–2 Peter; Revelation.
Ant.; BJ	Josephus, Jewish Antiquities; Jewish War.
Legat.; Contempl.	Philo, Legation to Gaius; The Contemplative Life.
LXX	Traditions of Greek translation of the Scriptures; the specific edition is identified in each context.
1QS; CD	Community Rule; Damascus Document. They are cited by column and line.

Christian and Greco-Roman sources

Abbreviation	Work or identification
1 Clem.	First Letter of Clement to the Corinthians.
Did.	Didache or Doctrine of the Twelve Apostles.
Ign., Eph.; Magn.; Trall.; Rom.; Philad.; Smyrn.; Polyc.	Ignatius of Antioch, middle recension: letters to the Ephesians, Magnesians, Trallians, Romans, Philadelphians, Smyrnaeans and Polycarp.
Herm., Vis.; Mand.; Sim.	The Shepherd of Hermas: Visions, Mandates and Similitudes.
Just., 1–2 Apol.; Dial.	Justin, Apologies; Dialogue with Trypho.
Iren., Haer. (Adv. haer.)	Irenaeus, Adversus haereses.
Tert., Marc. (Adv. Marc.); Apol.; Bapt.; Nat.	Tertullian, Against Marcion; Apology; On Baptism; To the Nations.
Clem. Alex., Paed.; Strom.; Protr.	Clement of Alexandria, The Instructor; Stromata; Exhortation to the Greeks.
Orig., Cels.	Origen, Against Celsus.
Epiph., Pan.	Epiphanius, Panarion.
Eus., HE; VC; Hier.	Eusebius, Ecclesiastical History; Life of Constantine; Against Hierocles.
Lact., Mort. pers.	Lactantius, On the Death of the Persecutors.
Cypr., Ep.; Laps.	Cyprian, Letters; On the Lapsed.
Ath., Fest.	Athanasius, Festal Letters.
Mart. Pol.; Pass. Perp.	Martyrdom of Polycarp; Passion of Perpetua and Felicity.
Tac., Ann.; Plin. Iun., Ep.; Plin. Mai., Nat.; Suet., Claud.	Tacitus, Annals; Pliny the Younger, Letters; Pliny the Elder, Natural History; Suetonius, Life of Claudius.
CTh; CJ	Theodosian Code; Justinian Code.

Corpora and reference tools

International sigla concordance. Internal references remain stable while being cross-mapped to the principal epigraphic, papyrological, and numismatic corpora.

Siglum / corpus	Field	Use in this volume	Concordance / control
CIL	Latin epigraphy	Latin inscriptions	Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum
SEG	Greek epigraphy	Greek inscriptions	Supplementum Epigraphicum Graecum
AE	Annual Latin epigraphy	Epigraphic concordances	L'Année épigraphique

(continued)

Siglum / corpus	Field	Use in this volume	Concordance / control
CIJ	Jewish epigraphy	Ancient Jewish inscriptions	Corpus Inscriptionum Judaicarum
FD	Delphi	Gallio inscription	Fouilles de Delphes III.4, 286
RIC	Roman imperial numismatics	Imperial coin types	Roman Imperial Coinage
BM	Museum catalogue	Verification of types and objects	British Museum Collection Online
P.Oxy.	Papyrology	Oxyrhynchus papyri	The Oxyrhynchus Papyri
P.Ryl.	Papyrology	P52 / Rylands collections	John Rylands papyri catalogue

Abbreviation	Corpus or reference tool
NA28; SBLGNT	Nestle–Aland, 28th edition; Society of Biblical Literature Greek New Testament.
SC; GCS; CCSL; CSEL	Sources Chrétiennes; Die griechischen christlichen Schriftsteller; Corpus Christianorum Series Latina; Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum.
LCL	Loeb Classical Library.
FD; SIG; CIJ	Fouilles de Delphes; Sylloge inscriptionum Graecarum; Corpus Inscriptionum Judaicarum.
P.Oxy.; P.Mich.; P.Bodmer	Publications of papyri from Oxyrhynchus, Michigan, and Bodmer.
GA; TM; LDAB	Gregory–Aland; Trismegistos; Leuven Database of Ancient Books.
NHC; BG	Nag Hammadi Codices; Berlin Codex, especially BG 8502.
RIC	Roman Imperial Coinage.
c.; BCE; CE	Approximately; before the Common Era; Common Era.

Classical works are cited by book in Roman numerals and by chapter and section in Arabic numerals; biblical texts are cited by chapter and verse. A range does not necessarily indicate a verbatim quotation of every line. Square brackets in epigraphic transcriptions mark restorations; an ellipsis indicates omitted material,

never an unacknowledged restoration of a lacuna. Transcription, translation and commentary are distinguished.

Short Greek words and phrases are retained in the original alphabet. Glossary transliterations use a readable system: ē and ō for long vowels, and th, ph and ch for theta, phi and chi. Proper names use their conventional English forms. The papyrological sigla P46 and $^{P}75$ identify manuscripts rather than text editions. An ancient inscription is not silently normalised into literary prose.

Historical maps

Paul's journeys and nodes of the Pauline networks



FIGURE 1A. Paul's first missionary journey (Acts 13–14). The sequence of cities and ports follows Acts; the cartographic line is editorial and does not claim to reconstruct every ancient road. [REC-GRAF/IA]. Illustrative schematic prepared for this edition; positions and routes are not a cartographic reconstruction to scale. Place names on the map are given in their Spanish forms.

The first itinerary brings movement, preaching and the formation of local groups into the same field of view. The sequence belongs to the narrative order of Acts,

rather than to an independent record of travel days and distances. The named city, the journey presupposed by the account and the line linking its endpoints must be distinguished. Reception, disputes and returns to earlier destinations introduce different timescales within the journey. A network approach attends to these relationships and their narrative transmission, without treating the continuous route as evidence of a uniform territorial organisation.



FIGURE 1B. Paul's second missionary journey (Acts 15:36–18:22). Explicit stops in the narrative are shown; regional travel across Asia Minor is represented approximately. [REC-GRAF/IA]. Illustrative schematic prepared for this edition; positions and routes are not a cartographic reconstruction to scale. Place names on the map are given in their Spanish forms.

The second itinerary extends the horizon towards Macedonia and Achaia. This expansion must be studied alongside changes of interlocutors, places of hospitality and forms of opposition described in Acts. A cartographic line cannot establish the duration or intensity of contact, or community stability. Paul's correspondence allows relationships that outlast the missionary's departure to be examined, together with disputes, envoys and shared expectations. Comparing the letters with Acts does not mean automatically filling the silences of one source with information from the other. Each witness retains its genre, audience and representational strategy.



FIGURE 1C. Paul's third missionary journey (Acts 18:23–21:17). The sequence from Troas to Jerusalem follows the stops named in Acts 20–21; earlier regional travel is approximate. [REC-GRAF/IA]. Illustrative schematic prepared for this edition; positions and routes are not a cartographic reconstruction to scale. Place names on the map are given in their Spanish forms.

The third itinerary highlights returns, stays and connections between communities already associated with the mission. Travel does more than generate new destinations: it sustains relationships through contact, accompaniment and communication. Acts selects episodes and stopping points with uneven narrative density. A briefly described stage does not demonstrate an absence of activity; a stay narrated at length does not measure community size. Reconstruction must distinguish travel time, time spent in a place and the space allotted to each episode by the narrative. The arrival in Jerusalem is interpreted within these relationships and obligations, without retrospectively imposing a later territorial ecclesiastical structure.

The journey to Rome belongs to a different context from the preceding missionary journeys. Movement is conditioned by custody, navigation and decisions beyond the traveller's control. Contacts and episodes of religious communication do not remove those conditions. In Acts 27–28, ports, sighted coastlines, islands and places where the text locates a stay must be distinguished: not every geographical



FIGURE 1D. Paul's journey to Rome (Acts 27–28). The map follows the narrative sequence of ports, coasts, and islands without treating every geographical reference as an actual stop. [REC-GRAF/IA]. Illustrative schematic prepared for this edition; positions and routes are not a cartographic reconstruction to scale. Place names on the map are given in their Spanish forms.

reference denotes a stopping point. Maritime conditions introduce diversions and interruptions. A schematic representation combines elements that the narrative presents as successive events. Missionary travel and transfer under custody may connect similar places without constituting the same kind of historical relationship.



FIGURE 2. Documented communities in the second century and their urban context. The figures indicate approximate total inhabitants of the city, not the number of Christians: they are demographic proposals for the imperial period. Rome, Alexandria, and Ephesus show the range between modelled figures and traditional estimates, not a statistical confidence interval. Lyon, Vienne, and Smyrna follow the supplement by Hanson, Ortman, and Lobo (2017); Philippi (*) is this edition's own calculation, based on 51 ha (Hanson, 2016; model 41.03 × A^1.34 from Hanson and Ortman, 2017, Table 5B). Antioch deliberately retains the traditional historiographical estimate of approximately 150,000 inhabitants; it is not presented as the result of the same allometric model applied to other cities and is kept as a point of comparison to highlight the divergence between estimation methods. The lines represent selected communication corridors, not trade volumes or routes for each community. The sources for the communities are Ignatius, Polycarp, Justin, Irenaeus and Eus., HE V.1 and HE VI.6. [ED; REC-GRAF].

Communities documented in the second century

Demographic sources: Hanson (2016), Cities Database, version 1.0 (OxREP), DOI 10.5287/bodleian:eqapevAn8; Hanson and Ortman (2017), JRA 30, 301–324, DOI 10.1017/S1047759400074134; Hanson, Ortman, and Lobo (2017), J. R. Soc. Interface 14, 20170367, supplement, DOI 10.1098/rsif.2017.0367. The areas are reconstructions from the Imperial period, and some boundaries incorporate later phases. The magnitudes do not constitute censuses from the year 200. Routes and connections: Strab., Geogr. VII.7.4 (Egnatia); V.3.6 (Appia); Sen., Ep. 77.1–2 (Alexandrian fleet at Puteoli); Acts 27–28 (Mediterranean voyage). Georeferenced editorial cartography: coordinates from Hanson (2016) and a simplified modern coastline from Natural Earth 1:50m, public domain.

Abstract

This monograph studies the formation of early Christianity as a historically plural process of constructing identity, authority, memory, ritual practice, and material representation, developed between Second Temple Judaism and the Greco-Roman Mediterranean world during the first to fourth centuries. Its central argument is that the later doctrinal and institutional configuration cannot be retrospectively projected onto the first decades of the Jesus movement. Reconstruction must begin with the critical convergence of texts, epigraphy, papyrology, archaeology, and iconography, weighing each witness according to its nature and date.

The research adopts a historical-critical methodology that distinguishes between highly reliable documentary data, widely accepted historiographical reconstructions, and open hypotheses. Numerological, gematric, esoteric, or symbolic correspondences for which no positive chain of transmission can be demonstrated are rejected as historical arguments. Religious comparison is used to contextualise and formulate problems, not to replace historical evidence.

The first chapters examine the Jewish origins of the Jesus movement, the centrality of Jerusalem, Paul's mission, the incorporation of Gentiles, and the historiographical problem of differentiating between Judaism and Christianity. Subsequent chapters study the plurality of the second century, canon and authority, community practices, persecution and martyrdom, material culture, iconography, Constantinian transformation, and institutionalisation in Late Antiquity.

Methodological abstract

The method combines three operations. The first is chronological: each witness is located according to its date of composition, its date of copying and its context of transmission, so that the undisputed Pauline letters, the gospels, second-century literature and imperial legislation are not read on a single plane. The second is documentary: objects, inscriptions, papyri and buildings are described according to their material status before they are interpreted, and the control sigla ([AUT], [IMG-HR], [FAC], [ED], [LAB], [REC-GRAF], [REC-GRAF/IA]) declare the actual degree of access to each piece of evidence. The third is comparative: similarities between Jewish, Greco-Roman, Iranian and Christian traditions are recorded as problems that require a demonstrable chain of transmission, not as proofs of dependence.

Degrees of certainty are expressed on three levels—attested datum, widely accepted reconstruction and open hypothesis—and are applied also to prosopography and to social network analysis, whose metrics depend explicitly on the selected corpus. The ancient calculation of Revelation 13:18 is examined as a specific philological and historical problem, paying attention to its manuscript variants, without making it a universal key to interpretation.

General Introduction

The origins of Christianity do not constitute the history of a fully formed institution progressing linearly from Jesus to the imperial Church. First-century sources, instead, reveal a movement born within Second Temple Judaism, initially organised around the memory of Jesus, the conviction that God had raised him from the dead, and eschatological expectations that needed to be articulated in the language of Israel's Scriptures. During the following decades, this movement spread through the cities of the Mediterranean, gradually incorporating non-Jews and producing new forms of authority, interpretation, and practice.

This book argues that the category of "early Christianity" is useful if employed as a historiographical tool and not as the name of a homogeneous reality. In the first century, there was not yet a single social, liturgical, or doctrinal form that could be identified without nuance with the Christianity of later centuries. Paul's letters, the Gospels, Acts, the Didache, 1 Clement, Ignatius, the Shepherd of Hermas, and apologetic literature belong to different contexts and should not be harmonised as if they were equivalent voices of the same institution.

Chronology imposes an initial hierarchy of sources. The undisputed Pauline epistles are the earliest surviving Christian documents and allow particular communities to be observed from within their own controversies. The Synoptic Gospels and Acts belong to a later phase of narrative and theological development; the Gospel of John represents another literary trajectory; the writers of the early and mid-second century already document processes of differentiation, the construction of authority, and disputes over apostolic memory. Temporal distance does not invalidate a source, but it modifies the kind of question that can be put to it.

The central problem is not to determine when an already defined essence called "Christianity" separated from another essence called "Judaism". Research over the last few decades has shown the difficulty of that scheme. The relationships between Jewish groups following Jesus, mixed communities, and predominantly Gentile congregations varied according to region and generation. The image of a single "parting

of the ways" has been largely replaced in contemporary discussion by models that recognise multiple, asymmetrical, and protracted processes.[1]

The same caution applies to terms such as "orthodoxy", "heresy", "Gnosticism", or "Jewish Christianity". The ancient term αἵρεσις could designate an option, school, or group; its transformation into a negative theological category was a historical development. In this work, "heresy" is used when an ancient source or a particular ecclesiastical tradition classifies a doctrine as deviant. For the historical description of second-century groups, terms such as "tendency", "school", "community" or "doctrinal position" are preferred where possible.

The methodology of this investigation rests on a simple rule: the strength of a claim must be proportional to the strength of the evidence. The execution of Jesus under Pontius Pilate, the existence of a community of Jesus' followers in Jerusalem, the role of James in it, or Paul's missionary activity among Gentiles can be affirmed with a high degree of certainty. In contrast, the exact identification of the meeting narrated in Galatians 2 with the episode in Acts 15, the nature of certain later apostolic traditions, or the precise chronology of some communities require a more cautious formulation.

This gradation does not lead to historical minimalism. Its purpose is precisely to allow for a positive narrative where the sources permit it. Critical history does not consist in indefinitely suspending judgement, but rather in explaining what we know, why we know it, and what remains disputed.

[1] Becker and Reed 2007; Fredriksen 2018; Lieu 2002. The argument distinguishes local processes of differentiation and avoids a single universal date of separation.

Method and documentary corpus

The research combines literary criticism, historical criticism, philological analysis, and the study of material culture. Literary sources are first read as documents produced in specific contexts: a letter is not interpreted as a chronicle, an apologetic work is not used as a neutral description of its adversaries, and a later historiographical account does not automatically replace contemporary testimony.

Where a question depends on vocabulary, the relevant original form is given with a brief English translation. Notes identify the loci and standard editions. The documentary appendix distinguishes specific checks from comprehensive consultation of the apparatus of variants; bibliographical identification of an edition is not presented as a new textual collation.

Material culture is treated as an independent body of evidence. Images, inscriptions, papyri and architectural spaces do not serve as decorative illustrations of conclusions reached in advance. Provenance, dating, writing material, archaeological context and preservation all form part of the argument. The Alexamenos graffito, the house-church at Dura-Europos and manuscripts containing staurograms are therefore analysed as evidence in their own right.

Comparisons with religions of the Empire are limited to verifiable historical issues. Formal similarity does not amount to dependence. Proposing cultural transmission requires compatible chronology, routes of contact, and positive evidence. This criterion excludes numerological, gematric, and esoteric genealogies from the argument.

The bibliographical apparatus distinguishes three levels: primary sources and critical editions; reference tools and corpora; and secondary scholarship. Engagement with contemporary research extends beyond citing names: each debate presents positions, arguments and evidence. Particular attention is given to developments in Pauline studies, Jewish-Christian relations, the ancient construction of heresy, and material culture.

Social history, urban networks and circulation

The reconstruction of the early Christian communities systematically incorporates the social and economic history of the Roman Mediterranean. Mission, hospitality, patronage, artisanal and commercial mobility, domestic structure, and urban inequalities provide a necessary context for interpreting the Pauline epistles and the formation of translocal networks. This approach makes it possible to engage with the tradition of social history represented by, among others, Wayne A. Meeks, Ekkehard and Wolfgang Stegemann, and Martin Goodman, without reducing religious experience to a purely socioeconomic explanation.[2]

Cities are not treated as mere points on a missionary itinerary. Corinth, Ephesus, Antioch, Philippi, Thessalonica, and Rome are analysed as specific urban environments, with civic structures, associations, houses, markets, ports, and mobility networks that conditioned the forms of gathering and transmission.

Orality, memory and written culture

The transmission of traditions about Jesus is studied within a culture in which orality and writing coexisted. The presence of a written text does not imply that oral transmission ceased, just as an oral tradition should not be imagined as a mechanical and immutable reproduction. The Gospels are considered literary products embedded in prior and parallel processes of memory, performance, teaching, and rewriting.

Contemporary discussion of orality, memory, and written culture are incorporated through specialised works, including the contributions of Werner H. Kelber and Chris Keith. This framework allows for a more precise description of the formation, circulation, and stabilisation of traditions without postulating a fixed text from the outset or, at the opposite extreme, a completely free transmission.[3]

The state of research

[2] Meeks 1983; Stegemann and Stegemann 1995; Goodman 2018. Associations, households and support relationships constitute social contexts; they are not equated without evidence with the legal status of each community.

[3] Kelber 1983; Keith 2020. Orality and manuscripts are studied as coexisting practices of transmission; the material medium alone does not establish the degree of stability of a narrative.

1. From linear models to historical complexity

For much of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, the history of Christian origins was narrated through relatively linear sequences: Jesus founded a community recognisable as Christian; Paul universalised his message; a progressively unified Church defined orthodoxy against lateral deviations; and the canon, the episcopate, and doctrine crystallised as the logical development of an initial core. This framework produced works of enormous documentary value, but it tended to read the first and second centuries retrospectively through institutional configurations better attested in the third and fourth centuries. Research in recent decades has replaced this teleology with models that privilege local processes, uneven chronologies, competition for authority, the circulation of texts, and the overlapping of identities.

The German historical-critical tradition was decisive in formulating the problem. Adolf von Harnack combined a monumental reconstruction of Christian expansion with a strongly articulated account of doctrinal formation and demarcation in relation to Marcion. Walter Bauer, in turn (Rechtgläubigkeit und Ketzerei im ältesten Christentum, 1934; Eng. trans. Orthodoxy and Heresy in Earliest Christianity, 1971), recast the relationship between "orthodoxy" and "heresy" as a historical question of regional distribution and institutional success. Subsequent historiography has challenged both the simplicity of a homogeneous early orthodoxy and the possibility of replacing it with an inverse model of originally unrestricted diversity. It is now more productive to ask what forms of authority operated in each city, which texts circulated, which practices groups shared or used to distinguish themselves, and when particular networks succeeded in presenting their own genealogies as universal.

The Anglo-American tradition broadened the field to include social history, the sociology of knowledge, Pauline studies, material culture, and network analysis. Wayne A. Meeks showed that Pauline communities should be studied within the structure of the Greco-Roman city; Peter Lampe reconstructed Roman Christianity as a constellation of domestic groups rather than a monolithic institution; subsequent work on associations, mobility, and networks has deepened this approach. At the same time, French and Italian research has made decisive contributions to the analysis of ancient heresy, Christian archaeology, episcopal institutions, and the construction of martyr memory. The present work adopts this methodological plurality as a working condition: no single discipline is by itself sufficient to reconstruct Christian origins.

This survey of scholarship does not attempt an exhaustive history of the discipline. Its purpose is to identify the debates that materially affect the interpretation

of the sources examined in this volume. Each section distinguishes questions of evidence from interpretative models and from the methodological choices adopted here. Schools and scholarly traditions are therefore not invoked as badges of authority: a historiographical position is preferred only insofar as it offers the most persuasive account of the available evidence while keeping its uncertainties explicit.

2. The Jewish origins of the Jesus movement: from Sanders to Paul within Judaism

The modern renewal of Pauline studies fundamentally altered the image of Judaism against which Paul had traditionally been read. E. P. Sanders (Paul and Palestinian Judaism, 1977) challenged the caricature of Judaism defined by the attempt to "earn" salvation through the accumulation of merits and proposed describing many forms of Second Temple Judaism through the category of "covenantal nomism": belonging to the covenant people precedes observance, which expresses and maintains that relationship. James D. G. Dunn popularised the term "New Perspective on Paul" ("The New Perspective on Paul", Bulletin of the John Rylands Library 65, 1983, 95–122) to encompass, despite significant internal differences, readings that reinterpreted Paul's polemics on "works of the Law" within conflicts concerning identity, circumcision, table fellowship and belonging, rather than as a simple opposition between Christian grace and Jewish legalism.

N. T. Wright developed a narrative reading of Paul centred on Israel, covenant, messianism, and new creation, while John M. G. Barclay reopened the question of grace through a comparative analysis of the concept of gift. These developments show that the New Perspective never constituted a uniform school. Its historiographical importance lies less in a common solution than in having compelled the reconstruction of the letters within real Jewish controversies and a wariness of theological oppositions inherited from modern debates.

A second phase, usually associated with the Paul within Judaism movement, has taken this shift further. Mark Nanos, Magnus Zetterholm, Paula Fredriksen, and Matthew Thiessen, among others, have insisted that the undisputed letters can be read as the discourse of a Jew convinced of the eschatological significance of Jesus, addressed primarily to Gentiles brought into allegiance to the God of Israel without needing to become ethnically Jewish. From this perspective, the warnings against circumcision in Galatians do not necessarily express a universal abolition of the Torah, but rather a debate about what Gentiles should do in the messianic age. The scope of this proposal continues to be debated, especially when attempts are made to extend

it to all Pauline passages or to reconstruct with excessive certainty the social status of each recipient.

This monograph adopts a position of critical convergence. It takes Paul's Jewish identity as a fundamental historical fact; it distinguishes what Paul demands of Gentiles from what can be presupposed for Jewish followers of Jesus; and it avoids describing Paul's mission as the conscious foundation of a separate religion. At the same time, it does not turn Paul within Judaism into a universal key: the internal tensions of the letters, regional diversity, and subsequent reception show that the reconfiguration of belonging was an ongoing process. The governing criterion is consistently textual and contextual: identifying recipients, interlocutors, disputed practices, and the rhetorical function of each argument.

Table 1. Scholarship on the Jewish origins of the Jesus movement: schools and authors

Scholarly school / author	**Central thesis**	**Principal evidence**	**Limitation identified in this work**
Classic confessional model	Paul contrasts the gospel of grace with legalistic Judaism.	Systematic readings of Romans and Galatians.	It tends to homogenise ancient Judaism and project later controversies.
E. P. Sanders	Second Temple Judaism should be described from the perspective of the covenant and not as a religion of merit.	Comparative Jewish literature and Paul.	The category of covenantal nomism does not exhaust Jewish diversity.
J. D. G. Dunn / New Perspective	The "works of the Law" relate to identity and belonging as well as soteriology.	Galatians, Romans, circumcision and table fellowship.	The New Perspective brings together different positions; it does not constitute a single thesis.
Paul within Judaism	Paul continues to act as a Jew and addresses many of his prohibitions of circumcision specifically to Gentiles.	Undisputed letters, ethnicity of recipients, eschatology of Israel.	Not all Pauline loci can be resolved by a single reconstruction of recipients.

(continued)

Scholarly school / author	Central thesis	Principal evidence	Limitation identified in this work
Position of this monograph	Paul is interpreted within Judaism, distinguishing requirements for Jews and Gentiles and keeping ambiguous loci open.	The undisputed letters take priority; Acts is used critically as a later source.	Avoid turning a useful historiographical framework into reconstructive dogma.

3. From the "parting of the ways" to multiple differentiations and overlapping configurations

The second structural debate concerns the relationship between Judaism and Christianity. Previous models sought a relatively definable moment of rupture: the mission to the Gentiles, the destruction of the Temple in 70 CE, a supposed decision at Yavne, the Bar Kokhba revolt, or the episcopal consolidation of the second century. Recent research has shown that these dates mark real transformations, but they do not function as a universal boundary. Mediterranean cities produced distinct ecologies; a community could share scriptures, social spaces, kinship ties, or practices with Jewish groups and, at the same time, construct discourses of intense opposition.

Judith Lieu has insisted that "Jewish" and "Christian" are categories whose apparent literary stability should not be confused with identically stable social boundaries. Daniel Boyarin has studied the production of these boundaries as a discursive process, while Adam H. Becker and Annette Yoshiko Reed have brought together studies that challenge the paradigm of a single separation. The value of these proposals lies not in asserting that there was never a separation, but in shifting the question: where, for whom, in what practice, and with what sources can a boundary be demonstrated? An anti-Jewish homily, a synagogue sanction, a funerary inscription, and an imperial decree describe different levels of interaction and should not be automatically assembled into a single chronology.

The Johannine occurrences of *ἀποσυνάγωγος*, the controversies of Matthew, the birkat ha-minim, the homilies of John Chrysostom, and Late Antique legislation must be situated within their own contexts. The chronological distance between them is precisely part of the evidence. Polemical language can reveal competitive proximity as well as entrenched separation. For this reason, the present work uses expres-

sions such as “multiple differentiations”, “asymmetrical boundaries”, and “overlapping religious configurations” when the sources show persistent contact; it reserves “separation” for specific contexts in which institutional or social exclusion is actually documented.

Table 2. Models of the “parting of the ways” and of multiple differentiation

Model	Implied chronology	Strength	Problem
Early rupture	40s–70s CE	It underlines the weight of the Gentile mission and the war of 66–70 CE.	It does not explain the persistence of overlapping practices and identities.
Yavne / synagogue exclusion	Late first century	Connects Johannine conflict with the formation of rabbinic Judaism.	The universal authority of Yavne and the early redaction of the birkat cannot be presupposed.
Progressive separation	First–second centuries	It recognises regional differences and long chronologies.	It may still assume a single and inevitable direction.
Ways That Never Parted / multiple boundaries	First–fourth centuries, varying by region	It addresses social porosity, controversy, and prolonged contact.	Taken to extremes, it can minimise boundaries that did harden locally.
This book’s criterion	Chronology by city, practice, and corpus	It integrates literary, rabbinic, epigraphic and legal sources.	It leaves open the possibility of different results depending on the region.

4. Marcion, Luke and the formation of textual authority

Research on Marcion is one of the fields in which philology most directly reshapes historical narrative. The surviving sources are mostly adversarial and later: Tertullian, Epiphanius, Irenaeus, and other authors cite or describe the Marcionite Gospel and Apostolikon within polemical projects. The problem lies in reconstructing, from these quotations, a lost text and then establishing its relationship with Luke and the Pauline collections. This operation requires distinguishing three levels: the text actually attested by a source; the critical reconstruction of the Marcionite text; and the genealogical hypothesis regarding priority or dependence.

Dieter T. Roth (The Text of Marcion's Gospel, 2015) has advocated an exceptionally cautious reconstruction, restricted to what the evidence allows. Jason BeDuhn has proposed a reading of Marcion that gives more weight to his scriptural programme as a coherent collection. Judith Lieu has shown the extent to which the historical figure of Marcion was produced by his adversaries and has demanded a careful separation of the teacher from the literary "arch-heretic". Matthias Klinghardt has formulated the most radical thesis: the gospel used by Marcion predated canonical Luke and is therefore crucial evidence for the formation of the Synoptic Gospels. This hypothesis forces a reconsideration of the direction of dependence and cannot be dismissed by mere appeal to patristic tradition.

This monograph adopts a deliberate methodological asymmetry. For the reconstruction of the Marcionite text, it takes as its primary evidentiary constraint the data that can be reliably attributed to the sources; for literary history, it keeps hypotheses of priority open without conflating them with directly preserved readings. The fact that a reconstruction is possible does not imply that all its words have the same degree of certainty. Similarly, the explanatory success of a synoptic model is not the same as the existence of a manuscript that proves it. For this reason, the apparatus in Chapter II explicitly records the source, state, and effect of each locus.

This debate also alters the history of the canon. If Marcion possessed a defined collection comprising a gospel and Pauline letters, his project constitutes a decisive moment in textual delimitation; but describing it as the "first New Testament" may suggest a material and conceptual stability greater than the evidence warrants. Irenaeus's response in favour of the fourfold Gospel, later lists, and manuscript practice show a process of selection, collection, and authority that did not advance at the same pace in all regions.

TABLE 3. Marcion and Luke: authors and approaches in scholarship

Author / approach	Marcion–Luke relationship	Dominant method	Use in this monograph
Harnack	Marcion abbreviates or reforms a gospel tradition linked to Luke.	Historical reconstruction based on heresiologists.	Historiographical value; its framework is not adopted without textual revision.
Roth	Cautious reconstruction of the Gospel of Marcion without overextending the testimony.	Verification of patristic quotations and allusions.	Reliable basis for attested loci.
BeDuhn	It underlines the coherence of the Marcionite scriptural project.	Reconstruction and analysis of Marcion's canon.	Reference point for the history of collection and authority.
Klinghardt	He defends the priority of the Marcionite gospel over the canonical Luke.	Synoptic criticism and textual reconstruction.	A hypothesis examined locus by locus, not an assumption of this book.
Lieu	Analyses the heresiological construction of Marcion.	History of reception and polemical discourse.	Guards against reading an opponent's portrayal as a transparent biography.

5. After "Gnosticism": categories, schools and practices

The term "Gnosticism" was long used as if it designated a coherent religion, characterised by radical dualism, a fall myth, a rejection of the cosmos, and salvation through knowledge. This synthesis proved useful as a classificatory tool, but it conflated very different systems and relied too heavily on the taxonomies of heresiologists. Michael A. Williams proposed abandoning the category as a unitary historical entity; Karen L. King examined its modern genealogy and showed how the opposition between "Christianity" and "Gnosticism" partly reproduced the polemical architecture of ancient sources. David Brakke has advocated a more restricted use of the term for certain formations, while Einar Thomassen and Ismo Dunderberg have reconstructed Valentinianism as a network of schools, rituals, exegesis and lifestyles, not simply as a deviation from the "Great Church" of the heresiologists.

The methodological consequence is decisive. A Nag Hammadi text should not first be classified as "Gnostic" and then explained from a supposed essence. One must begin with its language, literary form, scriptural traditions, cosmology, reading practices, possible location, and relationships with other texts. Only then is it legitimate to discuss whether the comparative label contributes anything. The same applies to names transmitted almost exclusively by adversaries, such as "Ophites", "Cainites", or certain genealogies of teachers: their existence as stable groups cannot be automatically deduced from a heresiological list.

Valentinus offers a particularly instructive case. The evidence places him within sophisticated Christian intellectual debates of the second century; Valentinian traditions used exegesis of texts that also circulated in communities that would later be considered proto-orthodox. The boundary is, therefore, contested from within. This monograph retains "Gnosticism" only as a secondary historiographical term, always defined and never used to explain a text in itself. It prefers to identify specific schools, authors, corpora, and practices.

Table 4. "Gnosticism" as a historiographical problem: comparative models and criteria

Model	Assumed unity	Advantage	Risk / corrective approach
Ancient heresiologists	Genealogy of errors from founding masters.	They preserve names, quotations, and sometimes unique descriptions.	They are polemical sources; their taxonomies are not taken as a neutral map.
Essentialist Gnosticism	Unified dualistic religion.	It facilitates comparison of motifs.	It homogenises different texts, groups, and chronologies.

(continued)

Model	Assumed unity	Advantage	Risk / corrective approach
Williams / King	Critique or dismantling of the category.	It requires each phenomenon to be reconstructed from specific sources.	It can make comparison difficult if all common vocabulary is removed.
Brakke / Thomassen / Dunderberg	Restricted use and reconstruction of specific formations.	It allows for the precise study of schools, rituals, and exegesis.	It requires specifying in each case which group and which corpus are being compared.
This book's criterion	Secondary category, never causal essence.	It combines comparison with historical source criticism.	Social identity is not inferred solely from doctrinal similarity.

6. Material culture, manuscripts and the turn towards artefacts

The history of Christian origins can no longer be written solely from literary works. The material turn has placed manuscripts, inscriptions, coins, architecture, funerary objects, and images within the same evidentiary field. Larry Hurtado drew attention to graphic features such as the nomina sacra, the staurogram, and the early Christian preference for the codex. Roger Bagnall and Brent Nongbri have forced a reassessment of dates, archaeological contexts, and assumptions about how quickly certain formats can be associated with religious identities. Chris Keith has insisted that the Gospels must also be studied as manuscript objects and as a social practice of reading.

This shift changes the questions that can be asked. A papyrus is not merely a medium for recovering a reading: its size, format, handwriting, corrections, page layout, and signs of use provide evidence for production, cost, readership, and circulation. Similarly, the Christian building at Dura-Europos is not a "church" in an abstract sense, but a building transformed within a precise archaeological sequence; and the Alexamenos graffito is not generic evidence of persecution, but a situated act of mockery whose interpretation depends on the medium and the social context of the Palatine Hill.

Digital humanities expand these possibilities through image databases, handwriting comparison, mapping, and network analysis, but they also introduce new risks.

The availability of a digital image is not equivalent to direct physical examination; algorithmic classification does not replace an explicit theory of the data; and a visualisation can create an appearance of greater precision than the underlying information. Chapter VII therefore establishes levels of observation [AUT], [IMG-HR], [FAC], [ED], [LAB], [REC-GRAF] and [REC-GRAF/IA], so that the reader can distinguish between direct inspection, digital images, facsimile consultation, published editions, laboratory analysis and graphic reconstruction.

The present work treats material culture as an independent archive and as a corrective to literary narrative. When text and object converge, the conclusion gains strength; when they diverge, the divergence is preserved. An inscription, a building, or a codex is not forced to confirm the history transmitted by Eusebius, Irenaeus, or the martyrdom accounts.

7. Prophets, miracle workers, and messianic pretenders: a comparison without equivalence

The comparative study of Jesus with sign prophets, miracle workers, and charismatic figures has oscillated between two extremes: the isolation of Jesus as a phenomenon without historical analogues and the reduction of his activity to a supposedly well-defined religious type. Research on prophetic figures of late Second Temple Judaism, holy men of the Mediterranean, and miracle literature allows for a more disciplined comparison. Theudas, the Egyptian, Honi, Hanina ben Dosa, Apollonius of Tyana, and Alexander of Abonoteichos do not form a homogeneous class; they belong to different eras, genres, and agendas.

Rebecca Gray demonstrated the importance of the popular prophets described by Josephus; studies of miracle stories and holy men have explored formal parallels with Greco-Roman narratives. The comparative value lies in isolating variables: charismatic authority, signs, healing, prophecy, relationship with crowds, response of authorities, and posthumous memory. Similarity in one of these dimensions does not demonstrate literary dependence or social identity. Apollonius, for example, is known primarily through a biography by Philostratus written in the third century; using him as an immediate mirror of the Galilee of Jesus without considering this distance would produce an anachronism.

Chapter VIII enters this debate through a disciplined typological comparison. The historical singularity of the Jesus movement is not formulated as an absence of parallels, but as a specific combination of eschatological proclamation, remembrance of the execution, affirmation of resurrection, and the capacity to generate lasting

translocal networks. The comparison serves to clarify differences, not to fabricate equivalences.

8. Historiography in Spanish and the position of this monograph

Research in Spanish is not a secondary appendage to Anglophone or Germanophone debates. In recent decades, it has produced collective syntheses, studies of the historical Jesus, sociology of the early Christian communities, analyses of the New Testament, and works on Christian diversity capable of engaging with international discussions. The collective work coordinated by Rafael Aguirre, *Así empezó el cristianismo* (How Christianity Began), is especially relevant for its attempt to reconstruct the origins as a social, historical, and plural process; the works of Santiago Guijarro have contributed to the study of the Gospels and the early Christian communities; and Antonio Piñero has disseminated in Spanish a non-confessional historical-literary approach to the formation of the New Testament. This monograph belongs to that scholarly conversation, while seeking to strengthen it through a more systematic integration of material culture, philology of individual loci, papyrology, epigraphy, and international historiographical comparison.

The distinctive contribution of this volume lies in bringing into a single analytical framework bodies of evidence that are often studied separately. Paul's letters are read against urban and economic structures; canon formation is set beside manuscript evidence and competing collections; episcopal lists are treated as documents of institutional memory; groups labelled heretical are reconstructed, where possible, from texts produced within those traditions; and archaeology is treated not as illustration but as evidence capable of qualifying, constraining, or contradicting literary narratives. The result is a history of convergence: the Christian unity visible in later centuries was historically real—if normative, partial and contested, as the Arian, Donatist and Melitian controversies of the fourth century show—but it was not present fully formed at the outset. It emerged through textual selection, ritual negotiation, episcopal authority, economic networks, doctrinal controversy, and legal transformation.

This stance also implies limitations. The book does not attempt to resolve ongoing debates or transform every uncertainty into a thesis. Where a date, authorship, textual reconstruction, or archaeological identification is uncertain, the degree of certainty is preserved. The aim of a reference work is not to maximise assertions, but to make explicit what is known, why it is known, what depends upon inference, and what remains open to revision.

9. Matrix of open problems and methodological decisions

Table 5. Matrix of open problems and methodological decisions

Problem	Main positions	Operational decision of the book	State
Paul and the Torah	Classic confessional model; New Perspective; Paul within Judaism.	Jewish contextualisation of Paul; distinction between Jewish and Gentile recipients; locus-by-locus analysis.	Open in several passages.
Judaism / Christianity	Early rupture; progressive separation; overlapping boundaries.	Regional and practice-based chronologies; do not postulate a universal date.	Differentiated by corpus and city.
Marcion / Luke	Lukan priority; complex dependence; Marcionite priority.	Roth for reliable reconstruction; Klinghardt as a debated hypothesis of textual genealogy.	Open debate.
Canon	Linear response to heresies; multiple processes of collection and authority.	Distinguish between collection, liturgical use, list, and formal exclusion.	Long-term process.
Gnosticism	Unitary category; dismantling of the category; restricted uses.	Working by school, text and practice; "Gnosticism" as a secondary label.	Ongoing terminological precision.
Monarchical episcopate	Uniform early institution; uneven regional development.	Do not retrospectively project the model of the third century onto the first.	Local reconstruction.
Manuscripts	Textual witnesses; social and material artefacts.	Integrate readings, writing material, scribal hand, format, use and provenance.	According to the level of observation.

(continued)

Problem	Main positions	Operational decision of the book	State
Charismatic figures	Jesus without analogies; Jesus as just another holy man.	Typological comparison without equivalence or automatic genealogy.	Comparative, not reductive.

Thesis and research question

The book asks how the identities, doctrines, practices, forms of representation and community structures of Jesus' followers took shape between their Jewish origins in the first century and their gradual institutionalisation within the Roman Empire by the end of the fourth century.

The thesis defended here is that this configuration was not the linear unfolding of a pre-existing identity, but rather the result of successive processes of scriptural interpretation, incorporation of Gentiles, circulation of texts, competition for authority, ritual development, and negotiation with institutions of the Roman world. The later unity—normative, partial and always contested—was real, but it was historically produced. That process can be reconstructed only if texts, objects and spaces are treated as independent bodies of evidence and every claim is kept proportional to the evidence that supports it: material culture therefore does not merely confirm the literary narrative but can correct it. That production was, moreover, a case of convergence among diverse fields of influence—Second Temple Judaism, Greco-Roman culture, imperial administration and, on the eastern margins, Syriac and Iranian traditions—whose articulation was decisively Pauline: the problem of Gentile belonging, the epistolary and communal medium, and the vocabulary that was later debated, canonised or combated all start with Paul.

CHAPTER I

From the Jesus Movement to the First Mediterranean Communities

1. The starting point: a Jewish movement of the first century

The reconstruction of early Christianity begins within Second Temple Judaism. Jesus, his first disciples, Paul, James, and Peter were all Jewish; their conflicts, expectations, and religious language developed in a world structured by the Scriptures of Israel, the Temple, the practice of the Torah, and a wide diversity of interpretations concerning purity, eschatology, the restoration of Israel, and divine action in history.

Presenting this movement as a "sect" can be useful if the term is used in a sociological sense, but it is misleading if it suggests that a separate religion existed from the beginning. The vocabulary of the New Testament itself does not offer a uniform self-designation. In Acts, for example, αἵρεσις can be used for both Jewish groups and the movement associated with Jesus, showing that the term could still mean "current" or "party" before fully acquiring the later technical meaning of "heresy" (cf. Acts 5:17; 15:5; 24:5, 14; 26:5; 28:22).

Eschatological expectation constituted one of the most important frameworks for interpretation. The proclamation that God had raised Jesus from the dead was not initially received as an isolated event, but as a sign of a decisive divine intervention. This conviction appears particularly early in Paul's letters, where Christ's resurrection is linked to the future resurrection of believers and to the imminence of eschatological fulfilment.

The importance of this Jewish matrix does not compel us to imagine uniformity. First-century Judaism encompassed a diversity of groups, practices, and positions; nor did the early communities of Jesus react in a single way to issues such as the observance of the Law, sharing meals, or the admission of Gentiles. This diversity is

not a secondary deviation from its origins, but rather part of the oldest material we possess.

1.1. Roman power and the conditions of provincial life

The Judea in which the Jesus movement arose was not a uniform political landscape. The death of Herod the Great led to a dynastic partition; from 6 CE, Judea, Samaria, and Idumea came under direct Roman administration, while Galilee and Perea remained under Herod Antipas during Jesus' ministry. Distinguishing these jurisdictions avoids presenting every Galilean conflict as an immediate action of the Roman prefect of Judea. Local authorities, the priesthood in Jerusalem, dynastic clients, and imperial representatives all had a share in an unequal distribution of power.

The prefect Pontius Pilate administered Judea from approximately 26 to 36 CE. The Caesarea inscription, which preserves part of his name and title, provides epigraphic confirmation of the office of praefectus Iudaeae. Tacitus retrospectively uses the title procurator in Ann. XV.44; the two designations should not be confused or harmonised by eliminating the discrepancy. The inscription and the Roman account belong to different genres and dates. Neither alone describes the trial of Jesus with the precision of a preserved court record.[4]

The Gospels place Jesus in villages, on roads, in homes, in synagogues, and finally in Jerusalem. This spatial variety is historically more important than an abstract opposition between "countryside" and "city." Galilee was connected to administrative centres and markets, but movement through these environments does not prove that Jesus received a specific urban education, nor does it entitle us to reconstruct his occupation or level of literacy from geographical proximity. Mobility and contact are conditions of possibility; a detailed biography requires further evidence.

It is also important to distinguish between ancient forms of taxation. Imperial taxes, agrarian obligations, religious dues, and debt relationships could coexist without constituting a single levy administered by the same agent. The parables and gospel controversies reflect a world of day labourers, tenants, landowners, moneylenders, and tax collectors, but they are literary compositions. Their historical use requires comparing the motifs with independent social documentation and not turning each story into a statistical description of Galilee.

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[4] Josephus, Ant. XVII.317–320; XVIII.1–4; Pilate's inscription: AE 1963, 104. Tacitus, Ann. XV.44. The epigraphic title and Tacitus's retrospective terminology survive as distinct witnesses. Goodman 2018 provides the general political and religious context.

The imperial cult formed part of the public representation of power in numerous Mediterranean cities. However, its intensity, forms, and relationship with Jewish groups varied. Later Christian resistance to public sacrifice cannot be projected onto the early followers of Jesus as a fully defined legal regime. Provincial history helps explain why a movement born in Judea could be perceived differently in Corinth, Rome, or Bithynia.

1.2. The Temple and the transformations of 70 and 135

The Temple in Jerusalem was a centre of worship, pilgrimage, authority, and resources. Its importance does not mean that all of Judaism was limited to the priestly institution. Diaspora communities, domestic practices, the reading of Scripture and local meeting places all belonged to a plural religious world that maintained different relationships with Jerusalem. The Theodotus inscription shows, within the city itself, the combination of reading of the Law, teaching and hospitality without displacing the sacrificial function of the Temple.

The war of 66–73 and the destruction of the sanctuary in 70 radically altered this organisation. Josephus is an indispensable source, but he wrote from a position committed to his own justification and to the Flavian dynasty. His account must be compared with archaeology and epigraphy. The *Iudaea capta* coins, issued in various denominations and types, document the imperial celebration of the victory. On them, the vanquished personification and military attributes construct a message of domination, not a neutral description of the experience of the inhabitants of Judea.[5]

The coinage obliges us to separate three levels: the military event, its propaganda, and its subsequent reception. The fact that the destruction of the Temple fostered new Jewish and Christian formulations does not demonstrate an immediate separation between two religions. Nor does the lament or theological interpretation of the catastrophe establish an identical reaction in all communities. Christian writings after 70 CE must be analysed according to their location, probable date, and literary strategy.

The Bar Kokhba revolt, between 132 and 135, brought about another transformation. The consequences of the reorganisation of Jerusalem as Aelia Capitolina are known through uneven documentation and later sources. For Christian history, it is

[5] Josephus, BJ VI.249–266 and VI.316–322. For the numismatic type, British Museum, record C_R-6540, RIC II.1, Vespasian 159: `https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/C_R-6540`. The catalogue verifies the type; it does not identify the specimens in the provided photograph.



FIGURE 3. Comparative composition of coin obverses and reverses associated with Vespasian and the Iudaea capta repertoire, prepared for this edition as a comparative plate. Individual specimen identifications are not declared on the plate; the catalogued specimen in Figure 4 provides the numismatic control. [ED].

especially relevant to distinguish between the chronology of this reorganisation, accounts of community authorities, and the retrospective interpretation of a religious rupture. The list of Jerusalem leaders preserved by Eusebius, HE IV.5, is a source for the ecclesiastical memory of the process; it does not constitute a complete contemporary local archive.

The tradition concerning a flight of believers to Pella before the war is examined with the same caution. Eusebius, HE III.5.3, preserves the account centuries after the events. Its value as testimony to a tradition does not warrant treating it as direct proof of a precisely dated collective migration. Nor does the absence of contemporary confirmation prove that the account is fictitious. What can be established historically



FIGURE 4. Additional numismatic comparison: Vespasian coin of the Iudaea capta type, c. 70 CE, Valkhof Museum, Nijmegen, according to Livius's record. Photograph by Marco Prins, CCo. The type celebrates imperial victory and must be interpreted within its minting context; it does not identify a Christian community. Inventory not recorded in the consulted record. [FAC; ED].

is more limited: in Late Antiquity, a collective memory circulated that explained the preservation of the community through a displacement and a religious warning.[6]

1.3. Multilingualism, diglossia and transmission

The linguistic landscape of Judea and Galilee in the first century was multilingual. Aramaic held a central place in everyday communication and in various Jewish spheres; Hebrew continued to be used in scriptural, liturgical, and documentary contexts; and Greek served as the language of administration, commerce, mobility, and written culture across large areas of the eastern Mediterranean. The exact proportion

[6] Eusebius, HE III.5.3; IV.5.1–4. The dating of the transmitting source differs from that of the events recounted. The account of Pella is presented as a tradition, without a contemporary document that would allow the migration to be dated.

of speakers and the social uses of each language varied by region, class, occupation, and communicative situation.

This plurality necessitates a distinction between the probable language of certain historical interactions and the language of the surviving documents. The Christian corpus of the first century that has come down to us is written in Greek. This does not prove that all previous preaching, teaching, or memory circulated exclusively in Greek. It does, however, demonstrate that when the traditions reached the literary form in which they were widely transmitted throughout the Mediterranean, Greek became the principal written medium to survive.

The transition between multilingual orality and Greek writing should not be represented as a single act of translation. It included reformulation, vocabulary selection, adaptation to Greek scriptural repertoires, and circulation among different communities. Therefore, terms such as Χριστός, κύριος, ἐκκλησία, or εὐαγγέλιον must be studied simultaneously as Greek vocabulary and as ways of expressing traditions rooted in Jewish Scripture and practice.

1.4. Textual ecology in the first half of the first century: Scriptures, archives and orality before Paul

The first half of the first century CE must be reconstructed as a multilingual ecology of texts, memories and reading practices, not as a landscape governed by a closed canon in the later sense. For the Jesus movement, moreover, the documentary situation is especially asymmetrical: before the Pauline epistles, we do not possess a securely identifiable Christian written corpus. This does not imply an absence of stable formulations. Traditions of sayings, passion narratives, formulas of faith, hymns, confessions, and scriptural arguments could have circulated orally or on media now lost; some of these units appear to have been incorporated later into letters and gospels. The historian must therefore distinguish between texts actually preserved from the period, works whose composition can be placed at that time, and traditions whose early existence can only be inferred retrospectively.

The immediate textual framework of Jesus and his first followers was Jewish. In Judea and Galilee, Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek coexisted, each with different functions depending on the region, institution, education, and type of document. The liturgical reading of Scripture, oral interpretation, the copying of scrolls, documentary production, and everyday communication were not evenly distributed among these languages. The diaspora added even greater diversity: in Alexandria, Asia Minor, Syria, Rome, and other urban centres, Greek played a decisive role in the trans-

mission of Scripture and in the articulation of Jewish identities within the Hellenistic and Roman world.

1.4.1. The Scriptures of Israel: authority without a "canon" identical to the later one

The Torah held an exceptional normative position, and the Prophets possessed widely recognised authority; the body of Writings, however, should not be described as if its scope and status were fixed in the same way as the medieval Masoretic canon. The Judean Desert manuscripts simultaneously demonstrate stability, textual plurality, and a diversity of repertoires. During this period, Hebrew forms of biblical books circulated that did not always coincide word for word with the later Masoretic text, along with Greek translations and parabiblical compositions that could function as Scripture or as authoritative interpretations within certain groups.

Aramaic was also part of this ecology. Daniel 2:4b–7:28 and Ezra 4:8–6:18; 7:12–26 contain extensive Aramaic passages; Jeremiah 10:11 preserves a short Aramaic phrase. In addition, there is a large body of extra-biblical Aramaic production documented at Qumran. The existence of Targumic practices of oral translation and interpretation is historically plausible, but this should not be confused with the early dating of the complete literary forms of the Targums that we know from later manuscripts.

1.4.2. The Septuagint and the Greek Scriptures of the Diaspora

The Greek translations of the Scriptures of Israel, conventionally grouped under the name Septuagint, form one of the fundamental archives for understanding Hellenistic Judaism and, subsequently, the scriptural language of Greek-speaking Christians. This was not a single, uniform edition comparable to a modern printed Bible: different books show distinct histories of translation, revision, and transmission. By the first century CE, however, a broad repertoire of Jewish Scriptures in Greek existed, used in diaspora contexts and also known in Palestine.

Alongside translations of books that would later become part of the Hebrew canon, the Greek tradition transmitted works such as Tobit, Judith, Wisdom of Solomon, Sirach, and 1–2 Maccabees. Their presence in later Christian manuscript traditions does not warrant the retrospective reconstruction of a single "Septuagint Bible" finalised in the year 30. It does, however, demonstrate that the textual world available to Hellenised Jews and early Christians was broader than the modern opposition between "canonical" and "apocryphal."

1.4.3. Qumran and the Jewish literature of the Second Temple

The manuscripts found at Qumran and other sites in the Judean Desert offer an exceptional sample of contemporary textual diversity, although they should not be automatically confused with the books that "all Palestine read". They document what was copied, preserved, and used by specific communities and, in some cases, preserve works known beyond that context. Among the sectarian and para-sectarian texts are the Community Rule (1QS), the Damascus Document (CD), the War Scroll (1QM), the Hodayot or Hymns ($1QH^a$), and various pesharim. The archive also includes numerous biblical copies and parabiblical compositions.

Aramaic production occupies a prominent place: the Genesis Apocryphon (1QapGen), fragments of 1 Enoch, the Book of Giants, and other texts reveal a literary landscape in which biblical rewriting, revelation, interpretation of patriarchal figures, and eschatological speculation could coexist. This plurality is crucial for contextualising early Christianity, but it does not justify direct genealogies between Qumran and Jesus without an independent chain of evidence.

1.4.4. Jewish works widely known in, or relevant to, the period

The modern expression "pseudepigrapha and apocrypha" is useful as a bibliographical classification, but it projects later boundaries onto a period in which the categories of authorship, authority, and corpus were more flexible. For the first half of the first century, a distinction must be made between works whose existence is directly attested, others whose composition is earlier but whose geographical circulation cannot be quantified, and texts whose final form is later than 70 CE.

Table 6. Textual ecology of the first century: texts and corpora

Text / corpus	**Language(s)**	**Status for 1–50 CE**	**Historiographical caution**
1 Enoch (collections)	Aramaic; Greek translations	Attested at Qumran; wider circulation likely	Work composed of layers; do not treat as a single book with a single date.
Jubilees	Hebrew	Well attested at Qumran	Important for calendars, rewriting of Genesis–Exodus and halakha.

(continued)

Text / corpus	Language(s)	Status for 1–50 CE	Historiographical caution
Tobit	Aramaic and Hebrew; Greek in later transmission	Attested at Qumran	It shows circulation in more than one language and different textual forms.
Ben Sira / Sirach	Hebrew; Greek translation	Wide Jewish reception	The Greek translation was made by the author's grandson before the Roman period.
Wisdom of Solomon	Greek	Probably Alexandrian; relevant to Hellenistic Judaism	Debated dating between the end of the Hellenistic period and the beginning of the Roman period.
1 Maccabees	Probably a Hebrew original; preserved in Greek	Known in Jewish and later Christian tradition	Do not infer uniform diffusion solely from its subsequent preservation.
2 Maccabees	Greek	Hellenistic/Roman circulation	Epitome of a work by Jason of Cyrene; martyrdom and Temple theology.
Letter of Aristeas	Greek	Known in Hellenistic Judaism	Literary account of the origin of the Greek translation of the Pentateuch.
Testaments of the Twelve Patriarchs	Greek; possible Semitic traditions	Uncertain status for 1–50 CE	The transmitted form contains dating problems and possible Christian reworkings.
4 Esdras and 2 Baruch	Hypothetical Semitic original behind preserved versions	Do not include as texts in circulation before 50	Their known forms respond to the crisis following the destruction of 70.

1.4.5. Philo, Hellenistic Jewish authors and Greco-Roman literary culture

Philo of Alexandria belongs entirely to this first half of the first century and constitutes a privileged source for observing how a Greek-speaking Jewish intellectual could read the Pentateuch using tools of allegorical exegesis, Hellenistic philosophy, and the political categories of the Roman world. Works such as *De opificio mundi*, *Legum allegoriae*, *De vita Mosis*, *De specialibus legibus*, and De migratione Abrahami show that Scripture could become the object of a sophisticated literary culture while still functioning as a core element of Jewish identity. The exact dating of each treatise and its circulation must be addressed on a work-by-work basis.

Also circulating, with varying degrees of dissemination, were compositions by earlier Hellenistic Jewish authors, now preserved only in fragments, such as Ezekiel the Tragedian, Artapanus, and other authors transmitted by later compilers. Their existence reminds us that Jewish production in Greek was not limited to biblical translations. In cities of the diaspora and among educated sectors of Palestine, this literature coexisted with Homer, historians, rhetoric, popular philosophy, and administrative documents in Greek and, in certain circles, Latin.

1.4.6. Before Paul: orality, formulas and absence of a preserved Christian corpus

For the years c. 30–50 CE, still greater caution is needed. We possess no Christian manuscripts that can be reliably dated to those decades, nor any complete Christian work predating the undisputed Pauline epistles. The Jesus movement, in its first generation, was fundamentally oral in the production and circulation of its memory: proclamation, teaching, scriptural debate, stories about Jesus, prophecy, prayer, and ritual formulas. Orality, however, does not preclude the use of auxiliary writing, lost letters, collections of quotations, lists, or notes; it simply does not warrant treating them as preserved documents.

Paul's letters preserve material that many scholars consider to predate the epistolary composition itself—for example, confessional or traditional formulations in 1 Corinthians 15:3–5, Romans 1:3–4, and Philippians 2:6–11—but their scope, original form, and dating are debated. Therefore, they should be described as pre-Pauline traditions proposed by literary analysis, not as recovered independent manuscripts. This point is crucial to avoid a double anachronism: imagining, on the one hand, a Christianity without texts or Scriptures and, on the other, projecting onto the 30s a Christian library similar to that of the second century.

1.4.7. Linguistic and geographical synthesis

In general terms, Hebrew held a central place in the copying and study of the Scriptures and in certain religious texts of Judea; Aramaic was a crucial language for communication and Jewish literary production; Greek served a large part of the diaspora and also functioned in cities and administrative circles in Palestine. These functions overlapped. It is not appropriate to assign a single language to "Palestine" and another to "the diaspora," but rather to reconstruct specific communities, levels of literacy, genres, and media.

TABLE 7. Languages of the first-century textual ecology

Language	Documentary examples	Approximate function
Hebrew	Torah and other biblical books; Jubilees; Ben Sira; Qumran texts	High relevance in Judea; not exclusive
Aramaic	Daniel/Ezra in part; 1 Enoch in part; Genesis Apocryphon; other Qumran texts	Language of communication and of Jewish literary production
Greek	LXX; Wisdom; 2 Maccabees; Philo; Letter of Aristeas	Central in the diaspora and also present in Hellenised Palestine
Latin	Administration and imperial presence; lesser weight in the preserved Jewish literature of the area	Unequal institutional relevance depending on region and context

1.4.8. The Latin horizon: literature, administration and education in the first century

Latin was part of the written landscape of the first century, but its importance varied drastically depending on the region and function. In Italy and large areas of the Roman West, it was the language of administration, law, the army, education, and literary production; in the eastern Mediterranean, however, Greek continued to be the main language of written communication, urban culture, and often even of interaction with the imperial administration. Therefore, reconstructing the textual world in which Christianity arose requires recognising the presence of Latin without mechanically transferring to the East a linguistic hierarchy specific to Rome or the western provinces.

In the first half of the first century, numerous authors from the Republic and the Augustan period remained fundamental. Cicero served as a model of prose, oratory, and philosophical argumentation; Caesar and Sallust continued to be historiographi-

cal and educational references; Lucretius represented a Latin exposition of Epicurean philosophy; and the poetry of Virgil, Horace, and Ovid occupied a central place in the literary culture of the elites. Livy offered a monumental narrative of Roman history. The circulation of these works should not be expressed through modern "most-read" rankings, which are difficult to quantify, but rather through evidence of copying, quotation, imitation, school curriculum, and literary reception.

The first century itself produced authors who document the evolution of this written culture: Seneca the Elder preserved repertoires of declamation; Seneca the Younger produced dialogues, moral treatises, epistles, and tragedies; Phaedrus adapted the fable to Latin; Persius cultivated satire, which Juvenal would extend into the early second century; Lucan reworked the civil war in epic form; Petronius offers a unique testimony of narrative prose and social culture; Pliny the Elder compiled the Natural History; Quintilian systematised rhetorical education; and Martial, Statius, Valerius Flaccus, and Silius Italicus document the density of the Flavian literary field. Tacitus begins his preserved production towards the end of the century, so his usefulness in contextualising nascent Christianity lies both in the political culture he describes and in his later testimony about Nero and the christiani.

The relevance of this literature to a history of Christian origins is contextual, not genealogical. Paul and the earliest surviving Christian authors wrote in Greek, and there is no basis for postulating direct dependencies on Virgil, Seneca, or Cicero without specific textual evidence. Nevertheless, the Roman educational system, rhetoric, legal categories, administrative vocabulary, and Latin literary genres were part of the imperial environment in which communities moved, were classified, and subsequently began to produce literature in Latin. At the end of the second century and during the third, when significant Latin Christian authors such as Tertullian appeared, this interaction became much more evident in the documentation.

Table 8. First-century authors and corpora

Author / corpus	**Chronology and representative works**	**Type of presence in the first century**	**Historical caution**
Cicero	First century BCE; speeches, De officiis, De natura deorum, letters	Model of prose, oratory and philosophy; educational and rhetorical use	Do not turn school influence into direct Christian dependence.
Caesar and Sallust	First century BCE; Bellum Gallicum, Bellum civile; Catilina, Iugurtha	Reference historiography and prose	Variable regional and school diffusion

(continued)

Author / corpus	Chronology and representative works	Type of presence in the first century	Historical caution
Lucretius	De rerum natura	Epicureanism in the Latin language and didactic poetry	Uneven reception; avoid generalising its reading
Virgil	Bucolicae, Georgica, Aeneis	Exceptional literary prestige and strong educational reception	Cultural centrality does not imply reading by early Christian communities
Horace and Ovid	Odes, Epistles, Ars poetica; Metamorphoses, Fasti, Tristia	Augustan poetry, education and elite culture	Distinguish literary reception from popular circulation
Livy	Ab urbe condita	Historical memory of Rome	Partial preservation and circulation by books/decades
Seneca the Younger	Dialogues, Epistulae morales, tragedies	Moral philosophy and Julio-Claudian literature	The alleged personal relationships with Paul belong to a later pseudepigraphical tradition
Lucan, Persius, Petronius	Bellum civile; Saturae; Satyrica	Neronian production and diversity of genres	Different chronology and audiences; do not treat them as a unified corpus
Pliny the Elder	Naturalis historia, 77–79 CE	Encyclopedism and technical culture of the Flavian era	It belongs to the second half of the century
Quintilian	Institutio oratoria, c. 95 CE	A privileged account of curriculum, reading, and rhetorical training	Late source for reconstructing educational habits of the first century
Martial, Statius, Valerius Flaccus, Silius Italicus	Flavian poetry	Urban literary field of the late first century	Do not extrapolate its audience to the Eastern Mediterranean

Tacitus	Agricola, Germania; Histories from the end of the first century	Senatorial historiography; later testimony about Nero	Annales XV.44 is a source from the beginning of the second century about events in 64

Sources and bibliography for the Latin horizon: Quintilian, Institutio oratoria, especially Book X, as ancient evidence of author selection and evaluation; Cicero, Caesar, Sallust, Lucretius, Virgil, Horace, Ovid, Livy, Seneca, Pliny, and Tacitus according to critical editions; William A. Johnson and Holt N. Parker (eds.), Ancient Literacies; William A. Johnson, Readers and Reading Culture in the High Roman Empire; works on education, books, and Roman written culture used with chronological caution. For the Roman East, Latin documentation should always be contrasted with the functional predominance of Greek in inscriptions, papyri, and urban communication.

Sources and reference bibliography: Emanuel Tov, Textual Criticism of the Hebrew Bible; Eugene Ulrich, The Dead Sea Scrolls and the Origins of the Bible; James C. VanderKam and Peter Flint, The Meaning of the Dead Sea Scrolls; John J. Collins, The Apocalyptic Imagination; George W.E. Nickelsburg, 1 Enoch; Martin Goodman, A History of Judaism; Timothy H. Lim, The Formation of the Jewish Canon; Philo of Alexandria, treatise by treatise according to critical edition; Septuagint according to Göttingen or specific critical editions by book. For the proposed pre-Pauline Christian literature, each formula must be discussed locus by locus and not transformed into an independent document without manuscript proof.

1.5. Qumran and the sectarian diversity of Second Temple Judaism

The Dead Sea Scrolls are indispensable for contextualising the diversity of Jewish life before and during the time of Jesus' first followers. The Community Rule (1QS) and the Damascus Document (CD) show communities that reinterpreted the Torah, regulated admission, purity, discipline, and communal life, and situated their existence within an intense eschatological expectation.

These documents should not be used as "sources of Christianity" in a genealogical sense. Their importance is comparative and contextual: they demonstrate that the formation of groups with strong identities, internal rules, sectarian readings of Scripture, and expectations about the end times was not unique to Christianity. They also prevent categories such as sect, purity, or eschatology from being defined exclusively based on the New Testament.

John J. Collins's research has also insisted that the movement represented by the sectarian texts should not be reduced solely to the archaeological site of Qumran. This distinction between corpus, movement, and site offers a useful methodological parallel for the study of early Christianity itself: the texts should not be automatically confused with a single, identifiable social community.[7]

1.6. Philo and the Judaism of the Diaspora

First-century Judaism cannot be reconstructed solely from Jerusalem. Philo of Alexandria testifies to a Jewish milieu deeply integrated into Greek language and intellectual forms without abandoning the centrality of the Scriptures of Israel. Works such as Legatio ad Gaium illuminate questions of citizenship, imperial cult, and communal conflict, while De vita contemplativa documents an early representation of ascetic and exegetical life.

Philo's importance to this monograph does not lie in making him a direct source for Paul or the Gospels. His value lies in showing that allegorical interpretation, the philosophical use of the vocabulary of λόγος, and dialogue with Hellenic categories were part of Jewish possibilities prior to the Christian expansion. Contact between Judaism and Greek culture did not begin with Paul.[8]

1.7. The Septuagint as an archive of interpretation

The term Septuagint or LXX does not designate a homogeneous translation produced all at once. The Greek translation of the Torah is linked to Hellenistic Judaism in Alexandria; other writings were translated, revised, and transmitted in different processes. The great later Christian Bibles bring together materials whose history predates that codicological form. Therefore, "the Septuagint" can refer to a translation tradition, a modern edition, or the content of a particular codex: these are not equivalent.

To study a Christian quotation, one must first identify the passage and then compare the Hebrew form, relevant Greek versions, and the reformulation introduced by the author. A verbal match with the Greek may demonstrate the use of a Greek scriptural tradition; it does not guarantee that the writer possessed the same set of books or the same text as a current edition. Paul, the evangelists, and second-century

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[7] 1QS V.1–13; VI.1–23; CD VI.11–VII.9. Reference edition: García Martínez and Tigchelaar 1997–1998. The divisions by column and line allow the document to be located, but do not demonstrate a direct institutional genealogy with the Christian communities.

[8] Philo, Contempl. 1–3 and 64–90; Legat. 132–139. Reference edition: Cohn and Wendland, Philonis Alexandrini opera quae supersunt. The comparison refers to documented uses and contexts.

authors could quote from memory, combine passages, or adapt the syntax to their argument.[9]

The reading of Scripture was a practice of meaning-making. The use of words like κύριος, νόμος, or διαθήκη drew on pre-Christian Greek-speaking Jewish traditions, even though their Christian contexts introduced new referents and associations. Philological analysis can describe these operations without postulating a complete doctrine behind each word. To do so, it must distinguish between lexical equivalence, explicit quotation, probable allusion, and subsequent interpretation.

The transmission of the divine name also requires a material approach. Jewish and Christian Greek manuscripts present diverse solutions: Hebrew characters, specific palaeographic forms, transliterations, or substitutions. Representations of the Tetragrammaton do not, in themselves, constitute mathematical equivalences or architectural codes. A historical reading identifies the manuscript, the hand, the support, and the function of the script. Interpretations that visually relate letters from different alphabets do not replace this investigation.

The result is a history of written and communal reception. The authority of the Scriptures of Israel did not depend solely on possessing a text: it involved reading it, translating it, memorising it, and debating it. The controversies surrounding Marcion and the arguments of Justin or Irenaeus are better understood within this history than through the opposition between a supposed original Jewish book and an entirely new Christian book.

1.7.1. Comparative matrix of scriptural corpora: Tanakh, Greek traditions and Christian Old Testaments

The following comparison does not assume that four closed "Bibles", equivalent to modern editions, existed in the first century. Its purpose is to show why "Scripture" in Paul, the Gospels and second-century authors cannot automatically be identified with the medieval Masoretic order or a modern confessional Old Testament.

[9] Reference edition: Rahlfs and Hanhart 2006, Septuaginta. For the problem of quotations, see Gal 3:6–14 and Rom 9:25–29; coincidences are assessed by passage, without equating the repertoire of an ancient writer with a modern edition.

TABLE 9. The Septuagint and other scriptural traditions: corpus and transmission

Corpus / tradition	Structure or order	Distinctive books / problems	Date / status	Historical use
Hebrew Tanakh	Torah–Nevi'im–Ketuvim	24 books in later Jewish reckoning; different order from the Christian Old Testament	Prolonged delimitation; later Masoretic tradition	Verification against the Hebrew textual tradition; not a closed codex from the year 30.
Septuagint / Greek traditions	Variable order depending on the book and codex	Tobit, Judith, Wisdom, Sirach, 1–4 Maccabees and others according to testimony	Translations and revisions from the Hellenistic period	Key to Christian Greek scriptural citations and language.
Protestant Old Testament	39 books; Christian order	Content equivalent to the Hebrew canon with a different division	Modern Western configuration	Do not use as a retroactive map of the first century.
Catholic Old Testament	Pentateuch, historical, wisdom, prophets	It includes deuterocanonical books	Long-term ecclesial reception	Distinguish from ancient textual plurality.
Orthodox Old Testament	Variable regional settings	It may include 3 Maccabees, Psalm 151, and others	There is no single Orthodox repertoire	Reception history, not reconstruction of the first century.
Other Jewish writings from the Second Temple	Modern collections of non-canonical texts	1 Enoch, Jubilees, Testaments, 4QMMT, 1QS, CD, Psalms of Solomon, etc.	Third century BCE–first/second century CE according to work	Exegetical, legal, apocalyptic, and sectarian diversity.
Early rabbinic literature	Mishnah, Tosefta, tannaitic midrashim	Stratified legal and exegetical traditions	Redaction from c. 200 onwards	Cautious comparison; not a direct mirror of the first century.

1.8. Theodotus and the Jewish spaces of reading and hospitality

The Inscription of Theodotus, found in Jerusalem, is a document independent of the New Testament. It describes the construction of a synagogue for the reading of the Law and the teaching of the commandments, along with facilities intended to accommodate people arriving from elsewhere. Its importance lies in showing that assembly, instruction, and hospitality could be integrated into a single Jewish institutional project. A pre-70 date has been defended in detail by John S. Kloppenborg, "Dating Theodotos (CIJ II 1404)," Journal of Jewish Studies 51 (2000): 243–280, against proposals for a later date.[10]

Documentary Window: Theodotus

Table 10. Documentary window: Theodotus

Field	Identification and scope
Document	Inscription of Theodotus, son of Vettenos.
Corpus	CIJ II 1404; historical inventory S 842.
Origin	Jerusalem; excavations of Raymond Weill, 1913.
Writing material and language	Limestone plaque; ten lines in Greek.
Dating	Usually earlier than 70; the discussion depends on the context of the find and the palaeography.
Genre	Dedication of a synagogue complex and hospitality facilities.
Presentation status	Selective semi-diplomatic transcription from the published edition; not a new autopsy of the stone.

Access to the evidence: [ED]. Selected Greek text (lines 1–5, with editorial restorations): ΘΕΟΔΟΤΟΣ ΟΥΕΤΤΗΝΟΥ ΙΕΡΕΥΣ ΚΑΙ ΑΡΧΙΣΥΝΑΓΩΓΟΣ … ΩΚΟΔΟΜΗΣΕ ΤΗΝ ΣΥΝΑΓΩΓ[Η]Ν ΕΙΣ ΑΝ[ΑΓ]ΝΩΣ[ΙΝ] ΝΟΜΟΥ

[10] Frey, CIJ II 1404. Presentation of the document and its restitutions: K. C. Hanson, Theodotus Inscription, `https://www.kchanson.com/ANCDOCS/greek/theodotus.html`. The synagogue context is analysed by its functions and not by an unproven identification with buildings in the Acts narrative.

ΚΑΙ ΕΙΣ [Δ]ΙΔΑΧ[Η]Ν ΕΝΤΟΛΩΝ. This semi-diplomatic transcription is provided for reference; it does not replace a diplomatic epigraphic edition.

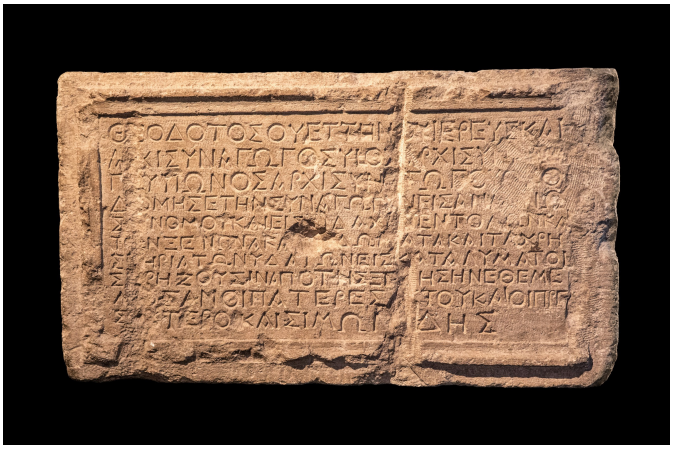


FIGURE 5. Inscription of Theodotus, CIJ II 1404, found in Jerusalem in 1913; Herodian period, date disputed. The Greek mentions reading the Law, teaching, hospitality, and water provision. Photograph of the object on display at the Israel Museum, Andrey Zeigarnik, 2019, CC BY-SA 2.0. [IMG-HR; ED].

The phrase *τὴν συναγωγ[ὴ]ν εἰς ἀν[άγ]νωσ[ιν] νόμου* means "the synagogue for the reading of the Law". Square brackets mark editorial restorations; accents and word division have been normalised. Only a passage from the edited text is cited, without reproducing a line arrangement that has not been checked here against the original.

The title *ἀρχισυνάγωγος*, "head of the synagogue", appears linked to the dedicator and members of his family. The inscription allows for the study of family history, office, and benefaction, but it does not prove that all synagogue offices were hereditary. Nor does it authorise the identification of the building with a synagogue mentioned in Acts. The functional similarity to later Christian networks can be used to compare forms of reading and hospitality; it does not demonstrate a direct transfer of an architectural programme.

1.9. Yavne, Rabbinic Judaism and the problem of the "separations"

Reconstructing the relationship between Judaism and Christianity after the destruction of the Temple requires abandoning two schemes that long dominated historiography: the idea of an instantaneous break in 70 CE and the image of a "Yavne Academy" that supposedly reorganised Judaism uniformly and simultaneously expelled Jesus' followers from the synagogues. Contemporary research tends to describe a longer process, regionally uneven and only fragmentarily documented.

Rabbinic evidence must be treated according to its own chronology. The Mishnah was compiled around the beginning of the third century and preserves traditions of varying antiquity; the Tosefta and the Talmuds are even later. None of these corpora can be read, without qualification, as a direct record of Jewish institutions from the last third of the first century. The same is true, in reverse, for Christian literature: Matthew, John, Acts, Ignatius, and Justin do not describe a uniform relationship with "Judaism," but rather situated controversies, identity constructions, and different rhetorical strategies.

Yavne—ancient Jamnia—was undoubtedly a significant place for certain sages after 70 CE, but the reconstruction of a formal council that would have definitively established the Hebrew canon and decreed a general exclusion of Christians lacks sufficient documentary support. The so-called birkat ha-minim presents a similar problem. Rabbinic sources attest formulae directed against groups considered deviant, but the identification of minim exclusively with Christians and the uniform dating of a centralised measure are hypotheses that must be argued on a case-by-case basis. The studies of Shaye J. D. Cohen, "The Significance of Yavneh: Pharisees, Rabbis, and the End of Jewish Sectarianism" (Hebrew Union College Annual 55, 1984), and Reuven Kimelman, "Birkat Ha-Minim and the Lack of Evidence for an Anti-Christian Jewish Prayer in Late Antiquity" (1981), set the terms of this revision.

For the history of early Christianity, the consequence is methodological. The expression "parting of the ways" is useful only if understood as a metaphor for multiple processes and not as a single event. In some cities, followers of Jesus and other Jews were able to continue sharing spaces, Scriptures, family networks, and practices for decades; in others, tensions may have taken on an exclusionary character sooner. Geography, social composition, and local history matter as much as doctrinal formulations.

Paul's letters show that controversies about circumcision, table fellowship and belonging to Israel existed long before 70 CE, but they do not prove the existence of two completely separate religions. Galatians 2, Romans 9–11, and Philippians 3 should be

read as the interventions of a Jew convinced of a mission to the nations, not as retrospective treatises on a Church already detached from Judaism. The literature of the late first and second centuries, on the other hand, documents a growing process of discursive differentiation. This differentiation was not linear: the most intense polemics may be precisely an indication of social proximity and competition for texts, traditions, and legitimacy.

The destruction of the Temple decisively altered the horizon for all Jewish groups, but its effects varied. For the followers of Jesus, the Temple traditions could be reinterpreted Christologically; for other Jews, the Torah, prayer, the synagogue, and domestic practices took on new forms. This process should not be described as if a fully established rabbinic Judaism immediately replaced a Temple religion while, in parallel, an equally established Christianity separated from it. Both institutional formations emerged only gradually.

This approach also allows for a more precise treatment of so-called "Jewish Christians". The category encompasses heterogeneous phenomena: communities that combined confession of Jesus and observance of the Torah, gospel traditions transmitted in Jewish environments, groups later labelled as Ebionites or Nazarenes, and heresiological accounts produced by adversaries. The label should not be projected backward as if it designated a unified Church of the first century. Each testimony must be dated, located, and evaluated according to its genre.

Accordingly, the analysis employs the terms "differentiation", "demarcation", and "separations" in the plural. The aim is not to identify a single moment at which an independent religion was "born", but to reconstruct the processes by which particular communities defined authority, Scripture, practice, ethnicity, and apostolic memory. This approach does not deny real processes of separation; it places them within a more complex and documentable chronology.

Sources and reference bibliography: Mishnah and Tosefta, treated according to the critical edition; Gospels of Matthew and John; Acts; Galatians and Romans; Ignatius of Antioch; Justin Martyr. For the modern discussion, see J.D.G. Dunn, *The Partings of the Ways*; Judith M. Lieu, *Neither Jew nor Greek?*; Paula Fredriksen, *Paul: The Pagans' Apostle*. These references serve as a check on the reconstruction.

1.10. Egypt, Exodus and Akhenaten: a historical comparison without speculative genealogies

Egypt, the Hyksos, the Exodus, and Akhenaten require a comparison grounded in the history of traditions, with careful consideration of chronology, language, and transmission. This context remains subordinate to the core of the work, the formation of Christianity: the first Christians read the Scriptures of Israel and inherited narratives whose literary form is linked to memories of Egypt. General similarities and speculative etymologies are insufficient to establish a direct historical genealogy.

The Second Intermediate Period and the presence of Asiatic populations in the eastern delta constitute an archaeological field independent of the biblical narrative of the Exodus. Avaris/Tell el-Dab'a documents dynamics of migration, settlement, and political power that help reconstruct Egypt in the second millennium BCE; however, it does not demonstrate the historicity of the Exodus nor does it allow for the direct identification of the Hyksos with Israel. The similarity between an episode of expulsion and a tradition of departure is insufficient to establish historical identity.

Ancient historiography already established associations between Hyksos, Jews, and accounts of expulsion. Josephus, in Against Apion, preserves and debates traditions attributed to Manetho. This material is important because it shows how, in Hellenistic and Roman times, Egypt could become a stage for identity disputes and conflicting memories. Its value for our topic lies in the reception and reformulation of traditions, not in using Josephus as a direct witness to the second millennium BCE.

The figure of Akhenaten requires similar caution. Atenism was a specific religious reform of the 18th Dynasty and must be studied through inscriptions, hymns, monuments, and the archaeology of Amarna. The old hypothesis of a simple genealogical relationship between Akhenaten, Moses, and biblical monotheism belongs to an intellectual history that can be studied, but should not be presented as a historical conclusion. The chronological, institutional, ritual, and theological differences are too great to substitute a general analogy for proof of transmission.

The comparison between the Great Hymn to Aten and Psalm 104, however, deserves a controlled philological treatment. Thematic similarities exist in the celebration of cosmic order, light, the cycles of nature, and the dependence of living beings on the divine. But the analysis must distinguish motifs widely disseminated in the hymnography of the ancient Near East from demonstrable literary borrowings. A similarity of imagery does not in itself establish textual contact, and differences in theological structure are as important as parallels.

Wisdom literature offers another, more productive field of comparison. The Instruction of Amenemope and Proverbs 22:17–24:22 have been the subject of philological discussion because they present more precise correspondences of form and content than broad symbolic analogies. This type of case shows what it means to argue responsibly for a literary relationship: sequences, vocabulary, structure, and chronology are compared, and plausible routes of transmission are evaluated.

For the history of Christianity, these problems matter because Christian authors inherited a Bible already shaped by centuries of cultural interaction. Matthew reinterprets the Exodus from Egypt; Paul uses traditions from the Exodus typologically; the Fathers develop readings of the sea, the manna, and the desert in baptismal, ecclesial, or ascetic terms. The scholarly interest lies not in making Egypt the "hidden origin" of Christianity, but in understanding how a scriptural tradition with a long history of contact was reread in new contexts.

Accordingly, Egypt is approached in three carefully delimited ways: as historical context for the biblical world; as a field for the history of traditions and controlled philological comparison; and as a setting for the Christian reception of scriptural motifs. Undocumented identity equations—Hyksos = Hebrews, Akhenaten = Moses, Aten = YHWH, or comparable chains of equivalence—are excluded from the historical argument.

Sources and reference bibliography: Josephus, Against Apion; Amarna texts and the Great Hymn to Aten in Egyptological editions; Psalm 104; Proverbs 22–24; Manfred Bietak on Tell el-Dabʿa / Avaris; Jan Assmann, Of God and Gods; Donald B. Redford, Egypt, Canaan, and Israel in Ancient Times; Miriam Lichtheim, Ancient Egyptian Literature; Mark S. Smith, God in Translation. These works serve as checks on the reconstruction.

I.II. The Jewish horizon of the Gospels: Temple, synagogue, calendar, purity and commandments

1.11.1. Documentary status and historical method

The Gospels are confessional documents composed and edited several decades after Jesus' public ministry. Their historical value lies at the intersection of memories of earlier practices, literary composition and controversies within the communities that transmitted them. This section distinguishes (a) practices widely attested by Jewish sources and archaeology, (b) debates within Judaism and (c) theological formulations particular to each evangelist.

Comparative verification draws on Josephus, Philo, Judean Desert manuscripts, epigraphy, miqva'ot, stone vessels, early synagogues, and, with explicit stratification, Mishnah, Tosefta, and later rabbinic materials. Late Antique rabbinic halakha is not retrospectively projected onto the first century.

1.11.2. The Temple of Jerusalem: worship, economy and conflict

Luke 2 situates the presentation and purification within the cultic system; Mark 11:15–19, Matthew 21:12–17, Luke 19:45–48, and John 2:13–22 transmit different versions of Jesus' action in the Temple precinct; Mark 13 and parallels rework the horizon of destruction. The money changers presuppose the sacrificial and monetary economy of the sanctuary, but the episode should not be reduced to a modern denunciation of commerce.

Criticism of the Temple has Jewish prophetic antecedents and does not automatically equate to a rejection of the Temple, the Torah, or Israel. The memory of the period after 70 CE intensified the symbolic weight of these narratives; therefore, a distinction must be made between the historical setting and post-70 redaction.

1.11.3. The synagogue—συναγωγή—as a local institution

Mark 1:21–28; 3:1–6; 6:2; Luke 4:16–30; John 6:59 presuppose the synagogue as a space for gathering, reading, teaching, and conflict. Archaeology confirms early synagogue institutions, but not a uniform architecture or liturgy.

John 9:22; 12:42; 16:2 and the term ἀποσυνάγωγος require caution: they may reflect later conflicts of the Johannine communities and do not prove a universal and coordinated expulsion of all believers in Jesus.

1.11.4. Household, table fellowship and commensality

Mark 2:15–17; Luke 7:36–50; 19:1–10 and other scenes depict meals where hospitality, purity, honour, patronage, and belonging are socially negotiated. Commensality creates and represents networks and boundaries; it links to later domestic ἐκκλησίαι without implying a uniform architectural model.

1.11.5. Jewish calendar and ritual temporality

פֶּסַח (pesaḥ) / *πάσχα* structures the passion narratives. The Synoptics and John present a different chronological relationship between the last meal and the Passover preparation; the divergence remains a problem. John also articulates episodes around סֻכּוֹת (sukkôt; *σκηνοπηγία*) and חֲנֻכָּה (ḥănukkāh; *ἐγκαίνια*).

Pentecost/Šavuʿot explicitly belongs to the context of Acts 2 and should not be introduced as though it were a festival developed within the four Gospels.

1.11.6. The Sabbath as an intra-Jewish controversy

שַׁבָּת (šabbāt) / *σάββατον* appears in debates concerning ears of grain, healing, necessity and interpretive authority (Mark 2:23–3:6 and parallels). The opposition "Jesus against Jewish law" is historically inadequate: these questions belong within the interpretive diversity of Judaism.

1.11.7. Bodily purity and ritual contamination

Skin conditions, flow of blood, corpses, and cultic reintegration presuppose Levitical categories that must be distinguished from sickness and sin. Mark 1:44 preserves the presentation before the priest; Mark 5:21–43 combines blood and death without turning ritual impurity into moral guilt.

1.11.8. Handwashing, food and Mark 7

Mark 7:1–23 // Matthew 15:1–20 discuss handwashing, purity, and tradition. Mark 7:19 presents difficulties of syntax and narrative voice; it should not be turned, without argument, into a historical decree abolishing Jewish dietary laws wholesale.

1.11.9. Circumcision, identity and belonging

Luke 1:59 and 2:21 present circumcision as a normal practice. The controversy over circumcising Gentiles belongs primarily to Paul and Acts; projecting it onto the entire ministry of Jesus would be an anachronism.

1.11.10. Qorbān, tithes, oaths and vows

קָרְבָּן (qorbān) / *κορβᾶν* in Mark 7:11–13, tithes in Matt 23:23 // Luke 11:42, and oaths in Matt 5 and 23 reveal practices of interpretation and the ordering of normative priorities. Criticism of a particular application does not amount to rejecting the Torah as a whole.

1.11.11. The double commandment: Deuteronomy and Leviticus

Mark 12:28–34 and parallels bring together Deut 6:4–5 and Lev 19:18. The passage shows that the ethics attributed to Jesus are formulated through the selection and ordering of Israel's Scriptures. The שְׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל (Šəmaʿ Yiśrāʾēl) provides a fundamental textual background.

1.11.12. Pharisees—Φαρισαῖοι / פְּרוּשִׁים

The Pharisees of the Gospels do not constitute a uniform bloc, nor are they simply equivalent to later rabbinic Judaism. The intensity of their polemics may express competitive proximity: Sabbath, purity, divorce, resurrection, and commandments are debates within a shared body of knowledge.

1.11.13. Sadducees, scribes, priesthood and Temple aristocracy

Σαδδουκαῖοι, γραμματεῖς, priests and high priests must be differentiated by social and institutional function. Grouping them as mere "religious adversaries" eliminates differences in position, authority and relationship with the Temple. The difference is not only social: according to Josephus (Ant. 13.297; 18.16–17; War 2.165) the Sadducees accepted as binding only what was written and denied the survival of the soul and posthumous rewards, and Mark 12:18–27 and Acts 23:8 present their rejection of the resurrection as the point of friction with the Pharisees and with the Jesus movement. Their positions on purity and on the authority of oral tradition are known only from later and partly hostile sources (rabbinic literature) and must be used with caution.

1.11.14. Tax collectors, "sinners" and social categories

τελῶναι and ἁμαρτωλοί are context-dependent narrative and social categories. Nor can עַם הָאָרֶץ (ʿam hā-ʾāreṣ) be used as an automatic equivalent of "common people" due to its complex semantic and rabbinic history.

1.11.15. Women within the Jewish ritual horizon

Purification after childbirth, bleeding, widowhood, pilgrimage, hospitality, and commensality place women within specific ritual and economic frameworks. The narrative data is qualitative evidence, not social statistics; questions of agency and leadership are addressed in the chapter devoted to them.

1.11.16. Scripture, citation and authority

γέγραπται ("it is written"), νόμος, προφῆται and ψαλμοί show that the Gospels argue from the Scriptures of Israel. A distinction must be made between exact quotation, allusion, echo, and editorial composition. In numerous loci, the quoted form approximates the LXX; in others, the relationship with Hebrew traditions or Greek revisions is more complex.

The Matthean formula "you have heard that it was said… but I say to you" is not interpreted as a simple replacement of the Torah by Christian legislation: it reorders and radicalises commandments within a Jewish exegetical universe, even though Matthean Christology grants Jesus singular authority.

1.11.17. Comparative overview table

TABLE 11. Comparative overview table

Scope	Matthew	Mark	Luke
Temple	Very strong	Strong	Very strong
Synagogue	Present	Present	Very strong
Sabbath	Several	Several	Several
Purity / food	Matt 15	Mark 7	Luke 11:37–41; cf. 10:8
Passover	Passion	Passion	Passion
Sukkôt	—	—	—
Ḥănukkāh	—	—	—
Qorbān	Matt 15	Mark 7	No explicit parallel preserved
Tithes	Matt 23	—	Luke 11:42
Circumcision	—	—	Luke 1–2
Scripture	Very intense	Intense	Very intense
Double commandment	Matt 22	Mark 12	Luke 10

Table 12. Continuation of "Comparative overview table"

Scope	John	Historical-critical observation
Temple	Very strong	Central institution; criticism does not automatically equate to rejection.
Synagogue	Present/controversy	John requires a distinction between narrated time and community context.
Sabbath	Distinctive healing episodes	Internal interpretive debates within Judaism.
Purity / food	John 2:6; 3:25; 18:28	Ritual purity and the table are thematised in different ways; there is no single shared controversy.
Passover	Several Passovers	Chronological divergence between the Synoptics and John.
Sukkôt	John 7–8	Central festival in Johannine architecture.
Ḥănukkāh	John 10:22	Dedication in the Johannine horizon.
Qorbān	No explicit parallel preserved	Vows and family duty.
Tithes	No explicit parallel preserved	Presupposed practice, placed within an ethical hierarchy.
Circumcision	John 7:22–23	Normal practice; the Gentile conflict is later.
Scripture	Very intense	LXX and other forms must be evaluated locus by locus.
Double commandment	—	Deut 6 + Lev 19 within Jewish interpretation.

1.11.18. Synthesis: continuity, controversy and differentiation

The density of Jewish institutions, calendars, ritual practices, forms of scriptural argument and social categories precludes describing the Jesus movement as a religion external to Judaism from its inception. Its controversies must first be analysed within diverse Jewish contexts. The later differentiation between Jewish communities and groups of believers in Jesus was uneven, regional and protracted.

Sources and reference bibliography: canonical gospels; Josephus; Philo; Judean Desert manuscripts; Mishnah and Tosefta according to their own chronology; Lee I. Levine, E.P. Sanders, Paula Fredriksen, Shaye J.D. Cohen, Jonathan Klawans, Jodi Magness, and Steve Mason. Magdala archaeology, miqva'ot, stone vessels, and early synagogues serve as material comparanda.

2. The sources and their unequal chronological value

The evidence for the first decades is fragmentary. We have no contemporary records of the Jerusalem community nor a chronicle written during Jesus' public ministry. Reconstruction depends on documents produced for specific purposes and at different times. To these must be added material culture—inscriptions, coins, built spaces—which should be interrogated as an autonomous body of evidence, not as mere illustration of the texts.

The undisputed Pauline epistles are the primary point of reference for the middle years of the first century. They are not systematic treatises: they respond to specific conflicts and presuppose shared information between author and recipients. Precisely for this reason, they possess extraordinary historical value. When Paul mentions Cephas, James, John, Barnabas, or communities in Judea, he does so incidentally within the context of problems that were not invented to narrate the origins of the movement.

The Acts of the Apostles is later and presents a coherent narrative of expansion from Jerusalem to Rome. Its historical value is considerable, but it must be evaluated episode by episode. Where it can be compared with Paul, agreement corroborates certain data; the differences also reveal the author's literary and theological perspective.

Josephus offers a particularly relevant external point of contact when he mentions the execution of James, "brother of Jesus, called Christ," during the procuratorial interregnum of approximately 62 CE (Josephus, Ant. XX.200 [20.9.1]). This reference does not reconstruct the Jerusalem community, but it confirms that James was

an identifiable figure due to his relationship with Jesus and places his death within a chronological framework independent of Acts.[11]

2.1. External sources: Josephus, Tacitus, Pliny and Suetonius

The reconstruction of Christian origins does not depend exclusively on texts produced by followers of Jesus. A small set of Jewish and Roman testimonies provides external points of comparison for certain facts preserved in Christian traditions. Their value is uneven and requires specific philological scrutiny: some passages are contemporary or nearly contemporary with the events they describe; others transmit later information; and in a key case, the so-called Testimonium Flavianum, textual history compels us to distinguish between a possible Josephian core and added Christian formulations.

The passage in Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64 (18.3.3), traditionally called the Testimonium Flavianum, cannot be used in the form transmitted by medieval manuscripts as if it were a completely independent account. Expressions that present Jesus in a confessional manner, particularly the assertion that he was the Messiah and the reference to his appearance after death, are widely considered Christian interpolations or reworkings. A significant body of scholarship, however, considers it likely that the text preserves a Josephian core concerning Jesus, his ministry, and his execution under Pilate; see, for example, John P. Meier, A Marginal Jew: Rethinking the Historical Jesus, vol. I (1991), ch. 3. The documentary appendix identifies the loci and distinguishes the received text from hypothetical restitutions, without presenting a modern reconstruction as a proven text of Josephus.[12]

Much less problematic is the mention in Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1). In the account of the actions of the high priest Ananus, Josephus identifies James as "brother of Jesus, called Christ." The incidental nature of the expression, its narrative integration, and the absence of confessional language make the passage generally accepted as authentic. Its historical importance lies in providing an external reference to James and in confirming that Jesus could function as an identifying referent within Josephus' account of events in the 60s CE.[13]

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[11] Josephus, Ant. XX.200–203. The identity of James and the episode of Ananus are studied within the framework of the administrative succession narrated by Josephus. Reference edition: Niese.

[12] Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64. The received text is distinguished from hypothetical restitutions; the documentary appendix records the problem. The reference edition is Niese; no variant is attributed to an unverified witness.

[13] Josephus, Ant. XX.197–203, esp. XX.200. The reference edition is Niese. The passage is cited as external testimony to James, not as a source for the activity of Jesus.

Tacitus, Ann. XV.44, written at the beginning of the second century CE, describes the Neronian repression following the fire of Rome in 64 CE and explains that the name of the Christians derived from Christus, executed during the reign of Tiberius by order of Pontius Pilate. The historian calls Pilate procurator, while the Caesarea inscription identifies him as praefectus; this terminological discrepancy does not invalidate the testimony, but it is worth remembering that Tacitus wrote several decades after the events. The passage is particularly relevant for documenting how a Roman senatorial author understood the origin of the group and its presence in Rome.[14]

Pliny the Younger, in Epistulae X.96–97, offers a different kind of testimony. Around 110–113, as governor of Bithynia-Pontus, he consulted Trajan about the legal procedure to follow against people denounced as Christians. Pliny reports that some met before dawn and alternately sang a hymn to Christ quasi deo, "as to a god," in addition to swearing an oath to certain behaviours. The document does not describe a complete liturgy and comes from interrogations conducted by a Roman magistrate; precisely for this reason, it constitutes an exceptional source for the social, ritual, and administrative history of provincial Christianity at the beginning of the second century.[15]

Suetonius, in Claudius 25.4, states that Claudius expelled from Rome the Jews who were causing disturbances, impulsore Chresto ("at the instigation of Chrestus"). The identification of Chrestus with Christus is possible and has often been argued, but it is not certain: Chrestus was also a known name, and the phrase may refer to a person present in Rome. If the passage alludes indirectly to disputes about Christ, it would be an early indication of conflicts within Jewish communities in the capital; if not, it remains evidence of the instability of the Roman diaspora under Claudius. The source should therefore be used as contested evidence, not as unequivocal proof of a fully differentiated Roman Christian community in 49.[16]

Taken together, these external sources do not, on their own, suffice to reconstruct the history of Jesus or the early communities, but they do provide independent points of reference. Josephus contributes to the chronology of James and, more cautiously, to the discussion about Jesus; Tacitus documents the Roman memory of the execu-

[14] Tacitus, Ann. XV.44.2–5. Textual reference: Fisher 1906. The designation procurator is distinguished from the epigraphic documentation of Pilate's office.

[15] Pliny, Ep. X.96.1–9; Trajan's reply, X.97.1–2. Textual reference: Mynors 1963. The correspondence refers to a governor's inquiry and not to a general code of persecution.

[16] Suetonius, Claud. 25.4. Textual reference: Ihm 1908. The expression impulsore Chresto requires that the ambiguity be preserved as to the name, its referent and what the author knew.

tion and the Christian presence in Rome; Pliny provides evidence for community practices and administrative policy; Suetonius illuminates, more ambiguously, the conflict-ridden environment of the diaspora. The methodology of this monograph gives each testimony a weight proportional to its proximity, genre, transmission, and degree of independence.

3. Jerusalem: Jewish memory, authority and continuity

Jerusalem appears as a centre of authority in the oldest testimonies. Paul, in retrospectively narrating his activity, presupposes that certain figures in Jerusalem enjoyed particular recognition. In Galatians 1:18 he states that, three years after his calling, he went up to Jerusalem to meet Cephas and remained with him fifteen days; he adds that he saw none of the other apostles except James, "the Lord's brother" (Gal 1:18–19).

This passage is historically more important than a later list of office-holders. It shows that, for Paul, Cephas and James belonged to a network of authority that he could not ignore, even though his own apostolic legitimacy did not depend on them. In Galatians 2:9, James, Cephas, and John are called οἱ δοκοῦντες στῦλοι εἶναι, "those who were considered pillars" (Gal 2:9). The phrase does not describe a later episcopal hierarchy, but rather recognised prestige within the movement.[17]

The Jerusalem community should not be imagined as a Gentile proto-church. Paul's own letters show that the debate about the incorporation of non-Jews took place within a Jewish framework. The question was not whether Israel remained relevant, but how Gentiles could participate in Israel's promises and what practices they should adopt.

The centrality of Jerusalem is also expressed in the collection organised by Paul for "the saints" in the city (Rom 15:25–31; 1 Cor 16:1–4; 2 Cor 8–9). The collection was more than just financial assistance: it served as a gesture of communion between the Gentile Pauline communities and the Jerusalem community. Its importance confirms that, even in a mission oriented towards the nations, the relationship with Jerusalem remained fundamental.

[17] Gal 1:18–19; 2:1–10; 1 Cor 15:3–7; Acts 1–5. The Pauline letters and the narrative construction of Acts do not have the same chronological proximity to the initial community.

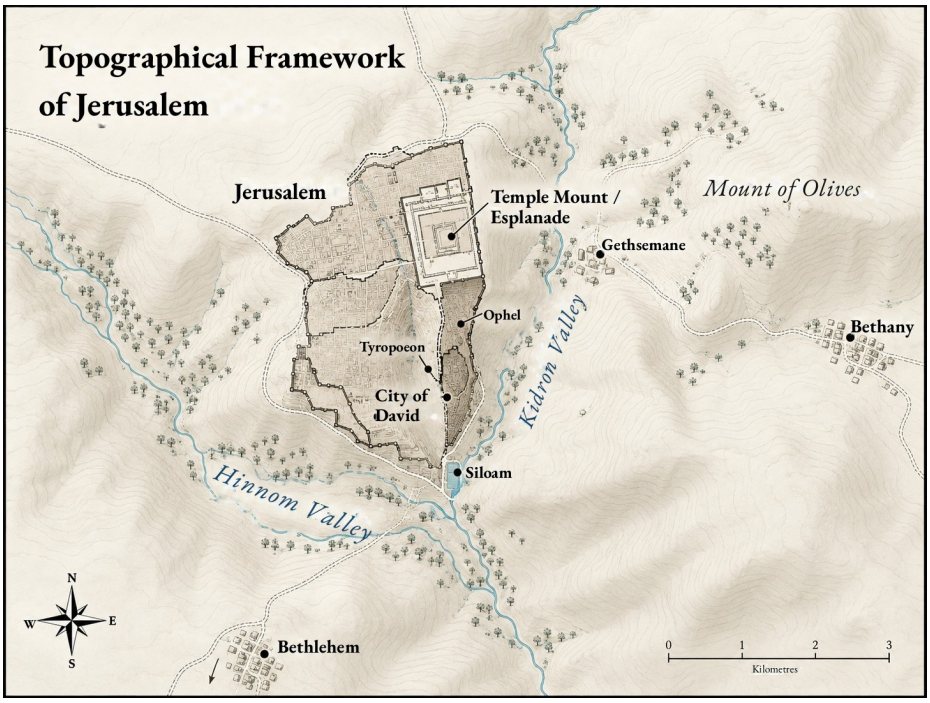


FIGURE 6. Topographical framework of Jerusalem. Editorial orientation map for the Second Temple period, showing the Temple precinct, Ophel, City of David, Siloam, Kidron Valley, Hinnom Valley, and Mount of Olives. Positions are topographical and do not claim an exact reconstruction of the city at a single date. [REC-GRAF/IA]. Illustrative schematic prepared for this edition; positions and routes are not a cartographic reconstruction to scale. Place names on the map are given in their Spanish forms.

4. Paul: calling, mission and communities

Paul is the best-documented figure in mid-first-century Christianity. His importance does not compel us to consider him the "founder of Christianity" in an absolute sense. Rather, his letters show that he joined a pre-existing movement, received earlier traditions, and had to negotiate his place in relation to other missionaries and authorities.

In Galatians 1:15–16 he describes his calling through prophetic language: God separated him from the womb and revealed his Son "to announce him among the nations"—ἵνα εὐαγγελίζωμαι αὐτὸν ἐν τοῖς ἔθνεσιν—(Gal 1:15–16). The formula places the Gentile mission within a vocation interpreted as a divine initiative. In Romans 11:13 he presents himself just as explicitly as ἐθνῶν ἀπόστολος, "apostle to the Gentiles."

The Pauline communities document the movement's expansion through urban centres of the eastern Mediterranean. Thessalonica, Philippi, Corinth, and the communities of Galatia were not simply points of a geographical campaign: they were social groups with their own conflicts concerning authority, sexuality, food, status, charismatic gifts, resurrection, and relationships with non-believers.

The First Letter to the Thessalonians is especially revealing because of its early chronology. Paul reminds his recipients that they turned "from idols to God"—πρὸς τὸν θεὸν ἀπὸ τῶν εἰδώλων—to serve the living God and await his Son from heaven (1 Thess 1:9–10). This formulation presupposes recipients from non-Jewish cultic practices and shows the radical nature of their religious reorientation.

Paul's mission, therefore, did not simply consist of converting pagans to a new religion already separate from Judaism. His project was to integrate Gentiles into the eschatological horizon of the God of Israel without necessarily requiring them to become Jews through circumcision. It is precisely here that one of the most intense debates in contemporary scholarship arises.

The so-called "New Perspective on Paul"—a label coined by James D. G. Dunn in 1982 (published in the Bulletin of the John Rylands Library 65, 1983) on the basis of E. P. Sanders, Paul and Palestinian Judaism (1977)—challenged the traditional representation of Judaism as a legalistic religion against which Paul supposedly discovered a religion of grace. Subsequent research has further developed this revision, insisting that many of Paul's statements about the Law are directed at Gentiles and do not constitute a general denial of Jewish identity (Thiessen 2016, 1–17; 73–102; Fredriksen 2017). The discussion continues, but the shift in framing is historiographically decisive.[18]

4.1. Gallio and the epigraphic anchoring of Pauline chronology

The imperial letter of Claudius known as the Gallio Inscription offers one of the most important external checks on Pauline chronology. The document comes from Delphi and deals with city affairs, not with Paul or Christians. Its significance stems from the mention of Lucius Junius Gallio as a friend of the emperor and proconsul. This mention is related to the episode in Acts 18:12–17, where Gallio exercises authority in Achaia.

The imperial title places the document in 52; the usual reconstruction of Gallio's term of office links it to 51–52. This synchronism should not be transformed into an

[18] 1 Thess 1:1–10; 1 Cor 16:5–9; Rom 15:22–29; Gal 1:15–24. Dunn 2009 and Fredriksen 2017 place Paul's mission in its Jewish and Gentile context.

exact date for each stage of Paul's journey. The inscription establishes an administrative framework; the account in Acts provides the narrative connection with the apostle. The strength of the argument depends on the convergence of both pieces of evidence and on the premises used to determine the duration of the office.[19]

Documentary Window: Gallio

TABLE 13. Documentary window: Gallio

Field	Identification and scope
Document	Letter from Claudius to Delphi, known as the Gallio inscription.
Corpus	*Fouilles de Delphes* III.4, no. 286; *Sylloge inscriptionum Graecarum*, no. 801 D.
Material and state of preservation	Stone; fragmentary text assembled from several fragments.
Language and genre	Greek; imperial communication concerning Delphi.
Dating	52, established by imperial titulary; Gallio's term usually placed in 51–52.
Relevant passage	Mention of Lucius Junius Gallio and the proconsulship; does not contain the name of Paul.
Control	Epigraphic publication by A. Plassart and presentation of the text by K. C. Hanson; the partial photograph does not allow a complete autopsy.

A selective semi-diplomatic transcription of the visible name is provided: ΓΑΛΛΙΩΝ (nominative; the omicron that follows, outside the frame, belongs to the next word). It is reproduced without accents and is not supplemented with words absent from the photograph. For context, the reconstructed continuous text refers to Gallio as "my friend and proconsul"; this translation depends on the edited

[19] Plassart 1970, FD III.4, no. 286; SIG, 3rd edition, 801 D. Documentary presentation: K. C. Hanson, The Gallio Inscription, `https://www.kchanson.com/ANCDOCS/greek/gallio.html`. Narrative synchronism: Acts 18:12–17. No fresh autopsy of the stone has been undertaken.

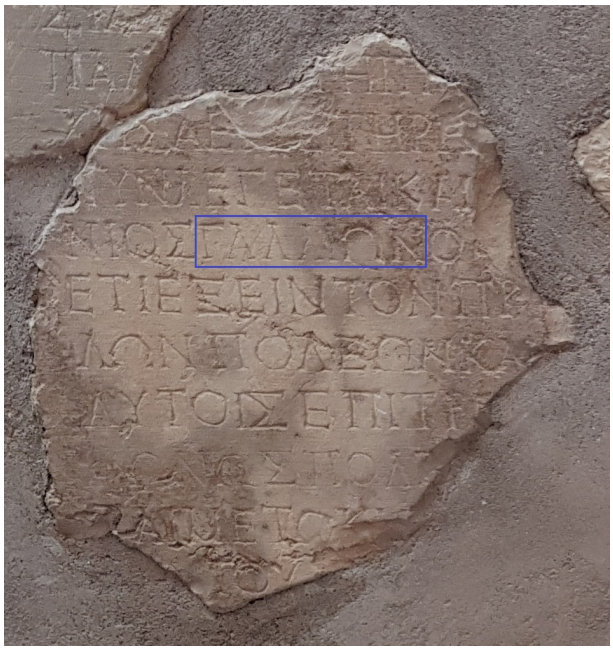


FIGURE 7. Fragment of the inscription of Gallio at Delphi, FD III.4, 286. Photograph by Gérard (2018), Delphes Gallion.jpg, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0, `https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/`. The inset of the source photograph is retained; reproduction at a higher resolution does not alter the inscription. [FAC].

reconstruction of the inscription, rather than an independent reading of the entire fragment reproduced here.

A continuous reconstruction is not printed as though all its letters survived. The distinction between the stone, the edited text and the translation is especially important here. The document securely attests Gallio's existence and administrative activity; its bearing on his encounter with Paul remains indirect.

4.2. From the New Perspective to Paul within Judaism

The revision initiated by the New Perspective did not exhaust the debate. A later line of thought, usually called Paul within Judaism, proposes reading Paul as a Jew who directs his instructions on circumcision, idolatry, and belonging primarily to Gentiles incorporated into the Messianic movement, without assuming that he himself abandoned Jewish practice or identity. The volume edited by Mark D. Nanos and Magnus Zetterholm programmatically formulates this perspective and compels a careful distinction between what Paul prescribes to Gentiles and what can be inferred from his own practice.

The usefulness of this approach does not require its adoption as the sole explanation. Its main contribution is methodological: it avoids transforming all of Paul's critique of the Law into a rejection of Judaism. At the same time, works such as John M.G. Barclay's *Paul and the Gift* have shown that the debate on grace, gift, and obedience cannot be reduced to the alternative of "Jewish legalism" versus "Christian grace." Barclay distinguishes several ancient ways of 'perfecting' the notion of gift and locates Paul's radicalism above all in the incongruity of the gift, given without regard to the recipient's prior worth.

This monograph uses these currents as interlocutors, not as school labels. For each passage, it asks who the intended audience is, what specific problem is being discussed, and what inference about Jewish or Gentile identity is actually authorised by the text.[20]

4.3. Work, house-workshop and logistics of the urban mission

Paul's mission had a material dimension that cannot be reduced to itineraries on a map. Paul repeatedly states that he worked with his hands (1 Thessalonians 2:9; 1 Corinthians 4:12; cf. Acts 18:3). Acts refers to him as *σκηνοποιός*, a term whose exact translation—tentmaker, leatherworker, or related trade—continues to be debated. What is certain is that Paul presents manual labour as part of his missionary economy.

In Roman cities, production, trade, and housing could coexist in spaces like the house-workshop or a taberna (shop or workshop). It is not possible to prove that each Pauline community literally arose in one of these settings, but the model helps us understand how work, hospitality, and sociability could overlap. The mission depended on networks capable of providing lodging, contacts, resources, and the circulation of

[20] Sanders 1977; Barclay 2015; Thiessen 2016; Nanos and Zetterholm 2015. These studies do not share a single interpretation and are cited according to the specific problem of Law, gift and Gentile addressees.

letters; the domestic and artisanal infrastructure was, therefore, part of the story of expansion.

From an archaeological perspective, the category of "house" should not be conceived as a private dwelling isolated from the productive space. In many Roman cities, workplaces and shops could be integrated with residential quarters. This combination allows for the formulation of a plausible material model for encounters arising from labour, patronage and commercial relationships, although the available evidence does not justify the archaeological identification of a specific "Pauline house-workshop" in Corinth or Ephesus. The usefulness of the model lies in linking mobility, manual labour, and urban sociability without transforming the hypothesis into the identification of a specific site.

The collection for Jerusalem must also be understood within this religious economy. It was not merely a theological symbol: it involved the mobilisation of resources between distant communities and demonstrates that Pauline networks could coordinate translocal economic transfers. Bruce W. Longenecker's study of poverty and Pauline economics provides a particularly useful framework for situating this practice within the Greco-Roman world.[21]

[21] 1 Thess 2:9; 1 Cor 9:1–18; Phil 4:10–20; Gal 2:10. Longenecker 2010 deals with the contexts of poverty and aid; an exhortation is not used as a demographic calculation.

4.4. Women, patronage and domestic networks

Paul's letters name women who played decisive roles in domestic and translocal networks. Prisca appears, along with Aquila, as a collaborator of Paul and linked to a church that met in their house (Rom 16:3–5). Phoebe is presented as διάκονος of the Cenchreae community and προστάτις of many, including Paul (Rom 16:1–2), vocabulary that demands we take seriously her capacity for service, representation, and patronage.

Junia appears alongside Andronicus in Rom 16:7. The feminine form of the name is widely recognised in contemporary scholarship. The precise scope of ἐπίσημοι ἐν τοῖς ἀποστόλοις remains debated, but the passage confirms her place within a prestigious network of authority and mission. Lydia, known from Acts 16, also offers a narrative representation of domestic hospitality and patronage in Philippi.

These figures prevent us from reconstructing the early communities solely on the basis of later male offices. The home, patronage, and economic mobility created spaces in which women with resources, networks, or prestige could exercise forms of leadership essential for the movement's circulation.[22]

4.5. Τέκτων and the limits of a professional biography of Jesus

Mark 6:3 calls Jesus τέκτων; Matt 13:55 uses the expression ὁ τοῦ τέκτονος υἱός, "the son of the τέκτων". The word may designate a craftsman engaged in construction and fabrication, particularly in wood; its scope depends on the context. "Carpenter" is a reasonable traditional translation, while the broader "craftsman" can avoid excessive specialisation. Neither choice establishes technical training comparable to the modern profession of architect.[23]

The word ἀρχιτέκτων contains an element of direction or leadership absent from τέκτων. Paul uses the former in 1 Corinthians 3:10 within a building metaphor: he lays a foundation and others build upon it. The passage describes his apostolic work through a professional image; it gives no warrant for attributing to Jesus a title that Mark does not use. The lexical relationship between the two terms must be explained without suppressing this morphological and contextual difference.

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[22] Rom 16:1–7; 1 Cor 11:2–16; Phil 4:2–3. The function attributed to a person, the vocabulary used, and the subsequent interpretation of that vocabulary must be distinguished.

[23] Mark 6:3; Matt 13:55; 1 Cor 3:10–17. Lexicographical reference: LSJ, s.v. τέκτων and ἀρχιτέκτων. The interpretation of the occupation described in the Gospels does not become a reconstructed professional biography.

Construction metaphors were especially effective for communities that needed to talk about cooperation, responsibility, and permanence. In 1 Corinthians 3, the warning about building materials is directed at the conduct of those who build the community. In other writings, house, temple, stone, or foundation articulate belonging and authority. These images are data for exegesis and the social history of language; they are not hidden blueprints or coded geometric instructions.

An academic history of Jesus must therefore remain proportionate to the evidence. The term used in the Gospel places him within a craft context, but does not permit reconstruction of his apprenticeship, enumeration of his works, or attribution of architectural calculations or doctrines to him. Precision preserves the distinction between a transmitted detail and an imagined professional biography.

5. Galatians 2: Jerusalem, communion and conflict

Galatians 2 is the most important surviving testimony for studying the relationship between Paul and the authorities in Jerusalem. Paul states that he returned to Jerusalem "after fourteen years" with Barnabas and Titus. There he expounded the gospel that he proclaimed among the Gentiles and received from James, Cephas, and John "the right hand of fellowship"—δεξιὰς ἔδωκαν... κοινωνίας—, with a division of missionary fields: they to the circumcised, and Paul and Barnabas to the Gentiles (Gal 2:1–10).

The agreement did not eliminate the conflicts. According to Paul himself, at a point he does not date relative to that agreement, a public dispute arose with Cephas in Antioch. Paul declares: κατὰ πρόσωπον αὐτῷ ἀντέστην, "I opposed him face to face" (Gal 2:11–14). The reason was Cephas's withdrawal from the table shared with Gentiles after the arrival of people associated with James. The episode shows that formal fellowship did not automatically resolve the practical consequences of Gentile inclusion.

This conflict should not be reduced to an abstract opposition between "Pauline Christianity" and "Judaism." The concrete question was who could share a table with whom and what that practice meant for community identity. Food was a space where purity, ethnicity, belonging, and authority converged. The intensity of Paul's reaction, our only surviving account of the incident, indicates that coexistence between Jews and Gentiles in Christ remained an open problem.

The narrative also qualifies F.C. Baur's classic model, which organised early Christianity around two coherent and opposing blocs, Petrine and Pauline. The sources show real conflicts, but alliances and positions were more fluid. Peter/Cephas could

share a table with Gentiles and then withdraw; Barnabas, Paul's collaborator, could temporarily align himself with that withdrawal. History is more complex than a stable dichotomy.[24]

6. Acts 15 and the problem of comparison

Acts 15 recounts a meeting in Jerusalem prompted by the question of whether Gentiles should be circumcised and observe the Law. The episode has traditionally been identified with the visit in Galatians 2. The identification is plausible and remains common, but it cannot be considered definitively proven.

The two narratives share important elements: Jerusalem, Paul and Barnabas, a discussion about Gentiles, the participation of key figures, and a resolution that avoids imposing circumcision on non-Jews. However, they differ in structure, emphasis, and outcome. Galatians does not mention the so-called apostolic decree; Acts does not reproduce the conflict in Antioch with the same narrative function.

The comparison must follow a methodological sequence: first, each text is reconstructed within its own argument; then, convergences and divergences are identified; only then is a historical relationship proposed. Harmonising them from the outset would produce a third narrative that does not fully coincide with either of the two sources.

The minimum consensus is more solid than the detailed identification: during the middle decades of the first century, there was a real controversy about the conditions for incorporating Gentiles, and leaders linked to Jerusalem and the Pauline mission participated in it. Circumcision and shared meals were concrete problems of community organisation, not later theoretical debates.[25]

[24] Gal 2:1–14. The autobiographical presentation of the encounter and its participants constitutes the primary testimony of the argument, without automatic harmonisation with Acts 15.

[25] Acts 15:1–29; Gal 2:1–14. The comparison maintains the differences in sequence and composition. The decree is identified by locus and its textual tradition requires consultation of NA28.

7. From controversy to increasingly Gentile configurations

The success of missions among non-Jews gradually altered the social composition of the movement. This transformation should not be described as an immediate replacement of a "Jewish Church" with a "Gentile Church." In different cities and regions, Jews and Gentiles continued to interact in various ways for generations.

Differentiation did not progress at the same pace in all cities. Jerusalem and Judea were shaped by the centrality of the Temple, warfare, and the reconfigurations after 70 CE; the diaspora communities operated within different civic, legal, and linguistic frameworks. Alexandria, Antioch, Rome, and the cities of Asia Minor should not be seen as mere stages in a single chronology. Urban geography altered the possibilities for interaction between Jews, Gentiles, and groups of followers of Jesus, and consequently, the speed and manner in which boundaries were constructed.

Recent historiography has challenged the idea of a single separation between Judaism and Christianity datable to the year 70, at Yavne, or at some other isolated event. The volume edited by Adam Becker and Annette Yoshiko Reed influentially articulated this problem through the image of "ways that never parted" in any simple fashion (Becker and Reed 2007). The value of this historiographical shift lies less in denying all differentiation than in compelling us to situate it historically.

The destruction of the Temple in 70 CE was undoubtedly a decisive transformation for multiple Jewish currents and for communities following Jesus. But its effects varied depending on the group. The Gospels composed after the war reflect new configurations of memory and conflict; Gentile communities could find themselves increasingly distanced from Jewish institutions; at the same time, Jewish practices, Scriptures, and categories continued to structure Christianity.

Therefore, this book uses the expression "differentiation between Judaism and Christianity" rather than "definitive separation" when referring to the period of the first and second centuries. In some contexts the boundaries became clear relatively early; in others they remained porous for longer.[26]

8. Authority and memory before institutionalisation

The early Christian communities did not lack authority; they lacked a single, unified form of authority. Paul appeals to his calling, to the received tradition, to Scripture, to his missionary work, and to his relationships with other apostles. Jerusalem possesses

[26] Gal 2:15–21; 3:1–29; 5:1–6; Rom 3–4. Thiessen 2016 and Fredriksen 2017 allow us to clarify the problem of the Gentile recipients.

prestige; James, Cephas, and John are "pillars"; the communities can acknowledge, discuss, or resist decisions.

This plurality explains why apostolic memory subsequently became such an important resource. As new generations debated doctrine, discipline, and authoritative texts, proximity to the apostles became an argument for legitimacy. But that stage should not be projected retrospectively onto the decades of Paul.

The circulation of letters was one of the material mechanisms for constructing memory. Paul wrote to specific communities, but his letters began to circulate beyond the original recipients. This process contributed to a set of occasional documents acquiring translocal authority. The history of the canon begins precisely with this materiality: texts copied, exchanged, read, and collected before being included in normative lists.[27]

9. Women beyond Paul: prophecy, martyrdom, patronage and ministries in the second–third centuries

Female agency does not end with the Pauline networks. In the second and third centuries, women appear in archives of a different nature: apocryphal narratives, martyrdom accounts, charismatic prophecy, inscriptions, ecclesiastical discipline, and normative literature. Comparison requires distinguishing between historically identifiable individuals, literary characters, and institutional categories.

Thecla belongs to second-century Pauline reception; Priscilla/Prisca and Maximilla show that women's prophetic authority could be central while also contested by heresiologists. Perpetua and Felicity permit analysis of martyrdom, status and slavery without treating the Passio as social statistics.

Widows, virgins, and deaconesses require terminological precision. The Didascalia Apostolorum and other normative sources show women exercising functions of assistance, access to domestic spaces, and mediation, but these should not be mechanically translated into modern categories of ordination.

[27] Gal 1:1; 1:11–24; 1 Cor 9:1–2; 15:8–11; 2 Cor 10–13. Apostolic defence is not equivalent to a unified institutional regulation.

Table 14. Women in the second and third centuries: figures and categories of ministry

Figure / Category	Century / region	Source	Function / representation
Thecla	II; Literary Asia Minor	Acta Pauli et Theclae	Asceticism, teaching, baptism in narrative
Priscilla and Maximilla	II; Phrygia	Eusebius, Epiphanius, adversarial tradition	Prophecy in the New Prophecy (Montanism)
Perpetua	III; Carthage	Passio Perpetuae	Martyr, visionary, complex narrative voice
Felicity	III; Carthage	Passio Perpetuae	Enslaved martyr
Widows	II–III; several regions	Didascalia and regulations	Assistance, prayer, discipline
Deaconesses	III–IV; Syria and the East	Didascalia and later testimonies	Assistance to women, baptism, domestic mediation
Patrons / Hostesses	I–III; urban	Epigraphy and texts	Resources, housing, mobility

Table 15. Continuation of "Women in the second and third centuries: figures and categories of ministry"

Figure / Category	Certainty	Caution
Thecla	B/C	Pauline reception, not a direct witness of the first century.
Priscilla and Maximilla	B	Mostly hostile sources.
Perpetua	A/B	Distinguish between autobiographical core and edition.
Felicity	A/B	Do not extrapolate to all Christian slaves.
Widows	B	Variable institutional category.
Deaconesses	B	Do not automatically equate with the male diaconate.
Patrons / Hostesses	B	Patronage must be proven on a case-by-case basis.

10. Pre-Constantinian Christian buildings: comparison and degrees of certainty

Dura-Europos remains the clearest case for examining a house adapted to Christian use before the Constantinian settlement: the architectural sequence, baptistery, and wall paintings allow space, ritual, and image to be related without reconstructing a premature "basilica". The Megiddo/Kefar ʿOthnay complex, with its paved hall and Christian mosaic inscription, offers an important third-century comparandum, although the precise function of the complex, its relationship to the camp of Legio VI Ferrata, and the fine chronology of its phases require caution.

The find at Kefar ʿOthnay (Legio), in the Megiddo prison compound (2005), allows this point of comparison to be made more precise. It is a plain assembly hall with a mosaic pavement decorated with geometric motifs and fish, and several Greek inscriptions. The principal one records that Akeptous, "lover of God", offered the table "to God Jesus Christ" as a memorial (τὴν τράπεζαν θεῷ Ἰησοῦ Χριστῷ μνημόσυνον); another states that a Roman officer, Gaianus, also called Porphyrius, paid for the mosaic. The editors (Tepper and Di Segni 2006) date it to about 230; other proposals lower it to the late third or early fourth century, and its functional interpretation remains debated. In any case it is neither a basilica nor a monumental building, and no comparable building is known for the first century: the evidence indicates that by the third century some Christian groups had halls of their own, a ritual "table" and explicit Christological language in a space of worship, before any imperial patronage.

This case, together with Dura-Europos, corrects a generalisation of the literary sources. Minucius Felix's Octavius has the pagan opponent say that Christians have "no altars and no temples" (Minucius Felix, Oct. 10.2), and the apologist accepts this in a theological sense (Oct. 32.1). That formula describes a rhetoric of difference from pagan temples, not a general material condition: in the third century there were Christians with a dedicated hall, a table offered to God and a decorated space. The correction is limited: it does not prove that such halls were the norm or that they existed in the first century, only that the literary argument cannot be read as a description of the communities' actual equipment.

A second body of testimony concerns the memory of the apostles at Rome, and in it veneration must be separated from worship. The theological distinction between the latria owed to God alone and the honour given to martyrs is formulated with precision only later; what the sources and finds document for the second and third centuries is a cult of memory beside tombs: the monument, the visit, the funerary meal and invocation. The literary sources are of unequal weight. 1 Clem. 5–6 presents Pe-

ter and Paul as examples of endurance unto death, alongside "a great multitude of the elect" who suffered, but does not name Nero or specify where Peter died; Ignatius, Rom. 4.3, presupposes that both apostles held special authority before the Roman community ("I do not command you as Peter and Paul did"); Dionysius of Corinth, c. 170, asserts that both founded the churches of Corinth and of Rome and suffered martyrdom "at the same time" (Eusebius, HE II.25.8), a claim with an evident apologetic interest in the unity of the two sees. The most important testimony is that of the presbyter Gaius, c. 200, against the Montanist Proclus: "I can show you the trophies (τρόπαια) of the apostles; if you go to the Vatican or to the Ostian Way, you will find the trophies of those who founded this Church" (Eusebius, HE II.25.7). Tertullian, c. 200–210, ascribes to Peter a death like the Lord's and to Paul one like John the Baptist's (Tertullian, Scorp. 15.3; Praescr. 36.3). This is a body of evidence datable to the late second century, not the first, and none of it proves by itself a cultic practice in the first century.

Archaeology allows what Gaius implies to be made more precise. The Vatican excavations of 1940–1949 identified in the necropolis beneath St Peter's an aedicula of the mid-second century set against the so-called "red wall", which scholarly tradition identifies with Gaius's "trophy"; the monument shows that by about 160–170 there was at the site a point of apostolic memory, not that it simply contained the apostle's remains, a question that remains debated. The graffito Πέτρ(ος) ἔνι, read and proposed by Margherita Guarducci on the adjoining wall, is disputed in both reading and date and should not be made to carry more weight than it bears. Firmer is the evidence of the Memoria Apostolorum on the Via Appia, at San Sebastiano (ad catacumbas): hundreds of graffiti, most from the later third century, attest refrigeria—funerary meals in honour of the apostles—and invocations such as "Paul and Peter, pray for Victor". The association with the year 258, when the relics are said to have been moved there during the persecution of Valerian, is a plausible but late reconstruction that depends on fourth-century sources. The value of the whole for this book is twofold: it confirms that the cult of apostolic memory took shape in the second century around the paired figure of Peter and Paul, and it shows that its material support was the funerary monument and the ritual meal, not a building for worship.

It is worth adding that this chronology should not be confused with that of the synagogues. In the first and second centuries there is no conversion of synagogue buildings into churches: the movement was born within the diaspora synagogues, which Paul uses in Acts as a platform (Acts 17:1–2; 18:4), coexisted with them, and separated from them unevenly and regionally, not all at once. The two milestones usually given as causes—the destruction of the Temple in 70 and the Birkat ha-Minim—

must be taken with the caution set out in the relevant chapter, since the second can be neither dated nor read as a general synagogue measure in 85–90. The oldest surviving Christian spaces are adapted houses, such as that of Dura-Europos (remodelled c. 240–256), which coexisted with its synagogue as an independent structure; the term domus ecclesiae is a modern category and not a standardised second-century architectural form. Conversions of synagogues into churches are later than the Constantinian peace and cannot be projected back onto the period this book studies.

The house gatherings can be described more precisely if the sources are distinguished from what is inferred from them. Justin, 1 Apol. 65–67 (c. 150–155, written at Rome), gives the earliest description of a Sunday meeting: reading of "the memoirs of the apostles or the writings of the prophets", exhortation by the president, standing prayers, the kiss of peace, bread and wine mixed with water, thanksgiving and distribution by the deacons, with exclusion of the unbaptised; it is an apologetic description addressed to a pagan audience, not a liturgical ordo. Pliny (Pliny, Ep. X.96, c. 112) places the gatherings "before dawn" and in two stages, with hymns to Christ "as to a god" and a later meal "common and harmless"; Tertullian (Tertullian, Apol. 39) describes the common chest, prayer for the emperors and the agape, not a secret cult; Minucius Felix (Oct. 8–9) transmits, in the mouth of the pagan opponent, the suspicions of nocturnal rites and recognition signs, which the Christian text refutes and which therefore cannot be taken as a neutral description. The figure of the ostiarius is attested at Rome c. 251 in Bishop Cornelius's letter (Eusebius, HE VI.43.11), which lists forty-two acolytes and fifty-two "exorcists, readers and doorkeepers"; the formal dismissal of catechumens and the discipline of the secret come from third-century and, above all, fourth-century sources, and the Apostolic Tradition attributed to Hippolytus is a text of debated date and composition. The picture of an adapted triclinium, a common table and a separate baptismal space rests, for this period, chiefly on Dura-Europos, and everything else—the doorkeeper recognising each attendee, the low voices of the psalms, the oil lamps—is plausible inference, not datum. Irenaeus (Haer. III.3.2–3), for his part, does not describe meetings but grounds the authority of the Roman tradition in the preaching of Peter and Paul and in the succession of Linus, Anacletus and Clement, which links to the cult of memory treated above.

Comparison with other meeting places must separate positive evidence from retrospective inference. A large house mentioned in a letter, a room capable of accommodating an assembly, and a building later transformed into a church are not equivalent kinds of evidence. Before Constantine, archaeology points to a plurality of solutions—domestic adaptation, association-like meeting rooms, and complexes

with specific ritual functions—but not to a universal Christian building type. Archaeology here does more than illustrate the texts: it can contradict the retrospective picture they project. The fourth-century transformation lies less in the ex nihilo invention of a form than in a new scale of patronage, urban visibility, and monumentality.

Conclusion

The first generation of the Jesus movement can be reconstructed with sufficient historical depth without turning uncertainties into voids. The movement arose within Judaism; Jerusalem functioned as a centre of memory and authority; Paul developed an intensive mission among Gentiles; and the incorporation of these Gentiles produced concrete conflicts regarding circumcision, table fellowship, the Law, and belonging.

The sources do not show an instantaneous break between Judaism and Christianity. Rather, they show a process of differentiation accompanied by profound continuities. Nor do they show two monolithic, opposing parties, but rather networks of people and communities whose positions could coincide, diverge, and transform.

This configuration forms the starting point for the second century. There, the question is no longer merely how to incorporate Gentiles, but who has the authority to interpret Scripture, which texts should be read, how correct teaching is defined, and how diverse groups construct apostolic genealogies. The shift from local controversies to more stable systems of authority is one of the central themes of the following chapter.

Summary

This chapter situates the Jesus movement within first-century Judaism and the political and social conditions of Roman Judea. It compares Paul's letters, the Book of Acts, and external literary and epigraphic testimonies, distinguishing contemporary evidence from later memory. Jerusalem, the incorporation of Gentiles, disputes over commensality, and the interpretation of the Law are examined as uneven processes of community formation, rather than an instantaneous separation between two religions.

Keywords: Second Temple Judaism; Paul; Jerusalem; incorporation of Gentiles; Roman Judea.

CHAPTER II

Marcion, Scripture and the Formation of the Canon

The second century demands a change of scale. Controversies no longer concern only the inclusion of Gentiles or the authority of specific missionaries, but also the relationship between the Scriptures of Israel and the Gospel, the identity of the God proclaimed by Jesus, the authority of the Pauline epistles, and the delimitation of texts that could be read as normative. Marcion of Sinope occupies a central place in this process, not because the history of the canon can be reduced to a reaction against him, but because his activity reveals that, by the middle of the second century, the selection, arrangement, and interpretation of Christian writings had become explicit problems of authority.

1. The historical problem of Marcion

Marcion was an active Christian figure in Rome during the second century and was later condemned by authors who presented themselves as defenders of the apostolic rule of faith. The exact chronology of his arrival in Rome, his break with the local community, and the spread of his churches depends on later testimonies, so it is important to avoid transforming a heresiological biography into a sequence securely established by documentary evidence. The conventional date of the Roman break, c. 144 CE, derives from a polemical computation by Tertullian (Adv. Marc. I.19), which places Marcion one hundred and fifteen and a half years after the preaching of Jesus, and should be treated as an estimate. What can be stated with confidence is that, in the second half of the second century, authors such as Irenaeus were aware of communities and doctrines associated with his name, and that Tertullian, at the beginning of the third century, was able to dedicate five books to refuting them.

The methodological difficulty is immediate: no work by Marcion survives in independent manuscript transmission. His Gospel, his Pauline collection, and the Antitheses must be reconstructed from adversaries—especially Tertullian,

Epiphanius, Irenaeus, and the Dialogue of Adamantius—who quote, paraphrase, or describe Marcionite materials for polemical purposes. Judith M. Lieu has emphasised precisely this point: the Marcion accessible to the historian is also the product of a long "construction of the heretic" by his opponents (Lieu 2015).

Therefore, the correct question is not "What did Marcion teach?" in the abstract, but "What elements of his thought and his texts can be reconstructed, through which witnesses, and with what degree of certainty?" The distinction is crucial if we are not to repeat as fact the rhetorical characterisations of his adversaries.

2. Heresiological sources and their value

Irenaeus offers one of the most influential early accounts. In Adversus haereses I.27, he attributes to Marcion an opposition between the God proclaimed by the Law and the Prophets and the Father of Jesus Christ; he adds that Marcion used a gospel related to Luke and a collection of Paul's letters. The passage is indispensable, but it is not neutral: Irenaeus presents these operations as deliberate mutilation of received texts and integrates them into a genealogy of heresy. His testimony must be used simultaneously as a source on Marcion and as a source on Irenaeus's polemical strategy.

Tertullian is still more important for textual reconstruction. Adversus Marcionem IV extensively discusses the gospel used by Marcion, and Book V discusses his Pauline epistles. The fact that Tertullian argues against specific readings allows for the recovery of numerous passages, but his procedure is not equivalent to a diplomatic transcription of the Marcionite text. He may quote from memory, summarise, combine formulations, and adapt his discussion to Latin. Dieter T. Roth has shown that any modern reconstruction must evaluate the form of each attestation individually and distinguish degrees of certainty (Roth 2015).

Epiphanius of Salamis, in Panarion 42, offers a later inventory of differences attributed to the Gospel of Marcion. He is chronologically more distant and no less polemical than Tertullian, yet he preserves details not always found in Tertullian. Tertullian and Epiphanius are treated as independent witnesses only where the history of literary dependence warrants it; agreement between them cannot by itself establish independent access to the same Marcionite exemplar.

Methodological note on witness dependence. Panarion 42 should not be mechanically counted as a second independent witness alongside Tertullian. Epiphanius works within a heresiological tradition that reuses earlier materials, and his relationship to Irenaeus, Hippolytus, and intermediate texts must be evaluated locus by locus. When Tertullian and Epiphanius agree, the agreement increases

the reconstructive value only if a literary dependence can be excluded or limited; otherwise, there is a risk of circular collation.

2.1. Justin as contemporary witness

Before Irenaeus and Tertullian, Justin Martyr offers one of the earliest surviving testimonies about Marcion. In 1 Apol. 26 he states that Marcion of Pontus was still alive and teaching his disciples to believe in a god distinct from and superior to the Creator; he adds, with evident polemical intent, that he had persuaded people "of every nation." In 1 Apol. 58 he again presents him as an active teacher with a wide following.

Justin's demonological rhetoric prevents us from using his description as a neutral portrait. Its historical value lies in other aspects: it establishes Marcion as a contemporary, confirms that his activity was known in Rome by the mid-second century, and shows that his movement had acquired sufficient visibility to be mentioned in an apology addressed to imperial power. Justin must therefore precede Irenaeus in the chapter's documentary sequence.[28]

3. The Gospel of Marcion and its relationship to Luke

Ancient adversaries identify the Marcionite gospel with a form closely related to Luke. Irenaeus describes it as a truncated Luke; Tertullian sets out his refutation by accepting, for the purposes of discussion, the gospel that Marcion acknowledges; Epiphanius lists passages present, absent, or altered. The modern task is to avoid accepting uncritically the direction of change presupposed by the accusation of "mutilation."

Roth's reconstruction offers a significant methodological advance because it does not propose a homogeneous text with the same degree of confidence in all its verses. His study classifies the evidence and reconstructs readings only when the combination of witnesses allows it. Consequently, this monograph does not print a continuous "Gospel of Marcion" as if it were a preserved manuscript; it presents only the loci necessary for the argument and expressly indicates the level of certainty of each reconstruction. Roth's work, published by Brill in 2015, constitutes a central reference tool here.

One particularly debated issue is the literary relationship between the Marcionite Gospel and Luke. The traditional explanation holds that Marcion abbreviated

[28] Justin, 1 Apol. 26; 58. Reference critical editions: Munier 2006 and Minns and Parvis 2009. Early testimony does not provide an independent copy of Marcion's Gospel.

and modified Luke. Other proposals suggest that both texts may derive from an earlier gospel form or that the textual relationship is more complex. This work does not adopt a general solution before examining specific passages; its priority is to distinguish what ancient sources attest to from what modern historiography infers.

In the current state of research, the most widely accepted explanation is that Marcion worked with a form of Luke and revised it according to his theological project. This position retains weight because it coincides with the general direction of patristic testimony and with numerous features of the textual relationship. However, it can no longer be presented as an indisputable fact. Among the serious alternatives are the priority of the Marcionite Gospel over the canonical form of Luke and the hypothesis that both depend, in different ways, on an earlier Gospel form. The reconstruction must therefore distinguish between probable dependence, direction of dependence, and degree of certainty for each reading.[29]

3.1. Decisive loci of the gospel recension attributed to Marcion

The following table does not present a continuous "Gospel of Marcion." It summarises loci where heresiological testimonies allow for an assessment of presence, absence, or degree of uncertainty. The aim is to show the reader how the reconstruction works and where the evidence ends.

Documentary comparison 1. Loci of the gospel recension attributed to Marcion: witnesses and assessment.

Luke 1–2

Irenaeus. General accusation of mutilation
Tertullian. Presupposes absence of the infancy narratives
Epiphanius. Explicit absence
Roth. Absence: high confidence
Evaluation. The Marcionite gospel did not contain the infancy narratives.

Luke 3:1 / 4:31

Irenaeus. —
Tertullian. Beginning of his ministry under Tiberius
Epiphanius. Beginning without childhood; Capernaum
Roth. Definite/highly probable presence

[29] Tertullian, Marc. IV.2–7; Epiphanius, Pan. 42. Roth 2015 offers a reconstruction by loci; BeDuhn 2013 and Klinghardt 2021 propose models that should be compared without confusing reconstruction and preserved witness.

Evaluation. Important for reconstructing the opening of the text**.**

Luke 4:16–30

Irenaeus. —
Tertullian. Discussed in Adv. Marc. IV
Epiphanius. Partially attested
Roth. Probable presence
Evaluation. Relevant locus for the initial order.

Luke 9:54–56

Irenaeus. —
Tertullian. Used in the controversy over punishment and goodness
Epiphanius. Partial testimony
Roth**.** Attested nucleus
Evaluation. Key to the antithetic **procedure**.

Luke 11:29–32

Irenaeus. —
Tertullian. Insufficient evidence
Epiphanius. Absence noted
Roth. Absent/probably absent
Evaluation. It should not be reintroduced by harmonisation.

Luke 15:11–32

Irenaeus. —
Tertullian. Inconclusive argument from silence
Epiphanius. Absence noted
Roth. Absence: high confidence
Evaluation. The **parable** of the prodigal son is not reconstructed as certain.

Luke 20:9–18

Irenaeus. —
Tertullian. Incomplete evidence
Epiphanius. Absence noted
Roth. Absent/probably absent
Evaluation. Example of omission with theological **consequences**.

Luke 22:19–20

Irenaeus. —

Tertullian**.** Complex tradition

Epiphanius. Partial testimony

Roth**.** Cautious reconstruction

Evaluation. Locus where a continuous edition would give a false sense **of** security.

3.2. Synoptic block of textual criticism: Luke and the recension attributed to Marcion

This apparatus compares four loci especially useful for illustrating the method of reconstruction. It does not take the old accusation of "mutilation" as a given, but distinguishes between directly attested readings, high-probability reconstructions, and simple silences in the sources. The direction of the textual change—whether Marcion abbreviates Luke, Luke expands an earlier form, or both depend on a previous stage—must be discussed after establishing which reading is actually documented.

Certainty scale

A = reading explicitly attested by more than one source or by a source with a sufficiently precise quotation; B = strong reconstruction from clear testimony; C = probable but debatable reconstruction; D = unattested text: neither presence nor absence can be inferred.

Documentary comparison 2. Luke 5:39 and other control loci: witness, reconstruction and degree of certainty.

Luke 5:39

Luke's critical text. ὁ παλαιὸς χρηστός ἐστιν

Reading attributed to Marcion. No surviving Marcionite testimony regarding its presence or absence

Grade D

Evaluation. Negative methodological case: it should not be called "secure omission".

Luke 10:21

Luke's critical text. πάτερ, κύριε τοῦ οὐρανοῦ καὶ τῆς γῆς

Reading attributed to Marcion. κύριε τοῦ οὐρανοῦ; the phrase "and of the earth" is unattested

Grade A/B

Evaluation. **Real** textual difference; the theological motivation must be formulated as interpretation, not as fact.

Luke 13:28

Luke's critical text. Ἀβραὰμ… Ἰσαὰκ… Ἰακὼβ… πάντας τοὺς προφήτας

Reading attributed to Marcion. πάντας τοὺς δικαίους

Grade A

Evaluation. **Strongly attested** substitution; alters the explicitness of the patriarchal-prophetic reference.

Luke 20:35

Luke's critical text. οἱ… καταξιωθέντες τοῦ αἰῶνος ἐκείνου…

Reading attributed to Marcion. ὁ θεὸς τοῦ αἰῶνος ἐκείνου… due to a different syntactic segmentation

Grade B

Evaluation. The controversy focuses on the syntactic attachment of "of that age" to θεός, not on an alleged omission of the resurrection.

3.3. Locus 1. Luke 5:39: a case in which silence cannot become omission

Modern tradition, from Harnack onwards, frequently attributed the omission of Luke 5:39 to Marcion because the preference for "old" wine seemed incompatible with a theology of rupture between the Creator God and the Father of Jesus Christ. However, Dieter T. Roth insists on a methodologically crucial point: indirect Marcionite sources attest neither to the presence nor to the absence of this verse. Harnack reconstructed its omission on grounds of dogmatic expediency, but this procedure creates negative evidence where the sources are silent.

The absence of Luke 5:39 from Codex Bezae (D) and in part of the Western tradition demonstrates, moreover, that the omission of the verse is not in itself a distinctively Marcionite trait. Therefore, this locus should be used as an example of critical discipline: one can discuss why the verse would have been inconvenient for a Marcionite reading, but one cannot assert that Marcion eliminated it. Roth classifies the Marcionite text of this verse as unattested.

Methodological consequence: the reconstruction of the Gospel attributed to Marcion cannot be completed through theological expectations. The apparatus must record "not attested" where Tertullian, Epiphanius, and the other sources do not provide data.

3.4. Locus 2. Luke 10:21: "Lord of heaven" and the absence of "the earth"

In Luke's critical text, Jesus addresses the Father as "Lord of heaven and earth." Tertullian, Adv. Marc. IV.25, and Epiphanius transmit a form attributed to Marcion's text in which the reference to earth is missing. Roth reconstructs with considerable confidence a reading containing κύριε τοῦ οὐρανοῦ, "Lord of heaven," without καὶ τῆς γῆς.

The divergence has evident theological potential within the Marcionite controversy because it permits the Father of Jesus to be distinguished from explicit sovereignty over the earth. However, the argument must be expressed carefully: the philological fact is the difference in reading; the explanation that the alteration was deliberately made to express a dualistic cosmology belongs to the level of historical interpretation. The causal sequence cannot be deduced solely from the variant.

This locus is particularly valuable because it shows the interaction between patristic reconstruction and general textual criticism. The apparatus of NA28 records no Greek variant omitting "and of the earth" at this point; the short reading comes from the patristic tradition about Marcion, and its priority over the long text requires further argument. The question of priority requires further argument.

3.5. Locus 3. Luke 13:28: Patriarchs and prophets versus "all the righteous"

The canonical text mentions Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and "all the prophets" in the kingdom of God. For the recension attributed to Marcion, Tertullian and Epiphanius allow the expression πάντας τοὺς δικαίους, "all the righteous," to be reconstructed in its place. Roth considers this locus sufficiently attested to incorporate it into his critical reconstruction.

The difference is historically significant. The Marcionite reading generalises the category of those admitted to the kingdom and eliminates the explicit enumeration of founding figures of Israel. It is reasonable to relate this textual form to the Marcionite dispute over the continuity between the Gospel and the Scriptures of Israel; however, the apparatus must distinguish between the given fact—the reading "all the righteous"—and the explanation of its origin.

The substitution offers one of the clearest examples of what a comparative edition can and cannot establish: the variant is documented; the specific editorial intention remains a historical inference.

3.6. Locus 4. Luke 20:35–36: punctuation, syntax and "the god of that age"

This passage calls for an important correction to overly free reconstructions. Tertullian does not accuse Marcion here of simply omitting the "flesh" or the idea of resurrection. The controversy revolves around how the phrase is segmented. The Marcionite tradition could read the sequence so that "of that age" modified "God," producing the meaning "the god of that age"; Tertullian insists on punctuating after "God," so that "that age" pertains to what the worthy will attain.

Roth reconstructs for Luke 20:35 a sequence that preserves both the reference to attaining that age and "the resurrection from the dead." Consequently, it is incorrect to describe this locus as a simple Marcionite suppression of the bodily resurrection. The problem is syntactic, hermeneutical, and theological: the same sequence of words could be divided differently to produce a different Christology and cosmology.

This example is especially useful for the monograph because it demonstrates that textual criticism is not limited to words present or absent. Punctuation, segmentation, and reliance on a patristic Latin translation can radically alter the reconstruction of a lost Greek text.

3.7. Method note: textual variant does not equate to ideological intention

The four preceding loci apply a rule that governs the entire monograph: first the reading is established, then its relative antiquity is assessed, and only then is its possible theological motivation discussed. The similarity between a variant and a known doctrinal position does not, in itself, demonstrate that the variant was created to express that doctrine.

Reference sources: Tertullian, Marc. IV.25; IV.30; IV.38; Epiphanius, Pan. 42; Roth 2015. For the problem of unattested loci and problematic references in NA28, see Roth 2022, pp. 52–60, especially note 7.[30]

[30] Roth 2015, reconstruction by loci. The work and primary passages are cited without preserving an inherited pagination that could not be verified. A precise discussion of a reading requires consultation of the copy of the edition.

4. The Apostolikon: Paul as textual authority

Marcion also compiled a collection of Pauline letters, traditionally called the Apostolikon. Ancient sources and modern reconstructions agree that Paul held exceptional authority within his scriptural project. This selection should not be explained simply as personal preference: it shows that, by the middle of the second century, the Pauline letters could already function as a transmissible corpus, susceptible to systematic ordering, editing, and interpretation.

Tertullian, in Adversus Marcionem V, discusses the Pauline epistles in turn and preserves information about the order and certain titles of the Marcionite collection; for example, he reports that the writing known to him as Ephesians appeared under the name Laodiceans in Marcion's corpus. This information should be evaluated within the broader discussion of the titles, circulation, and stabilisation of the epistles.

The existence of the Apostolikon does not mean that Marcion "invented" Paul, nor that he was the first to collect letters. There are indications of earlier Pauline circulation, and the very reception of Paul in 2 Peter (2 Pet 3:15–16) presupposes a plurality of letters. However, Marcion provides exceptional evidence for the programmatic use of a delimited Pauline corpus.

4.1. P^{46} and the materiality of an early Pauline collection

The history of the Apostolikon must be compared with the material evidence from non-Marcionite Pauline collections. The papyrus known as P^{46} (P.Mich. inv. 6238 and corresponding leaves in the Chester Beatty Library) is the oldest surviving manuscript of an extensive collection of Pauline letters. It is usually dated palaeographically to the late second or early third century; the University of Michigan describes it in general terms as written about the year 200.

The codex preserves a significant order: Hebrews appears immediately after Romans, a sequence that differs from that of most modern Bibles. The sequence shows that early Pauline collections could be organised in different ways and that the order of the letters was not yet universally fixed.

P^{46} demonstrates neither dependence on Marcion's Apostolikon nor Marcionite influence on later codices. Its value is comparative: it physically shows that, around the same chronological horizon in which the controversies surrounding Marcion were still active, collections of Pauline letters existed in codex form, each with its own selection and order. The history of the canon must therefore be constructed from specific communities, codices, and collections, not solely from normative lists.

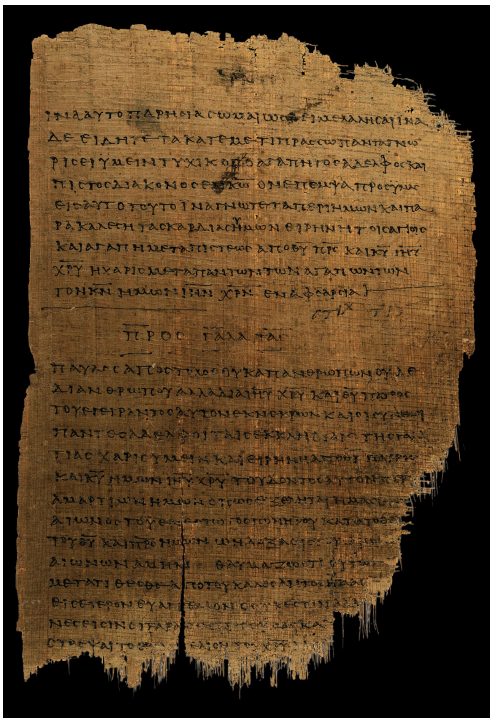


FIGURE 8. Facsimile of P46 with the end of Ephesians and the beginning of Galatians (Gal 1:1–8). Michigan, P.Mich. inv. 6238, old page 158. Approximate palaeographic dating c. 175–225, debated. Image from Michigan/APIS distributed by Wikimedia Commons as public domain. The title of the entry does not replace a comparison of the text. [FAC].

Documentary Window: P46

TABLE 16. Documentary window: P46

Field	Identification and scope
Siglum	Gregory–Aland P46, Beatty–Michigan Codex of Pauline Epistles.
Repositories	P.Mich. inv. 6238; leaves from Chester Beatty, Dublin.
Writing material and format	Papyrus; codex, not scroll.
Dating	Usually around 200, with a palaeographic margin that prevents fixing a year of copying.

(continued)

Field	Identification and scope
Origin	Acquired in Egypt; the exact archaeological context is not securely documented.
Content	Pauline Epistles and Hebrews; missing leaves and lines. The complete content of the missing parts is not assumed.
Relevant order	Hebrews follows Romans in the preserved and reconstructible sequence of the codex.
Editions	F. G. Kenyon, *The Chester Beatty Biblical Papyri* III; H. A. Sanders, *A Third-Century Papyrus Codex of the Epistles of Paul*; Michigan facsimiles and guide.

The inclusion of Hebrews in this collection is a material fact distinct from the historical question of its authorship. To complete the entry, a specific segment is presented: old page 158, the opening of Galatians (1:1–5), following the University of Michigan's guide and transcription. The numbers 1–10 correspond exclusively to the segment selected by the institutional guide, which begins mid-page; they are not the complete diplomatic numbering of the physical lines on the page. For a reproducible reference, the segment is therefore identified as old page 158, Gal 1:1–5, with reference to Sanders, Kenyon and the Michigan transcription. The lunate sigma (c) and the arrangement of the institutional transcription are preserved; this typographical choice is diplomatic and not a modern standardisation of Greek. Parentheses expand abbreviations and the open brackets reproduce the marking of the missing edge in the consulted transcription.

Table 17. P46: line-by-line diplomatic transcription

Line	Diplomatic transcription published by Michigan
1	παυλος αποστολος ουκ απ ανθρωπων ουδε
2	δι ανθρωπου αλλα δια ιη(co)υ χρ(ιcτο)υ και θ(εο)υ πατροc
3	του εγειραντος αυτον εκ νεκρων και οι cυν εμοι
4	παντες αδελφοι ταις εκκλησιαις της γαλα-
5	τιας χαρις υμειν και ειρηνη απο θ(εο)υ πατροc

(continued)

Line	Diplomatic transcription published by Michigan
6	και κ(υριο)υ ημων ιη(co)υ χρ(ιστο)υ του δοντος αυτον περι
7	αμαρτιων ημων οπως εξεληται ημας εκ τ[ου
8	αιωνος του ενεστωτος πονηρου κατα το θελ[ημα
9	του θ(εο)υ και π(ατρο)c ημων ω η δοξα εις τους αιωνας [των
10	αιωνων αμην

Translation of the meaning of the segment: “Paul, an apostle, not from human beings nor through a human being, but through Jesus Christ and God the Father, who raised him from the dead, and all the brothers who are with me, to the assemblies of Galatia: grace and peace from God the Father and from our Lord Jesus Christ, who gave himself for our sins to deliver us from the present evil age, according to the will of our God and Father, to whom be glory forever and ever. Amen.”

The guide records the placing of ἡμῶν after κυρίου in Galatians 1:3 and, in 1:4, the preposition περί where the comparison text has ὑπέρ. These differences document real transmission history without attributing to them a doctrinal controversy that the passage does not demonstrate. The transcription comes from an identified institutional publication: it is not presented as a new autopsy or as a complete collation of P^{46}. In line 6 the form αυτον is kept as printed in the Michigan transcription, without normalising it to ἑαυτόν.

5. The Antitheses and the problem of the two gods

The Antitheses are not directly preserved. Tertullian mentions them as a fundamental argumentative device of Marcion and attacks them chiefly in Books I–II and IV of Adversus Marcionem. The reconstruction must avoid two extremes: treating them as a book whose content could be restored word for word or reducing them to a caricature without historical substance.

The general principle attributed to Marcion contrasts the God of creation and the Law with the God revealed by Jesus Christ. Irenaeus summarises this opposition by distinguishing the God proclaimed by the Law and the Prophets from the Father of Jesus (Haer. I.27). The rhetoric of his adversaries intensifies these differences through pairs such as justice/goodness, known/unknown, and creator/Father. The

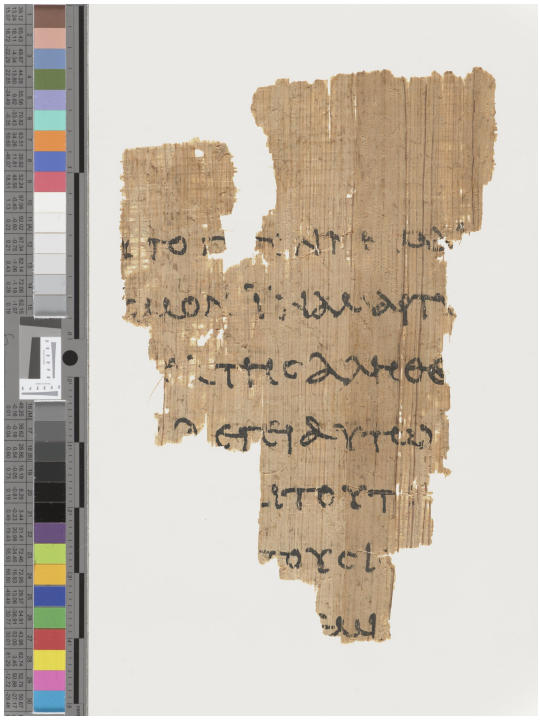


FIGURE 9. Fragment P52, P.Ryl. III 457, John Rylands Library, Manchester, with John 18:31–33 (recto) and 18:37–38 (verso), part of the interrogation before Pontius Pilate. Palaeographic dating debated, usually placed in the second century, with broader proposals. No exact year or absolute chronological primacy is assigned. Photograph by RylandsImaging, 2019, CC BY-SA 4.0. [IMG-HR].

historian must ask which of these oppositions reflect Marcionite formulations and which are polemical categories employed to make them refutable.[31]

5.1. Reconstructible examples of the antithetical procedure

The Antitheses are not preserved independently; therefore, the following examples are not printed as literal quotations from Marcion. They are reconstructions of the type of opposition that Tertullian attributes to his adversary. A first case contrasts the retributive legislation of the Creator—"an eye for an eye"—with the Gospel commandments not to retaliate and to turn the other cheek. For Marcion, according

[31] Tertullian, Marc. I–II and IV. The description of the Antitheses depends on a polemical work; the examples are not reproduced as literal words recovered from Marcion.

to Tertullian's polemical reconstruction, this difference would indicate two divine principles; Tertullian's response consists precisely in demonstrating that justice and goodness belong to the same God.

A second example revolves around punitive fire. The God of the Scriptures of Israel can punish by fire; in Luke 9:54–56, however, Jesus rejects the disciples' initiative to call down fire from heaven. The value of this locus for an antithetical argument is evident. At the same time, because we know this opposition only through an adversary, we must distinguish between Marcionite reasoning and the way in which Tertullian reorganises it to refute it.

A third type of antithesis contrasts the promises and signs of the Creator with the appearance of a Christ considered separate from that God. Here, it is not only moral maxims that are opposed: the debate centres on which Scripture can claim Christ as its own fulfilment. This level shows that the Antitheses constituted a theory of interpretation and divine economy, not simply a collection of paradoxes.

It is methodologically imprecise simply to classify Marcion as "Gnostic." His thought shares problems with other movements of the second century, but his relationship with creation, Scripture, Christ, and Paul has a configuration of its own. Lieu's work clearly demonstrates that Marcion must be situated within the Christian debate of the second century and not within a rigid, retrospectively constructed taxonomy.

6. A first New Testament?

The formula "first New Testament" is useful only if carefully defined. Jason BeDuhn has used it to highlight that Marcion brought together a gospel and a set of Pauline letters into a coherent scriptural collection (BeDuhn 2013). However, this formulation does not imply that Christian collections did not circulate before Marcion, nor that later communities simply adopted his model.

It is preferable to distinguish three phenomena: the circulation of individual writings; the formation of collections; and normative canonical delimitation. These processes overlap, but are not identical. Marcion clearly belongs to the second and contributes to the third, because his selection forced other authors to specify more precisely which texts they recognised and why. Even so, the formation of the canon of four Gospels and the New Testament corpus was gradual and cannot be attributed to a single reaction.[32]

[32] Gallagher and Meade 2017; Barton 1997; Lieu 2015. Normative reading, physical collection and closed list are distinguished.

7. Irenaeus and the defence of the fourfold gospel

At the end of the second century, Irenaeus provides decisive testimony to a new phase. In Adversus haereses III, he explicitly defends the authority of four Gospels and links them to the apostolic tradition. The historical force of this argument lies not only in the well-known symbolism of the number four, but also in the fact that it presupposes a body of Gospels already in circulation whose delimitation he needs to defend against real alternatives.

The response to Marcion, to Valentinian groups, and to other adversaries did not consist simply in establishing a list of books. It involved articulating a relationship between Scripture, the rule of faith, apostolic succession, and ecclesial reading. The canon must therefore be studied as part of a technology of authority: texts, interpreters, institutions, and apostolic memories legitimised one another.

In this context, "orthodoxy" does not designate an essence that existed complete from the beginning. It designates a historical configuration that acquired mechanisms of self-reproduction: lists, episcopate, genealogies of teaching, liturgy, and criteria of interpretation. Recognising this process does not mean denying the existence of early shared convictions; it means explaining how certain convictions managed to become translocal norms.[33]

8. Non-canonical gospels and ecologies of transmission

The formation of the fourfold gospel cannot be understood solely from the four texts that eventually acquired canonical authority. The second century and the centuries immediately following transmit a much wider constellation of writings presented as gospels, revelations, collections of sayings, or narrative expansions of episodes absent from Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John. The term "non-canonical" is used here descriptively: it indicates the later position of these writings in relation to the dominant church collections, not an intrinsic literary quality or a uniform date of exclusion.

The modern category of "apocryphal" also requires precision. Current scholarship increasingly uses the expression "early Christian apocryphal literature" to avoid the impression that there is a closed corpus perfectly parallel to the New Testament. These texts circulated in different ways, were read by different audiences, and did not always function as Scripture for separate communities. Manuscript evidence and ancient references require each work to be studied individually.

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[33] Irenaeus, Haer. III.11.8. Reference: Rousseau and Doutreleau 1974, SC 210–211. The fourfold argument is not used as a document of an identical canon in all communities.

The aim of this section is not to reconstruct a supposed homogeneous "alternative canon," but to show the diversity of forms in which Christians of the second to fourth centuries continued to write about Jesus, the apostles, Mary, revelation, and salvation. Comparison with the canonical gospels must be made on a case-by-case basis, taking into account genre, language, manuscript transmission, literary dependence, and context of use.

8.1. Gospel of Thomas: sayings, dependence and dating

The Gospel of Thomas, preserved in its entirety in Coptic as NHC II,2 and also known from Greek fragments from Oxyrhynchus, contains 114 sayings attributed to Jesus. It lacks a continuous narrative of passion and resurrection and organises its material as a collection of logia. This literary form makes it a central source for the study of the memory of Jesus's sayings, but it does not, on its own, demonstrate independence from the Synoptic Gospels.

The dating and literary relationship of Thomas to Matthew and Luke remain a subject of debate. Some scholarship has argued for an early, independent core; other studies, including those by Simon Gathercole and Mark Goodacre, have argued in detail that the known version of Thomas presupposes knowledge of the Synoptic Gospels. This monograph does not use Thomas as automatic proof of a pre-Synoptic tradition: it distinguishes between the possible antiquity of individual sayings and the date/composition of the writing as a whole.

From a material standpoint, the difference between the Nag Hammadi Coptic manuscript and the Greek fragments is methodologically decisive. The Coptic codex is considerably later than the text's composition; the Greek fragments demonstrate earlier circulation and support the view that the Coptic version derives from a Greek tradition.[34]

8.2. Judeo-Christian gospels: fragments and modern categories

The so-called Gospel of the Hebrews, Gospel of the Nazarenes, and Gospel of the Ebionites do not survive as complete books. They are reconstructed from fragments quoted or paraphrased by authors such as Clement of Alexandria, Origen, Epiphanius, and Jerome. The tripartite taxonomy is modern, and it is not always possible to determine whether each ancient reference refers to a different work.

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[34] Gospel of Thomas, NHC II,2; fragments P.Oxy. I 1, IV 654 and IV 655. Gathercole 2012 and Goodacre 2012 discuss the synoptic dependence; the date of individual sayings is distinguished from the composition of the writing.

Their importance for the history of the differentiation between Judaism and Christianity lies precisely in this difficulty. The fragments document forms of gospel tradition linked to communities that maintained Jewish practices, identities, or memories, but they do not allow for the reconstruction of a single "Judeo-Christian Church" or a linear genealogy from Jerusalem. The analysis is limited to what each fragment attests and avoids harmonising them into a continuous hypothetical gospel.

8.3. Gospels of revelation and cosmology



Figure 10. Provenances of Egyptian Christian material. Editorial orientation map showing Alexandria, the Fayyum, Oxyrhynchus, Hermopolis, Antinoopolis, Panopolis, Nag Hammadi, and Thebes. Points indicate provenances or find contexts discussed in the text, not population densities. [REC-GRAF/IA]. Illustrative schematic prepared for this edition; positions and routes are not a cartographic reconstruction to scale. Place names on the map are given in their Spanish forms.

The so-called Apocryphon of John, preserved in several Coptic recensions—among them NHC II,1; III,1 and IV,1—presents a post-resurrection revelation in which Jesus communicates a complex cosmogony to John. The work is fundamental

for studying traditions that modern historiography has linked to so-called "Sethianism." Its value, however, lies not in representing a universal Gnostic doctrine, but in documenting a specific form of Christian exegesis, myth, and revelation.

The Gospel of Truth, NHC I,3 and XII,2, is not a narrative gospel either. It is a homiletic or meditative composition centred on the knowledge of the Father, error, and revelation. Its affinity with Valentinian traditions is widely recognised, but its direct attribution to Valentinus cannot be considered certain. It is preferable to speak of a Valentinian text, or one close to that milieu, rather than presenting it as the master's own work.

The Gospel of Judas, preserved in the Codex Tchacos, offers a particularly illustrative case of the distance between composition and manuscript. Towards the end of the second century Irenaeus knew of a text called the Gospel of Judas; the surviving version is a Coptic translation in a later codex, probably from the late third or fourth century, and presupposes a Greek original. The text reverses the conventional assessment of Judas and places him within a cosmological revelation; its exact relationship to the work mentioned by Irenaeus must be formulated with caution, although the identification is widely accepted.

8.4. Infancy gospels and narrative expansion

The Protoevangelium of James expands upon the accounts of Jesus' origins through a narrative centred on Joachim and Anne, the birth of Mary, her consecration, and her virginity. The text demonstrates how, as early as the second century, the silences of the canonical gospels could become spaces for narrative and devotional elaboration. Its historical importance lies less in providing biographical information about Mary than in documenting the formation of Marian memory and piety.

The Infancy Gospel of Thomas recounts episodes from Jesus' childhood through miracles, punishments, and demonstrations of power. The tone of some accounts may seem strange to modern sensibilities, but precisely for this reason, it is a relevant source for studying how different communities imagined the childhood of a figure about whose early years the canonical gospels say very little.

These writings should not be classified simply as "late fiction" in a pejorative sense. They are reception documents: they reveal questions that the canonical texts left open and show how the memory of Jesus and his family continued to expand in Christian narrative practice.

8.5. Gospels of passion and apostolic authority: Peter and Mary

The Gospel of Peter is a particularly important witness to the reception of the passion and resurrection traditions. Recent research has strongly argued for its direct or indirect dependence on Synoptic materials; its value lies in showing how the passion narratives continued to be rewritten in the second century, incorporating new theological and narrative features.

The Gospel of Mary, preserved only in fragments in Coptic and Greek, shifts the focus of interest to Mary's revelatory authority and the conflict among disciples. Its importance for this monograph lies not in identifying a specific community behind the text, but in documenting that apostolic authority and the legitimacy of revelation could be articulated through figures and hierarchies different from those that dominated later ecclesial memory.

8.6. Nag Hammadi: material status, language and transmission

The discovery of the Nag Hammadi codices in 1945 transformed the study of early Christianity because it provided access to texts, some of which had until then been known only through their adversaries. However, the discovery does not eliminate the problem of transmission: the surviving codices are Coptic manuscripts from Late Antiquity, while many of the works they contain were composed centuries earlier and, in several cases, translated from Greek originals.

This distance must be recorded in every analysis. A text composed in the second century and preserved in a fourth-century Coptic codex does not constitute direct material evidence from the second century. Its content may date back to that period, but the preserved copy belongs to a different historical, linguistic, and monastic or ascetic context whose interpretation remains a subject of debate. The variations among different Coptic versions also show that the translation and copying were not mechanical processes.

For this reason, this monograph systematically distinguishes between the date of the manuscript, the probable date of composition, and the date of the first external references. The same distinction is applied to the canonical gospels and all early Christian literature.[35]

[35] King 2003; Brakke 2010; Williams 1996. The Nag Hammadi discovery does not demonstrate a uniform community behind all the works in the collection.

8.7. The myth of the "forbidden gospels"

The popular expression "forbidden gospels" oversimplifies a long and uneven process. There was no single act in the second century by which a central authority eliminated all alternative texts at once. Some writings were condemned by specific authors; others ceased to be copied in certain networks; still others continued to circulate for centuries in different contexts.

The survival of manuscripts depends on multiple factors: liturgical use, pedagogical value, attributed apostolic prestige, availability of copies, networks of copyists, language, writing material, doctrinal changes, and, in some periods, explicit censorship. Reducing this process to a conspiracy, or at the opposite extreme, to a purely spontaneous selection, distorts the material history of books.

Therefore, the problem of the canon is formulated as a history of circulation, selection, copying, reading, and delimitation. The authority of a text was produced in concrete practices before crystallising into normative lists.

8.8. Scroll, codex and the materiality of the collection

The early Christian preference for the codex is one of the most striking material features of Christian written culture. In a world where the scroll remained a common medium, Christian manuscripts of the second and third centuries show a disproportionately high presence of the codex. The phenomenon is well documented, although its causes remain debated.

The codex offered practical advantages for gathering various writings within a single physical unit, locating passages, and transporting collections. This capacity proved especially significant for corpora such as the Pauline epistles or, later, collections of gospels. However, it should not be claimed that the codex "caused" the canon: the relationship between book technology and textual delimitation is facilitative, not deterministic.

The history of the canon, therefore, must incorporate the material technology of writing. Selecting four gospels or compiling Pauline epistles was not merely an intellectual decision; it involved copying, arranging, binding quires, financing manuscripts, and ensuring their circulation.[36]

[36] Nongbri 2018; Hurtado 2006. Book form, selection of writings and copying chronology are considered related but distinct problems.

8.9. The transmission gap and the text of the canonical gospels

Textual criticism must apply the same rigour to the canonical gospels as it applies to Marcion and apocryphal literature. We possess no autographs of Matthew, Mark, Luke, or John. The first-century texts are reconstructed from later manuscripts, patristic quotations, and early versions, all of which belong to a history of copying with variants.

P^{52}, a small fragment of John, has traditionally been dated to the first half of the second century, although the precision of this palaeographic dating has been questioned and it is now better expressed as a broad range. P75, which preserves extensive portions of Luke and John, is usually dated to the early third century—although Brent Nongbri (2016) has argued for a fourth-century date—and is among the oldest witnesses to both Gospels in a single codex. The existence of these manuscripts reduces the gap between composition and the surviving copies, but does not eliminate it.

The methodological consequence is important: "canonical" does not mean "transmitted without variants." The relative stability of large portions of the text can coexist with local differences, omissions, additions, and different orderings. Modern critical editions are precisely the instrument that makes this history of transmission visible.[37]

Documentary Window: P75

Table 18. Documentary window: P75

Field	Identification and scope
Siglum	Gregory–Aland P^{75}, former P.Bodmer XIV–XV.
Custody	Vatican Apostolic Library, Pap.Hanna.1.
Writing material and format	Papyrus codex; extensive portions of Luke and John.
Dating	Generally third century; the palaeographic precision is disputed and is not converted into an absolute date.
Material information	Two gospels transmitted in the same codex; gaps and losses must be recorded by leaf.

[37] Palaeographic dating requires date ranges and independent checks; Nongbri 2018. Uneven transmission does not authorise replacing lost leaves with assumed content.

(continued)

Field	Identification and scope
Source of information	DigiVatLib catalogue and facsimile; CSNTM codicological identification.
Limit	Textual proximity to other witnesses does not demonstrate a direct copying relationship.

The presence of Luke and John within the same physical unit allows for the study of text selection and organisation without automatically inferring a complete codex of four gospels. The manuscript is also relevant to loci where the tradition varies. This importance does not eliminate the need to distinguish between the age of the copy, the possible age of a reading, and judgement on the authorial text.[38]

8.10. Summary critical catalogue

The following catalogue expands upon the previous selection and organises the principal non-canonical gospels and gospel texts from the first to the fourth century. The dates are working ranges, not absolute dates; the language indicated corresponds to the most probable original and is always distinguished from the language of the extant manuscript. The term "gospel" is retained when it forms part of the ancient title or the tradition of reception, even though some works are collections of sayings, revelatory dialogues, homilies, or infancy narratives rather than narrative gospels in the synoptic sense.

The classification avoids the "illusion of the canon": the authors and readers of the second and third centuries did not necessarily conceive of their output as a collection of "apocrypha" opposed to a closed New Testament. Following the problem posed by Eva Mroczek regarding the ancient literary imagination, it is necessary to reconstruct an ecology of texts, memories and revelations in which authorship, corpus, and authority remained fluid. The gradual establishment of canonical lists did not immediately halt the composition, copying, or reading of narratives about Jesus, Mary, and the apostles.

A distinction must also be made between composition and transmission. A second-century text may be preserved only in a fourth-century Coptic codex; a work

[38] CSNTM Catalogue, GA P75: `https://manuscripts.csntm.org/manuscript/View/GA_P75`. Vatican identification: Pap.Hanna.1, `https://digi.vatlib.it/view/MSS_Pap.Hanna.1`. The catalogue identification is used; it is not claimed that all images or variants of the facsimile have been checked.

known to a heresiologist may not have survived as an independent book; and a modern designation may group together fragments that Antiquity did not treat as a single text. Therefore, the table includes a column for material evidence and another for critical caution.

TABLE 19. Summary critical catalogue of texts

Text	Date of composition	Likely original language	Preserved testimony	Critical caution
Gospel of Thomas	second century; possibility of earlier materials discussed	Greek	NHC II,2 (Coptic, fourth century); P.Oxy. I 1, IV 654, IV 655 (Greek)	Collection of 114 sayings. Do not date the complete text to the first century nor assume independence from the Synoptic Gospels.
Gospel of the Hebrews	early to mid-second century	Probably Greek; Semitic origin disputed	Fragments cited by Clement, Origen, Jerome, and others	Lost Judeo-Christian text; not to be automatically confused with Nazarenes or Ebionites.
Egerton Gospel / P.Egerton 2	composition second century; manuscript c. 200	Greek	P.Egerton 2 + P.Köln 255	Ancient title unknown. Fragments of episodes about Jesus; relationship with John and the Synoptic Gospels disputed.
Gospel of Peter	second century, probably the second half	Greek	Fragment of Akhmim and other attributed/discussed fragments	Passion-resurrection narrative. Dependence on and relationship with canonical traditions remain debated.
Gospel of Mary	second century	Greek	BG 8502 (Coptic); P.Ryl. III 463 and P.Oxy. L 3525 (Greek)	Dialogue/revelation with conflict of authority among disciples. Do not infer an autonomous community without external evidence.

(continued)

Text	Date of composition	Likely original language	Preserved testimony	Critical caution
Gospel of Judas	second century, before Irenaeus c. 180	Greek	Codex Tchacos (Coptic, late manuscript)	Irenaeus is familiar with a Gospel of Judas; the identification with the Coptic work is plausible and widely accepted, but not demonstrable by autograph.
Gospel of Truth	mid- to late second century	Greek	NHC I,3 and XII,2 (Coptic)	It is not a narrative gospel but a homily/meditation. Valentinian affinity; direct authorship by Valentinus is not certain.
Protoevangelium of James	second half of the second century	Greek	Extensive Greek tradition and ancient versions	An infancy narrative centred on Mary. A source for reception history, not a contemporary biography.
Infancy Gospel of Thomas	second century, with a complex textual history	Greek	Greek recensions and Syriac, Latin and other versions	Childhood narratives of Jesus. It should be distinguished from the sayings Gospel of Thomas.
Gospel of the Egyptians	second century	Greek	Only fragments/patristic quotations	Lost work; very limited reconstruction. Not to be confused with the Coptic Gospel of the Egyptians of Nag Hammadi.
Gospel of the Ebionites	second century	Greek	Fragments mainly in Epiphanius	Judeo-Christian synoptic harmonisation reconstructed from a late hostile source.
Gospel of the Nazarenes	second–third centuries; uncertain dating	Disputed language: Aramaic/Hebrew or Greek	Patristic fragments, especially Jerome	The textual entity itself is debated; avoid reconstructing a complete book from heterogeneous fragments.

(continued)

Text	Date of composition	Likely original language	Preserved testimony	Critical caution
Traditions / Gospel of Matthias	second century	Greek	Patristic quotations and reports	Very fragmentary. The relationship between the Traditions of Matthias and a supposed Gospel of Matthias is uncertain.
Gospel of Philip	third century, probably first half to the middle of the century	Greek	NHC II,3 (Coptic, fourth century)	A collection of sacramental and exegetical reflections from a Valentinian milieu; not a narrative gospel.
Apocryphon of John	second–third centuries	Greek	NHC II,1; III,1; IV,1; BG 8502 (Coptic)	Post-resurrection revelation; several recensions. Fundamental for traditions called Sethian, not a model of all "Gnosticism".
Acts of Pilate / Core of the Gospel of Nicodemus	fourth century in its preserved Christian form; possible antecedents	Greek	Greek tradition and later versions	Text of the passion and trial of Jesus. The medieval form known as the Gospel of Nicodemus is composite and later.
Questions of Bartholomew	third–fourth centuries (range disputed)	Greek	Later Greek, Latin, and Slavic traditions	Apocalyptic/ revelatory dialogue. It should be distinguished from the lost Gospel of Bartholomew mentioned in lists.

Classification note. Pistis Sophia and other major revelatory treatises from the late third to early fourth centuries are discussed in the chapter on alternative movements and literatures, but are not included here as "gospels" in the strict sense. Similarly, Pseudo-Matthew and several Latin infancy cycles are later than the main chronological framework of this monograph and are reserved for reception history. Pistis Sophia is treated there as late Gnostic reception and complex composition, not as direct testimony from the schools of the second century.

8.11. From the catalogue to the history of circulation

The historical value of this repertoire lies not in counting titles "outside the canon," but in observing the persistence of gospel production after the composition of the four Gospels that ultimately became canonical. The second and third centuries simultaneously show narrative expansion, collections of sayings, post-resurrection revelations, rewritings of the Passion, and the elaboration of infancy traditions. The canonical closure was a process of selection and standardisation within a literary field that continued to produce texts.

Material transmission confirms this plurality: Oxyrhynchus preserves Greek fragments of Thomas and other gospels; Nag Hammadi preserves Coptic translations of earlier Greek works; the Tchacos Codex transmits Judas in Coptic; the Judeo-Christian gospels survive mainly through adversarial quotations. The documentary map is therefore asymmetrical: late manuscript abundance does not equate to widespread early circulation, and a lost work known only through quotations may have had a circulation that the vagaries of preservation have obscured.

8.12. Main canonical lists and configurations of the second–fourth centuries

The delimitation of the New Testament was not a single act. The following lists belong to different genres and should not be considered equivalent decrees.

Table 20. Canonical lists and configurations of the second–fourth centuries: witnesses

Testimony	Date	Configuration / data	Historical value	Caution
Irenaeus, Haer. III.11.8	c. 180	Explicit defence of four gospels	Milestone for the fourfold gospel	It is not a complete list of the NT.
Muratorian Fragment: Latin canonical list (codex in the Biblioteca Ambrosiana, Milan, eighth century)	Late second / third century; debated	Fragmentary Latin list of accepted and rejected books	Early Western testimony	Beginning lost; date and place disputed.
Origen apud Eusebius, HE VI.25	Third century	Recognised and disputed books	It shows diversity of reception	Transmitted by Eusebius.
Eusebius, HE III.25	Early fourth century	ὁμολογούμενα, ἀντιλεγόμενα and others	Reception taxonomy	Describes plurality rather than closing it off.

(continued)

Testimony	Date	Configuration / data	Historical value	Caution
Athanasius, Fest. 39	367	First preserved list coinciding with the current 27	Egyptian landmark	It did not instantly impose a universal canon.

9. Heresy, classification, and the construction of boundaries

The case of Marcion clarifies the vocabulary of "heresy." The Greek αἵρεσις could initially mean choice, school, or party; in second-century Christian literature, the term acquired an increasingly normative function. Irenaeus not only describes doctrines: he orders them within a genealogy of deviations and, by contrast, constructs a legitimate apostolic continuity.

Heresiology is therefore a dual source. It informs us about groups, teachers, texts, and practices that would otherwise be less well known, but at the same time it reconfigures these materials according to a strategy of refutation. Historical research must take advantage of its documentary density without automatically adopting its taxonomies.

In the chapters dedicated to Valentinians and other movements, the same rule applies. "Valentinian" designates, when the evidence allows, networks and traditions related to Valentinus and his successors; "Sethian" is used as a modern category for certain texts and mythologies, not as if it were necessarily a uniform ancient self-designation.

10. Spread and persistence of the Marcionite churches

The historical importance of Marcion did not end with the Roman controversy of the mid-second century. Justin presents him as a teacher whose teachings had spread widely; Tertullian, several decades later, attacks still-active Marcionite communities; later sources preserve accounts of his presence in various eastern regions. Although these testimonies are adversarial, their convergence rules out reducing Marcionism to an ephemeral intellectual circle. The Greek inscription from Deir Ali (ancient Lebaba, south of Damascus), dated 318/319 CE and naming a 'synagogue of the Marcionites', provides material evidence independent of heresiology.

The Marcionite churches must have possessed sufficient structures to sustain communities, ministers, liturgical readings, and textual transmission. This persistence is crucial to the history of the canon: a collection of Scriptures acquires historical efficacy when a community copies, reads, interprets, and transmits it.

The heresiological condemnation and social disappearance were not simultaneous processes. Ecclesiastical memory was able to classify Marcion as an adversary early on, while communities that identified with his tradition continued to exist for generations. The discussion carefully distinguishes between contemporary testimonies, later accounts, and geographical claims whose accuracy cannot be verified.

11. Conclusion of the chapter

Marcion brings into sharp relief a qualitative shift in second-century Christianity: texts are no longer merely vehicles for memory and teaching, but also explicit instruments for defining identity and authority. His Gospel and his Apostolikon demonstrate a coherent selection of Scripture; the responses of Irenaeus and Tertullian show that this selection was perceived as a dispute over the continuity between Jesus, the apostles, Israel, and the Church. The convergence of Marcion, Tatian—whose Diatessaron (c. 170) harmonised the four gospels into a single narrative—and Irenaeus makes it possible to describe three second-century editorial technologies without turning them into a linear sequence: the selection and delimitation of corpora, narrative harmonisation, and the stabilisation of a fourfold plurality. The contrast offers a macro-narrative of gospel formation: not an inevitable passage towards the canon, but concurrent responses to the same problem of textual authority.

The formation of the canon cannot be reduced to "Marcion brought about the New Testament." The evidence points to earlier processes of collection and circulation, and subsequent stabilisation was gradual. But Marcion was a catalyst of extraordinary importance because he forced the formulation of questions that could

no longer remain implicit: which gospel, which Paul, which God, which Scriptures, and which apostolic tradition should serve as the norm.

The following chapter examines how these questions developed within the Christian plurality of the second century, with particular attention to Ignatius, 1 Clement, the Didache, the Shepherd of Hermas, Justin, and Irenaeus. The focus is not on a linear progression from "diversity" to "orthodoxy," but rather on the historical formation of mechanisms of authority in specific communities.

Summary

This chapter examines Marcion, the authority of Scripture, and the formation of Christian textual collections. It studies the lost Marcionite Gospel and the Apostolikon through the testimonies of their adversaries, with explicit levels of reconstruction. P46 and P75 provide material evidence for the circulation and organisation of the texts. The non-canonical gospels and the Nag Hammadi writings are studied as distinct transmission histories. The chapter distinguishes between authoritative readings, codex collections, and closed canonical lists.

Keywords: Marcion; canon; textual transmission; P46; P75; non-canonical gospels.

CHAPTER III

Community Plurality and Mechanisms of Authority in the Second Century

The transition from the first to the second century is not simply the maturation of an already defined institution. On the contrary, the sources from this period reveal a landscape of communities simultaneously experiencing geographical expansion, doctrinal diversification, ritual elaboration, and competition for legitimacy. The memory of Jesus and the apostles, the interpretation of the Scriptures of Israel, the circulation of Christian texts, and the organisation of community life become explicit sources of authority. What in previous decades might have remained implicit or locally negotiated now begins to be formulated with greater precision and, in many cases, with greater combativeness.

This chapter examines that process without projecting onto it the retrospective image of an already consolidated "Great Church." Categories such as orthodoxy, heresy, and Gnosticism are employed with methodological caution: they are recorded when ancient sources use them or when they prove analytically useful, but they do not become the pre-established framework for organising the narrative. The aim is not to draw a straight line from plurality to uniformity, but to analyse how, in specific contexts, mechanisms of legitimation—episcopate, succession, rule of faith, collections of texts, liturgical practice, and heresiological discourse—were constructed that would later allow for more stable forms of collective identity. Modern discussion of this problem largely starts from Walter Bauer, Rechtgläubigkeit und Ketzerei im ältesten Christentum (1934; Eng. trans. Orthodoxy and Heresy in Earliest Christianity, 1971), whose thesis on the local priority of forms later declared heretical has been corrected on many points but still sets the agenda of the debate.

The sources from this period are diverse in genre and should not be harmonised. The letters of Ignatius of Antioch document a passionate defence of unity around the bishop and of the bodily reality of Christ's Passion. 1 Clement intervenes in a

conflict within the Corinthian community by appealing to the order and memory of the apostles. The Didache preserves practical instructions on ethics, baptism, fasting, prayer, and the Eucharist, along with tensions between itinerant prophets and local authorities. The Shepherd of Hermas offers a visionary and moral testimony of the Roman community, concerned with repentance and the social composition of the Church. Justin Martyr, through apologetics and dialogue, develops an interpretation of the Scriptures and the "memoirs of the apostles" that seeks to define the movement in relation to both Judaism and other Christian currents. Irenaeus of Lyons, for his part, represents a decisive moment in the articulation of the rule of faith, the fourfold gospel, and a genealogy of truth that is constructed in opposition to what he presents as deviations.

Each of these texts responds to particular situations. Ignatius writes in chains, in a context of crisis and on a journey towards martyrdom; 1 Clement intervenes from Rome in a conflict not its own; the Didache reflects the concerns of communities still negotiating the relationship between charism and office; Justin addresses both external and internal audiences; Irenaeus develops a far-reaching project in response to what he perceives as doctrinal threats. The diversity of genres, geographical horizons, and argumentative strategies is, in itself, a historical fact of major importance.

The chapter thus proceeds by successively analysing these testimonies, paying attention to their contexts, their vocabulary, and the mechanisms of authority that each one employs. Only after this particular examination is a synthesis offered of the main mechanisms by which the communities of the second century attempted to define, delimit, and transmit what they considered legitimate teaching and practice. The result is not the image of a uniform institution, but rather that of a field of forces in which real plurality and the search for coherence coexisted and shaped each other.

This approach connects the present chapter with the preceding ones. If the first century showed the emergence of the movement within Judaism and the conflicts arising from the incorporation of Gentiles, the second century reveals how these communities, now larger and more diverse, began to develop more explicit instruments of identity and regulation. The formation of boundaries was neither a single episode nor a homogeneous process; it was the cumulative result of local decisions, controversies, ritual practices, and memory strategies that, over time, acquired greater translocal reach.

1. The sources of the period and the diversity of its genres

The second-century sources do not form a homogeneous archive. A pastoral letter, a liturgical instruction, an apology addressed to imperial power, a prophetic vision and a treatise against doctrinal opponents construct their subject matter differently. The first methodological requirement is therefore to resist turning them into chapters of a single ecclesiastical history organised in advance.

1 Clement and the letters of Ignatius belong to epistolary networks, but they do not fulfil the same function. The former intervenes in a leadership crisis in Corinth and argues using biblical examples, cosmic order, apostolic memory, and community discipline. Ignatius, on the other hand, writes from a personal situation of captivity and makes unity around the bishop, the presbyters, and the deacons a repeated theme of exhortation.

The Didache offers a different kind of access. Its interest lies less in grand doctrinal formulations than in the regulation of practices: moral catechesis, baptism, fasting, prayer, hospitality, the Eucharist, discernment of prophets, and the appointment of local authorities. It is precisely this everyday materiality that makes it an extraordinary source for observing how a community attempts to transform charism and mobility into sustainable norms.

The Shepherd of Hermas combines vision, command, parable, and moral exhortation. Its historical value does not depend on reading its visions as a literal description of events, but on recognising the social and disciplinary problems that these visions presuppose: wealth, repentance, authority, exclusion, and reintegration.

Justin's Apologies and Dialogue with Trypho belong to still distinct registers. The author mounts a public defence of Christianity, claims rationality for Christian belief, and, at the same time, delimits his position in relation to Jews and other groups that also identify with Christ. With Irenaeus, finally, the classification of rival doctrines achieves a systematic structure: describing the adversary and defining one's own truth become inseparable operations.[39]

2. 1 Clement: order, conflict and apostolic memory

The so-called First Letter of Clement is a particularly important witness to the ways in which one community could intervene in the life of another without yet possessing the legal structures that would characterise later centuries. It was sent by the church

[39] Holmes 2007, texts and translations of the Apostolic Fathers; Gregory and Tuckett 2005, transmission and reception studies. Scholarly commentaries are identified by author in the bibliography.

at Rome to Corinth in response to a crisis in which some leaders had been removed from their positions. The letter does not present itself as a decree from an individual Roman bishop; it speaks on behalf of the sending community and builds its authority through argumentation, memory, and exhortation. The conventional date of c. 95–97 CE rests on the allusion in 1 Clem. 1:1 to misfortunes that had befallen the Roman community and on the tradition reported by Eusebius (HE III.16), although some studies allow a wider chronological range.

The Corinthian conflict is interpreted through the vocabulary of order. The term τάξις—order, arrangement—appears within a broader vision according to which God has arranged creation, worship, and community in an orderly manner. The argument is not merely administrative: transforming a local conflict into a problem of τάξις allows it to be endowed with theological and scriptural depth.

Philologically, τάξις belongs to a broad semantic field that can designate disposition, order, rank, or arrangement. The term circulated far beyond Christian vocabulary, in philosophical, civic, military, and cultic contexts. Its use in 1 Clement does not demonstrate a direct dependence on a particular school; it shows how a Greco-Roman lexicon of order could be put at the service of scriptural and communal argumentation.

One of the decisive passages is found in 1 Clement 42–44. There, the apostles appear as sent by Christ and, in turn, as those who established leaders in the communities and ensured the continuity of that ministry. The text is fundamental to the history of succession, but it must be read with precision. It does not yet unequivocally describe the monarchical episcopal system that Ignatius would defend in some cities of Asia Minor. It speaks of ἐπίσκοποι and διάκονοι—and, in 44.4–5, of πρεσβύτεροι, without clearly distinguishing the two terms—and seeks to legitimise continuity of service in response to a deposition deemed unjustified.

The use of Peter and Paul in 1 Clement 5 is equally revealing. Both serve as recent examples of perseverance and suffering. Rome does not base its intervention solely on geographical proximity or institutional precedence; it mobilises a shared apostolic memory to define models of conduct. Authority is thus built through example rather than through a fully developed legal theory.

The important historiographical point is twofold. On the one hand, 1 Clement shows that certain communities could attempt to correct others and that Rome possessed the symbolic resources to do so. On the other, to treat it at once as proof of an already established papal jurisdiction would be anachronistic. The evidence supports the conclusion that translocal intervention occurred and that apostolic memory was

invoked; the exact institutional form of this authority must be reconstructed without projecting later structures.[40]

3. Ignatius of Antioch: unity, episcopate and the reality of the Passion

The letters of Ignatius of Antioch offer a much more explicit picture of the bishop as a focus of unity. Written while their author was being taken under guard to Rome, the letters combine martyrological autobiography, communal exhortation, doctrinal polemic, and concern for the cohesion of the churches. The traditional dating under Trajan (c. 110 CE), based on Eusebius, has been questioned: some scholars propose the 130s or 140s (e.g. T. D. Barnes, "The Date of Ignatius," 2008). The question does not diminish their value as evidence for an episcopal model under construction, but it does affect where they stand in the second-century sequence.

In several passages, Ignatius articulates a triad formed by bishop, presbyters, and deacons. The rhetorical force of this structure is undeniable. In Smyrn. 8.1, for example, he urges his readers to follow the bishop as Jesus Christ followed the Father, and the presbytery as they would the apostles. The text reveals a clear ecclesiological project: visible communion must be organised around recognisable authorities.

However, the programmatic nature of the exhortation is precisely a reason not to universalise it. Ignatius insists on obedience because unity is contested. His letters document the existence and defence of an episcopal model in certain communities, rather than demonstrating that all the churches of the Empire had already adopted the same structure. Significantly, his letter to the Romans mentions no bishop of Rome.

The institutional problem is intertwined with the Christological one. Ignatius insists that Jesus truly suffered, was truly crucified, and rose again. The adverb ἀληθῶς—"truly"—acquires a polemical value in this context. The defence of the flesh of Christ is not an abstract speculation: it defines communion, the Eucharist, and authority against adversaries whom Ignatius considers incompatible with the community's identity.

The polemical value of ἀληθῶς stems precisely from its ordinary adverbial function: "truly," "in truth." Ignatius exploits this lexical simplicity to transform the reality of birth, suffering, and resurrection into a criterion of belonging. This is not a philosophical technicality imported without mediation, but a common word that, repeated within a Christological controversy, acquires confessional weight.

[40] 1 Clem. 5.1–7; 42.1–5; 44.1–6. Jaubert, SC 167; Holmes 2007. The loci and institutional scope are discussed in the documentary appendix.

The use of Χριστιανισμός also deserves attention. The word should not be automatically interpreted as the name of a religion already defined according to modern categories. In Ignatius, it functions within a discourse of differentiation and belonging, in tension with Ἰουδαϊσμός. Precisely for this reason, it is an important testimony that certain boundaries could be formulated with increasing clarity in some circles at the beginning of the second century.

Ignatius' contribution to the chapter's general problem is clear: episcopate, Eucharist, Christology, and discipline appear united as mechanisms of cohesion. Institutional authority does not arise separately from doctrinal content; both reinforce each other.[41]

4. The Didache: practice, ritual and negotiation between charisma and office

The Didache reveals a different kind of authority. Its opening teaching on the "Two Ways" places moral formation before dogmatic definition. The text then goes on to regulate baptism, fasting, prayer, the Eucharist, hospitality, and discernment of teachers and prophets.

Chapter 7 prescribes baptism "in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit," preferably in running water, but allows for adaptations when material conditions do not permit it. This detail is historically valuable: the norm does not ignore contingency, but rather incorporates alternatives. Early ritual practices already appear regulated, but not rigidly confined to a single material form.

Chapters 8–10 distinguish days of fasting and transmit Eucharistic prayers whose form does not exactly coincide with the Pauline or Synoptic accounts of institution. This divergence rules out reducing second-century liturgy to a single uniform line. The Didache preserves a communal tradition with its own vocabulary and accents.

Especially significant is the treatment of itinerant apostles and prophets in chapters 11–13. Charisma still possesses authority, but it needs criteria for discernment. The length of their stay, their relationship with money, and the consistency between teaching and conduct serve as practical indicators of authenticity.

Chapter 15 urges the community to appoint ἐπισκόπους καὶ διακόνους, "bishops and deacons," worthy of the Lord. The passage shows the coexistence of itinerant and local authority. Rather than a simple transition from charism to institution, the Didache documents an attempt to articulate both levels.

[41] Ignatius, Smyrn. 8.1–2; Philad. 4; Eph. 20.2. Reference to the middle recension: Holmes 2007; commentary by Schoedel 1985. The vocabulary of unity also constitutes an exhortation.

This combination makes the Didache a central source for the monograph's overall argument: authority is also produced through regulated practice. Baptising, fasting, receiving travellers, discerning prophets, and celebrating the Eucharist are acts that build identity as much as a doctrinal formulation.[42]

5. The Shepherd of Hermas: repentance, wealth, and a church in the making

The Shepherd of Hermas offers one of the densest testimonies on the moral and social life of Roman Christian communities in the second century. Its visionary form does not diminish its historical value; on the contrary, the images of towers, stones, women, angels, and commandments transform conflicts about belonging, sin, and restoration into a narrative grammar capable of disciplining the community.

The image of the tower built with stones of varying quality represents the Church as a reality that is simultaneously present and incomplete. Some stones are accepted, others are provisionally rejected, and still others can be readmitted after transformation. The metaphor presents a conception of belonging that is not reduced to instantaneous inclusion or exclusion: discipline is linked to the possibility of repentance.

The problem of post-baptismal repentance is central. Hermas recognises the gravity of sins committed after baptism, but does not build a community incapable of reintegration. Granting an opportunity for μετάνοια serves as a pastoral response to the tension between the ideal of purity and social reality.

The work also pays attention to wealth. The visions and parables presuppose believers with resources, businesses, houses, and social obligations. The Roman Christianity that emerges from Hermas is not a socially homogeneous community. Wealth, dependency, and patronage are part of the moral problem, making the work an indispensable source for a social history of the urban Church.[43]

6. Justin Martyr: apology, Scripture and boundary-making

Justin represents a shift in register. His Apologies present Christianity to imperial and learned interlocutors; the Dialogue with Trypho constructs an extensive dispute on Scripture, promise, and identity. In both cases, Christian authority is articulated through public argumentation and exegesis.

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[42] Did. 7.1–4; 9–10; 11–15. Critical edition identified: Rordorf and Tuilier 1998, SC 248. Local norms are compared with Ignatius without assuming an exact institutional synchronicity.

[43] Hermas, Vis. II.4.2–3; Mand. IV.3.1–7. Holmes 2007; Osiek 1999. The text distinguishes practices, revelation and discipline that should not be reduced to a single episcopal model.

In 1 Apol. 67, Justin describes a Sunday gathering in which "the memoirs of the apostles or the writings of the prophets" are read as long as time permits. The passage does not yet offer a definitive list of books, but it documents communal reading of apostolic writings alongside prophetic Scripture. In Dial. 103, the "memoirs" are linked to the Gospels. This terminology is crucial for reconstructing the transition between circulating texts and liturgically authorised repertoires.

Justin also names and classifies adversaries. His treatment of Marcion shows that the external demarcation against the Empire coexisted with internal demarcations between groups that claimed the Christian name. Apology and heresiology are not separate processes: defining what Christianity is before imperial power also entails deciding who can legitimately represent it.

The relationship with Judaism must be treated with equal precision. The Dialogue is neither a stenographic transcription of an actual discussion nor a neutral representation of second-century Judaism. It is a Christian composition that uses a Jewish interlocutor to expound an interpretation of Scripture and of the identity of God's people. Its historical value lies both in the arguments it preserves and in the literary form in which it constructs the distinction.[44]

7. Irenaeus of Lyons: rule of truth, fourfold gospel and succession

With Irenaeus, the construction of authority reaches a systematic scale. Adversus haereses is not merely a catalogue of doctrines considered erroneous; it is an architecture of legitimation. To refute his adversaries, Irenaeus must explain why a particular reading of Scripture, a particular tradition, and certain communities have a stronger claim to represent apostolic teaching.

The so-called regula veritatis functions as a normative summary of the framework within which the Scriptures must be interpreted. Its importance lies not in its being a fixed creed identical everywhere, but in enabling Irenaeus to assert that Christian truth possesses coherence prior to the fragmentary exegeses he attributes to his adversaries.

In Adv. haer. III, Irenaeus links this rule to the succession of bishops and to the public tradition of the churches. The Roman list in III.3 should not be read as mere administrative information: it serves a polemical function. The continuity of individuals and communities serves as an argument against teachers whose genealogy Irenaeus presents as recent or deviant.

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[44] Justin, 1 Apology 65–67; Dialogue 103.8. Editions of the Apologies: Munier 2006; Minns and Parvis 2009. Dialogue: Bobichon 2003. The distinction between works is maintained.

The defence of four gospels in Adv. haer. III.11.8 represents another mechanism of delimitation. Irenaeus does not merely acknowledge the existence of four texts; he argues that there must be four, no more and no less. The well-known analogy with the four winds and the four corners of the world has rhetorical value, but the most important historical fact is that at the end of the second century an author could defend a fourfold gospel as a normative collection against alternative selections.

Heresiology thus functions as a technology of authority: it names, classifies, genealogises, and orders. This observation does not compel us to accept Irenaeus's reconstructions of each adversary without question. On the contrary, it requires them to be read in two ways: as information—sometimes irreplaceable—about rival groups and as an active production of the boundaries it purports to describe.[45]

8. Valentinus, Valentinian traditions and the problem of "Gnosticism"

The label "Gnosticism" is too broad if used as an explanation before analysing the documents. For the second century, it is preferable to begin with specific teachers, schools, and corpora. Valentinus and the traditions that scholarship calls Valentinian constitute one of the best-documented cases of speculative, exegetical, and ritual Christianity that competed to define the legitimate interpretation of revelation.

Einar Thomassen's research has shown that "Valentinianism" does not designate a single, homogeneous organisation either. Texts, teachers, and communities exhibit internal diversity. The study must distinguish between what we know of Valentinus, what is attributed to his disciples, and what is preserved in Nag Hammadi writings related to Valentinian traditions.

The same caution applies to the texts that modern historiography groups as "Sethian." The category can be useful for comparing myths, divine names, and cosmological structures, but it should not automatically become the name of a unified historical Church. David Brakke has insisted precisely that the diversity of groups and practices necessitates a revision of the major inherited taxonomies.

The crucial point for this chapter is that these movements do not represent an irrelevant periphery. The need to respond to them helped to lead authors such as Irenaeus to formulate more sharply their criteria of tradition, Scripture, succession, and the rule of truth. The boundary was constructed in interaction.[46]

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[45] Irenaeus, Haer. I.10.1–3; III.3.1–4; III.11.8. The books are identified according to the relevant SC series; for III, SC 210–211. The origin of a rule and its subsequent reception are different problems.

[46] Thomassen 2006; Williams 1996; Brakke 2010. The classification of Valentinian materials requires specifying the works and the adversarial sources.

8.1. Critical catalogue of speculative currents and rival schools

The category "Gnosticism" does not reliably designate a unified religion, a common institution, or a continuous historical genealogy. Recent research has shown that ancient authors such as Irenaeus constructed polemical classifications grouping together very different teachers and groups, while modern historiography has added its own taxonomic categories. Therefore, the following catalogue does not offer a chain of "heresies," but rather a comparative map of teachers, networks, and corpora whose relationships to one another must be demonstrated on a case-by-case basis.

It is also necessary to separate textual provenance from social geography. The fact that a codex was found in Egypt does not prove that the group that originally produced each work lived in the place of discovery. Similarly, a heresiological account of Rome or Alexandria is not enough to reconstruct a stable organisation without independent evidence.

8.2. Simon and the construction of a heresiological origin

Acts 8 presents Simon as a Samaritan figure associated with magical practices and opposed to apostolic authority. Justin, Irenaeus, and later authors develop a much more extensive tradition in which Simon appears accompanied by Helena and becomes the ancestor of successive heresies. This genealogy should be read as a later heresiological construction, not as a demonstrable history of the formation of Gnosticism.

The phrase in Acts that refers to Simon as "the Great Power of God" is an early literary fact; the detailed doctrines later attributed to the Simonians come from later, polemical sources. Consequently, this book avoids presenting Simon as the "founder of Gnosticism" and instead studies how the memory of Simon was used to produce a genealogy of error.

8.3. Cerdo: a figure known almost exclusively through adversaries

Cerdo appears in Irenaeus and later heresiological traditions as an active teacher in Rome before or around the arrival of Marcion. He is credited with distinguishing between the God proclaimed by the Law and the Prophets and a higher God revealed by Christ. However, none of his writings survive, and biographical information depends on authors interested in constructing doctrinal genealogies.

For this reason, Cerdo should not be described as a "proven link" between a Syrian Gnosticism and Marcion. One can speak of affinities attributed by heresiological

tradition and of chronological proximity, but not of demonstrated doctrinal transmission.

8.4. Valentinus and Valentinian traditions

Valentinus was a Christian teacher active in the second century and associated with Alexandria and Rome by ancient sources. Later tradition even claimed that he aspired to the Roman episcopate, but this should not be taken as fact. What is well documented, however, is the breadth and diversity of the traditions that later authors identified as Valentinian.

Contemporary research, especially since the work of Einar Thomassen, insists that Valentinianism was not a monolithic organisation. Different schools, teachers, and texts shared certain schemata concerning the Pleroma, Sophia, ignorance, and restoration, but they developed them in different ways.

The Gospel of Truth, the Tripartite Treatise, and other texts related to Valentinian circles demonstrate a sophisticated Christian exegesis in dialogue with Scripture, apostolic tradition, and philosophy. It is not necessary to imagine these groups as completely external to the mainstream churches; in various contexts, the boundary was precisely the subject of dispute.

8.5. The so-called "Sethians": a historiographical category

The term "Sethian" is a modern category applied to a group of texts that share names, myths, and cosmological structures, including the Apocryphon of John. Seth plays an important role in several of these writings, but the existence of a unified Sethian Church, with a clearly defined organisation and geography, cannot be taken for granted.

Nor should an Egyptian origin be inferred simply because many texts were preserved in the Nag Hammadi codices. The find-spot of the codices, which were copied in the fourth century, is an archaeological datum; the social and geographical origin of each composition may be earlier and different.

The systems included in this category usually distinguish the transcendent God from demiurgic figures like Yaldabaoth and rework Genesis within complex narratives of emanation and revelation. But not all share the same degree of dualism or the same Christology, and "docetism" should not be automatically applied to the entire corpus.

8.6. Basilides and the Basilidians

Basilides taught in Alexandria during the first half of the second century and is known through Clement of Alexandria, Irenaeus, and other adversaries. Reconstructions of his system diverge markedly depending on the source. Hippolytus, for example, transmits a cosmogony different from that attributed to him by Irenaeus.

Concepts such as the 365 heavens or the name Abraxas belong primarily to the heresiological tradition concerning the Basilidians and should not be taken as a definitive exposition of Basilides' personal teaching. This case provides an excellent example of why it is necessary to distinguish between the master, the later school, and the polemical description.

8.7. Carpocrates and the Carpocratians

Carpocrates and his circle appear in Irenaeus, Clement, and other authors as representatives of a radical current. The accusations of promiscuity, debauchery, and ritual transgression are part of a polemical repertoire frequently used against rival groups and cannot be accepted literally without corroboration.

Sources attribute to the Carpocratians ideas about cosmic powers, transmigration, and the liberation of the soul. More important for a critical history is to observe how authors like Irenaeus used this group to define, by contrast, the moral and doctrinal limits of the legitimate community.

8.8. Marcion: polemical parallel, not "gnostic" by definition

Marcion frequently appears alongside so-called Gnostic currents because he radically distinguishes the Creator God from the Father revealed by Christ. However, his theology lacks many of the cosmological, genealogical, and mythological features characteristic of Valentinian traditions or the texts known as Sethian.

Therefore, this monograph does not classify Marcion as an unqualified "Gnostic." It studies Marcion and his movement as a rival Christian current with its own canon, churches, and theology, in dialogue and conflict with other forms of Christianity in the second century.

8.9. Manichaeism: independent late religion, not automatic culmination of Gnosticism

Manichaeism, founded by Mani in the third century within the Sasanian Empire, shares with certain earlier traditions a language of light, matter, knowledge, and dualism. However, it was an autonomous universalist religion, with its own scriptures,

missionary structure, and a self-understanding that integrated Christian, Iranian, and Buddhist traditions.

Simply classifying it as the "culmination of Gnosticism" obscures more than it explains. For the chronological scope of this monograph, it is relevant because it demonstrates that the Mediterranean and the late Roman Near East continued to produce transregional religious movements capable of competing with imperial Christianity.

Augustine's later experience as a Manichaean hearer confirms the religion's presence in Roman Africa during the fourth century, but that episode belongs to a historical context much later than that of Valentinus or Basilides.

8.10. Disciplined comparison of currents

Documentary comparison 3. Second-century currents: space, sources, chronology and caveats.

Simon / Simonians

Space. Samaria; subsequent reception in Rome

Sources. Acts 8; Justin; Irenaeus

Traits. Heresiological genealogy, "Great Power", Helen in later tradition

Historiographical caution. Very high dependence on polemical sources.

Cerdo

Space. Rome, second century

Sources. Irenaeus and later heresiologists

Traits. Distinction between God of the Law and higher God

Historiographical caution. No writings of his own survive; doctrinal transmission to Marcion not demonstrable.

Valentinians

Space. Alexandria / Rome and Mediterranean networks

Sources. Irenaeus; Clement; Nag Hammadi

Traits. Pleroma, Sophia, exegesis and restoration

Historiographical caution. Internal diversity; avoid treating Valentinianism as a homogeneous movement.

"Sethian" texts

Space. Geographical origin disputed; Coptic manuscripts found in Egypt
Sources. Apocryphon of John and related corpora
Traits. Rereading of Genesis, demiurgy, revelation
Historiographical caution. "Sethian" is a modern historiographical category.

Basilides / Basilidians

Space. Alexandria
Sources. Clement; Irenaeus; Hippolytus
Traits. Complex cosmogonies and soteriology
Historiographical caution. The sources offer incompatible reconstructions.

Carpocratians

Space. Alexandria and Mediterranean tradition
Sources. Irenaeus; Clement
Traits. Transmigration, cosmic powers, critique of norms
Historiographical caution. Accusations of sexual licence and debauchery are polemical and require caution.

Marcionites

Space. Rome; extensive eastern expansion
Sources. Justin; Irenaeus; Tertullian; Epiphanius
Traits. Two gods, Evangelion, Apostolikon
Historiographical caution. Well-organised rival movement; do not automatically classify as Gnostic.

Manichaeans

Space. Sasanian Mesopotamia; transcontinental expansion
Sources. Manichaean writings and Christian adversaries
Traits. Light/Darkness dualism, universalist prophecy
Historiographical caution. Independent religion of the third century; comparison, not direct genealogy.

8.11. Methodological consequence

This catalogue confirms that "Gnosticism" is only useful if employed as a second-order term and with an explicit definition. The procedure of this work consists of starting with the texts and the teachers, reconstructing their context, and only then deciding whether a typological comparison adds value.

Ancient heresiology is treated as a dual source: it provides information about real adversaries, but at the same time fabricates genealogies, exaggerates similarities, and uses moral accusations to create boundaries. The historian must study both levels.

8.12. Other voices from the second century: Polycarp, Diognetus, Tatian and Athenagoras

The reconstruction of the second century gains depth when texts that do not fit directly into the Marcion–Irenaeus axis are also incorporated. Polycarp's Letter to the Philippians conveys moral exhortation, uses Pauline traditions, and commemorates Ignatius; the Martyrdom of Polycarp, discussed in the following chapter, shows how that authority was transformed into martyrial memory.

The so-called Epistle to Diognetus, whose author and date are disputed (the second or early third century), offers a rhetorical portrayal of Christians as city dwellers who participate in social life without fully identifying with the surrounding religious order. It should be read as a literary apologetic, not as a sociological survey.

Tatian, a disciple of Justin, composed the Diatessaron, a gospel harmony that exerted enormous influence on Syriac Christianity. Its existence demonstrates that the reception of four gospels did not always imply four volumes read separately: the collection could be harmonised into a single liturgical narrative.

Athenagoras of Athens, in his Legatio pro Christianis, responds to accusations of atheism, incest, and cannibalism through a philosophical defence of Christian rationality. His work shows that apologetics in the second century was not a marginal genre, but rather a space in which Christians learned to translate their claims into categories understandable to the educated elites of the Empire.[47]

[47] Polycarp, Phil. 1–14; To Diognetus 5–6; Athenagoras, Leg. 1–4. References: Holmes 2007; Marrou, SC 33; Schoedel 1972.

8.13. Clement of Alexandria: philosophical culture and intellectual Christianity

Clement of Alexandria represents an intellectual Christianity that does not define Greek philosophical culture solely as an enemy. In Protrepticus, Paedagogus, and Stromata, philosophy can function as preparation, an educational tool, and a field for debate.

He is particularly important as a safeguard against a simplistic opposition between "Christianity" and "Hellenism." At the beginning of the third century, Christian authors could use Platonic, Stoic, and philological categories while still constructing an explicitly Christian identity. The term "Gnostic" even acquires a positive connotation in Clement when he describes the perfect believer, confirming that the vocabulary of gnosis did not belong exclusively to the groups classified by Irenaeus as heretics.[48]

8.14. From the first century to heresiological classification: the limits of retrospective chronology

The search for "heterodox movements" in the first century requires special caution. The earliest sources do not offer a map of churches clearly demarcated by systematic doctrines comparable to those described by Irenaeus, Hippolytus, or Epiphanius. The Pauline epistles, Revelation, the Johannine epistles, and other writings reveal real conflicts—over shared meals, circumcision, apostolic authority, prophecy, Christology, food sacrificed to idols, or sexual discipline—but turning every anonymous adversary into a direct ancestor of a second-century heresy is often a backward projection. This monograph therefore distinguishes three levels: first-century controversies documented by contemporary sources; names or groups whose existence is attested in near-contemporary texts; and heresiological genealogies constructed retrospectively by later authors.

[48] Clement of Alexandria, Paed. I.1; Strom. I.1. Textual reference: Stählin and successors, GCS. The analysis refers to training and reading programmes.

8.15. Nicolaitans, Balaam and Jezebel: adversaries of the Apocalypse

Revelation 2 mentions the Nicolaitans in connection with Ephesus and Pergamum and links the "teachings of Balaam" and the symbolic figure of "Jezebel" within the same polemical context. The text suggests that some communities in Asia Minor debated participation in sacrificial meals, sexual practices, and adaptation to the civic-religious environment. However, it does not allow for the reconstruction of a complete Nicolaitan theological system. Irenaeus and later authors identified the Nicolaitans with Nicholas of Acts 6:5 and attributed libertine behaviour to them. This genealogy should be treated as a heresiological reception, not as an independent fact about the first century. The historical interest of the passage lies precisely in observing how a local controversy could become, two or three generations later, a heretical identity established by the literature of controversy.

8.16. Cerinthus and the difficulty of reconstructing a teacher from the turn of the century

Cerinthus occupies a peculiar place between the end of the first century and the beginning of the second. Irenaeus presents him as an adversary of the Johannine tradition and attributes to him a Christology that distinguishes between Jesus and the Christ who descended upon him; the millenarian eschatology ascribed to him derives instead from Gaius of Rome and Dionysius of Alexandria, as quoted by Eusebius (HE III.28). Epiphanius and other heresiologists expand the dossier with data whose dependence and chronology are difficult to establish. The famous anecdote of Polycarp about John fleeing from a bathhouse upon recognising Cerinthus, transmitted by Irenaeus, has value for the polemical memory of Asia Minor, but cannot be used as a contemporary record. Cerinthus must be preserved as a probable historical figure, even though the exact content of his teaching remains partially reconstructed from the accounts of his adversaries.

8.17. Judeo-Christianities: Ebionites, Nazarenes and the problem of labels

The terms "Ebionites" and "Nazarenes" appear in patristic sources to describe groups that combined adherence to Jesus with various forms of Jewish observance. Modern scholarship has shown that it is unsafe to treat these labels as designating two stable, homogeneous, and clearly distinguishable churches over several centuries. Irenaeus, Origen, Eusebius, Epiphanius, and Jerome transmit partial, sometimes incompatible,

information on Christology, observance of the Law, use of the Gospels, and evaluation of Paul. The name "Ebionite" may also have acquired a generalising heresiological meaning. Consequently, this study speaks of Jewish Christianities and reconstructs each testimony by author and date. The fundamental fact is not the existence of a single "Ebionite Church", but the persistence, during the second–fourth centuries, of forms of Christian identity that maintained different positive relationships with the Torah, circumcision, the calendar and the memory of Jerusalem.

8.18. The Elkasaites: revelation, baptisms and Mesopotamian Jewish Christianity

The Elkasaites are known primarily through Hippolytus, Origen—cited by Eusebius—and Epiphanius. Sources connect them with a revealed work attributed to Elchasai/Elxai, with repeated baptismal practices, observances of a Jewish character, astrology, and a Christology difficult to reconstruct. Their location in Syro-Mesopotamian environments and their chronology of the early second century are plausible, but the details depend heavily on hostile testimonies. The group is important because it unsettles the overly simple narrative according to which Judaising Christianity disappeared rapidly after 70 CE. It also forces us to differentiate between continuity of Jewish practices, new prophetic revelations, and the development of hybrid community identities.

8.19. Docetism: Christological category, rather than a single church

"Docetism" derives from δοκεῖν, "to seem", and is used to describe Christologies in which Christ's suffering or corporeality is understood as an appearance or is reformulated in such a way that the Passion does not fully affect his divine being. As early as the beginning of the second century, Ignatius of Antioch was attacking adversaries who denied that Jesus Christ truly suffered "in the flesh." However, Docetism does not designate a single institution or an identical doctrine in all authors. It can appear combined with different anthropologies and cosmologies. Historiography must therefore avoid labelling every high Christology, or every distinction between Jesus and Christ, as "Docetism" without textual analysis. Its usefulness lies in describing a recurring Christological problem: how to articulate divinity, humanity, suffering, and salvation.

8.20. Encratism and ascetic networks: Tatian, continence and discipline

The term "Encratites" comes from ἐγκράτεια, meaning continence, and was used by heresiologists to classify ascetic tendencies that rejected or restricted marriage, meat, and wine. Tatian was later associated with the Encratites, although the relationship between his personal history, the Diatessaron, and a supposed Encratite organisation requires caution. What is historically relevant is the existence, during the second and third centuries, of Christian networks in which sexual renunciation, fasting, and certain dietary practices acquired particular soteriological significance. These currents should be studied alongside proto-orthodox asceticism, not as a completely separate world: the boundary between rigorous discipline and "heresy" was constructed differently depending on the author, region, and context.

8.21. Montanism or "New Prophecy": charism, gender and authority

The so-called New Prophecy movement arose in Phrygia during the second half of the second century, associated with Montanus, Priscilla, and Maximilla. Its adversaries described it as an aberrant, ecstatic prophecy, while its supporters understood it as an intensification of the Spirit's action. The sources are largely filtered through Eusebius and Epiphanius, but also through Tertullian's later adherence to the New Prophecy. The movement cannot be reduced to a marginal extravagance: it raises central questions of Christian history—who may prophesy, how revelation is recognised, what authority women prophets possess, how charisma and episcopate relate to each other, and what discipline should be required of the baptised. Its spread beyond Phrygia also demonstrates the transregional reach of second-century Christian networks.

8.22. Adoptionisms and monarchianisms: categories of the second–third centuries

The labels "adoptionism," "dynamic monarchianism," and "modalistic monarchianism" group together distinct controversies concerning the relationship between God, Christ, and the Holy Spirit. Theodotus of Byzantium, active in Rome in the late second century, was accused of holding that Jesus was a man upon whom divine power descended; Artemon appears in later sources within a similar genealogy. In another register, Noetus, Praxeas, and Sabellius were associated with forms of theology that so strongly defended divine oneness that their adversaries considered the distinction

between Father and Son insufficient. Later labels simplify debates whose vocabulary was still developing. Their study is essential for understanding why the Trinitarian and Christological languages of the fourth century did not emerge from nothing, but rather from more than a century of controversies concerning unity and distinction in God.

8.23. Novatian and the "pure": penitential discipline and schism in the third century

The Novatianist conflict developed in Rome after the persecution of Decius and was linked to the readmission of the lapsi, Christians who had yielded to sacrificial demands. Novatian, a Latin theologian of considerable stature, was consecrated by a group opposed to Cornelius in 251. The controversy cannot be adequately explained as a clash between "heresy" and "orthodoxy," since the two sides held much doctrinal ground in common; the immediate core was ecclesiological and disciplinary: who had the authority to grant reconciliation for grave sins and under what conditions. The Novatianist communities survived for centuries and were known in some regions as katharoi, "the pure." Their persistence demonstrates that disciplinary schisms could produce lasting institutions, their own hierarchies, and alternative memories of sanctity.

Chronological control note. The properly late-antique cases—Donatism, the post-Nicene controversies called "Arian," Priscillian and Manichaeism—are not analysed here as components of the second-century ecclesial landscape. Their substantive treatment belongs to Chapters XI–XII and the relevant regional sections. They are retained only in the diachronic comparative matrix that follows, as a long-term historiographical control with their chronology made explicit, in order to avoid both their artificial subordination to the second century and their disappearance from the comparative framework.

8.24. From polemical designation to historical category: how to use "pseudo-Christian", "heresy" and "Gnosticism"

In ancient and modern confessional literature, expressions equivalent to "false Christian," "pseudo-apostle," or "pseudo-Christian" appear. These are useful as demarcation markers, but not as neutral categories for the historian. To call a group "pseudo-Christian" before analysing its own texts would turn the conclusion of an ancient controversy into a premise of the investigation. Where possible, this monograph uses the names by which groups identified themselves, or the most precise historical designations; when only a name transmitted by adversaries is available, that dependence is indicated. Similarly, "Gnosticism" is reserved for explicitly defined comparisons and does not function as a general receptacle for all dualistic, ascetic, or non-Nicene theology.

8.25. Synoptic matrix of movements and degree of documentation

The following table does not establish a hierarchy of "orthodoxy." It is a diachronic control matrix: it summarises chronology, sources, and caveats from the second century to Late Antiquity, showing which movements can be reconstructed from their own documents and which depend almost entirely on adversaries. For that reason it includes, clearly dated, some third- and fourth-century comparanda that do not form part of the narrative development of this chapter. The "degree of documentation" describes the state of the sources, not the historical significance of the group or its chronological belonging to the second century.

Table 21. Diachronic comparative matrix of movements / labels and attributes

Movement / label (diachronic comparative matrix)	**Chronology**	**Main sources**	**Historiographical caution**
Nicolaitans	late first century	Rev 2; later Irenaeus	Do not reconstruct a system from subsequent reception.
Cerinthus	c. 90–120	Irenaeus; Eusebius; Epiphanius	Distinguish between Johannine memory and reconstructed doctrine.
Jewish Christianity / Ebionites	second–fourth centuries	Irenaeus; Origen; Eusebius; Epiphanius; Jerome	Variable labels; avoid a single "church".

(continued)

Movement / label (diachronic comparative matrix)	Chronology	Main sources	Historiographical caution
Elkasaites	second–third centuries	Hippolytus; Origen/ Eusebius; Epiphanius	High dependence on adversaries.
Docetisms	first–second centuries and later	Ignatius; Irenaeus; various texts	Christological category, not a unique organisation.
Valentinians	second–third centuries	Irenaeus; Clement; Tertullian; Nag Hammadi	Internal diversity; direct documentation exists.
Basilidians	second century	Clement; Irenaeus; Hippolytus	The sources offer incompatible reconstructions.
"Sethian" texts	second–fourth centuries	Heresiologists; Apocryphon of John and Coptic corpora	"Sethian" is a modern historiographical category.
New Prophecy / Montanism	second–fourth centuries	Eusebius; Epiphanius; Tertullian; fragmentary oracles	Separate anti-ecstatic controversy from actual practices.
Encratites	second–third centuries	Irenaeus; Clement; Eusebius	Do not equate asceticism with a single sect.
Monarchianisms	second–third centuries	Hippolytus; Tertullian; Eusebius	Subsequent labels group different debates.
Novatianists	from 251	Cyprian; Eusebius; legislation; Novatian	Long-lasting disciplinary schism.
Manichaeism	from the third century	Manichaean sources; Augustine; heresiologists	Autonomous religion in interaction with Christianities.
Donatists	fourth–fifth centuries	Optatus; Augustine; councils; legislation	Reconstruct from African history, not just polemicists.
Post-Nicene currents called "Arian"	fourth century	Creeds, councils, letters; Athanasius; Hilary	Do not treat them as a single party.
Priscillianists	late fourth–fifth centuries	Sulpicius Severus; councils; Priscillianist treatises	Distinguish accusations of magic from original texts.

8.26. Consequence for the history of early Christianity

The panorama of the first–fourth centuries should not be understood as a linear progression from initial diversity to inevitable orthodoxy. Nor should it be understood as an indefinite coexistence of equivalent Christianities without dominant institutions. The sources reveal a more concrete historical process: communities competing for texts, teachers, apostolic memories, rituals, and spaces; episcopal networks growing in density; councils producing formulas of communion; civil authorities increasingly intervening; and authors retrospectively classifying their adversaries. The result was the formation of powerful normative traditions, but this normativity must be explained historically. Studying the groups that were defeated, marginalised, or classified as heretical is not a digression: it is a privileged path to understanding how canon, creed, episcopate, discipline, and memory were constructed.

9. Rome: from apostolic memory to episcopal succession

9.1. The problem of the Roman episcopal lists: memory, succession and anachronism

The history of the Roman episcopate requires distinguishing three levels that later traditions tended to conflate: the apostolic memory of Peter and Paul, the existence of diverse leaders and ministries within the Roman community, and, finally, the formation of a retrospective sequence of individual bishops. The list transmitted by Irenaeus of Lyons in Adversus haereses III.3.3, written towards the end of the second century, is the earliest surviving testimony that offers an ordered chain from the apostles to Eleutherius. Its historical value is considerable, but it does not warrant simply projecting onto the decades between 60 and 100 the institutional form of the monarchical episcopate that the sources document more clearly elsewhere during the second century.

The letter known as 1 Clement, sent from Rome to Corinth towards the end of the first century, speaks of episkopoi and deacons and defends an orderly transmission of the ministry; however, it does not identify Clement as "bishop of Rome" in the later institutional sense. The Shepherd of Hermas, also linked to Rome and usually placed in the second century, suggests a community with prophets, presbyters, deacons, teachers, and other leaders; in Vis. II.4.3 it refers, in the plural, to "the presbyters who preside over the church", without mentioning a single bishop. These texts

advise caution regarding an image of a monarchical succession perfectly established from the outset.

Accordingly, the early names in the Roman list are preserved here as part of an ancient succession tradition, while a clear distinction is maintained between the probable existence of leading figures and the later reconstruction of a continuous episcopal line. Irenaeus deploys that sequence polemically, presenting the teaching he regards as apostolic as traceable through public and known churches in contrast to rival claims of secret tradition. The list is therefore both a historical datum and a heresiological argument.

From the last third of the second century onward, the documentation becomes denser. The Easter controversies associated with Victor, the Christological and disciplinary disputes of the time of Zephyrinus and Callistus, the schism of Hippolytus according to modern reconstructions, the crisis of Cornelius and Novatian, and the baptismal conflicts of Stephen and Cyprian reveal a Roman see with a growing capacity for coordination, correspondence, and arbitration. This increasing centrality should not be described teleologically as if all its later forms were already present from Peter onward, but neither can it be reduced to a retrospective fiction: during the second and third centuries, a real process of institutionalisation is documented.

9.2. From Linus to Eleutherius: the ancient succession according to Irenaeus and its limits

Irenaeus lists, after Peter and Paul, Linus, Anencletus/Anacletus, Clement, Evaristus, Alexander, Sixtus, Telesphorus, Hyginus, Pius, Anicetus, Soter, and Eleutherius. The tradition is not homogeneous in the form of the names or in the chronology. Later sources, especially Eusebius and the Late Antique Roman catalogues, provide episcopal durations and synchronisms that cannot always be independently verified. Critical practice, therefore, consists of distinguishing between an early attested nominal succession and a much more uncertain exact chronology.

Clement occupies an exceptional position because 1 Clement constitutes a Roman witness from the end of the first century, although the text is presented as a letter from the church of Rome and not as a personal writing of an episcopal monarch. Telesphorus is remembered by Irenaeus as a martyr; Anicetus appears in the tradition concerning Polycarp's visit to Rome and the discrepancy over the date of Easter; Eleutherius is a contemporary of Irenaeus and, therefore, represents the chronologically most secure end of the list. This gradation of certainty is not a flaw in the analysis: it is precisely the difference between a critical history of institutions and the mere reproduction of a traditional list.

9.3. Victor I and the Easter controversy: authority, communion and limits of intervention

With Victor I, towards the end of the second century, the documentation reveals a Roman intervention of supralocal scope. Eusebius, in his Ecclesiastical History V.23–25, preserves accounts of the Quartodeciman controversy: communities in Asia Minor maintained the celebration of Easter linked to the fourteenth of Nisan, while other groups defended the Sunday celebration. Victor attempted to exclude from communion those churches in Asia that maintained the Quartodeciman practice; Irenaeus, although he shared the Sunday practice, urged him to show moderation in a letter partly quoted by Eusebius (HE V.24.11–17).

This episode is important because it simultaneously reveals the capacity for initiative and resistance to that initiative. Rome could convene, communicate, and threaten to break off communion, but it did not yet possess an operational universal jurisdiction in the legal sense of later periods. The conflict illuminates the construction of authority through networks of letters, apostolic memory, ecclesial communion, and the capacity to forge regional consensus.

9.4. Zephyrinus, Callistus and Hippolytus: internal conflict and retrospective construction of legitimacy

The transition from the second to the third century is marked by openly polemical sources. The Refutatio omnium haeresium, traditionally attributed to Hippolytus, presents an extremely hostile image of Zephyrinus and, above all, of Callistus. It accuses its targets of Christological errors, lax discipline, and personal irregularities. The source is indispensable, but its genre demands a reading symmetrical to that applied to Irenaeus or Epiphanius: the adversary cannot automatically become a neutral narrator.

The disputes reveal central questions for Roman institutionalisation: who has the authority to readmit grave sinners, how marital discipline is structured, what Christological language is acceptable, and who can define it. The existence of rival groups presenting themselves as the legitimate church shows that the "succession" was not merely a chronological line, but a continually contested claim.

9.5. Cornelius and Novatian: penance, episcopal election and sociology of the church at Rome

The crisis following the persecution of Decius offers exceptional documentation. Cornelius and Novatian were elected by rival factions in Rome in 251, and the problem of the lapsi—Christians who had sacrificed, obtained certificates, or yielded under pressure—became a major ecclesiological issue. Cyprian of Carthage and the documents preserved by Eusebius support a partial reconstruction of the controversy.

Eusebius (HE VI.43) transmits a letter from Cornelius that describes a Roman community with forty-six presbyters, seven deacons, seven subdeacons, numerous acolytes, exorcists, lectors, and doorkeepers, in addition to a large body of people receiving support. Although the figures come from a partisan source and must be read in their polemical context, they provide unusually detailed evidence for the organisational and welfare scale of urban Christianity in the mid-third century.

Novatian was not simply a doctrinal "heretic": his break was primarily related to discipline, penance, and episcopal legitimacy, even though his movement later developed its own lasting ecclesial identity. This case demonstrates that the boundaries between schism, discipline, and heresy are not interchangeable, ahistorical categories.

9.6. Stephen I and Cyprian: baptism, communion and conflict between sees

The controversy over baptism administered outside the Catholic communion pitted Stephen of Rome against Cyprian of Carthage and African synods in the 250s. The issue was not secondary: it affected the understanding of sacramental efficacy, the identity of the Church, and the authority of regional traditions. Cyprian defended the rebaptism of those who came from groups considered heretical; Rome maintained a different practice, accepting in certain cases the laying on of hands without repeating the baptism.

The Cyprianic letters reveal a network of churches that recognised one another, engaged in intense disputes, and appealed to memory, custom, and apostolic tradition. Presenting the episode as a mere exercise in "papal primacy" or, conversely, as proof that Rome lacked any supralocal authority impoverishes the evidence. The conflict documents precisely a stage of institutional negotiation in which prestige, antiquity, communion, and episcopal autonomy were still being balanced in uneven ways.

9.7. From Valerian's persecution to the Tetrarchy: cemeteries, memory and community government

During the third century, the history of Roman church leaders became intertwined with the administration of cemeteries, charitable assistance, and the commemoration of martyrs. Sixtus II died during Valerian's persecution; the tradition concerning Lawrence belongs to a reception history that must be analysed in layers. The development of funerary complexes and the use of catacombs do not in themselves prove an early centralised structure, but they do show that the management of burials, anniversaries, and the commemoration of martyrs acquired increasing institutional importance.

The Liberian Catalogue and the Depositio episcoporum of the Chronograph of 354 (the so-called Philocalian calendar) provide, as early as the fourth century, an organised record of Roman bishops and martyrs. These are fundamental Late Antique documents for studying how Rome constructed a sacred chronology of its own leaders. Their testimony is especially valuable when combined with funerary epigraphy and contemporary sources, but it should not be uncritically projected back to the first and second centuries.

9.8. Miltiades and Sylvester: from persecution to imperial patronage

The Constantinian shift radically altered the material conditions of the Roman episcopate. Miltiades appears linked to the resolution of the Donatist conflict through the Synod of Rome in 313, convened within a context of imperial intervention. The relationship between emperor and bishops introduced new possibilities regarding arbitration, property ownership, construction, and public representation.

Sylvester I, bishop for much of Constantine's reign, occupies a disproportionately large place in later legend and a relatively limited one in contemporary sources. He did not personally preside over Nicaea: the Roman see was represented by legates. Medieval narratives that portray Sylvester as Constantine's baptiser and recipient of a territorial "Donation" belong to later phases and cannot be used as evidence for the fourth century. The contrast between the historical Sylvester and the legendary Sylvester offers an exemplary case of the medieval construction of institutional memory.

9.9. Liberius, Damasus and Siricius: doctrinal conflict, monumentalisation and decretals

Liberius's episcopate unfolded against the backdrop of the post-Nicene controversies and the imperial pressure of Constantius II. His exile and the problem of the Formulas of Sirmium demonstrate the extent to which the bishop of Rome could become entangled in imperial doctrinal politics. Sources are biased, and assessments of his conduct vary; the episode must be studied through letters, ecclesiastical historians, and modern reconstructions, not through later categories of institutional impeccability.

Under Damasus I (366–384), the Roman see acquired a new monumental and epigraphic visibility. His election was accompanied by violence between rival factions; subsequently, he promoted the memory of martyrs through metrical inscriptions and reinforced the Christian topography of Rome. Jerome's activity in his circle and the growing importance of biblical Latin belong to this same cultural horizon, although the relationship between Damasus and the Vulgate must be formulated precisely and without oversimplification.

Siricius, elected in 384, already stands on the threshold of a new documentary practice. His letter to Himerius of Tarragona, from 385, is generally considered the first papal decretal preserved in a fully developed form. The importance of the document lies not in demonstrating that the later papacy existed fully from the first century, but in showing how, towards the end of the fourth century, the Roman see was developing normative genres, claims to disciplinary action, and a more defined institutional vocabulary.

9.10. Critical matrix and repertoire of the Roman episcopal succession (first–fourth centuries)

The Roman succession is presented here on two complementary levels. Table 22 provides a high-density verification matrix for cases that decisively alter the institutional reconstruction; the complete chronological repertoire that follows (Table 23) preserves the set of names transmitted by Irenaeus, Eusebius, the Liberian Catalogue, and related traditions. At both levels, the [ED] status applies: critical edition, textual testimony, and/or controlled historiographical inference. For the first and early second centuries, "bishop of Rome" is used as a retrospective designation when the monarchical structure is not documented by a contemporary source.

Table 22 (III.2). Ancient succession of the see of Rome (first–fourth centuries)

Table 22. Ancient succession of the see of Rome (first–fourth centuries): documentary verification matrix [ED]

Figure / bishop and conventional chronology	Primary reference testimony [ED]	Historical-critical assessment and inferential status
Peter (d. c. 64–67 CE)	1 Clem. 5.4; Irenaeus, Haer. III.3.2–3; Eusebius, HE III.1.	A foundational apostolic figure of immense traditional significance, but ecclesiologically anachronistic if he is simply described as holding office within a Roman "monarchical episcopate." First-century sources do not document a centralised episcopal bureaucracy comparable to that of later centuries; the link between Petrine memory and episcopal succession belongs to a process of institutional construction.
Linus (trad. c. 67–76 CE)	Irenaeus, Haer. III.3.3 (SC 211).	First name in Irenaeus's sequence after the apostles. The exact chronology and nature of his functions are not supported by contemporary archives; the list should be read as the institutional memory of the late second century.
Anencletus / Anacletus (trad. c. 76–88 CE)	Irenaeus, Haer. III.3.3; Eusebius, HE III.13.	A single figure in the earliest surviving sequence. The later cataloguing tradition that separated "Cletus" and "Anacletus" reflects subsequent transmission and should not artificially multiply the succession.
Clement (trad. c. 88–99 CE)	Irenaeus, Haer. III.3.3; 1 Clement (SC 167).	A Roman figure of exceptional historiographical importance. However, 1 Clement is an anonymous community letter sent in the name of the church of Rome; the text is not presented as a decree signed by an individual monarchical bishop.
Victor I (c. 189–198/199 CE)	Eusebius, HE V.23–25 (GCS, Eusebius Werke II).	A milestone of translocal intervention. His actions in the Quartodeciman controversy show a strong intention to discipline communion between churches, but the resistance of Irenaeus and the Asian communities prevents this authority from being described without nuance as a fully constituted papal jurisdiction.

(continued)

Figure / bishop and conventional chronology	Primary reference testimony [ED]	Historical-critical assessment and inferential status
Zephyrinus (c. 198/199–217 CE)	Refutatio IX, traditionally attributed to Hippolytus; Eusebius, HE VI.20.	A period of intense doctrinal and factional conflict in Rome. The Refutatio is a polemical and hostile source; its accusations should be read as evidence of an internal dispute, not as a neutral description of Zephyrinus's administration.
Callistus I (217–222 CE)	Refutatio IX; Catalogus Liberianus.	He is traditionally associated with the administration of the Appian Way cemetery and a more inclusive penitential policy. The conflict with the circle of Hippolytus shows that Roman episcopal authority remained a subject of intra-ecclesiastical dispute.
Fabian (236–250 CE)	Cyprian, Ep. 9; Eusebius, HE VI.29; Depositio martyrum.	Martyred at the beginning of Decius's persecution. Later tradition attributes to him an administrative division of Rome into seven ecclesiastical districts linked to deacons; this detail should be treated as transmitted institutional memory, not as a preserved contemporary administrative record.
Cornelius (251–253 CE)	Cyprian, Epistulae (CSEL 3.2); Eusebius, HE VI.43.	The Novatianist conflict produced an extraordinary epistolary archive. The letter preserved by Eusebius offers one of the densest organisational snapshots of urban Christianity in the third century: 46 presbyters, 7 deacons, 7 subdeacons, and more than 1,500 widows and needy people under their care, in addition to other ministries.
Stephen I (254–257 CE)	Cyprian, Ep. 69–75; Eusebius, HE VII.5.	The controversy over rebaptism pitted Rome against Cyprian and several African synods. The Cyprianic dossier reveals a strong Roman claim to continuity and authority, but a fully formulated medieval papal legal theory should not be retrospectively projected onto it.

(continued)

Figure / bishop and conventional chronology	Primary reference testimony [ED]	Historical-critical assessment and inferential status
Sylvester I (314–335 CE)	Synodal letter of the Council of Arles (314) to Sylvester; transmitted conciliar subscription lists associated with Nicaea.	A figure at the Constantinian threshold. The medieval Donatio Constantini is not evidence for the fourth century. Monumentalisation and ecclesiastical privileges depended decisively on imperial initiative; Sylvester did not attend Nicaea in person, and the transmitted subscription tradition represents Rome through legates. This subscription tradition must be distinguished from the surviving body of conciliar canons.
Damasus I (366–384 CE)	Damasian epigraphy; Jerome, Epistulae; CTh XVI.1.2.	Monumental, epigraphic, and political consolidation of the Roman see after an election marked by factional violence. His epigrams sacralised the martyrial topography of Rome; his relationship with Jerome facilitated the revision of the Latin Gospels. The edict Cunctos populos should be read as imperial intervention in the public definition of orthodoxy, not as a simple decree of Roman supremacy.
Siricius (384–399 CE)	Directa ad decessorem (385), Latin canonical tradition.	Threshold of a new bureaucratic practice. His response to Himerius of Tarragona is usually considered the first papal decretal preserved in a developed legal form; it adopts a rescriptive register that brings episcopal documentation closer to imperial administrative forms.

Table 23. Complete chronological register of the transmitted Roman succession

Bishop / conventional chronology	Main testimony	Critical observation
Linus (c. 60s–70s)	Irenaeus, Haer. III.3.3	Early name of the succession; exact chronology uncertain.
Anencletus / Anacletus (c. 70s–90s)	Irenaeus; catalogue tradition	Name variation; do not duplicate Cletus/Anacletus without discussing the tradition.
Clement (c. 90s)	Irenaeus; 1 Clement	1 Clement is a letter from the Roman church; personal authorship and exact position must be distinguished.
Evaristus (late first / early second century)	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Chronology dependent on later lists.

(continued)

Bishop / conventional chronology	Main testimony	Critical observation
Alexander I (early second century)	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Limited contemporary documentation.
Sixtus I/Xystus (early second century)	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Not to be confused with Sixtus II, a martyr of the third century.
Telesphorus (d. c. 135–137)	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Irenaeus remembers him as a martyr.
Hyginus (c. 138–142)	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Context of doctrinal diversity in Rome.
Pius I (c. 140–155)	Irenaeus; Liberian Catalogue	Tradition links him chronologically with Hermas; details uncertain.
Anicetus (c. 155–166)	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Encounter with Polycarp and difference regarding Easter.
Soter (c. 166–175)	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Roman correspondence and charity indirectly attested.
Eleutherius (c. 175–189)	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Contemporary of Irenaeus; securely attested endpoint of his list.
Victor I (c. 189–198/199)	Eusebius HE V.23–25	Quartodeciman controversy; documented supralocal intervention.
Zephyrinus (c. 198/199–217)	Hippolytus/Refutatio; Eusebius	Main hostile source; Christological controversies.
Callistus I (c. 217–222)	Hippolytus/Refutatio; Eusebius	Penitential discipline and Christology in a polemical context.
Urban I (c. 222–230)	Eusebius; catalogues	Scarce contemporary documentation.
Pontian (230–235)	Liberian Catalogue; Depositio	Exile to Sardinia; relatively better established chronology.
Anterus (235–236)	Roman catalogues	Brief episcopate.
Fabian (236–250)	Eusebius; Cyprian	Martyr under Decius; strong institutional memory.
Cornelius (251–253)	Cyprian; Eusebius HE VI.43	Novatian schism; important sociological description of the Roman church.
Lucius I (253–254)	Cyprian; catalogues	Return from exile and continuity of the penitential question.
Stephen I (254–257)	Cyprian, Epistulae	Controversy over the baptism of heretics and ecclesiastical authority.
Sixtus II (257–258)	Cyprian; Depositio martyrum	Martyr under Valerian.
Dionysius (259–268)	Eusebius; epistolary tradition	Doctrinal exchanges with Dionysius of Alexandria.
Felix I (269–274)	Catalogues; late testimonies	Distinguish contemporary data from later attributions.
Eutychian (275–283)	Catalogues	Limited documentation.

(continued)

Bishop / conventional chronology	Main testimony	Critical observation
Gaius (283–296)	Catalogues; Depositio episcoporum	Later tradition expands his biography without a secure basis.
Marcellinus (296–304)	Eusebius; Donatist/later tradition	His conduct during the persecution was the subject of later polemical accounts.
Marcellus I (c. 306/308–309)	Catalogues; Damasian tradition	Conflicts over readmission of lapsi; chronology discussed.
Eusebius (c. 309/310)	Damasian inscription; catalogues	Disciplinary conflict; brief episcopate and exile.
Miltiades (311–314)	Eusebius; Constantinian documentation	Roman Synod of 313 in the Donatist conflict.
Sylvester I (314–335)	Eusebius; indirect conciliar acts	Age of Nicaea; history must be separated from medieval legend.
Mark (336)	Catalogues	Very brief episcopate.
Julius I (337–352)	Athanasius; synodal correspondence	Intervention in Nicene controversies and reception of exiles.
Liberius (352–366)	Athanasius; Hilary; historians	Exile under Constantius II; controversy over formulary allegiances.
Damasus I (366–384)	Inscriptions; Jerome; civil/ecclesiastical sources	Violent election; monumentalisation of the memory of the martyrs.
Siricius (384–399)	Epistula ad Himerium	Development of decretal responses and Roman discipline.

9.11. Rome as an observatory of liturgy, discipline and ministries

The evolution of Roman authority cannot be studied solely through lists of bishops. Ritual practices and the ordinary organisation of communities reveal how the institution developed from the ground up. Justin, in First Apology 65–67, describes baptism, Sunday gatherings, the reading of the memoirs of the apostles and the writings of the prophets, prayer, the kiss of peace, the Eucharist, distribution by deacons, and the collection for the needy. This description is not a "Roman missal" in the later sense, but it is one of the richest sources for urban Christian practice in the mid-second century.

The Didache, although not Roman, offers an indispensable point of comparison: baptism in running water when possible, fasting, prayers, the Eucharist, itinerant prophets, and the election of bishops and deacons. Comparison among the Didache,

Justin, Ignatius, 1 Clement, and the Apostolic Tradition—whose attribution, date, and location are debated—supports a reconstruction of families of practice without assuming a uniform universal liturgy.

Baptism functions simultaneously as a rite of incorporation, a communal boundary, and a problem of authority. Its specific form varies in the sources; its theology is not monolithic either. The controversy between Stephen and Cyprian demonstrates that, in the third century, the question of whether a baptism administered outside of communion should be repeated could divide regional churches without either side considering the matter trivial.

The Eucharist provides another privileged vantage point. Paul offers the oldest surviving Christian testimony on the communal meal and its conflicts; the Didache preserves formulas different from the Pauline and Synoptic ones; Ignatius links the Eucharist, unity, and the episcopate; Justin describes a Sunday rite with reading, exhortation, prayer, offerings, and distribution. Historical development should not be presented as a linear sequence from a simple form to a fixed liturgy, but rather as a gradual convergence of local practices.

Penance clearly illustrates the institutional transformation. The Shepherd of Hermas debates the possibility of repentance after baptism; the controversies surrounding the lapsed after Decius necessitated the definition of reconciliation procedures; Novatian and Cornelius represent divergent responses to post-persecution discipline. Episcopal authority became visible, among other things, in the capacity to administer exclusion, reconciliation, and communion.

The ministries also reveal a process. Paul mentions apostles, prophets, teachers, episkopoi, and deacons in various contexts; 1 Clement rationalises ministerial continuity through a record of appointment and succession; Ignatius insists on a triad of bishop-presbytery-deacons; the Didache still preserves a tension between local ministers and itinerant charismatics. There is no single date on which the monarchical episcopate "was born" for all the churches. The evidence necessitates regional and chronologically staggered reconstructions.

Assistance to the poor, widows, orphans, prisoners, travellers, and confessors is not a social appendix to institutional history: it is one of its infrastructures. Paul's collections, the charity mentioned by Dionysius of Corinth regarding Rome, and the figures transmitted in Cornelius's letter show that redistribution, hospitality, and care helped to produce networks of dependence, reputation, and authority.

9.12. Methodological note on episcopal titles and primacy

Throughout this book, early references to the church of Rome are not translated automatically into later legal categories. "Primacy", "apostolic see", "pope", and "jurisdiction" have distinct semantic histories. When such terms are used for the first through fourth centuries, the evidentiary level is specified: apostolic memory, honorific precedence, capacity for mediation, disciplinary intervention, reception of appeals, or normative formulation. The aim is neither to deny nor to presuppose historical continuities, but to describe them at the precise point at which the sources permit them to be observed.

The history of the leaders of the Christian community in Rome requires a distinction between tradition of succession and institutional reconstruction. Linear lists of "bishops of Rome" are ancient, but not contemporary with the earliest names they contain. Irenaeus of Lyons, at the end of the second century, offers in Adversus haereses III.3.3 the first preserved sequence of Linus, Anacletus, Clement, and their successors up to Eleutherius; Eusebius reproduces and expands upon it in the fourth century. These lists are fundamental historical sources for the Roman church's memory of continuity, but they do not, in themselves, demonstrate that Rome possessed from the 60s onward a form of monarchical episcopate identical to that of the third century.

Clement's First Letter itself is significant. The writing speaks on behalf of the church of Rome and does not present Clement as an individual author or as a monarchical bishop issuing a personal decision. The traditional attribution to Clement is ancient and plausible as the memory of a prominent Roman figure, but the document, as it survives, does not bear an episcopal signature. Therefore, the monograph distinguishes between "Clement" as a traditional figure in the Roman succession and 1 Clement as an anonymous community letter.

Modern research has proposed various models to explain this documentary tension. One influential line of thought—represented above all by Peter Lampe, Die stadtrömischen Christen in den ersten beiden Jahrhunderten (1987; Eng. trans. From Paul to Valentinus, 2003)—maintains that Rome retained a relatively collegial structure for much of the second century, composed of several domestic communities and local leaders, before the consolidation of a more centralised monarchical episcopate. Other studies emphasise that the succession lists reflect an institutional memory already sufficiently strong in Irenaeus's time. It is not necessary to resolve the entire institutional history with a single model; what is necessary, however, is to avoid retroactively projecting the third-century form onto the first century.

The word "pope" requires similar caution. In Late Antiquity, papa/pappas was an honorific title applied to various bishops and did not function from the beginning as the exclusive designation for the bishop of Rome. In this work, "bishop of Rome" is primarily used for the first–fourth centuries, reserving "pope" when describing later tradition or when the historical context warrants it.

The following sequence is therefore offered as a critical table of the Roman episcopal tradition and not as an exact chronology of pontificates from Peter. For the first and early second centuries, the dates are approximate and depend on later chronographies; from the third century onward, the documentation becomes progressively denser.[49]

TABLE 24. Bishops of Rome: figures, chronology and status of titles

Figure / bishop	Approximate date	Testimony / context	Critical evaluation
Peter	d. probably in the 60s CE	Ancient Roman tradition; 1 Clem. 5; Irenaeus; Eusebius	Founding apostolic figure; it is not appropriate to describe him as "bishop of Rome" in a later institutional sense.
Linus	trad. late 60s–70s	Irenaeus, Adv. haer. III.3.3; Eusebius	First name of the Irenaean succession; exact chronology not contemporary.
Anencletus / Anacletus	trad. c. 70–90	Irenaeus; Eusebius	A single figure in the oldest list; the Cletus/ Anacletus duplication belongs to later traditions.
Clement	trad. late first century	1 Clement; Irenaeus; Eusebius	An early Roman figure of great importance; the individual authorship of 1 Clement is not expressed in the text.
Evaristus	trad. late first–early second century	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Known primarily for succession lists.
Alexander I	trad. first half of the second century	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Chronology dependent on later catalogues.
Sixtus I	trad. first half of the second century	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Attested in the succession lists; few firm biographical details.

[49] Irenaeus, Haer. III.3.3; Eusebius, HE III.2; III.13–15; V.6.1–4. Lampe 2003 contextualises Roman plurality. The traditional dates of the table are not an entirely contemporary chronology.

(continued)

Figure / bishop	Approximate date	Testimony / context	Critical evaluation
Telesphorus	d. c. 135–137	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Irenaeus remembers him as a martyr; greater traditional density than immediate predecessors.
Hyginus	c. 138–142	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Chronologically associated with teachers such as Valentinus and Cerdo in later sources.
Pius I	c. 140–155	Irenaeus; later tradition	His period roughly coincides with Hermas and Marcion's Roman activity; biographical details require caution.
Anicetus	c. 155–166	Irenaeus; Eusebius, HE V.24	Meeting with Polycarp about Easter; important testimony of liturgical diversity.
Soter	c. 166–175	Irenaeus; Eusebius	Limited documentation but succession already close to Irenaeus.
Eleutherius	c. 175–189	Irenaeus, contemporary	Last of the list of Adv. haer. III.3.3; highly important for studying the polemical function of the succession.
Victor I	c. 189–198/199	Eusebius, HE V.23–25	The Quartodeciman controversy; greater visibility of translocal Roman intervention. The supposed "Latinisation" must be formulated with caution.
Zephyrinus	c. 198/199–217	Hippolytus; Eusebius	Frequently omitted in modern summaries; important for Roman Christological controversies.
Callistus I	217–222	Hippolytus; Roman tradition	Associated with ecclesiastical administration and rigorist conflict; should not be dated from 199.
Urban I	222–230	catalogues and Eusebius	Limited biographical information.

(continued)

Figure / bishop	Approximate date	Testimony / context	Critical evaluation
Pontian	230–235	Catalogus Liberianus; epigraphy	Deported to Sardinia; resignation traditionally linked to exile.
Anterus	235–236	catalogues	Very brief episcopate; scarce documentation.
Fabian	236–250	Cyprian; Eusebius	Martyred under Decius. The accounts of "seven districts" come from later tradition and should not be presented without qualification.
Cornelius	251–253	Cyprian; Eusebius	Election and conflict with Novatian; valuable epistolary documentation.
Lucius I	253–254	Cyprian; catalogues	Brief episcopate in post-Decian context.
Stephen I	254–257	Cyprian; Firmilian; Eusebius	Controversy over the baptism of heretics and episcopal authority.
Sixtus II	257–258	Cyprian; Depositio martyrum	Executed during the persecution of Valerian.
Dionysius	259–268	Eusebius; Athanasius	Reorganisation after Valerian; participates in Trinitarian controversies.
Felix I	269–274	catalogues; later tradition	Limited firm data.
Eutychian	275–283	catalogues	Relatively stable traditional chronology; poorly documented biography.
Gaius	283–296	catalogues	Transitional figure prior to the Great Persecution.
Marcellinus	296–304	catalogues; subsequent controversy	Episcopate during the beginning of the Great Persecution; traditions on apostasy are late and polemical.
Marcellus I	c. 306/308–309	catalogues; Damasian epigraphy	Post-persecution activity; exact chronology disputed.
Eusebius	309/310	catalogues; Damasian epitaph	Roman conflict surrounding the lapsi; very brief episcopate.

(continued)

Figure / bishop	Approximate date	Testimony / context	Critical evaluation
Miltiades	311–314	Eusebius; Constantinian sources	Bishop under Maxentius and at the time of the agreement of 313; the Roman synod of 313 met at the Lateran complex.
Sylvester I	314–335	Eusebius and the conciliar tradition	Bishop during Nicaea and the first Constantinian monumentalisation; Constantine, not Sylvester, is the main imperial agent of construction.
Mark	336	catalogues	Brief episcopate.
Julius I	337–352	Athanasius; conciliar correspondence	He intervened in episcopal controversies of the post-Nicene period and supported Athanasius.
Liberius	352–366	Athanasius; Hilary; imperial sources	Exile and pressure under Constantius II; a central episode for the limits of Roman authority in the face of imperial power.
Damasus I	366–384	Damasian epigraphy; Jerome; conciliar sources	After a disputed election, he promoted the cult of martyrs, Petrine memory, and the prestige of the Roman see; he commissioned Jerome to revise the Latin biblical text.
Siricius	384–399	Decretal Directa ad decessorem (385) and correspondence	First papal decretals preserved in developed form; he was not the first to use the title pope, which is earlier than and not exclusive to Rome.
Anastasius I	399–401	Jerome and ecclesiastical sources	It marks the transition between the fourth and fifth centuries.

The table also corrects several common problems in modern devotional lists. Zephyrinus should be listed between Victor I and Callistus I, with an approximate chronology of c. 198/199–217; the episcopate of Callistus I belongs to 217–222, not to a chronology beginning in 199; and the separation between Cletus and Anacletus

does not belong in Irenaeus's earliest list. Similarly, some institutional attributions—such as the division of Rome into seven districts under Fabian—come from later traditions and require treatment as such.

The historiographical importance of the list lies not in demonstrating an unbroken bureaucratic chain from Peter, but in observing how, towards the end of the second century, succession had become an argument for legitimacy. Irenaeus uses the Roman sequence against doctrinal adversaries: the institutional genealogy functions as public proof against teachings he accuses of being secret or recent. Eusebius inherits this logic and makes it the structure of his own historical narrative.

During the third and fourth centuries, the situation changed. Epistolary, conciliar, epigraphic, and administrative sources allow for a much more precise tracing of specific bishops. The Roman see gradually developed a capacity for translocal intervention, but this authority continued to be negotiated with other bishops, synods, and emperors. Speaking of the "papacy" for the entire period is possible as a historiographical convenience only if this evolution is made explicit.[50]

10. Synthesis: mechanisms of authority in the second century

Documentary comparison 4. Mechanisms of authority in the second century: domains and witnesses.

Order and Ministry

Main testimonies. 1 Clement; Ignatius; Didache

Historical function. To stabilise leadership and discipline

Interpretive limit. There was no single universal structure.

Monarchical episcopate

Main testimonies. Ignatius

Historical function. To concentrate visible, Eucharistic and disciplinary unity

Interpretive limit. Local/regional model, not a demonstration of imperial uniformity.

[50] Eusebius, HE V.23–25, Paschal controversy. For the fourth century, catalogues, correspondence, and conciliar documentation are distinguished; the Liber Pontificalis is not used as a uniform contemporary archive.

Memory and apostolic succession

Main testimonies. 1 Clement; Irenaeus
Historical function. To link present authorities with a legitimising past
Interpretive limit. Genealogy is also a polemical strategy.

Rule of truth / faith

Main testimonies. Irenaeus
Historical function. To offer a normative framework for interpretation
Interpretive limit. It does not yet equate to a legally fixed universal creed.

Collections of texts

Main testimonies. Justin; Irenaeus; codices
Historical function. To delimit authoritative readings and apostolic memory
Interpretive limit. Circulation, collection and canon are not identical stages.

Liturgy and practice

Main testimonies. Didache; Justin
Historical function. To produce identity through repeated habits
Interpretive limit. Practices vary regionally.

Prophecy and revelation

Main testimonies. Didache; Hermas
Historical function. To maintain charismatic authority and discipline it
Interpretive limit. Charisma and institution coexist.

Heresiology

Main testimonies. Justin; Irenaeus
Historical function. To classify adversaries and produce borders
Interpretive limit. Ancient taxonomies are not neutral descriptions.

Martyrdom and exemplary conduct

Main testimonies. Ignatius; martyrdom traditions
Historical function. To transform suffering and memory into authority
Interpretive limit. A distinction must be made between martyrdom literature and proconsular acts or other court records.

II. Apostolic memory and eastern expansion

II.1. Thomas and India as a problem of memory and transmission

The tradition linking the apostle Thomas to India belongs to a long history of reception. The *Acts of Thomas preserve a* narrative of mission, asceticism, and martyrdom, the composition of which is usually placed in the third century, in an environment related to Syriac Christianity. Its distance from the first century prevents it from being read as a contemporary diary of the apostle. Its value is, however, considerable for studying the eastern projection of apostolic memory.[51]

The appearance of the name Gondophares in this literature may be related to an Indo-Parthian context known from other sources. The identification of a real name makes a historical horizon of composition or of tradition plausible, but it does not confirm all the episodes of a narrative. Similarly, ancient trade networks with the Indian Ocean demonstrate possibilities for circulation, not the individual itinerary of a character without sufficient contemporary documentation.

For this monograph, it is essential to separate four questions: when was the work composed, what prior memory could it have used, which communities transmitted its different versions, and when were the local traditions linked to Thomas consolidated? This distinction preserves the theme of eastern expansion without presenting it as a first-century fact established with the same degree of certainty as Paul's activity attested in his letters.

The reception of Thomas also shows that apostolic authority was not constructed solely in Rome or Asia Minor. Syriac traditions organised their own space of memory, translation, and belonging. Their study is part of a broader Mediterranean and Eastern history, but it requires a specific apparatus for each language and version. A reference to a modern translation does not replace the examination of ancient recensions.

[51] Acts of Thomas, especially the initial mission narrative and the account of martyrdom. Reference edition: Bonnet, Acta apostolorum apocrypha II.2, 1903. The presence of Gondophares is treated as a check on a name, not as a comprehensive verification of the account.

12. Open questions and limits of reconstruction

The evidence examined supports a reconstruction of specific mechanisms of authority, but it does not eliminate several open questions. The intervention of 1 Clement from Rome demonstrates a translocal capacity for exhortation and correction, although it does not, in itself, authorise projecting later legal categories onto the end of the first or beginning of the second century.

Similarly, Ignatius's insistence on the bishop can be read as evidence of a strong institutional model and, simultaneously, as an indication that this model still required defence. The normative force of discourse should not be automatically confused with sociological uniformity.

The Didache presents a different problem: its composition and possible stratification affect how its practices are reconstructed. The instructions on prophets, local authorities, baptism, and the Eucharist must be read with regard to the possibility of distinct layers and contexts of transmission.

These issues do not weaken the reconstruction; they define its limits. The second century can be described with sufficient historical density without turning every documentary difference into a single evolutionary sequence.

13. Pagan criticism and apologetic response: an arc between the second and fourth centuries

The delimitation of Christian identity did not occur solely through internal controversies. From the second century onward, learned pagan authors examined the historicity of the traditions about Jesus, the coherence of Scripture, the conduct of the apostles, and the Christian claim to religious exclusivity. These criticisms compelled Christian apologists and exegetes to respond on the same philological, philosophical, and historical ground as their adversaries.

The documentation presents a specific problem: much of the anti-Christian literature is not preserved in independent manuscript transmission. Celsus is known primarily through Origen; Hierocles, through Eusebius; Julian, mainly through Cyril of Alexandria; and the anti-Christian corpus attributed to Porphyry must be reconstructed from scattered testimonies whose attribution to a single work remains a subject of debate. Therefore, each argument must indicate whether it comes from a direct quotation, a paraphrase, or a later attribution.

Furthermore, it is not advisable to simply group Celsus and Porphyry under the same philosophical label. Celsus belongs to the horizon of Middle Platonism of the second century; Porphyry, on the other hand, writes within the Neoplatonism of the

third century. The chronological and intellectual difference matters, because anti-Christian criticism transforms as Christianity itself does.

13.1. Celsus: historical, social and philosophical criticism

Celsus's Logos Alēthēs, probably composed in the second half of the second century, has been lost and must be reconstructed from Origen's Contra Celsum. The Christian apologist quotes extensive passages from his adversary, but the modern reconstruction should not present Celsus's text as if we possessed a continuous manuscript.

Celsus introduces, among other strategies, a Jewish interlocutor who questions the birth of Jesus and reproduces the polemical tradition according to which Mary conceived a child with a soldier named Panthera. This detail belongs to a polemical construction from the second century and does not constitute independent biographical evidence about Jesus. Its importance lies in showing that the legitimacy of Jesus' birth and miracles had already entered the realm of public controversy.

Celsus also ridicules the social composition of Christian communities, mentioning artisans, uneducated people, women, and children as recipients of the preaching. Origen responds that the ethical transformation produced by the message constitutes an indication of its power. The contrast shows how the same social phenomenon could be interpreted as a sign of vulgarity by the critic and as moral efficacy by the apologist.

On a philosophical level, Celsus questions the incarnation, bodily resurrection, and the idea that the universal divine order could be concentrated in a particular history. His critique reveals a conflict between different conceptions of providence, matter, revelation, and religious citizenship.[52]

13.2. Porphyry: philology, Daniel and the critique of apostolic coherence

Porphyry of Tyre, a disciple of Plotinus, was remembered by Christian authors as one of their most formidable intellectual adversaries. Tradition speaks of an anti-Christian work in fifteen books, but the reconstruction of this corpus is problematic: fragments and testimonies have been gathered since Harnack, while recent research debates which materials actually belonged to a single work entitled Contra Christianos.

[52] Origen, Cels. I.28; I.32; I.68; III.44; III.55; VIII.55. References: Koetschau 1899 and Chadwick 1953. The accusation about Panthera is identified as a polemic transmitted by Origen.

Jerome explicitly attributes a critique of the book of Daniel to Porphyry's Book XII: the philosopher maintained that Daniel had not prophesied in the sixth century BCE, but rather that an author from the time of Antiochus IV had recounted, in prophetic form, events that had already occurred. Modern scholarship independently dates the final form of Daniel to the context of the Maccabean crisis; this does not make Porphyry the founder of modern biblical criticism, but it does demonstrate the antiquity of a historical reading of the problem.

Porphyry was also associated with objections based on scriptural discrepancies and directed against the consistency of apostolic authority. The case of Galatians 2:11–14 proved especially fertile: the confrontation between Paul and Cephas could be read as evidence of a real conflict among apostolic leaders. Jerome explains in Epistle 112 that earlier Christian commentators had proposed an interpretation of the scene as a prearranged strategy, precisely to respond to Porphyry's accusation. Augustine rejected this solution because, in his view, it compromised the veracity of Scripture.[53]

13.3. Hierocles and Apollonius of Tyana: the comparative problem of miracles

At the beginning of the fourth century, Hierocles composed the Philalēthēs, an anti-Christian work preserved only indirectly. Eusebius of Caesarea responds in Against Hierocles and cites the most distinctive core of the argument: the comparison between Jesus and Apollonius of Tyana.

Hierocles argues that Christians proclaimed Jesus divine based on miracles, while pagan observers could accept prodigies attributed to Apollonius without thereby making him a god. Eusebius responds by subjecting Philostratus's Life of Apollonius to a critique of its credibility and coherence.

This episode is methodologically important because it illustrates a dispute over criteria for evidence. The question is no longer simply which miracles are recounted, but which sources transmit them, what level of education is attributed to their authors, and what inferences can be drawn from an extraordinary account.[54]

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[53] Jerome, Commentary on Daniel, prologue, on the attribution to Book XII of Porphyry. Morlet 2011 studies the problems of the anti-Christian corpus. The philosophical classification is used only as historical context for the author.

[54] Eusebius, Hier. 1–2. The comparison with Apollonius is known from his refuter; Digeser 2012 contextualises criticism and religious politics.

13.4. Julian and Against the Galileans: imperial critique of Christianity

The emperor Julian composed Contra Galilaeos around 362–363. The work, probably in three books, does not survive directly; most of the known fragments come from Cyril of Alexandria's Contra Iulianum, written decades later. Modern scholarship insists that the reconstruction should not be printed as if it were a reliable, continuous text.

Julian questions the Christian appropriation of the Scriptures of Israel, contrasts Hellenic civic and cultic traditions with Christian claims, and attacks the historical coherence of a religion that, in his view, had distanced itself as much from Jewish practices as from traditional Greco-Roman religion.

His testimony is especially valuable because it comes from an emperor initially raised in a Christian environment and later committed to a policy of restoring traditional cults. Contra Galilaeos thus belongs to both the intellectual and the political history of the relationship between Christianity and the Empire.[55]

13.5. Assessment: pagan criticism and apologetic response from the second to the fourth century

The following table summarises some of the most significant intellectual clashes. The final column avoids turning the Christian refutation into a simple victorious response: each axis is used to identify which historical or hermeneutical problem was exposed by the controversy.

Documentary comparison 5. Pagan criticism and apologetic response: themes and witnesses.

[55] Julian, Against the Galileans, fragments preserved mainly by Cyril, Against Julian. Editorial reference: Neumann 1880. The transmitter is always identified, and the complete preservation of the original is not claimed.

Historicity and genealogy of Jesus

Pagan criticism. Celsus, preserved in Origen: illegitimate birth, Panthera, magic learned in Egypt and humble social origin of the movement.

Christian response. Origen, Contra Celsum I–II: challenges the reliability of the accusation and shifts the argument towards moral coherence, the expansion of the movement and the meaning of the signs.

Historical-critical evaluation. Celsus documents a second-century controversy, not an independent biography of Jesus. Origen combines historical, theological and sociological defence.

Daniel and prophecy

Pagan criticism. Porphyry, according to Jerome: Daniel is a composition of the time of Antiochus IV that presents past events as prophecy.

Christian response. Jerome, Commentariorum in Danielem: defends the antiquity and prophetic scope of the book, discussing language, history and fulfilment.

Historical-critical evaluation. The Maccabean dating of the final form of Daniel is now widely accepted on independent grounds. The ancient controversy anticipates historical-philological questions, not the complete modern method.

Galatians 2 and the apostolic conflict

Pagan criticism. Porphyry, according to Jerome: the confrontation between Paul and Peter reveals **rivalry**, inconsistency and reciprocal accusations of simulation.

Christian response. Jerome, Ep. 112, attributes to earlier commentators a reading of the episode as an agreed pedagogical strategy; Augustine rejects that solution because it compromises the veracity of the story.

Historical-critical evaluation. The episode demonstrates that the tension of Gal 2 was perceived in Antiquity as a problem of apostolic coherence and generated divergent exegetical responses.

Miracles and credibility

Pagan criticism. Hierocles compares Jesus to Apollonius **of** Tyana and argues that miracles are not enough to prove divinity.

Christian response. Eusebius, Against Hierocles, criticises the reliability and contradictions of the Philostratean tradition on Apollonius.

Historical-critical evaluation. The controversy shifts the discussion towards criteria of testimony, authorship and credibility of the sources.

Israel, Hellenism and Christianity

Pagan criticism. Julian argues that the "Galileans" appropriated the Jewish Scriptures while abandoning practices of Israel and rejecting traditional Hellenic cults.

Christian response. Cyril of Alexandria, Contra Iulianum, responds by means of a Christological and scriptural defence of continuity and fulfilment.

Historical-critical evaluation. The dispute shows that in the fourth century Christian identity had to be justified simultaneously against Jewish heritage, classical culture and imperial power.

The value of this section does not lie in awarding a retrospective victory to one side. Pagan controversies compelled Christian authors to clarify interpretive criteria, address apparent contradictions, and justify the relationship between biblical tradition, philosophy, and imperial order. In turn, Christian responses preserved many of the criticisms they sought to refute.

Asymmetric transmission requires a permanent rule: when a lost pagan author is reconstructed from a Christian refutation, the monograph always cites the transmitting source and avoids presenting the reconstruction as a recovered autograph text.

14. Epidemics, crises and persecution: avoiding automatic causality

The great epidemics of the second and third centuries coincided with periods of political and religious tension, but this chronological overlap does not justify attributing persecutions to epidemics, nor plagues to religious conflicts. The Antonine Plague developed from the 160s onward, and the so-called Plague of Cyprian from the mid-third century; the measures taken by Decius and Valerian addressed issues of loyalty, sacrifice, imperial discipline, and governance, which require their own documentary analysis. At the same time, the epidemics disrupted mobility, mortality, taxation, recruitment, markets, and assistance networks. In this context, Christian communities could interpret illness through eschatological or providential categories while simultaneously organising care, burials, and material aid. Chapter XIII specifically examines this intersection between illness, medicine, ritual, and charity.

Conclusion

The second century did not immediately produce a uniform Church; rather, it produced mechanisms capable of making increasing unification possible. Ministerial order, succession, rule of truth, liturgy, collections of texts, and classification of adversaries arose in different contexts and did not advance at the same pace.

Plurality was real, but so was the search for coherence. The communities differed and, in that context, apostolic memory and public continuity acquired value; multiple texts circulated and some collections began to function as preferred repertoires; rival teachers existed and the definition of a rule of truth became a polemical necessity. These correlations do not by themselves prove a causal relation: they describe conditions that coexisted and that the authors of the period themselves invoke to justify their proposals.

The formation of borders was, therefore, a productive process. It not only excluded: it also created vocabulary, institutions, practices, and archives. Later centuries would inherit these instruments and deploy them on a new scale when the relationship with the Empire, persecution, martyrdom, and finally imperial patronage transformed the conditions of existence of the communities.

Summary

This chapter examines second-century Christian plurality through the mechanisms by which communities constructed and authorised their collective identity. It analyses 1 Clement, Ignatius, the Didache, the Shepherd of Hermas, Justin, Irenaeus, the Roman succession traditions, the Valentinian and other second-century movements, and the pagan intellectual response from Celsus to Julian. It distinguishes teachers, schools, corpora, and heresiological constructs in the study of "Gnosticism." It argues that episcopal structures, apostolic memory, rules of truth, textual collections, ritual practices, polemical classifications, and external philosophical criticism developed unevenly but together created mechanisms that made later forms of Christian unity possible.

Keywords: second-century Christianity; authority; apostolic succession; episcopate; heresiology.

CHAPTER IV

Persecution, Martyrdom and Imperial Administration (Second–Fourth Centuries)

Relations between Christian communities and Roman power cannot be described as a uniform and uninterrupted persecution from Nero to Constantine. The sources show an irregular sequence of local episodes, casuistic administrative procedures, and imperial measures of varying scope. Only in the third century did genuinely empire-wide policies emerge that systematically affected Christian communities.

This distinction is essential for a critical history. Later Christian memory tended to organise episodes of violence within a continuous narrative of witness and martyrdom. That memory has enormous historical value, but it is not the same thing as a single state policy sustained over three centuries.

Prelude. From the burning of Rome to Pliny's correspondence: coercion and memory in the first century

The first century offers no evidence of a continuous imperial policy against all Christian groups. The best-documented episode is the Neronian repression following the fire of Rome in 64, known chiefly from Tacitus (Ann. XV.44), who wrote several decades after the event. The passage presents the Christians as an already identifiable group in Rome and describes exemplary punishments, but it does not support the reconstruction of a general edict applicable throughout the Empire. Its historical value lies in showing an action of imperial power confined to the city of Rome and the availability of a religious minority as an object of public stigmatisation. Later Christian memory transformed this episode into a pivotal point in the tradition concerning Peter and Paul, whereas the surviving evidence allows us to speak with confidence only of a specific situation in Rome.

Suetonius's account of Claudius and the riots instigated by Chrestus (Claud. 25.4) pertains to a different problem: it does not describe a Christian persecution in the technical sense, and its interpretation depends on whether Chrestus refers to Christ—and thus to intra-Jewish conflicts over the messianic proclamation—or to an agitator of that name. The expulsion, or restriction, of certain Jews from Rome around 49 CE must therefore be methodologically separated from the Neronian repression. This distinction allows the chapter to cover the period from the first century to the Great Persecution without fabricating an uninterrupted line of coercion.

1. Pliny and Trajan: procedure before programme

The correspondence between Pliny the Younger and Trajan, Epistulae X, 96–97, constitutes the clearest administrative evidence from the beginning of the second century (c. 110–113). As governor of Bithynia-Pontus, Pliny consulted the emperor because he did not know exactly how to proceed against people accused of being Christians. His uncertainty shows that he was not acting on the basis of a specific and uniform penal statute dedicated exclusively to Christianity.

Trajan replies that Christians should not be actively sought out, that anonymous accusations should not be admitted, and that those who deny being Christian and demonstrate adherence to public worship by sacrificing should be released. The procedure is fundamentally administrative and political: persistence in refusing a legitimate order from a magistrate, and refusal to participate in public worship, could become grounds for condemnation.

Pliny also provides valuable information about Christian practices: meetings before dawn, singing to Christ quasi deo ("as to a god"), and moral commitments. This information nevertheless comes from interrogations and the perspective of a Roman governor.[56]

2. Martyrdom of Polycarp: memory, exemplary conduct and discipline

The Martyrdom of Polycarp, composed in Asia Minor after the death of the bishop of Smyrna, is one of the earliest Christian accounts of martyrdom developed as an exemplary narrative. It is not a literal court record: it combines local memory, epistolary features, biblical exegesis, and a typology of the imitation of Christ.

Its historical value lies precisely in this elaboration. The text defines what constitutes legitimate martyrdom, discourages the reckless pursuit of arrest, and constructs the memory of the body and relics within a community that celebrates the martyr's anniversary. The judicial event thus becomes a ritualised memory.[57]

[56] Pliny, Ep. X.96–97. Reference edition: Mynors 1963. de Ste. Croix 2006 and Rebillard 2012 help to distinguish administrative action from local identities.

[57] Mart. Pol. 9–10; 15–18. References: Holmes 2007; Musurillo 1972. The narrative scenario is distinguished from the procedural data that can be verified.

3. Perpetua and Felicity: gender, status and African memory

The Passio Perpetuae et Felicitatis, linked to Carthage at the beginning of the third century, preserves sections presented as the story of Perpetua and a vision attributed to Saturus, brought together by an editor. The text combines first-person narration, martyr narrative and communal shaping.

Perpetua, a young woman of relatively high social standing, and Felicity, an enslaved and pregnant woman, show how gender and legal status permeate Christian memory. The narrative does not erase the social hierarchies of the Empire, but rather reorders them around confession and martyrdom.[58]

4. Decius: sacrifice, certification and imperial reach

Under Decius (249–251), a general edict to sacrifice was issued in early 250; its implementation is documented by papyrus certificates, the so-called libelli. Not all the details of the edict have been preserved, and it is inaccurate to reduce the measure to a law directed solely against Christians. The obligation to sacrifice nevertheless bore particularly heavily on those who considered the act incompatible with their religious identity. The standard study of the general character of the measure is J. B. Rives, "The Decree of Decius and the Religion of Empire," Journal of Roman Studies 89 (1999).

The crisis created categories of those who had sacrificed, obtained certificates, or resisted, and opened a lasting conflict over the readmission of the lapsed. Cyprian of Carthage and Roman correspondence document how an imperial policy produced new internal ecclesiological disputes.[59]

4.1. Documentary Window: a libellus of sacrifice

Table 25. Documentary window: a libellus of sacrifice

Identification	**P.Oxy. IV 658; certificate of sacrifice from the time of Decius; 14 June 250 CE (20 Payni, year 1 of Decius).**
Date	250 CE

[58] Pass. Perp. 3–10; 14–21. Musurillo 1972. The voices and redactional phases of the narrative are considered before using it as a homogeneous record of a process.

[59] Cyprian, Laps. 7–9; 15–18; letters from the Decian crisis. P.Oxy. IV 658 provides an administrative document distinct from the ecclesiastical memory. Text of De lapsis: Bévenot 1972, CCSL 3.

(continued)

Identification	**P.Oxy. IV 658; certificate of sacrifice from the time of Decius; 14 June 250 CE (20 Payni, year 1 of Decius).**
Medium	Administrative papyrus.
Content	Declaration before commissioners that the bearer had performed the sacrifice and tasted the offerings according to the order.
Historical value	Direct material evidence of the bureaucratic mechanism employed during the Decian sacrificial policy.

5. Valerian: pressure on leaders and structures

Under Valerian, especially between 257 and 258, imperial policy was more clearly directed against community leaders, assemblies, and structures. The documentation transmitted by Cyprian and Eusebius reveals a more selective approach than that of Decius.

The executions of Cyprian in Carthage and of Sixtus II in Rome quickly passed into martyrial memory. The contrast between these two periods shows that not all persecutions used the same mechanisms or pursued identical administrative objectives.[60]

6. The Great Persecution and the Tetrarchy

The so-called Great Persecution, which began in 303 under the Tetrarchy, was the most extensive effort to dismantle Christian institutions before Constantine. The measures included the destruction of meeting places and Scriptures, the loss of legal privileges, and, in later phases, demands for sacrifice. Its application varied considerably between regions.

Eusebius and Lactantius are primary sources, but both write from highly interpretive Christian perspectives. Their accounts must be considered alongside legislation, papyri, epigraphy, and regional chronologies. The intensity of persecution in the East was not identical to that observed in the territories ruled by Constantius Chlorus.

[60] Cyprian, Ep. 80.1, on the measures of Valerian; Eusebius, HE VII.10–13. The scope of each norm is distinct from that of local action.

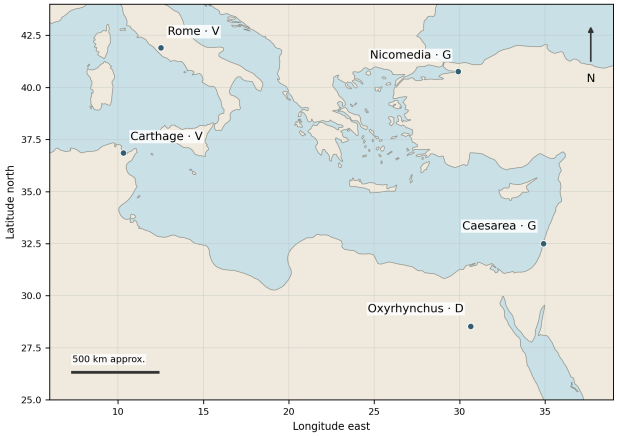


FIGURE 11. Locations with selected documentation of coercion and certification. D: Decius, Oxyrhynchus, P.Oxy. IV 658 (14 June 250; 20 Payni, year 1 of Decius), certificate of sacrifice that does not by itself identify a Christian. V: Valerian, Rome and Carthage (258), Cyprian, Ep. 80.1, and Acta proconsularia Cypriani. G: Great Persecution, Nicomedia (303), Lactantius, Mort. pers. 12–13, and Caesarea Maritima, provincial capital of Palestine (Syria Palaestina), Eusebius, Martyrs of Palestine. The points refer to documents of different genres, not to a uniform intensity of persecution or a complete inventory of victims. Cartography by the author on Natural Earth, public domain. [ED; REC-GRAF].

The destruction and surrender of books also created a problem of documentary memory. In Africa, accusations of traditio would later fuel the Donatist conflict, where fidelity during persecution became a criterion of episcopal legitimacy.[61]

[61] Eusebius, HE VIII.2–6; Lactantius, Mort. pers. 12–16. Barnes 2011 and Digeser 2012 situate the tetrarchic sequence; dates and places are not merged into a uniform persecution.

7. Galerius and the Edict of Toleration of 311

In 311 Galerius issued an edict of toleration that acknowledged the failure of the repressive policies and once again permitted Christian gatherings, on the condition that public order was respected and prayers were offered for the welfare of the state. Lactantius preserved the Latin text, and Eusebius a Greek version. According to Lactantius, the edict, issued when Galerius was already mortally ill, was posted at Nicomedia on 30 April 311 (Mort. pers. 35.1: pridie Kalendas Maias).

The document rules out any account of toleration as an initiative of Constantine alone in 313. The legal transformation started within the Tetrarchy itself and must be understood as a broader political process.[62]

8. Martyrdom acts: document, memory and literature

The category of Acta martyrum does not in itself guarantee a literal transcription of the judicial process. Some works preserve plausible formulas and frameworks of interrogation; others are later literary compositions that develop hagiographic themes.

For each piece, the date of the event, the date of composition, the manuscript tradition, and the degree of reworking must be distinguished. The historical question is not only whether an episode occurred, but also how it was remembered, what elements were added, and what function it fulfilled in the community that transmitted the story.[63]

Conclusion

Between the second and early fourth centuries, the Christian experience of state coercion was real, but uneven. The memory of martyrdom transformed local episodes into translocal models of identity. Persecution, therefore, must be studied simultaneously as administrative history and as a history of memory.

[62] Lactantius, Mort. pers. 34; Eusebius, HE VIII.17. The edict of 311 is earlier than the agreement of 313 and has its own formulation.

[63] Musurillo 1972; Moss 2012. Acts and passions require analysis of transmission, genre and purpose, in addition to the possible procedural core.

Summary

This chapter examines Roman measures against Christians from Pliny and Trajan to the Great Persecution and Galerius's Edict of Toleration in 311. It rejects the model of uninterrupted persecution throughout the Empire and distinguishes between administrative procedure, imperial policy, judicial practice, and the memory of martyrdom. It pays particular attention to the Martyrdom of Polycarp, the Passion of Perpetua and Felicity, the libelli from the time of Decius, the measures of Valerian, and the documentary asymmetry between Christian accounts and administrative evidence.

Keywords: persecution; martyrdom; Decius; Valerian; Diocletian; Galerius.

CHAPTER V

Space, Manuscripts and Early Christian Iconography

Material culture is not merely a secondary illustration of what we already know from texts. Objects, inscriptions, manuscripts, funerary spaces, and buildings possess their own chronologies and contexts. In this chapter, they are treated as autonomous sources capable of confirming, qualifying, or contradicting reconstructions based exclusively on literature.

The central methodological problem lies in avoiding two extremes: considering every ancient symbol as unequivocally Christian or, conversely, denying specificity to images and objects when their archaeological context allows for a reasonable attribution. Christian visual identity emerged through the selection, reuse, and reinterpretation of repertoires shared with the Greco-Roman world.

1. The codex and the materiality of the collection

The surviving Christian manuscripts show an early preference for the codex. This preference was not absolute, but it was marked enough to set Christian practice apart from large sectors of Greco-Roman literary culture, in which the roll remained of great importance.

The codex facilitated the gathering of various writings into a single physical unit, the location of passages, and the transport of collections. P^{46} is a prime example for the Pauline epistles; P^{75}, for Luke and John. Material technology did not create the canon, but it conditioned the concrete possibilities of collection and reading.

Each manuscript must be analysed separately: writing material, format, number of columns, nomina sacra, order of books, hands, and corrections. Textual criticism is also the archaeology of the book.[64]

[64] Hurtado 2006; Nongbri 2018. The Christian use of the codex does not prove that every ancient codex is Christian nor that every collection constitutes a complete canon.

2. Staurogram and nomina sacra

Among the most striking palaeographic features of certain early Christian manuscripts is the staurogram, a ligature of tau and rho used in some abbreviations related to σταυρός and σταυρόω. In certain manuscripts, the sign has been interpreted as an early form of visualising the cross within the writing itself.

The interpretation must remain tied to the specific manuscripts and their dating. The sign should not be turned into a universal emblem of early Christianity. Its relevance lies in showing how writing and image could be superimposed on the page.

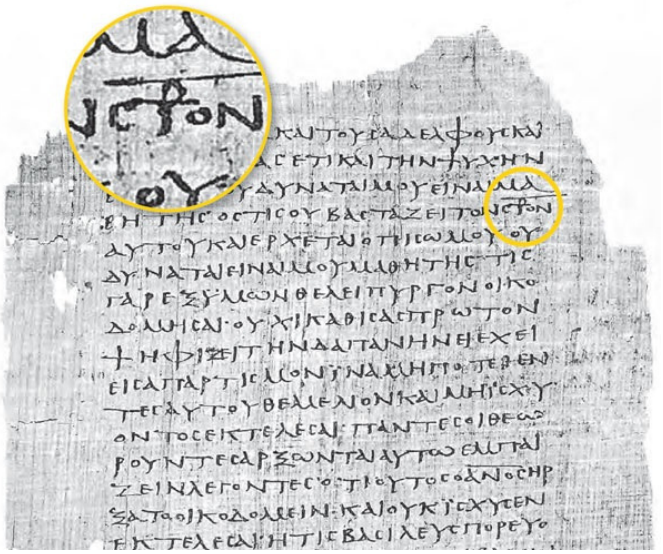


FIGURE 12. Detail of the staurogram in Luke 14:27, P75 (Bodmer XIV–XV, now Pap. Hanna 1, Vatican Apostolic Library). Palaeographic dating debated between the late second and fourth centuries; the image alone does not date the manuscript. Reproduction declared in the public domain (PD-Art/PDM) on Wikimedia Commons. [FAC].

2.1. STAUROGRAM AND CHRISMON AS DISTINCT SIGNS

The tau-rho ligature and the chi-rho monogram must be distinguished graphically and functionally. The staurogram incorporates letters associated with the abbreviation of words from the σταυρός family. The chi-rho monogram combines the first letters of Χριστός and acquired particularly important public visibility during the fourth century. Sharing a rho neither makes them necessary stages of a single evolution nor demonstrates a common origin for all their uses.

Early examples of the staurogram are studied in manuscripts such as P^{66} and P^{75}, among others. The attribution to P46 should not be repeated as if its ^{mere} age proved the presence of the same phenomenon. Each claim requires identification of the specific instance and a corresponding reproduction. The visual interpretation of the sign as evoking a crucified figure is a historical proposition that is discussed in terms of form and context, not a fact equivalent to the mere existence of the ligature.[65]

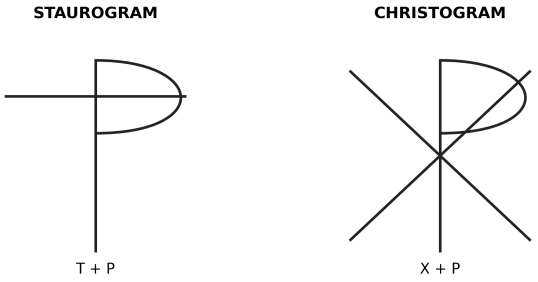


FIGURE 13. Analytical comparison of tau-rho and chi-rho. Modern graphic composition to distinguish staurogram and chrismon; it is not a facsimile of ancient writing. [ED; REC-GRAF].

The materiality of abbreviations matters. A nomen sacrum often combines contraction, inflection, and a supralinear stroke. The form changes according to the grammatical case: a list of isolated letters can conceal this relationship. Repetition within a codex reveals a scribe's habits and, at times, corrections by another hand. To describe these phenomena, it is not enough to reproduce a modern emblem detached from the page.

Early Christian writing was not identical everywhere. The selection of abbreviated words, the frequency and form of strokes could differ. It is not appropriate to turn a repertoire of sacred names into a universal code that every reader would understand in the same way. The object attests a scribal practice; its social interpretation requires comparing testimonies and acknowledging the loss of information about those who produced and used them.

[65] Hurtado 2006, on manuscript artifacts and the tau-rho ligature; Jensen 2017, on the history of the cross. P^{66} and $P^{75\ are\ distinguished}$ from $P^{46.}$ The existence of the sign is attributed to specific witnesses; no new list of loci is offered without collation.

2.2. Tau, Ezekiel 9 and the formation of a visual grammar of the cross

The relationship between the letter tau, Ezekiel 9, and the earliest Christian symbols of the cross must be approached through a strictly philological and palaeographic reformulation. The starting point is not a universal symbolic genealogy, but rather a problem of texts, spellings, and receptions. In Ezekiel 9:4–6, the sign placed on the foreheads of the righteous depends on the textual tradition and the history of the letter's graphic forms. The ancient Hebrew taw and later Greek forms should not be confused, nor should it be assumed that every ancient cruciform sign inherently possessed a Christian meaning.

The Septuagint offers a particularly important field of study here because Greek-speaking Christian communities received Ezekiel through a Greek text whose terminology could be typologically reactivated. Later Christian reception interpreted Ezekiel's protective sign in light of the cross, but this reading must be distinguished from the historical sense of the prophetic passage. The typological procedure is a fact of reception; it does not constitute proof that the author of Ezekiel anticipated a Christian form. It should also be noted that the Septuagint renders the Hebrew תָּו as σημεῖον; the explicit reference to the letter tau derives from the versions of Aquila and Theodotion, as reported by Origen (Selecta in Ezechielem 9).

Early manuscript documentation necessitates a second distinction. The staurogram—the tau-rho ligature that appears in some Christian manuscripts—is not equivalent to the chi-rho monogram, nor should it be confused with a cross drawn independently. Its importance lies in showing how a scribal convention could acquire a visual dimension within the text. Papyri such as P^{66}, P^{75}, and P^{45} have been central to the discussion, although each example must be dated and described with palaeographic caution.

The interpretation of the staurogram as one of the earliest visual representations of Jesus crucified is suggestive because the rho can evoke a head above the tau crossbar. However, the analysis should be presented as a historiographical interpretation and not as self-sufficient evidence. The abbreviative function, the tradition of sacred names, and the graphic context of the codex are equally relevant. The strength of the argument arises from the convergence of form, use, and Christian context, not from an isolated geometric resemblance.

The history of the Christian cross does not gain rigour by connecting it to every previous cruciform figure; on the contrary, such accumulations obscure the routes

of transmission that can actually be demonstrated. A legitimate comparison must specify object, date, origin, medium, function, and historical chain of reception.

The subsequent development of the cross as a public symbol also requires distinct chronologies. Before the fourth century, the cross could appear allusively, textually, or graphically, without yet occupying the monumental position it would acquire in imperial Christian culture. The Constantinian transformation did not create the symbolism of the cross from scratch, but it changed the possibilities for its display. Therefore, manuscripts, gems, graffiti, sarcophagi, inscriptions, and literary narratives must be studied in separate series before being integrated into a comprehensive history.

A comparison of tau, the staurogram, the chi-rho monogram and the simple cross requires attention to date, medium, context, certainty of identification and bibliography. This approach preserves the historical value of the evidence without turning a sequence of similarities into an imaginary genealogy.

Sources and reference bibliography: Ezekiel 9:4–6 in Hebrew and the Septuagint; early Christian papyrological evidence; Larry W. Hurtado, *The Earliest Christian Artifacts*; palaeographic studies on the *nomina sacra* and staurogram. The identification of each papyrus must rest on a catalogue and a critical edition.

3. The Alexamenos graffito: mockery, the cross and external perceptions

The so-called Alexamenos graffito was found in the Paedagogium on the Palatine Hill and depicts a human figure to the left, with a raised arm, facing a crucified figure with a donkey's head on the right. The Greek inscription is usually interpreted as a mockery: "Alexamenos worships his god." Its dating is generally placed between the late second and third centuries, with different proposals depending on the archaeological context.

The scene is often interpreted as an anti-Christian caricature. Its importance lies in documenting how crucifixion could function as an object of ridicule precisely because the shameful execution was central to Christian identity. The donkey's head also connects with ancient accusations of onolatry levelled against both Jews and Christians.

The graffito is not a Christian image produced for devotion; it is a hostile image. It is therefore a particularly valuable testimony to external social perception.[66]

[66] The graffito of Alexamenos, Paedagogium of the Palatine; Tertullian, Apol. 16 and Nat. I.11–14, as a comparison of accusations of onolatry. Jensen 2017 analyses the history of the representation of the cross.

3.1. Documentary Window: the Alexamenos graffito

Table 26. Documentary window: the Alexamenos graffito

Origin	**Paedagogium, Palatine Hill, Rome.**
Custody	Palatine Museum / Parco archeologico del Colosseo.
Dating	Late second–third century; range disputed.
Medium	Incised graffito on wall plaster (*intonaco*).
Inscription	ΑΛΕΞΑΜΕΝΟΣ ΣΕΒΕΤΕ ΘΕΟΝ, with popular spelling; approximate meaning: "Alexamenos worships [his] god."
Interpretation	Likely anti-Christian caricature of a crucified man with a donkey's head.

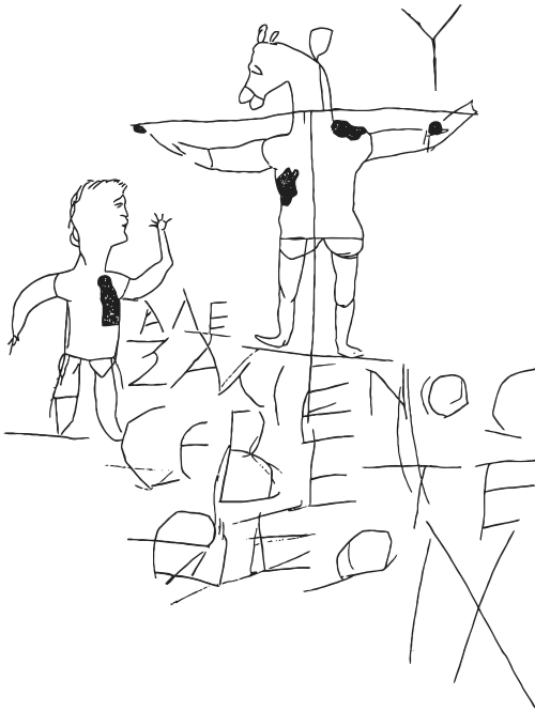


Figure 14. Alexamenos graffito: line reproduction supplied for this edition as a reading aid for the motif and inscription. It is presented alongside, and does not replace, the photograph of the original support in Figure 15. [ED].

3.2. Onolatry, Alexamenos and the languages of religious hostility

The Alexamenos graffito should not be interpreted in isolation. Contextualising the accusation of onolatry alongside anti-Jewish and anti-Christian polemics places the image within a broader Roman repertoire of accusation, mockery, and religious stereotyping.

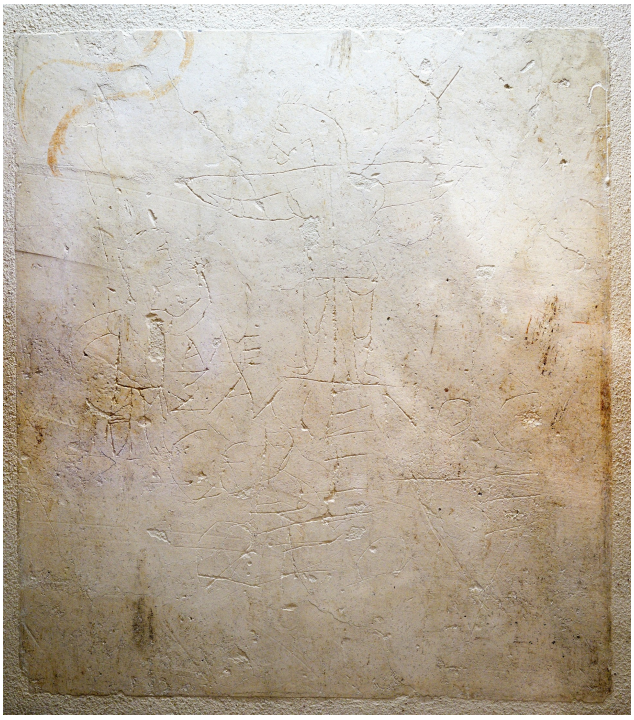


Figure 15. Alexamenos graffito: photograph of the original support preserved in Rome. The photograph remains the primary material document; Figure 14 serves only as a graphic reading aid. [IMG-HR; ED].

The so-called onolatry—the accusation of worshipping a deity with the form or head of a donkey—circulated in polemics against Jews and could later be reused against Christians. The relevant point is not to establish an automatic continuity between each testimony, but to study how an available stereotype could shift among groups perceived as strange, exclusive, or ritually suspect. Josephus, in refuting accusations transmitted in anti-Jewish traditions, is an essential source for reconstructing the polemical background; Tacitus, Hist. V.3–4, explicitly transmits the story that the Jews consecrated in their sanctuary the effigy of the ass that had guided them in

the desert; Tertullian (Apol. 16; Nat. I.11) names him as the source of the rumour later applied to Christians.

The Palatine graffito depicts a crucified figure with a donkey's head, accompanied by an individual in an attitude of veneration, and the inscription usually interpreted as "Alexamenos worships his god." Its value for the history of Christianity is exceptional because it documents an external and mocking perspective on a Christian practice or identity. It does not, in itself, demonstrate what the Christians depicted believed, nor does it authorise the reconstruction of a theology of the cross; it does, however, document the social perception of a cult associated with an executed person and the possibility of combining religious mockery with social humiliation.

The associated inscription known as "Alexamenos fidelis" has been used to reinforce the Christian identification, but it must be kept separate from the main graffito and described according to its archaeological and epigraphic context. Its proximity or association does not justify merging both testimonies into a single documentary scene. A complete record should identify the catalogue number, place of discovery, support, epigraphic reading, and specialised bibliography.

Opposition to Christianity can be analysed on three levels: popular, intellectual, and administrative. The popular level includes rumours, caricatures, and accusations of secret practices; the intellectual level comprises articulated criticisms such as those of Celsus, Porphyry, Hierocles, and Julian; the administrative level corresponds to imperial procedures, rescripts, and decrees. These levels intersect, but they are not equivalent and should not be reduced to the generic term "persecution."

Tertullian and Minucius Felix are particularly valuable sources for studying accusations that apologists attribute to their opponents: cannibalism, incest, impiety, or monstrous worship. The historian must resist the temptation to simply accept that all these accusations circulated with the frequency or in the exact form attributed to them by the Christian defence. The apologetic text selects and dramatises objections in order to refute them. Its historical value lies both in the accusations transmitted and in the strategy of response.

This context connects the Alexamenos graffito with the discussion of pagan criticism while preserving its material specificity. Caricature, philosophical treatise and imperial rescript are distinct kinds of evidence. Together they show that Christian identity could be rejected on social, religious, philosophical or political grounds; examined separately, they allow closer reconstruction of who is speaking, to whom, and in response to what problem.

Sources and reference bibliography: Josephus, Contra Apionem; Tacitus, Historiae V; Tertullian, Ad nationes and Apologeticum; Minucius Felix, Octavius; archae-

ological and epigraphic documentation of the graffito of Alexamenos. Popular reconstructions of the graffito require reference to a catalogue, photograph, or specialised publication.

4. Ichthys: sign, word and context

The fish appears in numerous Greco-Roman contexts and is not inherently Christian. Its Christian identification depends on the archaeological, epigraphic and textual context. The relationship between ἰχθύς and the Christological acronym Ἰησοῦς Χριστὸς Θεοῦ Υἱὸς Σωτήρ belongs to an ancient tradition, but not every fish represented in a tomb or mosaic should be automatically interpreted using that acronym.

When inscription, funerary context, and iconographic repertoire converge, the fish can function as a sign of belonging, baptism, food, or Christology. Its historical value lies precisely in this controlled polysemy.

4.1. Fish, baptism and language of belonging

The Christian use of the fish does not depend on a single explanation. Gospel accounts of fishing and feeding, mission metaphors, and baptismal practices provided distinct repertoires that could converge. Tertullian opens *De baptismo* with a comparison between believers and little fish born in water after the pattern of Christ, whom he explicitly calls 'our ἰχθύς' (Bapt. 1.3: nos pisciculi secundum ἰχθὺν nostrum Iesum Christum in aqua nascimur). The document demonstrates an explicit association between ichthyological language and baptism around the turn of the second and third centuries; it does not, on its own, date the first Christian image of a fish.[67]

The acronym Ἰησοῦς Χριστὸς Θεοῦ Υἱὸς Σωτήρ condenses a Christological confession into the letters of ἰχθύς. Augustine, in Civ. *Dei* XVIII.23, relates this reading to a tradition of Sibylline verses. The Greek acrostic is indeed preserved in Oracula Sibyllina VIII.217–250, a Christian section usually dated between the late second and the third century. His testimony corresponds to a late antique reception of the formula; it should not be used to attribute the same acrostic to any earlier funerary painting. Documenting the acronym and identifying an image are different operations.

The popular narrative that two strangers successively drew halves of a fish as a password during a general persecution does not enjoy the documentary support of the

[67] Tertullian, Bapt. 1; Augustine, Civ. XVIII.23. The first locus relates fish and water; the second transmits the acrostic. Reference reproductions: New Advent, `https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0321.htm` and `https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/120118.htm`. These are older translations, not substitutes for the critical apparatus.

texts discussed above. It can be studied as a modern tradition, but not incorporated as a verified description of a practice from the first or second centuries. The discreet nature of a symbol does not demonstrate universal clandestinity or a protocol for recognition.

Food contexts also require precision. A fish with loaves of bread can belong to a meal scene, a representation of abundance, or an interpretation of the Gospel narratives. To propose a Eucharistic interpretation, one must evaluate the inscription, arrangement, location, and relationship to other figures. When these checks do not resolve the case, it is appropriate to consider several possibilities rather than establishing a single equivalence.

4.2. Abercius and the geography of a Christian identity

The epitaph of Abercius provides testimony of particular importance because it links personal memory, travel, pastoral language, and food. Its fragments were recovered in Hieropolis, Phrygia, in the nineteenth century; the text is also known through a literary tradition and by the partial reuse of its formulas in the epitaph of Alexander, dated to 216. These testimonies must be distinguished: letters preserved in stone, epigraphic reception, and hagiographic narrative do not possess identical value.[68]

Documentary Window: the Epitaph of Abercius

Table 27. Documentary window: the Epitaph of Abercius

Field	Identification and scope
Document	Epitaph of Abercius; fragments of a funerary monument.
Place	Hieropolis, Phrygia, present-day Turkey.
Custody	Vatican Museums, Christian Lapidary.
Dating	Late second or early third century; earlier than Alexander's epitaph of 216, which reuses part of the text.

[68] Vatican Museums, Christian Lapidary, Cippo di Abercio: `https://www.museivaticani.va/content/museivaticani/en/collezioni/musei/lapidario-cristiano/abercio/cippo-di-albercio.html`. The record distinguishes the fragments and their history of discovery. The photograph provided does not allow for verification of the complete text or proof of its episcopal authorship.

(continued)

Field	Identification and scope
Transmission	Stone fragments, epigraphic reception and a literary version transmitted in a Life of Abercius.
Embedded image	Photographic detail; it does not fully reproduce the reconstructed monument.
Limit	Episcopal identification also depends on tradition; not every restitution of the epitaph is attributed to a visible letter.

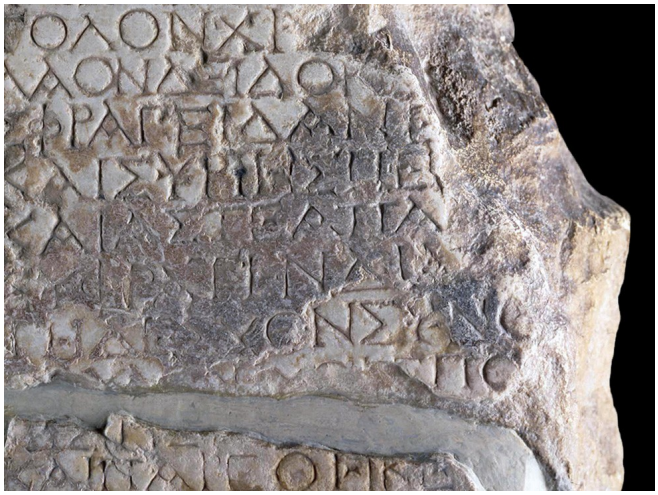


FIGURE 16. Inscription of Abercius. Photograph of the inscribed support; the original is preserved in the Christian Lapidary of the Vatican Museums. The fragments were recovered at Hieropolis in 1883; restorations are controlled in the critical edition and documentary apparatus. [IMG-HR; ED].

The language of the shepherd, the fish and food supports a well-grounded Christian interpretation when their relationships within the epitaph and its reception are considered. It is not a dictionary in which each word has a single, invariable meaning. The combination of images constructs a religious identity intelligible to particular readers while taking the form of a funerary monument within a wider epigraphic culture.

The reference to travel offers clues about a recognised Christian geography. The mention of Rome and eastern regions reveals an identity capable of expressing itself beyond a single locality. However, an epitaph is neither a day-by-day travelogue nor

a census of communities. Its commemorative function selects experiences and integrates them into a self-description. Individual memory and translocal belonging must be studied together, without substituting one for the other.

No complete diplomatic transcription is reproduced from a partial photograph. An edition of the whole requires the collation of fragments, old copies, and literary testimony, with explicit markings for each restitution. In this presentation, the image supports the material identification, and the documentary window delimits the scope of the interpretation. The Eucharistic reading of the whole is a supported historical interpretation, not a recovery of all the practices of the community that produced the monument.

5. Shared repertoires and Christian symbols

5.1. The Good Shepherd

The figure of the young shepherd carrying a sheep has a long history in Greco-Roman art and can appear as a criophorus, an image of care, charity, or pastoral life. In Christian contexts of the third and fourth centuries, the same visual form could be interpreted in light of traditions about Christ as a shepherd.

It is not methodologically correct to derive each Christian Good Shepherd from a single prototype, nor to claim that mere resemblance demonstrates religious continuity. Iconography functions through shared repertoires and contextual reinterpretation.

5.2. Alpha and Omega between apocalyptic text and representation

The expression “Alpha and Omega” appears in Revelation 1:8; 21:6; 22:13. Its effectiveness derives from the use of the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet to express totality. It should be studied in conjunction with the formulas “first and last” and “beginning and end” and with their scriptural antecedents, especially Isaiah 44:6 and 48:12. This literary relationship is a verifiable area of analysis; it does not require proposing hidden geometric values for the letters.[69]

[69] Revelation 1:8; 21:6; 22:13. The speaker’s identity is determined by context. The formula added to Revelation 1:11 in some traditions is not used as if it belonged without question to the source text. See NA28 for the passage apparatus.

The attribution of the voice requires attention to the context. Revelation 1:8 explicitly identifies the Lord God; Revelation 21:6 belongs to the proclamation of the one seated on the throne; Revelation 22:13 appears within a final sequence where the speaker's identification must be discussed in light of 22:12 and 22:16. Harmonising the three occurrences as if they had identical narrative presentation obscures an exegetical issue. Later Christological reception may adopt the formula, but it does not eliminate the textual differences.

Nor should the expression be introduced in Revelation 1:11 without pointing out that its presence depends on certain later forms of tradition. Comparing editions and manuscripts is here a strictly text-critical matter. Doctrinal affinity with other verses is no reason to supplement a shorter reading. The constitution of the text and theological interpretation follow different procedures.

On monuments and inscriptions, the letters A and Ω may be combined with a chi-rho monogram or a cross. The object must be dated by its context and its own characteristics; citing Revelation only identifies one possible interpretation. It does not establish that the original maker read a specific codex or that each viewer understood the programme in the same way. The history of representation studies precisely how a literary expression acquires visual uses in new media.

The formula reveals both continuity and transformation. It originates from an archive of writing and exegesis, but its funerary or public use can condense identity, protection, and hope. Historical analysis describes this condensation without turning it into proof of a universal doctrine predating the evidence. The chronology of the images and that of the texts are set against each other; neither replaces the other.

5.3. The Lamb and the difference between Johannine traditions

John 1:29 and 1:36 apply the expression *ἀμνὸς τοῦ θεοῦ*, "Lamb of God," to Jesus. Revelation uses *ἀρνίον* throughout (never *ἀμνός*) in its great depiction of the sacrificed and victorious Lamb. The difference in vocabulary does not require us to completely separate the two traditions, but it does prevent us from treating them as a single, repeated quotation. Each text incorporates the image within its own literary construction.[70]

The scriptural horizon includes the Passover lamb of Exodus 12, sacrificial language, and the figure of Isaiah 53:7. The relationship between these elements must be argued in each passage. In John, the reference to the Passover and the unbroken bones

[70] John 1:29 and 1:36 use *ἀμνός*; Revelation 5:6–14 uses *ἀρνίον*. The lexical difference alone does not establish two incompatible doctrines. Textual usage is distinct from the dating of visual representations.

is part of the Passion narrative; in Revelation 5, the figure combines the condition of having been sacrificed with the authority to open the book. Identifying antecedents does not reduce a composition to the mechanical reproduction of a single source.

The apocalyptic image contains a decisive narrative reversal. The announcement of the Lion of the tribe of Judah leads to the vision of a Lamb standing as if sacrificed. This contrast belongs to the logic of the narrative and allows for the analysis of a formulation of power based on death and vindication. Its historical study does not require asserting that a previous animal cult was directly transformed into Christology. Iconographic comparison may raise questions, but the concrete transmission requires proof.

Images of lambs in Christian art also require distinguishing functions. An animal next to a shepherd does not necessarily represent Christ himself; it may depict a member of the flock. A lamb associated with a cross, an inscription, or an apocalyptic programme may admit another identification. The attribution depends on the arrangement of the whole. An interpretation that assigns the same referent to all the animals erases the diversity of the repertoires.

The liturgical uses of the Agnus Dei developed later and must be dated independently of first-century vocabulary. The existence of a phrase in a gospel does not prove the contemporaneous existence of every formula of the Mass known afterwards. Textual history, ritual history, and image history are related, but they do not necessarily advance simultaneously.

5.4. The anchor and everyday objects

Hebrews 6:19 compares hope to an anchor for the soul. The comparison uses a maritime object to express stability and, within the letter's argument, links it to access to the sanctuary. The power of the metaphor stems from the object's ordinary function; it does not require the anchor to have originally been a religious symbol. When it appears in a Christian context, this textual association can contribute to its interpretation, but it does not predetermine the meaning of each representation.[71]

Clement of Alexandria (Paed. III.11.59–60) permits certain motifs on the seals his readers used in daily life. Among them are a dove, a fish, a ship, and an anchor. The passage documents a normative discourse on the selection of images and the memory

[71] Clement of Alexandria, Paed. III.11.59–60, on appropriate signs for seals; Hebrews 6:19, on the anchor as a metaphor for hope. Reference edition of the Paedagogus: Stählin, GCS 12. For checking content: `https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/02093.htm`.

they could activate; it is not equivalent to a catalogue of symbols exclusive to a community. Its usefulness lies in showing how an object of ordinary use could participate in moral and religious formation.

The depiction of an anchor does not prove that a cross was deliberately concealed to evade the authorities. That hypothesis requires independent evidence. Visual similarities between objects may facilitate reinterpretations, but they do not prove a clandestine protocol. The Christian meaning is strengthened when there is an inscription, a burial context, association with other motifs, or comparison with contemporary uses.

The material history of these signs includes their manufacture, circulation, and use. Seals are related to identification and security; lamps to illumination and consumption; tombstones to funerary memory. Transferring a motif from one medium to another modifies its possibilities for interpretation. An academic history preserves this difference and asks not only what was represented, but who could have seen it, in what situation, and with what other elements.

6. Roman catacombs: burial, memory and image

The Christian catacombs of Rome constitute one of the most extensive material archives of the third and fourth centuries. Complexes such as San Callisto, Priscilla, and Domitilla contain inscriptions, cubicula, paintings, and spaces dedicated to the memory of martyrs. They were not permanent secret refuges of an underground Church; their primary function was funerary.

Their pictorial programmes include praying figures, Jonah, scenes of salvation, banquets, and pastoral figures. The repetition of certain motifs shows how biblical and funerary repertoires were combined to express hope, protection, and remembrance.

The so-called Crypt of the Popes in San Callisto adds an institutional dimension: inscriptions and burials of Roman bishops from the third century document the progressive monumentalisation of episcopal memory.[72]

[72] Jensen 2000; Snyder 2003. Funerary topography, epigraphy, and visual programmes are considered together; the catacombs are not interpreted as permanent shelters.

6.1. Noah, the dove and the visual memory of salvation

Genesis 6–9 recounts the flood, the building of the ark, and the renewal of life. The scene of the dove with an olive leaf in Genesis 8:11 offers a hint of the receding waters within the narrative sequence. This immediate meaning should not be replaced by an abstract emblem of peace attributed without nuance to all cultures and periods. Reading it as a sign of reconciliation belongs to a history of interpretation that must be reconstructed through texts and objects.[73]

The biblical account of the ark provides dimensions in cubits, but converting to metres requires choosing a historical unit of measurement that the text does not define with sufficient precision for all modern uses. Nor has archaeology identified any vessel corresponding to these dimensions. The interest for Christian history lies in the reception of the account and its relation to practices of salvation, not in geometric reconstructions presented as proofs of the doctrine's origin.

1 Peter 3:20–21 explicitly links preservation through water with baptism. This connection is an important textual fact because it provides an explicit ancient link between the story of Noah and a Christian ritual. Tertullian, *in De bapt. 8*, uses the dove and the olive branch in his argument for baptism. Comparison of these two documents clarifies continuity and exegetical reformulation without assuming that every funerary representation of Noah corresponded to the same ritual use.

Images of a figure in a small chest may allude to the episode, but its identification depends on the presence of attributes and the overall programme. The abbreviated representation of the ark is not a ship's plan: it is a narrative device for recognition. Funerary scenes condensed stories of liberation along with other biblical episodes. The observer could recognise a narrative from a few elements, even if part of its interpretive context is lost to us.

The comparison with Mesopotamian flood traditions belongs to the history of the Genesis texts. It must be made based on identified versions, languages, dates, and specific literary relationships. It does not provide an automatic way to derive Christian baptism from a Babylonian ceremony, nor does it demonstrate architectural equivalences between the different vessels. Between a narrative antecedent and a Christian practice, there are processes of transmission and reception that require their own documentation.

[73] Genesis 6–9, particularly 8:6–12; Matthew 3:16; Mark 1:10; Luke 3:22; John 1:32. Tertullian, De baptismo 8, presents a baptismal reception of the dove. The ancient association is distinct from geometric equivalences unrelated to the loci.

The reception of Noah thus reveals a general characteristic of Christian visual culture: the image can select a moment from the narrative and combine it with new communal concerns. Text, object, and practice converge historically. They are not interchangeable pieces of a timeless symbology.

7. Dura-Europos: a Christian building on the Syrian frontier

The Christian building at Dura-Europos is a major archaeological witness to third-century Christian practice. A domestic structure was modified around the middle of the third century and was buried when sections of the city were incorporated into the defences before the fall to the Sasanids in 256/257.

The classical interpretation as domus ecclesiae—a private house adapted for worship—remains useful, but it should not be treated as a transparent archaeological category or as a universal stage between private house and basilica.

The baptistery contained mural paintings with scenes interpreted as the Good Shepherd, the healing of the paralytic, and women in a scene whose identification has been debated. The ensemble demonstrates that by the mid-third century, a community could invest resources in a specific ritual space and a figurative programme before the Constantinian monumentalisation.

7.1. Documentary Window: the Christian building at Dura-Europos

Table 28. Documentary window: Christian building at Dura-Europos

Place	**Dura-Europos, middle Euphrates, present-day Syria.**
Christian phase	Remodelling of a domestic structure in the third century, usually placed c. 240.
Terminus ante quem	256/257, abandonment/destruction of the city after the Sasanian conquest.
Spaces	Enlarged meeting room, baptistery, courtyard and outbuildings.
Painting	Baptistery programme with biblical and pastoral scenes.
Caution	Do not turn Dura into a universal model of pre-Constantinian Christian architecture.

7.2. Architectural reading of the Christian building of Dura-Europos

The building's adaptation reveals specific spatial decisions. The expansion of a room by removing an interior partition created a gathering space distinct from the original domestic compartments. The baptistery, on the other hand, concentrated a water feature and a pictorial programme within a separate enclosure. The articulation between the courtyard, circulation areas, and rooms reveals multiple uses within the existing structure, without the need to imagine a miniature basilica.

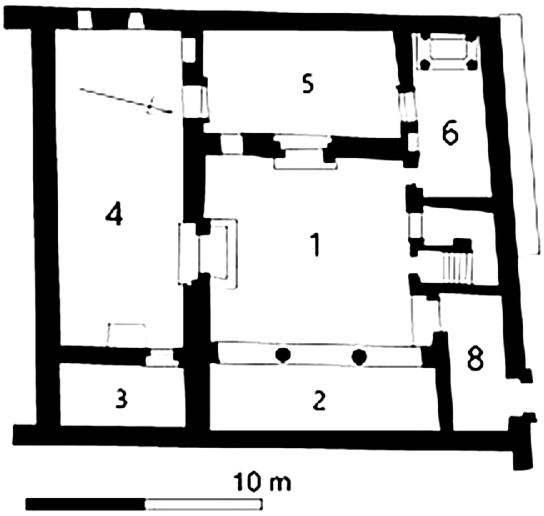


Figure 17. Dura-Europos, Christian building: archaeological plan reproduced from the historical documentation supplied for this edition. The graphic scale is retained and no hypothetical elevations are added. [IMG-HR; ED].

Three-dimensional reconstruction helps clarify proximity and access, but the modern illustration combines domestic references with graphic decisions about elevation, roofing and furnishings. It is read alongside the archaeological plan as an aid to spatial orientation, without assigning every depicted detail to Dura-Europos or treating it as ancient evidence for the complete appearance of the building.

The assignment of each space must follow specific evidence. An installation, a threshold, a wall modification or a painting may support an interpretation, whereas drawn furnishings do not acquire archaeological certainty merely by appearing in an axonometric view. The form, location and function of an altar or any other furnish-

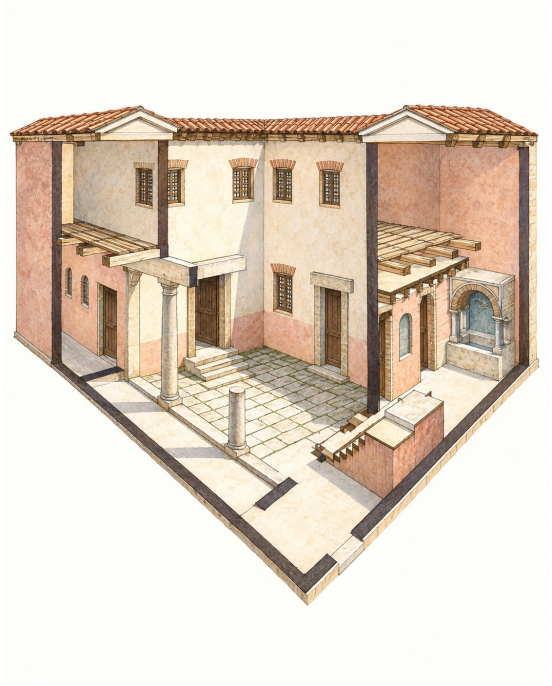


FIGURE 18. Roman house in axonometric section. Modern illustration prepared for this edition to clarify domestic space and its possible adaptation for communal use. It is not a verified archaeological reconstruction of the Christian building at Dura-Europos; its documented plan appears in Figure 17. [REC-GRAF/IA].

ing must be established from the excavated evidence, rather than from the illustration.

The chronology combines the inscription associated with the domestic construction, usually dated to 232/233, the later Christian adaptation, and the closure of the context during the city's final crisis. The date of approximately 240 for the remodelling is an accepted estimate, not an absolute date of dedication preserved in the record. This distinction allows Dura to be used as evidence predating Constantine without making each phase of construction a fixed year.[74]

The proximity of the synagogue, Mithraeum, and other cultic buildings allows for a comparison of urban resources, workshops, and practices of spatial transforma-

[74] Kraeling 1967, The Christian Building, final excavation report VIII.2; Peppard 2016. Institutional record of the building and its documentation: Yale University Art Gallery, `https://duraeuropos.artgallery.yale.edu/christian-building`. The provided drawings are identified as modern reconstructions; no unverified publisher is assigned to them.



FIGURE 19. Wall painting from the Christian baptistery at Dura-Europos: the Good Shepherd and the representation of Adam and Eve (third century, before 256/257 CE). Yale University Art Gallery, inv. 1932.1200, object 34493. Material evidence for a figurative Christian iconographic programme before the Constantinian transformation. Open-access digital reproduction; Yale identifies this image as CC0. [FAC].

tion. It does not demonstrate that all the communities shared a theology, nor that the paintings necessarily came from a single artist. Technical or formal similarities require a study of execution and context. The historical interest of Dura lies in this concrete coexistence and in the possibility of contrasting the material structures of different communities.

8. Pre-Constantinian Christian meeting spaces and buildings: comparative assessment

Outside of Dura-Europos, the evidence for specifically Christian buildings predating Constantine is fragmentary and uneven. The table separates archaeologically identifiable spaces from houses associated by literary tradition or from buildings whose Christian interpretation is disputed.



FIGURE 20. Dura-Europos: synagogue wall paintings in museum display. The originals from the synagogue were transferred to the National Museum in Damascus; the image is used as material context for the third-century figurative programme. [IMG-HR; ED].

TABLE 29. Pre-Constantinian meeting spaces: sites and complexes

Site / complex	Date	Type of evidence	Interpretation
Dura-Europos	c. 232/233 house; adaptation c. 240	Archaeology, paintings, baptistery	Adapted domestic building
Megiddo / Kefar ʻOthnay	Third century	Mosaic and inscription	Christian meeting space
Rome: tituli	Third–fourth centuries; uneven	Literary tradition and urban archaeology	Properties associated with communities
Aqaba / Aila	Late third–early fourth century; debated	Excavated architecture	Possible early church building
Capernaum, Peter's house	First–fourth-century phases	Domestic archaeology, graffiti, transformation	Evolving Christian memorial site

TABLE 30. Continuation of "Pre-Constantinian meeting spaces: sites and complexes"

Site / complex	Degree	Caution
Dura-Europos	A	Exceptional case, not a universal stage.
Megiddo / Kefar ʻOthnay	A/B	Exact function and context require verification.
Rome: tituli	B/C	Many are only clearly documented later.

(continued)

Site / complex	Degree	Caution
Aqaba / Aila	B/C	Chronology and identification debated.
Capernaum, house of Peter	B/C	Do not automatically call the first-century phase a "church".

9. Symbolism of the synagogues in Judea, Samaria and Galilee (first–third centuries): evidence, limits and the case of Magdala

The visual culture of synagogues from the first to third centuries demands particularly strict chronological caution. The imagery now associated with the Late Antique synagogue—menorah flanking the ark, lulav, etrog, shofar, biblical scenes, and, in some cases, zodiac wheels—largely belongs to programmes of the fourth to sixth centuries. Projecting this repertoire onto the first century would produce a material anachronism comparable to attributing the basilica-like monumentality of the Constantinian period to the apostolic communities. For the Second Temple period and the first generations after 70 CE, the surviving evidence is sparser, fragmentary, and regionally uneven.

9.1. Architecture before iconography: rooms, benches and community orientation

The buildings archaeologically identified as first-century synagogues primarily reveal a spatial organisation: rectangular or nearly rectangular halls, perimeter benches, controlled access, and, in some cases, interior columns or supports. Gamla, Masada, and Herodium, among other sites from this period, provide evidence for the organisation of gatherings, readings, and participants without requiring elaborate iconographic programmes to be postulated. Architecture constitutes the main evidence here; the absence of surviving figurative images should be interpreted neither as proof of absolute aniconism nor as licence to reconstruct lost decorations.

The inscription of Theodotus, found in Jerusalem and usually dated to the Second Temple period, is particularly important because it documents a synagogue linked to the reading of the Law, teaching, and hospitality. Its value is institutional and epigraphic: it confirms functions and patronage, but it does not preserve an iconographic repertoire that would support reconstruction of the decoration of a first-century Jerusalem synagogue.

9.2. The Magdala Stone: menorah, Temple and visual memory

The exceptional case is the so-called Magdala Stone, from a synagogue in the settlement of Migdal/Magdala in Galilee and generally dated before the destruction of the Temple in 70 CE. On one of its faces appears a representation of a seven-branched menorah (מְנוֹרָה) in a context that includes architectural and geometric motifs, as well as objects interpreted by various researchers in relation to the Temple in Jerusalem. The importance of the find lies not only in the antiquity of the image, but also in the fact that it shows how a synagogue community could visually construct the space and objects of the sanctuary while the Temple still stood.

Interpretations of the stone are not unanimous. Some readings understand it as a symbolic condensation of the Temple and its furnishings; others emphasise its liturgical, architectural, or cosmological character. This volume must therefore avoid presenting as definitive an identification that still belongs to archaeological debate. What is certain is more limited and, at the same time, highly significant: the menorah is represented in a pre-70 CE synagogue context, and the piece demonstrates that the relationship between synagogue and Temple could be expressed materially without the two spaces being equivalent.



Figure 21. Magdala Stone, from a first-century synagogue near the Sea of Galilee, predating 70 CE. Photograph by Hanay, 2012, CC BY-SA 3.0. The menorah and the interpretation of other motifs are controlled by the excavation context; no relief reconstructions have been added. [IMG-HR; ED].

9.3. Menorah and other media: from a sanctuary motif to an identity marker

In the first and second centuries, the menorah also appears on media other than synagogue buildings: coins, lamps, ossuaries, graffiti, and other objects. Therefore, the symbol should not be studied solely as architectural decoration. Its frequency and function change over time. In late Roman times, the menorah becomes one of the most recognisable visual signs of Jewish identity, but this process cannot be traced back as a fully formed system to the decades of Jesus or Paul.

The problem is methodologically parallel to that presented by the Christian cross: the early presence of a motif does not yet imply a uniform visual grammar or a single social function. The same symbol can participate in the memory of the sanctuary, community identity, funerary ornamentation, or collective affirmation, depending on the medium and the context.

9.4. Judea, Samaria and the inequality of the archaeological record

The distribution of evidence is very uneven. In Judea and the area around Jerusalem, buildings, inscriptions, and objects survive from which institutions and practices can be reconstructed, but the surviving synagogue decoration from the first–third centuries is limited. For Samaria, the picture is even more fragmentary, and a distinction must also be made between Jewish and Samaritan communities, whose ritual and architectural histories are not interchangeable. The best-known Samaritan synagogues largely belong to later periods and follow their own repertoires.

The scarcity of finds does not demonstrate an absence of symbols; it demonstrates, above all, the limits of preservation, excavation, identification, and dating. In a work that uses material culture as an autonomous archive, this difference between "undocumented" and "nonexistent" must remain visible.

9.5. The late antique change: mosaics, zodiac and complex programmes

From the fourth to sixth centuries onward, the landscape changes markedly. Synagogues in Galilee and other regions feature mosaics, inscriptions, arks or representations of arks, menorahs, lulavim, etrogim, shofarot, and, in some cases, zodiacal compositions. Hammath Tiberias and Beth Alpha are renowned examples of a phase in which Jewish communities developed considerably more complex visual programmes. These materials are fundamental for studying Late Antique Judaism, but they are not belated snapshots of first-century Judaism.

The synagogue zodiac is a good example of the risk of back-projection. Its presence in late antique mosaics shows the Jewish appropriation of a Mediterranean cosmological repertoire; it does not prove that the Twelve Apostles, the Twelve Tribes, or the organisation of first-century communities were structured according to a zodiacal system. Any comparison between series of twelve must remain within the history of symbols and reception rather than be treated as evidence of proven genealogy.

9.6. Chronological verification table

Table 31. Chronological verification table

Period	Preserved decorative evidence	Main symbols / materials	Interpretation criteria
First century, before and after 70	Very low to low	Menorah in Magdala; geometric and architectural motifs; institutional epigraphy	Magdala is exceptional. The architecture and inscriptions carry more weight than a systematic figurative repertoire.
Second–third centuries	Low and regionally uneven	Menorah on various media; funerary repertoires and objects; fragmentary synagogue evidence	Do not infer complete visual programmes from isolated objects. Separate Judea, Galilee, and Samaria.

(continued)

Period	Preserved decorative evidence	Main symbols / materials	Interpretation criteria
Fourth–sixth centuries	High in numerous sites	Menorah, ark/Torah, lulav, etrog, shofar, figurative mosaics, biblical scenes and zodiac	It corresponds to Late Antique Judaism; these programmes should not be projected retrospectively towards the first century.

9.7. Relationship with the Jesus movement and the first Christian communities

This collection of material helps to contextualise the Jesus movement without turning Jewish objects into "Christian antecedents." Jesus, his first followers, and Paul belonged to worlds in which synagogue, Scripture, Temple, pilgrimage, and the memory of Israel remained living references. Archaeology helps to define this environment precisely and, at the same time, compels us to abandon overly uniform images of first-century Judaism.

Comparisons with early Christian spaces should be based on verifiable functions—meeting, reading, eating, teaching, patronage, domestic adaptation—and not on retrospective visual similarities. A room with benches is not, in itself, a "proto-church," just as a third-century Christian building does not justify an identical reconstruction of Pauline gatherings of the first century.

Sources and reference bibliography: the Theodotus inscription; archaeological documentation from Magdala, Gamla, Masada and Herodium; Lee I. Levine, The Ancient Synagogue; Anders Runesson, Donald D. Binder and Birger Olsson, The Ancient Synagogue from Its Origins to 200 C.E.; Jodi Magness's studies of Jewish archaeology and ancient synagogues; Zeev Weiss's work on the art and synagogues of Galilee; and archaeological publications from Magdala. Particular interpretations of the Magdala Stone require citation of the relevant archaeological publication and a distinction between description and reconstruction.

10. Sarcophagi and funerary monumentalisation

During the fourth century, Christian sarcophagi show an increase in narrative and Christological repertoires. Scenes from Jonah, miracles of Jesus, Peter, Daniel, and the traditio legis are integrated with Roman sculptural conventions.

The adoption of Roman formats and workshops demonstrates that the Christianisation of the image did not imply a break with the techniques and genres of imperial material culture. Innovation occurred through iconographic selection, juxtaposition, and reinterpretation.[75]



FIGURE 22. Daniel in the Lions' Den on the Sarcophagus of Junius Bassus, dated 359. Post-Constantinian funerary monument, housed in the vicinity of St Peter's Basilica / Vatican Grottoes. Photograph distributed by Vanderbilt, Art in the Christian Tradition, ACT 46350; Jim Womack and Anne Richardson, CC BY-SA 4.0. A detail is reproduced, not a reconstruction of the sarcophagus. [FAC].

[75] Jensen 2000; Krautheimer and Ćurčić 1986. The identification of sculptural programmes must specify each support and phase; an exclusively Christian innovation cannot be deduced from the sarcophagus genre.

II. Scripture and construction metaphors

II.1. Tabernacle, sanctuary and Christian reading of space

Exodus 25–31 and 35–40 present instructions and details of the construction of the mobile sanctuary. The text articulates materials, crafts, furnishings, and the divine presence within a covenant narrative. It can be studied as a literary description of the cult and the manufacture of objects; it does not automatically constitute a report of an excavated structure. The precision of certain measurements does not eliminate problems of composition, transmission, and historicity.[76]

The inner sanctuary described in 1 Kings 6:20 has equivalent dimensions of length, width, and height. This information comes from a literary representation of Solomon's Temple. It does not justify attributing to it a demonstrable relationship with modern mathematical constants, still less a chain of dependence on other monuments based solely on formal coincidence. Ancient measurements, the proportions described, and their reception must be distinguished from numerical equivalences constructed by a later interpreter.

Hebrews 8–10 offers an explicit Christian appropriation of the language of sanctuary, priesthood, and sacrifice. Its argument shifts the focus to Christ's ministry and access to God; it does not propose a template for building churches. Mistaking this exegesis for technical instructions obscures the work's genre. Its relationship to later Christian architecture belongs to a history of reception that must be documented on a case-by-case basis.

The same care applies to temple language used for the community or the body. In 1 Corinthians 3:16–17, the argument is addressed to a community whose cohesion is threatened. The author's use of *ναός* does not prove that his addressees possessed a separate place of worship. The referent and the rhetorical function are reconstructed within the discourse. The metaphor can precede monumental architecture without being its sole cause.

The history of Christian spaces thus links three different archives: sanctuary texts, testimonies of gatherings, and material remains. None replaces the others. The tabernacle and the Temple provided languages of authority and presence; houses offered resources for hospitality and gathering; the public buildings of the fourth century

[76] Ex 25–31 and 35–40; 1 Kings 6; Hebrews 8–10; 1 Corinthians 3:10–17; 1 Peter 2:4–5. Prescription, narrative, and reception are studied, without turning the scriptural description into an archaeological survey or a numerical key.

introduced new programmes and scales. The transformation was not a belated execution of a single plan preserved from the beginning.

Conclusion

Material culture reveals dimensions of Christian identity that doctrinal treatises do not record: which texts were copied together, how sacred names were abbreviated, which symbols circulated, how the dead were buried, and which spaces were adapted for gatherings and baptism. Materiality does not automatically confirm literature; it is an independent line of evidence whose convergence with the texts must be demonstrated on a case-by-case basis.

Summary

This chapter treats manuscripts, inscriptions, funerary spaces, images, and buildings as autonomous evidence for early Christian history. It examines the ancient codex, the nomina sacra and staurogram, the graffito of Alexamenos, the symbolism of ichthys, the Good Shepherd, the Roman catacombs, the Christian building of Dura-Europos, and fourth-century sarcophagi.

Keywords: material culture; codex; staurogram; Alexamenos; Dura-Europos; catacombs.

CHAPTER VI

From Galerius to Theodosius: Constantine, Nicaea and the Imperial Transformation

The fourth century cannot be reduced to a sudden conversion of the Empire or an instantaneous institutional victory for the Church. The period between 311 and the end of the century saw, in succession, tolerance, patronage, doctrinal controversy, religious legislation, and new forms of monumentalisation. Christianity went from being a periodically persecuted religion to occupying a privileged position within the State, but the process was discontinuous and did not produce immediate uniformity.

1. 311 and 313: tolerance, restitution and the so-called "Edict of Milan"

Galerius's edict of 311 had formally ended the persecution in large areas. Two years later, after the meeting of Constantine and Licinius in Milan, a broader policy of religious freedom and restitution of property was agreed upon.

The expression "Edict of Milan" is a historiographical convention. No edict issued in Milan with that title survives; the measures are known from related texts preserved by Lactantius and Eusebius. The settlement of 313 did not make Christianity the official religion, but rather expanded freedom of worship and ordered the restitution of property.[77]

[77] Lactantius, Mort. pers. 34 and 48; Eusebius, HE X.5.2–14. The so-called Edict of Milan is explained as an agreement and communications of application, not as a single Latin original preserved with that title.

2. Constantine and the patronage of the churches

Constantine increasingly intervened in Christian affairs through donations, privileges, arbitration of conflicts, and monumental construction. Imperial patronage altered the scale of resources available to certain churches and made bishops more visible political actors.

The Donatist conflict demonstrates, however, that imperial support did not produce automatic unity. Constantine convened tribunals and councils to resolve an African dispute that combined the memory of persecution, episcopal legitimacy, and sacramental discipline.[78]

2.1. Sol, coins and religious change in the time of Constantine

The depiction of Sol on Constantine's coins is a document of imperial communication. The legend SOLI INVICTO COMITI and the radiate figure make it possible to study public associations between the emperor and a patron deity. Its presence does not constitute a complete personal confession, but neither should it be eliminated to produce a retrospectively uniform image of the reign. Different means of representation can preserve earlier formulas while religious patronage and alliances change.[79]

The Roman cult of Sol has a history predating Aurelian; the reorganisation and imperial promotion of the third century do not justify describing it as a completely new cult introduced from a single location in the East. Solar deities, their epithets, and their links with other cults must be identified through documentary evidence. The term *"Invictus" does not, in* itself, imply that every object dedicated to a deity with that epithet belongs to the same religious institution.

Constantine's shift is best observed through a chronology of decisions: patronage of Christian communities, restitution of property, intervention in disputes, construction of buildings, and modification of propaganda. Not all of these actions occurred in 312, nor did they immediately eliminate all previous signs. The evidence documents a cumulative transformation whose pace varied according to medium,

[78] Optatus of Milevis, Contra Parmenianum I.22–26; Eusebius, HE X.5.18–7.2 (Constantine's letters to Miltiades, Chrestus of Syracuse, Caecilian and Anullinus); Augustine, Breviculus collationis cum Donatistis. Barnes 2011 and Drake 2000 offer frameworks for distinguishing patronage, politics, and religious representation.

[79] Types bearing SOLI INVICTO COMITI are identified by reign, mint, and issue before inferring religious changes. Barnes 2011 and Lenski 2012 offer contexts for Constantinian imperial communication; the presence of a legend does not equate to a confessional autobiography.



FIGURE 23. Nummus, probably of Constantine I, SOLI INVICTO COMITI type, c. 310–319; the record gives London as the probable mint. PAS, FindID 256321 (SWYOR-0040D3). Photograph by Amy Downes, West Yorkshire Archaeology Service; The Portable Antiquities Scheme/The Trustees of the British Museum, CC BY-SA 2.0. This solar type is not identified with a chrismon. [FAC; ED].

audience, and region. The emperor's religious biography should not be reduced to a binary alternative devoid of historical sequence.

Christian solar language does not necessarily depend on a direct borrowing from Roman worship. Malachi 3:20 in Hebrew numbering—4:2 in other traditions—offers the image of the "sun of righteousness"; light and dawn belong to a broad scriptural repertoire. When a Christian author uses a solar image, its context and referents must be identified before asserting cultic dependence. The availability of shared metaphors allows for comparison, but does not in itself prove a conversion of Sol into Christ.

2.2. The day of the Sun and the regulation of rest

Constantine's constitution, preserved in CJ III.12.2 and promulgated on 7 March 321, orders rest for judges, the urban population and workshops on the venerabilis dies solis, with an exception for timely agricultural work. This is a civil measure with specific conditions of application. It did not institute Christian Sunday worship: Justin, 1 Apol. 67, had already described a gathering on the so-called day of the Sun in the second century. Nor does the law's vocabulary establish that its sole purpose was to impose a solar cult.

The difference in documentary genre is decisive. Justin explains a communal practice; the legal text regulates work and public activity. The coincidence of the day facilitates a history of convergence between the civil calendar and religious practice, but it does not turn the two documents into evidence of a single institution. Subsequent regulations on rest show new appropriations and adjustments; each provision must be cited with its own date and context.

CTh II.8.18 (= CTh VIII.8.3; XI.7.13), transmitted under the names of Gratian, Valentinian II, and Theodosius I (although Gratian had died in 383) and posted at Aquileia on 3 November 386, suspends litigation, business, and the exaction of claims on that day. Its wording is particularly significant: "solis die, quem dominicum rite dixere maiores". The constitution therefore does not simply replace a "solar" designation with a "Christian" one; it juxtaposes both within late Roman legal language. The consular reference to Honorius nobilissimus puer and Evodius securely dates the measure to 386; 383 belongs to other constitutions and must not be transferred to this locus. The law is later than, and distinct from, Constantine's constitution of 7 March 321 (CJ III.12.2). The Codex Theodosianus that preserves it was itself promulgated in 438, so the date of the individual constitution must be distinguished from the date of the compilation that transmits it.

2.3. 25 December and the limits of explanation by substitution

The *Chronography of 354* is a central testimony because it brings together civil and Christian materials with their own histories. The civil calendar records *Natalis Invicti* on 25 December; the *Depositio martyrum* records the birth of Christ in Bethlehem on the same date. This juxtaposition documents the coexistence of two calendrical usages in the fourth century. It does not, on its own, establish which one produced the other, nor a single act of substitution.[80]

Several hypotheses have been advanced to explain how the date was fixed. One relates the Christian celebration to the festive and solar context of the Roman winter; another studies Christian calculations that linked conception, passion, and birth. These proposals cannot be evaluated solely on the basis of their symbolic appeal. The texts that actually attest to them, their chronology, and their relationship to local practices must be identified. An explanation of origin requires more than a coincidence of date.

No contemporary decree from Julius I or Liberius survives that would justify attributing to them, with the precision usual in popular accounts, the universal creation of Christmas on 25 December. The absence of such a document compels us to formulate the conclusion in terms of attestation and diffusion, not of a known papal decision. Eastern reception also presents differences: the history of a feast should not be reconstructed as if all sees had simultaneously adopted the same calendar.

The Mithraic tradition does not provide a parallel birth narrative with a secure date that can be used without question as a source for Christmas. The iconography of the birth from a rock belongs to its own contexts and does not reproduce the Gospel narrative of Bethlehem. A comparative study can describe coexisting images and calendars; to defend dependence between narratives, it needs positive links of transmission. Religious history does not progress through lists of decontextualised similarities.

[80] Chronography of 354: civil calendar, 25 December, N·INVICTI; Depositio martyrum, VIII kal. Ian., birth of Christ in Bethlehem. Reference edition: Mommsen, Chronica minora I, 1892. The sections of the dossier are distinguished and a single causality is not attributed to the coincidence.

2.4. The labarum and the testimonies of the victory of 312

Lactantius, *Mort. pers.* 44, and Eusebius, *VC* I.28–31, offer different accounts of the sign associated with Constantine's victory. Lactantius describes a warning received in a dream and a sign applied to shields; Eusebius presents a vision and the subsequent construction of a standard. The texts should not be merged into a single narrative that eliminates differences in scene, medium, and time of composition.[81]

Eusebius's account adds the claim of having received sworn confirmation from the emperor. This statement belongs to the work's strategy of establishing authority. It is not equivalent to an immediate written testimony preserved from 312, nor does it allow for external verification of every detail of the vision. The historical problem lies in evaluating an account transmitted later and its function within a Christian imperial biography.

The chi-rho monogram refers to Χριστός through recognisable letters. The form of the labarum combines elements of military representation with a growing Christian significance. Its interpretation requires neither speculative etymologies nor cosmological correspondences foreign to the sources. Roman standards already had functions of identity and cohesion; the new symbol reformulates these functions within a specific religious policy.

Numismatics and dated objects provide independent checks on literary accounts. They document when, and in which media, certain symbols acquired public visibility. However, the earliest surviving example does not necessarily equate to the first historical use. Regional differences in minting and the uneven survival of objects prevent us from reconstructing an instantaneous and universal adoption.

The labarum is, therefore, a case of convergence between the memory of victory, imperial authority, and religious representation. Academic analysis preserves the differences between accounts and compares their functions. It does not claim that all the details of the narratives are confirmed, nor that their differences negate any historical information about the transformation of propaganda.

[81] Lactantius, Mort. pers. 44; Eusebius, VC I.28–31. Reference editions: Moreau, SC 39; Winkelmann, Eusebius Werke I.1. The accounts maintain their differences regarding dream, vision, shields, and standard.

3. Nicaea 325: Christology, empire and conciliar authority

The Council of Nicaea of 325 was convened by Constantine in the context of the controversy associated with Arius and his adversaries. Its confessional formula used ὁμοούσιος to affirm the relationship of the Son to the Father and condemned certain propositions considered incompatible with that faith.

Nicaea did not "invent" the divinity of Jesus. The veneration of Christ, the language of pre-existence, and multiple forms of Christology predate the council by centuries. Nicaea intervened in a dispute about how these claims were to be articulated conceptually within a common doctrinal framework.

Nor did Nicaea decide the canon of the New Testament. Its surviving canons deal with disciplinary and ecclesiastical matters, not a list of biblical books.[82]

4. Imperial architecture: from adapted house to public basilica

The transformation of the fourth century became visible in stone. The Lateran complex in Rome, the Vatican basilica built over the memoria of Peter, the Holy Sepulchre in Jerusalem, and the Nativity in Bethlehem are examples of a new scale of patronage and sacred topography.

The Christian basilica adopted and transformed a Roman architectural type suitable for large gatherings, processional circulation, and axial focus. Monumentalisation altered the relationship between community, city, and power.

The Holy Sepulchre is particularly significant because Constantinian patronage united exegesis, local memory, and architecture. The construction itself does not prove the archaeological authenticity of each topographical identification; it does demonstrate that in the fourth century the State could transform Christian memory into an imperial monument.[83]

4.1. Basilica programme and circulation practices

The emergence of large Christian buildings in the fourth century cannot be explained as the copying of a single prototype. The Roman basilica tradition offered resources for gathering and representation, but Christian projects also depended on the site, patronage, the size of the community, and their relationship to places of memory.

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[82] Nicene Creed and its anathemas of 325; Ayres 2004. The council produced no documented decision on the canon of the New Testament.

[83] Eusebius, HE X.4; VC III.25–40. Krautheimer and Ćurčić 1986 contextualise architectural programmes. The construction sequence requires specific testimonies.

The history of a building is reconstructed through its phases, not through a formal genealogy deduced from a resemblance.[84]

The naves, structural supports, apse, and entrances organised ways of gathering, observing, and moving about. The lighting of the central nave and the differentiation of sectors could contribute to the hierarchical organisation of acts and participants. However, not all the elements of a preserved floor plan allow for the precise reconstruction of a liturgy. The furnishings may have changed, and excavations often yield fragments from different phases. Ritual texts, inscriptions, and architectural remains must be compared and contrasted without automatically filling in the gaps.

Constantinian projects in Rome and Jerusalem reveal distinct objectives. Basilicas linked to episcopal sees, apostolic memoriae, or sites in the life of Jesus do not share the same topographical context. The tomb, pilgrimage, gatherings, and the relationship with power could all necessitate different spatial arrangements. Monumentalisation is a process of site selection and funding, as well as a shift in the scale of construction.

Decoration plays a part in this process. Inscriptions, materials, images, and the arrangement of spaces could establish an authoritative memory and make patronage visible. These are not ornamental additions made later to a supposedly neutral architecture. Their chronology, however, must be demonstrated: decoration from a later phase does not automatically document the building's inaugural programme.

The transition from the adapted house to the public basilica altered the conditions of visibility and access. This does not mean that all domestic gatherings disappeared, nor that all regions had equal resources. The coexistence of scales necessitates a pluralistic history of Christian architecture. The built forms are evidence of investment, organisation, and memory; not an automatic reflection of an identical doctrine throughout the Empire.

[84] Eusebius, HE X.4; VC III.25–40; Krautheimer and Ćurčić 1986, Early Christian and Byzantine Architecture. Patronage programmes, functions, and construction phases are distinguished; formal similarity does not demonstrate a single religious prototype.

5. Eusebius: historiography in a time of transition

Eusebius of Caesarea's Ecclesiastical History is the first major continuous narrative of Christian history. Its documentary value is immense because it preserves letters and fragments of works now lost. At the same time, its narrative structure reflects a theological project of continuity and providence.

The Vita Constantini deepens this perspective by presenting an extraordinarily favourable image of the emperor. Using Eusebius means exploiting his documentary riches without automatically adopting his providential interpretation.[85]

6. Athanasius and Festal Letter 39: a canon of twenty-seven books

In 367, Athanasius of Alexandria listed, in his thirty-ninth Festal Letter, the twenty-seven books that make up the present New Testament. It is the first surviving list that exactly matches that set.

The letter is a milestone, not an instantaneous universal decree. The history of the canon continued to show regional variations and differences in reception. Athanasius also distinguishes between canonical books and other writings recommended for reading by those preparing for the Christian life.[86]

[85] Eusebius, HE I.1 and X; VC I.1–11. The author's providential perspective and document selection are considered.

[86] Athanasius, Fest. 39.5–7. Gallagher and Meade 2017 and Gwynn 2012 contextualise list, reading and episcopal authority; the date of 367 does not represent simultaneous universal closure.

7. From Constantine to Theodosius

After Constantine, imperial policy towards Christianity continued to change. Constantius II favoured certain theological solutions; Julian attempted to revitalise traditional cults and reduce Christian privileges; after Valens's Homoian policy in the East, Gratian and Theodosius I again favoured Nicene forms of Christianity.

The Edict of Thessalonica of 380, promulgated by Theodosius I, Gratian, and Valentinian II, established the Nicene Christian faith, identified with the bishops of Rome and Alexandria, as the imperial norm. It did not, however, make Christianity the only existing religious practice overnight, nor did it instantly abolish all traditional cults.

The Council of Constantinople in 381 consolidated a new phase of doctrinal definition. Even then, controversies, dissenting communities, and regional differences persisted.[87]

7.1. Imperial norm and persistence of religious differences

CTh XVI.1.2, promulgated in 380, identifies a confessional norm through the faith associated with Damasus of Rome and Peter of Alexandria. The document contributes to the construction of a religious identity supported by the State. Its text does not amount to the immediate disappearance of all traditional cults nor to the effective conversion of all inhabitants of the Empire. The legal norm and its application must be studied separately.[88]

Subsequent provisions concerning sacrifices, temples, and religious practices belong to a sequence of decisions with different recipients and conditions. It is inaccurate to condense them into a universal abolition dated the same day as the edict of 380. Buildings could be abandoned, reused, or continue to be used in various ways; archaeology and local documentation allow the reach of the regulations to be tested.

The persistence of differences within Christianity itself also reveals the limits of uniformity. The condemnation of a doctrine did not automatically eliminate its adherents, nor did imperial support guarantee a conflict-free reception. Bishops, communities, local aristocracies, and administrators all participated in concrete negotia-

[87] CTh XVI.1.2; XVI.10.10–12. Ayres 2004; Rebillard 2012. Norms are distinguished from their application and from the effective identity of populations.

[88] CTh XVI.1.2, 27 February 380; XVI.10.10–12, provisions of 391–392. The book, title, and constitution number identify each rule without dependence on the pagination of a translation. Reference edition: Mommsen and Meyer 1905.

tions. Institutionalisation involved coercion, patronage, and the pursuit of consensus, with mixed results.

The analysis of the fourth century must therefore distinguish between doctrinal professions, legal categories, and observable behaviours. A person could participate in overlapping civic and religious networks; an object or a building does not necessarily reveal all of its affiliations. The history of Christianisation gains precision when it preserves these distinctions rather than describing a complete replacement of one culture by another at a single moment.

Conclusion

The institutionalisation of the fourth century was more a transformation of scale than a point of origin. The textual, ritual, episcopal, and polemical structures developed during the preceding centuries acquired imperial resources, monumental architecture, and new conciliar mechanisms. The result was a much greater capacity for coordination and exclusion, but never complete uniformity. Fourth-century imperial Christianity is therefore an outcome to be explained, not a key with which to read the three preceding centuries retrospectively.

Summary

This chapter examines the transformation of Christianity from Galerius's tolerance in 311 to the end of the fourth century. It distinguishes the agreements of 313 from the later establishment of imperial Christianity and analyses Constantine's patronage, the Council of Nicaea, the monumental basilicas, Eusebius's historiography, Athanasius's Festal Letter 39, and the gradual emergence of Nicene imperial normativity under Theodosius.

Keywords: Constantine; Nicaea; Galerius; Athanasius; canon; Theodosius.

CHAPTER VII

Religious Frontiers, Material Philology, and Advanced Methods for the Study of Christian Origins

Research on Christian origins has changed scale over recent decades. It is no longer sufficient to establish a sequence of doctrines, authors, and councils: reading practices, manuscript circulation, social boundaries, languages, writing supports, habits of copying, and urban settings must be reconstructed together. This chapter brings into a single methodological discussion five problems that recur throughout the monograph: the relationship between Judaism and early Christianities; the reconstruction of the Gospel used by Marcion; the material sociology of the manuscript; the critique of the modern category of "Gnosticism"; and the archaeological interpretation of Dura-Europos. It also sets out a protocol for incorporating digital humanities and physicochemical analysis without implying observations of original objects that have not in fact been undertaken.

1. From the "parting of the ways" to overlapping religious configurations

The metaphor of the "parting of the ways" was useful for questioning confessional narratives that assumed a fully established Christianity from the 30s of the first century onward. However, even a slow separation can retain an overly linear image: two initially united communities that, after a certain point, gradually drift apart. The studies collected by Adam H. Becker and Annette Yoshiko Reed in *The Ways That Never Parted*, along with the proposals of Daniel Boyarin and other specialists, compel us to consider less orderly scenarios. Practices, texts and networks of sociability that do not fit neatly into two distinct institutional blocs coexisted in different cities and periods.

In this book, the expression "overlapping religious configurations" functions as an analytical tool rather than as a new essentialist label. It designates situations in which people or groups may share scriptures, calendars, urban spaces, exegetical repertoires, or family relationships without that overlap implying complete identity. A social boundary may be highly significant to a religious leader and yet barely visible to a municipal observer. Likewise, a homily condemning attendance at a synagogue expresses a desire to establish a boundary while simultaneously presupposing that some hearers might cross it.

Antioch offers a particularly important laboratory. John Chrysostom's late polemic against Christians who participated in Jewish festivals or practices should not simply be projected back to the first century; it does, however, demonstrate that in the fourth century, institutional distinction could coexist with behaviours that episcopal preaching perceived as ambiguous. Alexandria presents another type of overlap: the use of the Septuagint, the Philonic tradition, allegorical exegesis, and Christian polemics are all part of the same intellectual ecosystem, though not of an undifferentiated community.

Rome adds a third configuration. The presence of diverse Jewish communities, the early arrival of Jesus' followers, and the multiplicity of Christian groups in the second century make it inadequate to describe the city with a simple line from "synagogue" to "church." Funerary inscriptions, literary sources, and topography suggest distinct networks that may have shared language and biblical repertoires. The analysis must therefore distinguish three levels: internal self-definition, polemical classification by adversaries, and external administrative perception.

The methodological consequence is decisive. Expressions such as "Judeo-Christian", "Gentile Christian", "synagogue", or "Church" cannot function as closed boxes when the sources themselves describe ongoing processes. Each locus

is examined in terms of its actors, location, date, practices, and vocabulary. The boundary is not presupposed; it is reconstructed from the evidence.

1.1. Philological window: ἀποσυνάγωγος and the narrative construction of exclusion

The adjective ἀποσυνάγωγος appears in John 9:22; 12:42; and 16:2 and is usually translated as "expelled from the synagogue" or "excluded from the synagogue." Morphologically, it is a compound formed from συναγωγή with the prefix ἀπο-, which expresses separation. Its presence in the fourth Gospel is historically important, but it does not automatically authorise the reconstruction of a universal Jewish decree against Christians at the end of the first century.

John 9:22 links the fear of the blind man's parents with a decision attributed to οἱ Ἰουδαῖοι: ἵνα ἐάν τις αὐτὸν ὁμολογήσῃ χριστόν, ἀποσυνάγωγος γένηται, "so that if anyone confessed him as Messiah / Christ, he would be outside the synagogue." The historical value of the passage depends on distinguishing the time narrated—the life of Jesus—from the social horizon of the evangelist. The scene can preserve the memory of later conflicts without in itself providing the date, geographical scope, or institutional procedure of an exclusion.

The comparison with John 16:2, which announces ἀποσυναγώγους ποιήσουσιν ὑμᾶς, shows that the term belongs to a rhetoric of communal conflict. This evidence must be compared with later rabbinic literature and the complex history of the Birkat ha-Minim, rather than equating a liturgical formula whose transmission is difficult to trace with a council that decreed a definitive rupture. The classic hypothesis linking ἀποσυνάγωγος to the Birkat ha-Minim derives from J. Louis Martyn, History and Theology in the Fourth Gospel (1968); for the history of the liturgical text and its dating problems, see Ruth Langer, Cursing the Christians? A History of the Birkat HaMinim (2012).

2. Marcion between textual reconstruction and the synoptic problem: Roth and Klinghardt

The Gospel associated with Marcion presents one of the most difficult philological problems of second-century Christianity because the text is not preserved in a complete Marcionite manuscript. Its reconstruction depends on adversarial testimonies, especially Tertullian, Epiphanius, and the Dialogue of Adamantius, as well as scattered allusions. The classic reconstruction was Adolf von Harnack's Marcion: Das Evangelium vom fremden Gott (1921; 2nd ed. 1924). Dieter T. Roth (The

Text of Marcion's Gospel, 2015) has insisted that a responsible reconstruction must distinguish between quotation, paraphrase, allusion, and silence; the absence of a verse in a patristic refutation does not necessarily prove its absence in the Marcionite Gospel. The comparative apparatus in § 2.1 applies this protocol to four loci of varying degrees of certainty.

The traditional view holds that Marcion's Gospel derives from a form of Luke and that the differences are explained, to varying degrees, by editing, reception, or transmission. Matthias Klinghardt has radically reopened the problem by proposing that the Marcionite Gospel, or a form very close to it, predates the canonical gospels and played a role in their formation. In his reconstruction (2015; English edition 2021), the question shifts from "what Marcion removed from Luke" to "what literary relationships best explain the set of agreements and divergences."

A critical research monograph should not resolve this bifurcation by majority vote. It should evaluate what kind of evidence supports each hypothesis. The Marcionite priority thesis gains strength when a shorter reading or a different sequence seems to explain the Lucan form without presupposing a doctrinally motivated edit. It loses strength when it depends on highly uncertain reconstructions of a text known only through polemicists or when a reading can be better explained by ordinary textual variation, patristic adaptation, or rhetorical selectivity in quotation.

A three-layered protocol is therefore adopted. First, the attested text is reconstructed with each heresiological witness identified separately. Second, that evidence is compared with the manuscript tradition of Luke without allowing NA28 to stand in for the textual state of the second century. Third, any inference concerning literary direction is kept explicitly distinct from the previous two operations. Only at this third level does a discussion of priority become methodologically meaningful.

TABLE 32. Roth and Klinghardt: problems in reconstructing Marcion's Gospel

Problem	**Roth: prudent reconstruction**	**Klinghardt: priority hypothesis**	**Criterion adopted**
Text status	Reconstruction based on patristic testimonies graded by quality	Extensive reconstruction integrated into a theory about the formation of the gospels	Separate reconstructed text from dependency inference

(continued)

Problem	Roth: prudent reconstruction	Klinghardt: priority hypothesis	Criterion adopted
Relationship with Luke	The relationship is evaluated locus by locus; not every difference is a "mutilation"	The Marcionite Gospel is proposed as earlier and a source for the canonical ones	Do not assume direction; test explanatory readings in both directions
Patristic silences	They do not automatically equate to omissions	They can be integrated into patterns involving shorter textual forms	Mark "unattested" instead of "absent" unless there is positive evidence
Historiographical result	Caution regarding the available text	Reconfiguration of the synoptic problem and the canon	Keep both hypotheses visible and grade certainty by locus

Documentary verification matrix for the Roth–Klinghardt debate. The table does not replace an edition of the witnesses, nor does it turn a modern reconstruction into an ancient manuscript.

2.1. Comparative apparatus of critical variants: the Gospel of Marcion [REC-MAR] versus the canonical text of Luke

The comparison of Marcionite testimonies requires distinguishing between the attested reading, the modern editorial reconstruction, and the proposed doctrinal explanation. The table compares the critical Greek text of Luke, an indirect testimony from Tertullian, and a Greek reconstruction of the Gospel attributed to Marcion. In the middle column, only the Latin fragment in quotation marks is a quotation: the paragraphs in English are editorial commentary, not translations of a fully printed Latin quotation. [REC] designates reconstructed text; [ED], verification against an edition or textual testimony. The A–D scale expresses the degree of certainty of the reconstruction, not the relative antiquity of the reading.

The comparison is read in conjunction with the apparatus developed in Chapter II, § 3.2–3.7. Here the aim is to visualise the philological problem; there the direction of textual change and the limits of theological inferences are discussed more fully.

LOCUS 1. Luke 10:21 — "Lord of heaven" and the reference to the earth

Documentary status: [REC/ED] · certainty of reconstruction: A/B.

TABLE 33. Luke 10:21 — "Lord of heaven" and the reference to the earth. Control text, Tertullian's testimony and reconstruction [REC-MAR]; status [REC/ED], certainty A/B

Control text: Luke (NA28)	Tertullian, Adv. Marc. IV.25 — indirect testimony and commentary	Greek reconstruction [REC-MAR]
Ἐν αὐτῇ τῇ ὥρᾳ ἠγαλλιάσατο [ἐν] τῷ πνεύματι τῷ ἁγίῳ καὶ εἶπεν· Ἐξομολογοῦμαί σοι, πάτερ, κύριε τοῦ οὐρανοῦ καὶ τῆς γῆς...	"Gratias enim, inquit, ago, et confiteor, domine caeli..." Tertullian's quotation preserves "Lord of heaven" without reproducing "and of earth" at this point.	... Ἐξομολογοῦμαί σοι, [πάτερ,] κύριε τοῦ οὐρανοῦ ... [REC]. The absence of καὶ τῆς γῆς is reconstructed with high probability from the patristic dossier; by contrast, Tertullian ("gratias ... ago, et confiteor") does not transmit "pater" and adds a formula of thanksgiving, so that neither the vocative πάτερ nor the opening verb (ἐξομολογοῦμαι or εὐχαριστῶ) is fixed: they are printed in square brackets as control text, not as an attested Marcionite reading.

Evaluation. The philological evidence is the short form attested by the polemical record. Relating it to the Marcionite separation between the Father of Jesus and the creator is historically plausible, but it remains an inference about motivation. The short reading must also be compared with the wider Lucan tradition; therefore, it does not function as an exclusive "doctrinal signature."

LOCUS 2. Luke 13:28 — patriarchs and prophets versus "all the righteous"

Documentary status: [REC/ED] · certainty of reconstruction: A.

TABLE 34. Luke 13:28 — patriarchs and prophets versus "all the righteous". Control text, Tertullian's testimony and reconstruction [REC-MAR]; status [REC/ED], certainty A

Control text: Luke (NA28)	Tertullian, Adv. Marc. IV.30 — indirect testimony and commentary	Greek reconstruction [REC-MAR]
ἐκεῖ ἔσται ὁ κλαυθμὸς καὶ ὁ βρυγμὸς τῶν ὀδόντων, ὅταν ὄψησθε Ἀβραὰμ καὶ Ἰσαὰκ καὶ Ἰακὼβ καὶ πάντας τοὺς προφήτας ἐν τῇ βασιλείᾳ τοῦ θεοῦ...	Tertullian's Latin dossier and Epiphanius's inventory are used by modern reconstructions to control the replacement of the patriarchal enumeration by a general category of the righteous. The exact form of each quotation must be distinguished from editorial retroversion.	... ὅταν ὄψησθε πάντας τοὺς δικαίους ἐν τῇ βασιλείᾳ τοῦ θεοῦ... [REC]. The reading "all the righteous" has strong enough attestation to enter the reconstructed text.

Evaluation. The variant substitutes a general category of the righteous for the explicit enumeration of Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and the prophets. The divergence is strongly attested, but the apparatus does not turn it into automatic proof of an "anti-Jewish" operation. The textual fact and the explanation of its genesis remain separate; Roth and Klinghardt differ precisely in the historical direction they assign to this type of divergence.

LOCUS 3. Luke 20:35–36 — syntactic segmentation and "the god of that age"

Documentary status: [REC/ED] · certainty of reconstruction: B.

Table 35. Luke 20:35–36 — syntactic segmentation and "the god of that age". Control text, Tertullian's testimony and reconstruction [REC-MAR]; status [REC/ED], certainty B

Control text: Luke (NA28)	**Tertullian, Adv. Marc. IV.38 — indirect testimony and commentary**	**Greek reconstruction [REC-MAR]**
οἱ δὲ καταξιωθέντες τοῦ αἰῶνος ἐκείνου τυχεῖν καὶ τῆς ἀναστάσεως τῆς ἐκ νεκρῶν…	Tertullian's polemic allows us to reconstruct a different segmentation of the syntactic chain. His testimony should not be printed as if it preserved a Greek manuscript: it is an adversarial Latin witness whose punctuation and interpretation are part of the dispute.	… ὁ θεὸς τοῦ αἰῶνος ἐκείνου… [REC], according to a syntactic distribution in which "of that age" is associated with θεός. The reconstruction is less certain than in Luke 13:28.

Evaluation. This locus shows that the [REC-MAR] reconstruction is not simply a matter of additions and omissions. Punctuation, segmentation, and reliance on Latin mediation can change the meaning without simply altering the lexical inventory. This is why the passage is classified as B and not A: the difference is significant, but the exact Greek form remains reconstructed.

LOCUS 4. Luke 5:39 — heresiological silence and the discipline of evidence

Documentary status: [REC/ED] · certainty of reconstruction: D (not attested).

TABLE 36. Luke 5:39 — heresiological silence and the discipline of evidence. Control text, Tertullian's testimony and reconstruction [REC-MAR]; status [REC/ED], certainty D (not attested)

Control text: Luke (NA28)	**Tertullian, Adv. Marc. IV.11 — indirect testimony and commentary**	**Greek reconstruction [REC-MAR]**
[καὶ] οὐδεὶς πιὼν παλαιὸν θέλει νέον· λέγει γάρ· Ὁ παλαιὸς χρηστός ἐστιν.	Tertullian discusses the sequence of the wineskins and the wine in Adv. Marc. IV.11, but the indirect record does not provide sufficient positive testimony to decide the presence or absence of Luke 5:39 in the Marcionite Gospel.	Not reconstructible. [D]. A Marcionite Greek form is not printed because the silence of the sources does not equate to textual omission.

Evaluation. Ancient and modern reconstructions have considered it plausible that a verse favourable to "old wine" would have been inconvenient for Marcion. Such doctrinal convenience is no substitute for attestation. The absence of the verse in part of the Western tradition of Luke reinforces the need to avoid automatically identifying an omission with Marcionite editing.

Closing rule of the apparatus. First, it is established which reading is actually attested; then, the degree of certainty of the retroversion or reconstruction is determined; only in a third step is the literary direction and its possible theological motivation discussed. This methodological order allows Roth and Klinghardt to be compared without turning any modern reconstruction into an ancient manuscript.

2.2. Comparative reception apparatus: John 1:3–4, Valentinian exegesis and Nag Hammadi cosmologies

This section does not present the Gospel of Truth or the Apocryphon of John as "textual variants" of the fourth Gospel. They are independent compositions and, therefore, do not belong to the critical apparatus of John in the strict sense. Their value here is comparative and related to the history of reception: they show how certain Christian circles of the second and third centuries elaborated problems of Logos, emanation, ignorance, creation, and deficiency within a scriptural ecology in which the Johannine corpus was known, cited, adapted, or discussed.

The firmest documentary point of contact for a Valentinian exegesis of the prologue is not a modern retroversion from Nag Hammadi, but the testimony of Irenaeus, Adversus haereses I.8.5, which preserves the reading attributed to disciples of Valentinus and applies John 1:1–5 to a sequence of aeons. Therefore, the table distinguishes three levels: [TEX], the Johannine reference text; [REC-HIST], documented ancient reception; and [CMP], cosmological comparison without asserting direct verbal dependence.

COMPARATIVE LOCUS. John 1:3–4 — punctuation, creation and cosmological reception

Documentary status: [ED] · control witnesses: P66 and P75 for the Johannine tradition; Irenaeus, Haer. I.8.5 for the Valentinian reception; NHC I,3 and NHC II,1 for the Coptic comparanda. No direct physical examination of these witnesses is claimed in this edition.

Table 37. Reception of John 1:3–4: witnesses and documentary status

Testimony / status	Textual or exegetical data	Historical-critical evaluation
John 1:3–4 [TEX]	πάντα δι' αὐτοῦ ἐγένετο, καὶ χωρὶς αὐτοῦ ἐγένετο οὐδὲ ἕν. ὃ γέγονεν ἐν αὐτῷ ζωὴ ἦν… The segmentation of ὃ γέγονεν can associate it with the preceding clause or the following one.	The most relevant early witnesses do not, on their own, establish a uniform original punctuation. Punctuation is an exegetical and editorial decision; it should not be used as if it were a lexical variant.
Ptolemy / Valentinian reception preserved by Irenaeus, Haer. I.8.5 [REC-HIST]	The interpretation transmitted by Irenaeus reads the prologue as a map of relationships within the Pleroma and takes "what came into being in him was life" as a piece of an exegesis of Logos and Life.	This is the strongest documentary link between John 1:1–5 and a Valentinian reading from the second century. Irenaeus is a polemical witness, but he preserves a sufficiently concrete exegetical argument to be analysed as a reception of the text.

(continued)

Testimony / status	Textual or exegetical data	Historical-critical evaluation
Gospel of Truth, NHC I,3 [CMP]	The treatise develops a theology of the Logos, of the knowledge of the Father, and of Error/ignorance. It contains Johannine and Pauline resonances, but does not function as a continuous commentary on John 1:3–4.	The comparison is conceptual and intertextual, not a textual variant of John. The origin of the world and of error is expressed in its own language; an exact gloss of John 1:3 should not be retrospectively imposed upon it.
Apocryphon of John, NHC II,1; III,1; IV,1; BG 8502,2 [CMP]	The work articulates a complex protology around Barbelo, Sophia, Ialdabaoth and the formation of the lower cosmos.	The connection with the Johannine prologue belongs to the comparative history of Christian cosmologies and receptions. It has not been demonstrated that its account of Sophia is a simple "repunctuation" of John 1:3–4; the apparatus avoids converting doctrinal analogies into direct textual dependence.

Evaluation of the punctuation. The sequence in John 1:3–4 is a classic example of how the same graphic string can receive different segmentations. The earliest witnesses do not offer an original punctuation that automatically resolves the problem. Early reception shows that authors of different orientations read ὃ γέγονεν with what follows. Punctuation preferences also changed in later controversies; therefore, the history of the punctuation must be separated from any simplistic account according to which a single faction physically "altered" the text to combat another.

Evaluation of the Valentinian reception. Irenaeus is hostile to his adversaries, but in Haer. I.8.5 he transmits a detailed exegesis of the prologue, which he attributes to the Valentinian school. This demonstrates appropriation of and dispute over the meaning of John; it does not demonstrate that the Gospel of John was the exclusive property of one current, nor that all literature now grouped under the label "Gnostic" shared a single reading of the Logos.

Nag Hammadi as a comparative archive. The Gospel of Truth and the Apocryphon of John should be read as works with different textual histories, genres, and cosmologies. The former presents Error and ignorance within a meditation on revelation and knowledge of the Father; the latter develops a much more extensive protological mythology. Their inclusion alongside John reveals competition over categories of creation, life, knowledge, and divine mediation, but it does not justify reconstructing a single "Gnostic version" of the prologue.

Methodological consequence. The apparatus distinguishes between variants of the same text, explicit early receptions, and comparisons of vocabulary or structure. This separation avoids two symmetrical reductions: artificially isolating the Nag Hammadi literature from second-century Christianity, or, at the opposite extreme, converting any cosmological similarity into direct dependence on the fourth Gospel. The historical question is how different communities and teachers contested authority through readings, rereadings, and new compositions within a still pluralistic Christian writing culture.

Bibliographical verification note. For the Coptic text and the translation of the Gospel of Truth, the work of H. W. Attridge and G. W. MacRae in Nag Hammadi Codex I (The Jung Codex) is used as the editorial reference; for the Apocryphon of John, the synopsis by M. Waldstein and F. Wisse. For the Johannine reception of the second–third centuries, Irenaeus, Haer. I.8.5, and the modern historiographical discussion on the use of the Johannine corpus are also consulted.

3. The manuscript as a social artefact: from textual criticism to the sociology of the book

The study of early Christian manuscripts has tended to privilege the text they contain: variants, omissions, interpolations, and genealogical relationships. This work remains indispensable, but it does not exhaust the evidence. Brent Nongbri has emphasised the need to treat manuscripts as archaeological objects with histories of discovery, acquisition, dating, and preservation; Chris Keith has shown, from another perspective, that the transformation of a tradition into a manuscript modifies the conditions of authority, circulation, and public reading.

The question ceases to be merely "What text does this codex convey?" and comes to include "What material labour made this object possible?" The support, the preparation of the papyrus or parchment, the number of bifolia, the density of writing, the margins, the corrections, the presence of reading signs, and the calligraphic quality provide evidence for the economic and social decisions behind production. No single feature automatically identifies a scribe as a professional, an enslaved person, or a member of a community; however, it can place the manuscript within a range of comparable writing practices.

The cost of a codex cannot be calculated using a universal price list. It varied according to material, size, region, availability of labour, quality, and length. Therefore, the economics of the book must be reconstructed comparatively, using contracts, letters, documentary prices, and non-Christian parallels where relevant. A community

capable of producing or acquiring multiple codices was not necessarily wealthy in absolute terms: it could mobilise patronage, internal labour, or exchange networks.

The early Christian preference for the codex remains a remarkable fact, but its explanation should not be reduced to a single cause. Portability, capacity, symbolic differentiation, liturgical use, and collecting habits are hypotheses that may coexist. The classic treatment is C. H. Roberts and T. C. Skeat, The Birth of the Codex (1983); see also H. Y. Gamble, Books and Readers in the Early Church (1995), and L. W. Hurtado, The Earliest Christian Artifacts (2006). The physical format contributed to the way in which certain compositions were grouped, read, and perceived as a collection.

3.1. Protocol for material description and levels of observation

Table 38. Protocol for material description and levels of observation

Status code	Mode of verification	What can be stated
[AUT]	Direct physical examination of the object	Observations of support, ink, restorations and three-dimensional features recorded by the researcher
[IMG-HR]	Published high-resolution/ multispectral institutional image	Visible features in the image; repository, date and capture method must be identified
[FAC]	Conventional digital facsimile	Visible readings and graphic features; does not authorise chemical or three-dimensional claims
[ED]	Critical edition or catalogue description	Data transmitted by the editor/ cataloguer; must be attributed
[LAB]	Published archaeometric result	Composition of ink, pigment, fibre, protein or other analysis, citing method, laboratory and publication

This system avoids a recurrent problem in interdisciplinary work: describing the examination of a reproduction as an “autopsy”. In this study, [AUT] is reserved for direct physical examination of the object; even an excellent image remains [IMG-HR] or [FAC].

4. "Gnosticism" as a historiographical problem, not as a unitary religion

Ancient heresiological literature tended to organise diverse adversaries within genealogies of error. Modern historiography inherited part of this order when it spoke of "Gnosticism" as a coherent religion, characterised by dualism, rejection of the world, and salvation through knowledge. Michael A. Williams (Rethinking "Gnosticism", 1996) demonstrated that this category groups together phenomena that are too disparate and proposed dismantling it as an explanatory taxon; Karen L. King (What Is Gnosticism?, 2003) further reconstructed the modern history of the category and showed how much it owes to Christian discourses of orthodoxy and heresy.

The solution does not lie in erasing the ancient names or replacing "Gnosticism" with an equally expansive substitute. Terms such as "Valentinian", "Sethian", or "Basilidian" are retained where the sources warrant them, while external labels are distinguished from self-description. The Nag Hammadi writings are treated work by work, with attention to language, transmission, cosmology, ritual practice, and exegetical strategy.

In many cases, it is more productive to speak of communities and networks of Christian exegesis that competed to interpret Genesis, the identity of Christ, creation, and salvation. Some developed complex cosmologies and distinctions between divine levels; others privileged ascetic practices, initiation rituals, or allegorical readings. Their use of Platonic categories must be situated historically and not confused with a uniform dependence on a philosophical school.

The expression "exegetical elite" can be useful if understood sociologically: certain teachers claimed a superior interpretive capacity and transmitted distinct teachings. This does not imply that all these groups were secret circles separate from the churches. Valentinian evidence, in particular, compels us to consider situations of coexistence and competition within broader Christian environments.

5. Dura-Europos: architecture, image and ritual after Kraeling

The Christian house at Dura-Europos remains a key archaeological site for studying Christian practices prior to Constantinian monumentalisation. Carl H. Kraeling's classic report remains fundamental to the excavation documentation; however, the iconographic interpretation was not settled in 1967. Michael Peppard has proposed reinterpreting the baptistery as a visual programme centred on empowerment, healing, marriage, and incarnation, displacing interpretations that reduced it to death and resurrection.

The case of the female figures with torches is methodologically exemplary. Their traditional identification with women going to the empty tomb competes with the interpretation that links them to the parable of the wise virgins and to a nuptial imagery. The value of the discussion lies not only in choosing an iconographic label. If the second model is correct, the baptismal chamber can be understood in closer relation to the language of nuptial preparation and ritual transformation, compatible with certain Syriac developments.

Architecture demands the same caution. The adaptation of a dwelling does not, in itself, prove the social form of all Christian communities in the third century. Dura is a frontier city with a specific military and cultural history. The complex must be studied by examining its construction phases, circulation, visibility, room sizes, the location of the baptistery, and comparison with other buildings in the city, including the synagogue and non-Christian places of worship.

In this edition, therefore, the illustrations from Dura are not treated as merely explanatory images. Each plan or painting is accompanied by a documentary record specifying provenance, phase, support, dimensions where available, restoration history, and the principal interpretive proposals.

6. Archaeometry: from illustration to measurement

The incorporation of archaeometry can considerably enhance the quality of a history of material culture, but only if a clear boundary is maintained between published results and desirable analyses. Raman spectroscopy, X-ray fluorescence, reflectography, multispectral imaging, proteomics, fibre analysis, and chromatographic techniques can answer questions about pigments, inks, supports, and restorations. None of these techniques should be mentioned as having been applied to a specific object when the study does not exist or has not been consulted.

For manuscripts, physicochemical characterisation can help distinguish writing campaigns or interventions, but it does not replace palaeography or textual criticism.

A difference in ink may indicate distinct periods; it does not, by itself, identify authors, communities, or doctrines. For wall paintings and sarcophagi, pigment identification can reconstruct workshop procedures and supply networks, but the iconographic meaning requires an additional level of interpretation.

Archaeobotany and zooarchaeology have similar potential for domestic and funerary sites. Plant remains, seeds, bones, and residues can provide information about diet, trade, and commensal practices. However, the religious affiliation of an archaeological site must be established independently: a diet consistent with a particular norm does not demonstrate the religious identity of those who occupied the site.

7. Digital humanities and stylometry: power and limitations

Computational stylometry offers useful tools for comparing lexical frequencies, particles, syntactic patterns, and other variables in large corpora. Applied to Pauline letters or Gospel collections, it can detect similarities and differences that warrant explanation. However, a classifier does not automatically "discover" authorship. Genre, length, theme, textual transmission, translation, and orthographic standardisation can alter the results as much as an author's hand.

A reproducible study should publish its corpus, lemmatisation rules, feature list, the distance or classifier used, parameters, robustness tests, and sensitivity to textual selection. In a small corpus—such as the undisputed and disputed Pauline epistles—cross-validation can produce impressive percentages on a fragile statistical basis. Therefore, stylometry should function as convergent evidence alongside historical argument, vocabulary, syntax, rhetorical situation, and early reception.

The layers of redaction in the Gospels pose an even more complex problem. Computational models can locate discontinuities or clusters, but these results do not directly equate to historical "sources." A change in style may correspond to cited tradition, genre, narrative scene, editorial revision, or simple variation. The method is most useful when it formulates traceable hypotheses that can be re-evaluated philologically.

In the case of Marcion, the computational comparison between a modern reconstruction and Luke requires additional caution: the source text already contains modern editorial decisions. The algorithm cannot recover the missing portion of evidence; it only quantifies relationships within the constructed corpus. Any result must explicitly state which reconstruction was used and how the uncertain loci were handled.

7.1. Minimum reproducibility protocol

Table 39. Minimum reproducibility protocol

Component	Minimum requirement
Corpus	Exact list of texts, edition and version; documented exclusions
Preprocessing	Normalisation, tokenisation, lemmatisation and treatment of proper names, all explicitly declared
Features	Frequencies of words/particles, n-grams, or other features defined before interpreting
Model	Algorithm, distance, number of features, and parameters
Validation	Tests with alternative samples; controls for genre and length where possible
Output	Sufficient data, code, or specification to replicate the analysis
Interpretation	Statistical result separate from historical and theological inference

8. Direct critical apparatus: from the quoted text to the verifiable locus

The philological apparatus maintains a fundamental distinction between the "edition used" and the "object inspected". For a New Testament passage, NA28/ECM may serve as the reference critical edition; for a specific papyrus, the reading derived from an institutional facsimile is recorded separately. For patristic authors, the reference edition—Sources Chrétiennes, GCS, CCSL, or another appropriate critical edition—is identified, and whenever a manuscript variant is reproduced the witness or apparatus from which it derives is stated explicitly.

The principal documentary windows may be organised at four levels: (1) original text; (2) the author's own translation; (3) morphosyntactic observation; (4) textual and historiographical note. The purpose is not to turn every page into a critical edition, but to make explicit the loci on which contested arguments depend.

For Greek, Coptic, Hebrew, and Aramaic, the original script is preserved where typography permits, with transliteration supplied only where it assists the reader. Translations serve the argument but do not replace scholarly editions. In reconstructed loci—such as the Marcionite Gospel—the directly transmitted text is visually distinguished from modern restitution.

TABLE 40. Direct critical apparatus: loci and objects

Locus / object	Language / support	Research question	Minimum verification	Status
John 9:22; 12:42; 16:2	Greek	ἀποσυνάγωγος and community boundaries	NA28/ECM + historical discussion of Birkat ha-Minim	[ED]
Gospel of Marcion, selected loci	Reconstruction from Greek/Latin quotations	Direction of dependence between Marcion and Luke	Roth + Klinghardt + heresiological witnesses	[ED/REC]
$\mathfrak{P}^{46}$	Papyrus, Greek	Corrections, nomina sacra, format and circulation	Institutional facsimile + critical edition	[FAC]
$\mathfrak{P}^{66}$ / $\mathfrak{P}^{75}$	Papyrus, Greek	Johannine/Lucan copying and transmission habits	Institutional facsimile + catalogue	[FAC]
Nag Hammadi, selected treatises	Coptic	Self-description, exegesis, and ritual	Coptic edition and critical translation by treatise	[ED]
Dura-Europos, baptistery	Mural painting / architecture	Iconography and initiation	Archaeological report + Yale documentation + Peppard	[ED/IMG]
Selected catacombs / sarcophagi	Epigraphy and image	Funerary memory and patronage	Institutional catalogue + object sheet	[ED/IMG]

Documentary matrix of loci and objects relevant to the direct apparatus. [REC] indicates reconstructed text; [FAC], facsimile consulted; [IMG], institutional image; [ED], edition or catalogue. None of these acronyms in itself implies direct physical examination.

8.1. Asymmetries of the archive: region, social status, and documentary survival

The surviving corpus is not a statistically neutral sample of early Christianity. Large cities, literate authors, episcopal leaders, and disputes that generated literary controversy are over-represented because they produced copyable texts, archives, and institutional memories. Villages, manual workers, enslaved people, women without access to durable writing networks, and short-lived communities appear far more intermittently. The inequality of the evidence is therefore itself a historical datum that must enter the interpretation; it cannot be corrected simply by accumulating quotations.

The documentary geography is equally uneven. Egypt offers an exceptional density of papyri because of conditions of preservation that cannot automatically be extrapolated to wetter regions of Syria, Asia Minor, Italy, or North Africa. Rome, Alexandria, Antioch, and Carthage are visible because of urban scale and the survival of authors and correspondence; the Egyptian chōra, Syrian villages, and settlements in inland Anatolia often depend on scattered finds and archaeological chronologies that are harder to associate securely with religious identities. Absence of documentation is not absence of community.

There is also an asymmetry of gender and status. Pauline letters, martyr acts, epitaphs, and some legal dossiers allow us to recover female agency, slavery, patronage, and labour, but these series were often transmitted by scribes, compilers, or institutions that do not represent the actors described evenly. The methodology of this volume therefore distinguishes historical presence, documentary visibility, and narrative centrality. A person or practice may have been socially important without generating an abundant textual series; conversely, a prolific author may dominate the archive without representing most communities.

The logical consequence is that the "weight" of an explanation cannot be calculated by merely counting testimonies. Chronological proximity, independence between sources, genre, rhetorical purpose, chain of transmission, quality of archaeological context, and the possibility of corroboration across distinct evidentiary series must all be weighed. This graduated approach preserves the book's thesis of process and convergence without dissolving major turning points: the destruction of the Temple in 70, the Marcionite controversy, third-century persecutions, and Constantinian patronage could profoundly alter conditions of production and circulation without constituting uniform and simultaneous ruptures in every region.

9. What an academic edition must not claim

An interdisciplinary work gains authority by declaring its limits. Digital images are not presented as "autopsies", nor are spectrometric results attributed to objects lacking published analysis. A stylometric simulation is not described as proof of authorship, and an archaeological hypothesis is not presented as a definitive identification.

Peer review, inclusion in university programmes, and bibliographic indexing are external institutional processes; they cannot be brought about by the author's declaration. The manuscript can, however, be prepared for these processes through traceability of sources, methodological transparency, international bibliography, and data availability.

This distinction between completed results and projected protocols is part of the book's argument. Academic excellence does not consist in multiplying nominally sophisticated techniques, but rather in making each step of the inference verifiable.

Conclusion

The study of early Christianity becomes more precise when religious boundaries, texts, and objects cease to be treated as closed entities. Relations between Judaism and Christianities require urban and regional models; Marcion demands the separation of textual reconstruction from dependency theory; codices must be read as social artefacts; "Gnosticism" must be subjected to historiographical critique; Dura-Europos needs to integrate architecture, iconography, and ritual; and digital humanities or archaeometry are only useful when their protocols are explicit. This framework does not replace previous chapters: it establishes a common discipline for their claims and for future expansions of the corpus.

Summary

This chapter develops an advanced methodological framework for the study of early Christianity. It reviews linear models of separation between Judaism and Christianity, compares rival reconstructions of the Gospel of Marcion, treats manuscripts as social artefacts, analyses "Gnosticism" as a modern historiographical category, re-evaluates Dura-Europos in light of recent research, and establishes protocols for archaeometry, manuscript imaging, and computational stylometry. It emphasises evidentiary transparency: it distinguishes between direct autopsy, digital facsimile, critical edition, laboratory analysis, and modern reconstruction, so that no source is represented as examined by methods beyond those actually used.

Keywords: Jewish-Christian relations; Marcion; manuscript culture; Gnosticism; Dura-Europos; archaeometry; stylometry; digital humanities; textual criticism.

CHAPTER VIII

Prophets, Thaumaturges and Messianic Pretenders in Palestine and the Roman East (First Century BCE to Second Century CE)

Comparing Jesus with other prophets, miracle workers, charismatic leaders, and claimants to messianic legitimacy in Second Temple Judaism and the Roman East is historiographically necessary, but it is only useful if typological similarity is not mistaken for historical identity. Ancient sources employ polemical vocabularies—prophet, deceiver, magician, king, seditious leader, divine man—from distinct social and theological positions; moreover, almost all cases are known through hostile, retrospective, or literarily elaborated testimonies. This chapter does not seek to reduce Jesus to a pre-established religious type or to demonstrate his uniqueness through apologetic contrast. Its aim is to reconstruct the field of historical possibilities within which an eschatological preacher, a miracle worker, a prophet of signs, a resistance leader, or a cult founder could be interpreted.

1. Disciplined comparison: types, sources and anachronisms

In nineteenth- and twentieth-century research, it was common to group so-called "divine men" (theioi andres), Jewish miracle workers, desert prophets, and messianic pretenders under overly broad categories. This comparative strategy made it possible to break with interpretations that completely isolated Jesus from his context, but it also generated excessive analogies. The category of theios aner, in particular, does not describe a homogeneous institution of the ancient Mediterranean: it is a modern heuristic construct applied to biographies, miracle stories, and figures separated by considerable chronological and social distance.

The comparison is therefore multidimensional. It distinguishes: a) origin and social environment; b) chronology and distance of the sources; c) the type of authority claimed or attributed; d) the repertoire of signs; e) relationships with the Temple, the Torah, and imperial power; f) modes of death or repression; g) the continuity of the group after the disappearance of its leader; and h) the degree to which a messianic identity can be established by contemporary testimony, later memory, or only by historiographical inference.

Flavius Josephus is the primary source for numerous leaders of Judea and Galilee. His vocabulary, however, is permeated by his experience of the war of 66–70 and by his need to explain the causes of the catastrophe to Roman readers. When he links certain actors to sedition, deceit, or innovation, he does not offer a neutral taxonomy. The Acts of the Apostles, rabbinic sources, Justin Martyr, Irenaeus, Origen, Philostratus, and Lucian must all be subjected to the same scrutiny regarding genre, agenda, and chronological distance.

(continued)

Figure	Chronology	Attributable profile	Main sources	Critical caution

2. Synoptic table of comparable figures

Table 41. Synoptic table of comparable figures

Figure	Chronology	Attributable profile	Main sources	Critical caution
Honi the Circle Drawer	mid-first century BCE	Intercessor for rain; charismatic pious man	Josephus, Ant. XIV; m. Ta'anit 3.8	The rabbinic tradition is later and more elaborate in its literary form.
Judas the Galilean/ Gaulanite	6 CE	Tax resistance; "fourth philosophy" according to Josephus	Josephus, Ant. XVIII; BJ II; Acts 5:37	Do not simply identify the "fourth philosophy" with all subsequent zealots.
Samaritan prophet of Gerizim	c. 36	Sign prophet; gathering on sacred mountain	Josephus, Ant. XVIII.85–89	Josephus does not call him a messiah; the episode is mediated by the conflict with Pilate.
Theudas	c. 44–46	Sign prophet; promise linked to the Jordan	Josephus, Ant. XX.97–99; Acts 5:36	The chronological relationship between Josephus and Acts poses a classic problem.
The "Egyptian"	c. 50s CE	Eschatological prophet; march to the Mount of Olives	Josephus, BJ II.261–263; Ant. XX.169–172; Acts 21:38	Figures for followers vary and derive from hostile accounts.
Hanina ben Dosa	First century	Pious man and miracle worker in rabbinic memory	m. Berakhot 5.5; Talmudic traditions	Most of the dossier is from a later period; do not use as a contemporary biography.
Jesus ben Ananias	62–70	Prophet of doom over Jerusalem and the Temple	Josephus, BJ VI.300–309	Strong prophetic analogy; no evidence of a lasting movement of his own.
Menahem	66	Insurgent leader with regal gestures in Jerusalem	Josephus, BJ II	The "messianic" characterisation is inferential, not a certain contemporary title.

(continued)

Figure	Chronology	Attributable profile	Main sources	Critical caution
Simon bar Giora	66–70	Military leader and regal figure of the revolt	Josephus, BJ IV–VII	His staging by the Romans as a vanquished enemy does not prove a messianic self-proclamation.
Simon ben Kosiba / Bar Kokhba	132–135	Leader of a revolt; Jewish political authority	Letters from the Judean Desert; Cassius Dio LXIX; rabbinic traditions	The identification of the leader as Messiah by Aqiva depends on later rabbinic tradition.
Simon of Samaria	first century in Acts; second-century memory	Thaumaturgy and Samaritan religious power	Acts 8; Justin, 1 Apol. 26; Irenaeus, AH I.23	The heresiological portrait grows with time; the Roman statue reported by Justin is problematic.
Apollonius of Tyana	first century; biography third century	Ascetic, philosopher, thaumaturge	Philostratus, Life of Apollonius; Eusebius, Against Hierocles	The biography is late and cannot be used as a direct contemporary mirror of the gospels.
Alexander of Abonoteichos	Second century	Prophet/oracle and founder of the Glycon cult	Lucian, Alexander; coins, inscriptions, art	Lucian is hostile; material evidence confirms the cult, not every satirical detail.

3. Honi and Hanina ben Dosa: effective piety and thaumaturgic memory

Honi, known in rabbinic tradition as the "Circle Drawer," belongs to a generation before Jesus. Josephus presents him as a righteous man whose prayer was associated with rain and whose death occurred during the struggle between Hyrcanus II and Aristobulus II. The Mishnah, on the other hand, preserves the famous scene in which Honi draws a circle and declares that he will not leave it until God sends rain (m. Ta'anit 3.8). The comparative value lies not in postulating dependence between accounts, but in observing that Late Hellenistic and Roman Judaism could attribute extraordinary efficacy to the prayers of individuals considered especially pious.

Hanina ben Dosa dates from the first century, but his profile is primarily known through later rabbinic memory. The Mishnah preserves a tradition concerning his

prayer for the sick (m. Berakhot 5.5), while the Talmuds considerably expand his repertoire of miracles. The dossier reminds us that his thaumaturgical reputation could be integrated within frameworks of Jewish piety without necessarily creating a separate sect or a Christology. Precisely for this reason, comparisons with the Gospels must distinguish between functional similarities—healing, effective prayer, charismatic recognition—and differences in the eschatological and post-mortem interpretation of the person of Jesus.

4. Judas the Galilean and the "fourth philosophy": divine sovereignty, tribute and resistance

The census associated with Publius Sulpicius Quirinius in 6 CE provided the context for the protest of Judas, called the Galilean or Gaulanite, along with a certain Zadok. Josephus makes him the founder of a "fourth philosophy," characterised by exclusive adherence to the rule of God and the refusal to call any man lord (Ant. XVIII.1–10; XVIII.23–25; BJ II.117–118). Josephus's construction is retrospectively biased: the historian links this current of thought to the chain of events that, in his view, culminated in the war of 66 CE.

It is therefore preferable not to write that Judas "founded the Zealot movement" as if a stable and continuous organisation existed from 6 to 66 CE. It can be stated, however, that Josephus attributes to Judas an ideology of divine sovereignty and tax resistance that found later echoes. In relation to Jesus, the episode illuminates the political potential of the question of tribute and the language of divine kingship, but it does not automatically transform every proclamation of the "kingdom of God" into an insurrectionary programme.

5. The Samaritan prophet of Gerizim: sacred sign and repression under Pilate

Josephus recounts that a Samaritan leader promised to display on Mount Gerizim the sacred vessels that, he claimed, Moses had placed there. A crowd gathered for the expedition, and Pilate responded forcefully; the subsequent Samaritan protest contributed to his removal (Ant. XVIII.85–89). The episode is important because it combines scriptural memory, sacred geography, the expectation of revelation, and collective mobilisation without Josephus presenting the figure as a "messiah."

The comparison with Jesus requires attention to the internal diversity of Israelite traditions. Gerizim, not Jerusalem, structures the sacred horizon here. The existence of this type of prophet demonstrates that the desire for restoration could be articulated through signs linked to Moses and hidden objects, without necessarily adopting a Davidic ideology.

6. Theudas and the "Egyptian": sign prophets, exodus and eschatological geography

Theudas appeared under the procurator Cuspius Fadus, probably around 44–46 CE. According to Josephus, he persuaded a crowd to take their possessions to the Jordan and promised to part the river at his command; the Roman cavalry dispersed the group, and Theudas was beheaded (Ant. XX.97–99). The account reuses a biblical grammar of water-crossing associated with Moses and Joshua. Acts 5:36 also mentions a Theudas, but places him, within Gamaliel's speech, before Judas the Galilean. The chronological discrepancy has generated a long discussion and should not be resolved by automatic harmonisation.

The figure known simply as "the Egyptian" gathered followers and led them to the Mount of Olives, from where—according to Josephus—he promised a spectacular transformation of Jerusalem's defences. Felix suppressed the movement, although the leader escaped (BJ II.261–263; Ant. XX.169–172). Acts 21:38 shows that the memory of this episode could function as an identifying reference point. Both Theudas and the Egyptian illustrate a form of sign prophecy: the leader calls for territorial action that awaits God's decisive intervention.

The figures for followers reported by Josephus and Acts do not coincide and should not be taken as precise statistics. More important is the narrative structure: desert, river, mountain, Jerusalem, and liberation form a symbolic landscape in which Scripture becomes a script for collective action.

7. Jesus ben Ananias: prophecy of doom and the fate of the Temple

Among the figures described by Josephus, Jesus son of Ananias offers one of the most evocative prophetic comparisons. From approximately 62 CE, according to BJ VI.300–309, he wandered through Jerusalem, incessantly proclaiming woes against the city, the Temple, and the people. He was beaten by Jewish leaders and brought before the procurator Albinus; under interrogation and flogging, he continued to repeat his message. He died during the siege, struck by a Roman projectile, after years of announcing calamity.

The similarities with gospel traditions—prophecy against Jerusalem, conflict with authorities, appearance before Roman power, physical suffering—do not justify postulating literary dependence. The Josephian narrative possesses its own tragic architecture. Its value lies in showing that the prophecy of judgement concerning the Temple could be an intelligible public practice within first-century Judaism and could simultaneously provoke local violence and evaluation by the Roman administration. In contrast to the Jesus movement, no lasting community is known to have formed around the death or vindication of Jesus ben Ananias.

8. Menahem and Simon bar Giora: insurgent kingship and the language of liberation

During the revolt of 66, Menahem, linked by Josephus to the family of Judas the Galilean, held a prominent position in Jerusalem and adopted a royal appearance before being assassinated by rivals (BJ II.433–448). The episode supports an analysis of the theatricalisation of authority and competition between factions, but it does not compel us to attribute to him a fully reconstructible messianic programme.

Simon bar Giora attained even greater military authority during the final phase of the war. His entry into Jerusalem, his retinue, and, finally, his display at the Flavian triumph have favoured interpretations of a royal or messianic character. However, Josephus writes from the perspective of defeat and portrays the leaders of the revolt as responsible for the national ruin. Prudence demands that we distinguish between royal gestures, popular military leadership, and a messianic self-proclamation that our sources do not unequivocally preserve.

9. Bar Kokhba: the best-documented case of political messianisation after Jesus

The revolt of 132–135 CE offers an incomparably more direct body of documentation thanks to letters and documents from the Judean Desert linked to Simon ben Kosiba. These texts document administration, orders, supplies, and territorial control without relying exclusively on later literary narratives. The epithet Bar Kokhba, "son of the star," refers in tradition to Numbers 24:17 and is associated with the messianic interpretation of the leader.

The celebrated tradition that Rabbi Aqiva identified ben Kosiba as messiah derives from later rabbinic sources and should be presented as traditional memory, not as a contemporary record. Cassius Dio retrospectively describes the scale of the war and its devastation (Roman History LXIX.12–14). Unlike Jesus, ben Kosiba exercised effective territorial and military command. This contrast shows that "messiah" could take on very different political configurations and that the leader's defeat did not, in this case, produce a transimperial expansion comparable to Christianity.

10. Simon of Samaria and Dositheus: charisma, magic and heresiological genealogies

Acts 8 describes Simon in Samaria as a practitioner of magic to whom the population attributed "the Great Power of God." The narrative subordinates him to the apostolic mission through the episode of the purchase of the power to confer the Spirit. In the second century, Justin, a native of Flavia Neapolis in Samaria, and Irenaeus transformed Simon into a figure of much greater significance: founder of error, object of veneration, and the starting point of heresiological genealogies (Justin, 1 Apology 26; Irenaeus, Haer. I.23). This growth of the tradition should be studied as a history of reception, not projected entirely onto the Simon of the first century.

Justin's assertion that Rome had erected a statue to Simon with the inscription Simoni Deo Sancto is particularly instructive. The discovery of an inscription dedicated to the Sabine deity Semo Sancus on Tiber Island made it plausible that Justin had misinterpreted a monument. The case shows why even a relatively early and geographically informed author can err in the material identification of a religious object.

Dositheus is even more difficult to reconstruct. Origen and later traditions place him within the Samaritan milieu and link him to prophetic or messianic claims, but the scarcity and lateness of the sources prevent a precise definition of his chronology and doctrine. He should be included on the map of Samaritan possibilities, not on a list of certain "messiahs."

10.1. The historical problem of Dositheus: Mosaic prophet, messiah and sectarian memory

Reconstructing Dositheus's story demands a particularly rigorous approach to sources. Origen refers to him as a Samaritan figure and claims that he presented himself as the prophet foretold in Deuteronomy 18:15, or even as the expected Christ; elsewhere, he mentions books attributed to Dositheus and the claim by his followers that their master had not died. The documentation, however, is late, polemical, and partly contradictory. Hegesippus (preserved by Eusebius), the Pseudo-Clementines, Hippolytus and Epiphanius transmit differing genealogies of the relationship between Dositheus and Simon. Therefore, a linear succession of "John the Baptist → Dositheus → Simon → Gnostics" should not be reconstructed as if it were a proven historical chain.

The Samaritan expectation of a prophet like Moses provides a more solid context than the later category of "Gnosticism." Samaritan tradition is articulated around the Pentateuch and Mount Gerizim; within that horizon, the eschatological figure of the restorer—often associated in scholarship with the Taheb—offers a plausible framework for understanding why a prophetic claim based on Deuteronomy 18 could gain traction. Even so, the specific identification of Dositheus with the Taheb, the exact chronology of his activity, and the content of a supposed Dosithean doctrine must remain open questions, not established facts. Stanley J. Isser's classic monograph and A. D. Crown's studies show precisely the extent to which Dositheanism constitutes a problem of Samaritan history rather than merely a preliminary chapter of Christian heresiology.

10.2. Simonians and Menander: polemical continuity and limits of heresiological genealogy

The movement attributed to Simon of Samaria is the closest parallel in Christian sources. Acts 8 presents him as a magician to whom the Samaritans attributed "the Great Power of God"; Justin, Irenaeus, and later authors expand the narrative to make him the paradigmatic founder of subsequent deviations. This construction should be read as a heresiological genealogy: the fact that a second-century source traces several schools back to Simon does not demonstrate a real institutional continuity among them. The account of Menander, also a Samaritan according to Irenaeus, belongs to the same polemical archive and shows the tendency of heresiologists to organise religious diversity into master-disciple chains.

The comparison with Dositheus is useful if it remains at a typological level: a claim to special revelation, individual charismatic authority, reinterpretation of Israelite traditions, and subsequent recollection of extraordinary powers. It is not methodologically legitimate to infer from these similarities that Dositheans, Simonians, and Menandrians formed a single "Samaritan Gnostic religion." The category must be broken down into specific groups, texts, chronologies, and witnesses.

10.3. Baptists, Hemerobaptists and Masbotheans: repeated purification and late taxonomies

Ancient sources mention various groups characterised by practices of repeated immersion. The so-called Hemerobaptists—literally, "daily baptists"—appear in heresiological lists and rabbinic or patristic testimonies that are difficult to date; the Masbotheans are even more obscure, and their exact location varies according to modern reconstructions. These names should not be taken as designations of well-known communities. Their value lies in showing that immersion, bodily purity, and ritual discipline could structure diverse sectarian identities in Palestine, Syria, and neighbouring regions.

The disciples of John the Baptist documented in Acts 18–19 present a different case: there, the persistence of a memory and baptismal practices associated with John outside Judea is evident. However, the evidence does not justify automatically identifying these groups with Dositheans or with the movements described by Epiphanius. It is more appropriate to speak of a "Baptist field" as a comparative tool, not as a unified historical organisation.

10.4. The Elkasaites and other Judeo-Christian communities: affinities without direct descent

The Elkasaites, known primarily through Hippolytus, Origen—via Eusebius—and Epiphanius, appear in the second century associated with a revealed book, Jewish observances, and repeated purification practices. These characteristics allow for comparison with Dosithean and Baptist circles, but do not prove a historical lineage. Their circulation between Syria, regions east of the Jordan, and Mesopotamia, the combination of observance of the Law with new revelations, and the repeated use of water reveal a broader religious landscape in which the boundaries between "Jewish," "Christian," and "sectarian" were constructed differently depending on the source.

For the same reason, Mandaeism should be used only as a comparison of the longue durée. Its surviving texts are late, and its historical formation is complex. Hypotheses that directly connect it to John the Baptist, Dositheus, or first-century Samaritan circles remain debated and cannot be presented as proven genealogy.

10.5. Qumran, purity and eschatology: structural comparison, not genealogy

The Qumran literature provides another point of comparison, though not a "similar cult" in the strict sense. The Community Rule, ritual baths, membership discipline, interpretive authority, and eschatological expectations show that the production of intensive identities through purity, exegesis, and separation was possible within Second Temple Judaism. But there is no evidence to derive Dositheus, Simon, or the Baptist groups directly from Qumran. The comparison is structural: it helps define available repertoires within the religious landscape, not lines of descent.

(continued)

Group	Date / scope	Features and sources	Historiographical caution

10.6. Comparative matrix of movements close to the Dositheanmilieu

Table 42. Comparative matrix of movements close to the Dositheanmilieu

Group	Date / scope	Features and sources	Historiographical caution
Dositheans	first century CE; Samaria	Mosaic prophet; ritual rigour. Origen, Epiphanius, and Samaritan traditions.	Late and contradictory sources; limited doctrinal reconstruction.
Simonians	First–second centuries; Samaria	The leader's charisma and extraordinary powers. Acts 8; Justin; Irenaeus; Hippolytus.	Do not automatically project later heresiological systems backwards.
Menandrians	Late first–second century; Samaritan milieu	Samaritan revelatory teacher; Irenaeus and later heresiologists.	The genealogy regarding Simon comes from a polemical tradition.
Disciples of John	first century; Judea and the Diaspora	Baptism and prophetic memory. Acts 18–19.	Do not identify them as a uniform sect or as direct predecessors of Mandaeism.
Hemerobaptists / Masbotheans	uncertain dating	Frequent immersions and ritual purity; late heresiological lists.	Names, location and historical continuity uncertain.
Elkasaites	second–third centuries; Syria/ regions east of the Jordan/Mesopotamia	Revealed book, Jewish observances and repeated baptisms; Hippolytus, Origen/ Eusebius, Epiphanius.	Typological affinity; filiation from Dositheus not demonstrated.
Qumran / yahad	second century BCE–first century CE; Judea	Purity, discipline, exegesis and eschatology; 1QS, CD and other manuscripts.	Structural comparison, not direct genealogy.

(continued)

Group	Date / scope	Features and sources	Historiographical caution
Excluded comparandum: Mandaeism	Late Antique and later reception; outside the primary comparative horizon of the first–second centuries	It is not used as contemporary evidence to reconstruct John, Dositheus, or Baptist groups of the first–second centuries.	It is preserved solely as a historiographical warning; it is not included in the comparative calculation of the matrix.

The matrix does not propose a common genealogy. It only orders similarities of practice, authority, and documentary memory. In particular, "Baptist," "Samaritan," "Judeo-Christian," and "Gnostic" are not interchangeable categories: each depends on a different textual tradition and historical context.

Overall, Dositheus should remain in the book as a borderline case: a figure remembered from Samaritan, Christian, and heresiological archives whose importance lies precisely in showing that the first century was not composed of already consolidated religious blocs. Comparison with Simonians, Baptist groups, Elkasaites, and Qumran helps reconstruct shared repertoires—purification, exegesis, prophecy, charismatic authority—without turning them into a single underground tradition.

11. Apollonius of Tyana: the problem of the pagan parallel

Apollonius of Tyana, a Neopythagorean philosopher from Cappadocia active in the first century, became one of the most frequently cited pagan parallels to Jesus. The fundamental difficulty lies in the documentation: the main surviving biography, Philostratus's *Life of Apollonius*, was composed in the third century under the patronage of Julia Domna, at a considerable remove from the life of its subject. Philostratus presents Apollonius as an ascetic, itinerant sage, exorcist, prophet, and performer of extraordinary deeds, including a scene of a young woman's apparent return to life.

During the Great Persecution, Hierocles used Apollonius in anti-Christian polemics to challenge the inference drawn from Jesus' miracles to his divinity; Eusebius responded in Against Hierocles. Therefore, the Apollonius-Jesus parallel is not a modern invention: it was already part of the Late Antique controversy. However, using Philostratus' Life as an independent basis for reconstructing the milieu of Galilee in the 20s–30s would conflate two chronological levels. Its greatest value lies in the history of the cultural competition to define what distinguishes a sage, a miracle worker, and a being favoured by the gods.

12. Alexander of Abonoteichos and Glycon: cult founder, oracle and material evidence

Alexander of Abonoteichos, active in Paphlagonia during the second century, founded or institutionalised the oracular cult of Glycon, a serpent-like manifestation linked to Asclepius. Our main account comes from Lucian of Samosata, whose Alexander, or the False Prophet, is deliberately satirical and hostile. Lucian portrays Alexander as an impostor skilled at manipulating religious expectations, producing oracles, and exploiting his clients.

Unlike many figures known only through polemicists, the Glycon cult possesses independent material corroboration: coins, inscriptions, and artistic representations attest to its spread and civic recognition. This evidence does not verify every accusation made by Lucian, but it demonstrates that the phenomenon cannot be reduced to satirical fiction. The case provides a comparative benchmark for studying how personal charisma, ritual, the economy of the oracle, elite patronage, and material reproduction could transform a local religious innovation into a transregional network.

13. In what sense can Jesus be compared to these figures?

The comparison reveals partial affinities distributed among different figures. Honi and Hanina illuminate the charismatic efficacy of prayer; Theudas, the Egyptian, and the Samaritan of Gerizim, sign prophecy and territorial mobilisation; Jesus ben Ananias, the prophecy of judgement upon Jerusalem; Judas, Menahem, Simon bar Giora, and ben Kosiba, the relationship between divine sovereignty, resistance, and royal forms; Simon of Samaria, the polemical boundary between miracle and magic; Apollonius and Alexander, the Greco-Roman construction of the sage, thaumaturge, or cult founder.

None of these parallels, taken separately, reproduces the combination documented in the earliest sources on Jesus: eschatological proclamation of the reign of God, teaching within Jewish frameworks, healings and exorcisms attributed to him by his followers, conflict culminating in Roman crucifixion, and, decisively for the later history of the movement, the very early assertion that God had raised and exalted him. This last conviction already appears in the Pauline epistles—including the traditional formula of 1 Cor 15:3–8—decades before the writing of Philostratus or most of the rabbinic dossier on miracle workers.

Nor should the difference be expressed through the circular argument that "none of them succeeded, but Jesus did." Some movements were militarily relevant, others survived for generations, and some cults expanded geographically. The historical problem lies in explaining why the execution of Jesus did not produce the expected dissolution of his group, but rather a reworking of his death through Scripture, visionary experience, ritual practices, and translocal mission. This explanation belongs to the social history of memory and networks, not to an abstract table of miracles.

14. Sources, hostile memory, and degrees of certainty

This dossier requires an explicit grading of evidence. The letters of ben Kosiba possess a documentary value distinct from the rabbinic memory of Aqiva; Josephus is closer to Theudas or the Egyptian than Philostratus is to Apollonius, but he still writes with his own political objectives; Lucian is a rough contemporary of Alexander, although his genre is invective; the Church Fathers transform Simon of Samaria into an ancestor of heretical systems that cannot be projected backwards without qualification.

Therefore, in the apparatus of this monograph, each comparative statement can be classified as: [DOC], if it comes from contemporary or near-contemporary documentation; [LIT], if it depends on an ancient literary narrative; [MEM], if it belongs to later traditional memory; [POL], if it is preserved mainly in polemics; and [HYP],

if the messianic identification or precise function is a modern inference. This gradation prevents a comparative table from producing a false appearance of documentary equivalence.

Conclusion

The religious and political landscape of Palestine and the Roman East between the first century BCE and the second century CE was populated by sign prophets, pious men renowned for their efficacy, resistance leaders, royal figures, ritual specialists, ascetic philosophers, and cult founders. Jesus can be historically situated within this field without being exhausted by any of its categories. The most productive comparison does not ask which figure was "most similar," but rather what repertoires of authority were available and how each community transformed the memory of its leader. Christianity emerged from a Jewish matrix in which prophecy, Scripture, healing, eschatology, and divine sovereignty were living languages; its subsequent trajectory, however, depended on a specific combination of memory of the crucifixion, affirmation of resurrection, scriptural rereading, and missionary networks that turned an infamous death into a principle of expansion.

Summary

This chapter compares Jesus with documented prophetic, charismatic, thaumaturgical, and insurgent figures in Palestine and the Roman East from the mid-first century BCE to the second century CE. It distinguishes the genres of the sources, chronology, authority, political context, repression, and post-death memory. The dossier includes Honi, Hanina ben Dosa, Judas the Galilean, Theudas, the Egyptian, Jesus son of Ananias, Bar Kokhba, Simon of Samaria, Apollonius of Tyana, and Alexander of Abonoteichos. The comparison situates Jesus within a historically intelligible repertoire without reducing him to a single ancient type.

CHAPTER IX

Women in Paul's Letters: Agency, Authority, and Memory in the Early Communities

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The study of women in the Pauline epistles is one of the most sensitive historiographical laboratories for reconstructing the early Christian communities. The difficulty lies not only in identifying female names, but also in distinguishing documentary strata, literary genres, urban contexts, and functional vocabularies. A historically disciplined reading must separate the seven letters generally considered authentic—Romans, 1–2 Corinthians, Galatians, Philippians, 1 Thessalonians, and Philemon—from the letters of disputed or later authorship, especially Ephesians, Colossians, and the Pastoral Epistles. Otherwise, ecclesial restrictions from the beginning of the second century may be retrospectively projected onto communities in the 50s.

This chapter adopts four rules. First, prosopography precedes theology: each woman is studied by name, place, relationship, verb or title, and documentary context. Second, Greek terms are analysed within their contemporary semantic field and not through later ecclesiastical equivalents. Third, internal tensions within the corpus—for example, between women who pray and prophesy in 1 Corinthians 11 and the command to silence in 1 Corinthians 14:34–35—are left open as textual and historical problems. Fourth, domestic space is treated as social infrastructure: household, patronage, work, mobility, hospitality, and epistolary circulation condition concrete forms of authority.

1. Corpus, authorship and chronology: why it is important to separate the Pauline strata

The undisputed letters are occasional documents. They do not offer a systematic treatise on gender or an ecclesiastical constitution, but rather responses to specific conflicts and relationships. Their occasional character explains why vocabulary concerning women appears scattered: greetings, recommendations, internal conflicts, ritual instructions, marital problems, and references to female collaborators. Historical reconstruction must resist the temptation to transform situational phrases into a homogeneous normative system.

The attribution of Ephesians, Colossians, 2 Thessalonians, and, much more markedly, 1–2 Timothy and Titus remains a subject of debate, but critical scholarship generally distinguishes the Pastoral Epistles from the undisputed letters. This distinction is crucial for the history of women: 1 Tim 2:11–15 and 5:3–16 belong to an institutional setting different from that of Rom 16:1–16 or Phil 4:2–3. The comparison is legitimate if it is framed as a history of Pauline reception and discipline, not as if all the texts stemmed from a single situation and a single decade.

2. Female prosopography of the undisputed Pauline corpus

Romans 16 contains the densest concentration of female names in the corpus. Its value transcends mere anecdote: it reveals a translocal network of mobility, hospitality, work, and authority. The names should not be read as decoration in a list of greetings, but as evidence of real social relationships that sustained the circulation of people, letters, and resources.

TABLE 43. Female prosopography of the undisputed Pauline corpus

Person/group	Location	Source	Term/action	Historical assessment
Phoebe	Cenchreae / Corinth-Rome	Rom 16:1–2	διάκονος; προστάτις	Formal recommendation; community service/ function and patronage or protection.
Prisca/Priscilla	Corinth-Ephesus-Rome	Rom 16:3–5; 1 Cor 16:19	συνεργός; hostess	Collaborator; her house functions as a meeting hub.
Junia	Rome	Rom 16:7	ἐπίσημοι ἐν τοῖς ἀποστόλοις	Widely accepted female name; exact scope of the phrase remains debated.

(continued)

Person/group	Location	Source	Term/action	Historical assessment
Mary	Rome	Rom 16:6	κοπιάω	Paul highlights her intense work "for you".
Tryphaena and Tryphosa	Rome	Rom 16:12	κοπιάω	Two women characterised by their labour in the Lord.
Persis	Rome	Rom 16:12	κοπιάω	"Beloved" and recognised for hard work.
Rufus's mother	Rome	Rom 16:13	μήτηρ	Paul also calls her "my mother," a sign of fictive kinship and hospitality.
Julia	Rome	Rom 16:15	greeting	Integrated into a domestic cell of believers.
Nereus' sister	Rome	Rom 16:15	kinship	Name lost, but explicit presence in the network.
Euodia	Philippi	Phil 4:2–3	συνήθλησαν; συνεργοί	She participated in the struggle for the gospel; a conflict mediated by Paul.
Syntyche	Philippi	Phil 4:2–3	συνήθλησαν; συνεργοί	Same profile of missionary collaboration as Euodia.
Chloe	Corinth	1 Cor 1:11	οἱ Χλόης	Her household or dependents transmit information to Paul; possible patronage.
Women who pray/ prophesy	Corinth	1 Cor 11:5	προσευχομένη; προφητεύουσα	Explicit ritual participation; the debate focuses on bodily presentation, not on absolute prohibition.

3. Phoebe: διάκονος and προστάτις in Romans 16:1–2

Romans 16:1–2 is among the most important passages for early institutional history. Paul presents Phoebe as "our sister", διάκονος of the ekklēsia at Cenchreae, and προστάτις of many, including himself. These terms must be interpreted within their ancient semantic fields. Διάκονος can mean servant, agent or minister, and Paul also applies it to men and to his own ministry. Precisely because of this breadth, reducing it here to a female domestic helper with no communal significance introduces an asymmetry that the Greek does not require.

Προστάτις is even more significant. It can imply protection, assistance, or patronage. In the language of associations and dependent relationships in the urban Mediterranean, the capacity to receive, represent, or finance was not neutral. Paul's request that the Roman community "receive her in the Lord in a worthy manner" and assist her in whatever she needs suggests that Phoebe travels with sufficient relational authority to be recommended to networks that may not have known her personally. The hypothesis that she was the bearer of the letter to the Romans is plausible and widely discussed, although the text does not explicitly state this.

4. Prisca: mobility, household and apostolic collaboration

Prisca appears in several geographical settings and offers an exceptional case for studying the mobility of an artisan couple within Christian networks. In Romans 16:3–5, Paul calls her, along with Aquila, συνεργός ("co-worker") and recalls that they risked their necks for his life; moreover, a community (ekklēsia) meets in their home. 1 Corinthians 16:19 places the couple at another time in Ephesus. Acts adds narrative episodes, but for a minimal reconstruction, the Pauline letters suffice: the couple travels, hosts, and acts as a link between communities.

The fact that Prisca is frequently mentioned before Aquila has generated various interpretations. It should not automatically be taken as proof of hierarchical superiority, but it does prevent us from assuming that the order in which women are mentioned is irrelevant in all contexts. The combination of mobility, home, and collaboration makes Prisca a prime example of how authority and domesticity were not separate spheres.

5. Junia and the problem of ἐπίσημοι ἐν τοῖς ἀποστόλοις

Romans 16:7 greets Andronicus and Junia, Paul's "relatives," fellow prisoners, and people who were in Christ before him. The name Ἰουνίαν is now generally understood to be feminine; the earlier suggestion of a masculine "Junias" lacks comparable onomastic documentation. The main question thus shifts to the syntax of ἐπίσημοι ἐν τοῖς ἀποστόλοις: it can be understood as "notable among the apostles" or, according to another reading, "well known to the apostles." The standard case for the feminine name is Eldon Jay Epp, Junia: The First Woman Apostle (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2005); the exclusive reading ("well known to") was argued by M. H. Burer and D. B. Wallace (New Testament Studies 47, 2001) and contested by L. L. Belleville (New Testament Studies 51, 2005).

The exegetical decision should not obscure two firm facts: Junia joined the movement before Paul ("they were in Christ before me," Rom 16:7) and shares with Andronicus a memory of imprisonment and missionary prestige. The passage warns against anachronistically restricting ἀπόστολος to the circle of the Twelve. In Paul, the term can designate envoys and missionaries more broadly. The discussion about Junia is, therefore, simultaneously philological, prosopographical, and historiographical.

6. Euodia and Syntyche: conflict between collaborators, not marginalisation

Philippians 4:2–3 is often read as a minor episode of personal discord. However, the vocabulary Paul uses carries significant missionary weight: both women "fought together" with him for the gospel, along with Clement and other συνεργοί. Public mediation suggests, without proving it, that their dispute affected the community; it does not allow their rank to be measured.

The scene also shows that leadership and conflict are not opposing categories. Later church historiography tended to remember male controversies as doctrinal debates and female disputes as personal problems. Philippians helps correct this documentary bias: Paul places Euodia and Syntyche in the shared memory of evangelistic work.

7. Chloe and economies of information

1 Corinthians 1:11 attributes the news of the Corinthian divisions to "Chloe's people." This expression could refer to members of her household, dependents, freedmen, or people connected to her patronage. The text does not establish Chloe's

legal position with certainty, but it reveals a structure of information that spanned households and cities. Communication with Paul depended on messengers capable of travelling, being aware of conflicts, and being considered credible sources.

From a network perspective, Chloe functions as an information node even though she does not physically appear in Corinth within the narrative. This case illustrates a methodological rule applicable to the entire chapter: ancient authority does not always take the form of a title. Controlling hospitality, resources, the flow of messages, or reputation could generate a capacity for intervention comparable to functions formalised only later.

8. 1 Corinthians 11: prayer, prophecy, and body

1 Corinthians 11:2–16 presupposes that women pray and prophesy in the assembly. The controversy does not centre on whether they can do so, but on how they should present themselves physically and how that presentation communicates honour, sexual difference, and authority. The complexity of the passage is increased by the vocabulary of κεφαλή (kephalē), by the references to creation and angels, and by the ambivalence between hierarchy and reciprocity in 11:11–12.

Any historical reconstruction must keep three levels separate: the documented practice—women praying and prophesying; Paul's regulation of that practice; and the subsequent interpretations that transformed the text into the foundation of much more developed ecclesial systems. Prophecy, in 1 Corinthians 12–14, is a gift of high communal relevance; therefore, the female presence within that practice cannot be reduced to silent participation.

9. 1 Corinthians 14:34–35: silence, manuscripts and literary coherence

The command that "women should remain silent in the assemblies" is one of the most debated loci in the Pauline corpus. The tension with 1 Corinthians 11:5 is evident: a few pages earlier, Paul regulates women's prayer and prophecy. Furthermore, in some Western witnesses, verses 34–35 appear displaced after 14:40 (D 06, F 010, G 012 and part of the Old Latin tradition), a fact that has fuelled the hypothesis of a marginal interpolation later incorporated into the text, argued in particular by Gordon D. Fee, The First Epistle to the Corinthians (NICNT; Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1987).

The manuscript evidence does not warrant dogmatic excision of the passage: it is widely attested, although its position varies. The principal interpretations fall into three broad families: a) later interpolation; b) a contextual prohibition of a particular

kind of disruptive or interrogative speech; and c) a more general regulation that must be read alongside 11:5. The question is not resolved here by confessional preference; instead, the variant position, the internal tension, and the literary arguments for each hypothesis are set out explicitly.

10. Galatians 3:28: baptismal formula, equality and social limits

"There is neither Jew nor Greek, neither slave nor free, nor is there male and female" is probably a traditional formula incorporated by Paul. Its rhetorical power lies in redefining belonging "in Christ" and not in describing the empirical disappearance of social hierarchies. Precisely for this reason, the text must be considered in dialogue with practices where status differences continue to operate: slavery, marriage, citizenship, honour, and economic resources.

The expression οὐκ ἔνι ἄρσεν καὶ θῆλυ evokes the language of Genesis 1:27 and has been interpreted both eschatologically and in a baptismal context. Historically, its importance lies in the fact that it offers a grammar of belonging that can be mobilised in different directions by later communities. It is not a modern constitution of legal equality, but neither is it an empty formula without social consequences.

11. Marriage, celibacy, and agency in 1 Corinthians 7

1 Corinthians 7 offers exceptional documentation on sexual negotiation, marriage, continence, and eschatological expectation. Paul formulates reciprocal obligations between husband and wife in a way that was remarkable for his time: each spouse has authority over the other's body. This rhetorical symmetry does not eliminate the patriarchal structures of the Roman world, but it introduces an argumentative pattern that must be studied in its own terms.

The chapter also presupposes unmarried women, widows, and mixed marriages. Paul's personal preference for continence is framed within his "present distress" and an expectation that the time was short. The subsequent history of Christian virginity should not be projected directly onto this passage. Here, abstinence is an eschatological and missionary choice rather than a monastic institution.

12. Philemon and female invisibility: Apphia and the household

The brief letter to Philemon also greets Apphia and Archippus, in addition to the ekklēsia gathered in the house. Apphia frequently disappears from reconstructions focused exclusively on Philemon and Onesimus. However, her inclusion among the initial recipients suggests that the conflict concerned a broader domestic and communal unit. The house is not a backdrop: it is the space where property, slavery, kinship, and religious gathering intersect.

This supports a prosopographical caution: not every female name can be assigned a position that does not exist in the source, but omitting it reproduces a reverse bias. The method of this monograph records presence, syntactic position, and context before attributing functions.

13. From Paul to the Pauline tradition: Ephesians, Colossians, and Pastoral Epistles

Diachronic comparison reveals a shift towards domestic and institutional stabilisation. The so-called domestic codes of Colossians and Ephesians regulate relationships between wives and husbands, children and parents, and slaves and masters. The Pastoral Epistles, likely written after Paul, address widows, teaching, and female authority with greater intensity. This movement should not be described simply as a "fall" from an original equality, but rather as evidence that the Pauline legacy was reappropriated within communities facing challenges related to reputation, discipline, and generational transmission.

1 Timothy 2:11–15, in particular, should be cited as evidence of Pauline reception and not as a key to automatically reconstructing the Corinthian assemblies several decades earlier. Similarly, Romans 16 should not be idealised as documenting an egalitarian system without hierarchies. The historical reality lies between these two extremes: real female agency within deeply stratified ancient structures.

14. Thecla and the imagination of a Pauline female authority

The Acts of Paul and Thecla, probably from the second century, is not a contemporary source for the historical Paul. However, it is essential to the history of his reception. The figure of Thecla transforms Paul's preaching on continence into a narrative of female autonomy, family conflict, mobility, and teaching. Tertullian (De baptismo 17) testifies that the text could be used in debates about women's authority precisely because some readers treated it as a significant apostolic account.

Thecla must therefore appear in this chapter as a second body of evidence: she does not prove what happened in the communities of the 50s, but she demonstrates what possibilities of agency Christian communities of the second century could imagine when rereading Paul.

15. Women, slavery and domestic vulnerability

The ancient household contained deep-rooted legal hierarchies. Enslaved women could participate in the same assembly as free owners and, at the same time, remain subject to sexual coercion, forced labour, and a lack of legal autonomy. Christian fraternal language did not automatically eliminate these conditions. A social history of women must avoid confusing ritual equality with legal emancipation.

The importance of studying gender and status simultaneously is later observed in figures like Felicity, an enslaved and pregnant woman in the Passio Perpetuae et Felicitatis, or in epitaphs where freedwomen and patron-client relationships continue to structure Christian identity. Although these sources are later than Paul, they help us perceive which dimensions are silenced in letters written from male positions of literacy and authority.

16. Prosopography, networks and centrality: a transparent quantitative model

The women in the undisputed corpus can be incorporated into a social network analysis if a distinction is made between explicit and inferred links. A minimal graph would have people and communities as nodes, and textually attested relationships as edges: collaboration, cohabitation, recommendation, kinship, hospitality, shared imprisonment, or circulation of information. No arbitrary weights would be assigned to theological terms; metrics should be derived from published, reproducible rules.

In an initial model, Prisca and Aquila appear as translocal nodes due to their presence in more than one city; Phoebe as a bridge between Cenchreae and Rome; Euodia and Syntyche as internal collaborators in Philippi; Chloe as an informational node; and Junia and Andronicus as a link to believers whose adherence preceded Paul's. Mathematical centrality does not equate to ecclesiastical hierarchy, but it reveals a density of relationships that a linear reading of the letters would obscure.

17. Historiography: from invisibility to critical reconstruction

Modern historiography on early Christian women has gone through several phases. An initial tradition tended to interpret women's titles through later ministerial categories or to minimise them as informal language. Feminist and social research in the last third of the twentieth century recovered the agency of women as patrons, prophetesses, widows, enslaved women, and domestic leaders. Works by Elisabeth Schüssler Fiorenza, Ross Shepard Kraemer, Margaret Y. MacDonald, Carolyn Osiek, and others shifted the focus from "what office they could hold" to the concrete social conditions of authority, domestic space, kinship, and memory.

The most recent reassessment also demands avoiding a compensatory narrative in which every mention of women is transformed into formal leadership. The standard must be symmetrical: neither minimising nor maximising. Name, verb, title, position in the letter, epigraphic comparison, and urban context constitute the basis for grading certainty.

18. Epigraphy, martyrdom, and female authority in the third and fourth centuries

Evidence later than Paul allows the question to move from literary memory into material culture. Epitaphs, funerary inscriptions, and Christian dedications identify women through kinship, legal status, and, occasionally, titles or functions. Such evidence should be read without automatically converting every designation into an "office" equivalent to ministries standardised in later centuries. Its value lies precisely in revealing local vocabularies of prestige, service, widowhood, patronage, and belonging.

The martyr acts provide a different register. Perpetua and Felicity show, in early third-century Africa, how gender, slavery, maternity, vision, and narrative authority could converge within a single dossier. In the fourth century, the expansion of female asceticism and aristocratic Christian networks made new forms of patronage, foundation, hospitality, and spiritual authority more visible. These forms do not simply continue the Pauline pattern unchanged, but they allow the transformation of women's possibilities for action to be followed across different social and institutional settings.

19. Matrix of prosopographical certainty

TABLE 44. Matrix of prosopographical certainty

Degree	Definition	Example
A	Function or relationship explicitly stated in an authentic letter	Phoebe: διάκονος / προστάτις; Prisca: συνεργός; Euodia and Syntyche: συνεργοί.
B	Strong social inference from documented relationship	Chloe as the head or reference of a house/information network; the mother of Rufus (Rom 16:13) as a figure of fictive kinship and hospitality.
C	Plausible but not explicit hypothesis	Phoebe as the bearer and first oral interpreter of Romans.
D	Useful later reception, not evidence for the historical Paul	Thecla as a Pauline disciple; late ecclesial reconstructions of female offices.

Conclusion

The undisputed Pauline epistles document a female participation that cannot be reduced to a single model. Women pray and prophesy, collaborate in mission, offer homes, protect, carry information, intervene in conflicts, and are remembered for work and imprisonment. The same corpus preserves regulations concerning the body, marriage, and assembly order, showing that this agency operated within patriarchal and slave-owning societies. The historical convergence that characterises this monograph appears here with particular clarity: charismatic authority, domestic patronage, urban mobility, and subsequent institutionalisation do not follow one another as pure stages, but rather overlap and are negotiated.

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Summary

This chapter reconstructs the agency of women in the undisputed Pauline letters through prosopography, philology, and social history. It distinguishes these letters from later Pauline traditions, analyses Phoebe, Prisca, Junia, Euodia, Syntyche, Chloe, and the women who prophesy at Corinth, and examines disputed passages such as 1 Corinthians 14:34–35. Domestic networks, patronage, mobility, prophecy, slavery, and textual reception are treated as overlapping forms of authority, while later ecclesiastical offices are not projected retrospectively onto the Pauline communities.

CHAPTER X

Textual Ecologies of the Second Century: Literature, Science, Administration and Christianities in the Roman Empire

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The second century should not be reconstructed from a retrospective canon of "great authors." Textual circulation depended on language, region, literacy, school networks, private libraries, administration, associations, and copying markets. The aim of this chapter is to situate Christian literature within a broader documentary ecology: Latin historiography, the Greek Second Sophistic, philosophy, medicine, astronomy, legal and administrative texts, Jewish traditions, and diverse Christian production. Comparison helps measure both cultural continuity and innovation.

1. What does it mean to say that a text "circulated"?

For the ancient world, circulation did not mean mass production. It could mean public reading, school copying, private lending, transmission through patronage networks, preservation in libraries, or indirect reception through citation. Therefore, rankings such as "most read texts" should be avoided unless specific evidence exists. The history of the book in the second century deals with uneven survival: Egypt preserves papyri that other regions have lost, and authors transmitted through late antique education survive better than popular or administrative literature.

2. Latin literature: imperial memory, satire and administration

TABLE 45. Latin literature: imperial memory, satire and administration

Author	Works	Chronology	Relevance to the Christian context
Tacitus	Historiae; Annales; Agricola; Germania	c. 98–120	Senatorial historiography; Tac., Ann. XV.44 is a late external testimony about Neronian repression.
Pliny the Younger	Epistulae; Panegyricus	c. 100–113	Plin. Iun., Ep. X.96–97 documents provincial procedure against Christians in Bithynia-Pontus.
Suetonius	De vita Caesarum	c. 120	Suet., Claud. 25.4 and Suet., Ner. 16.2 form part of the external dossier on Jews and Christians, with distinct interpretive problems.
Juvenal	Saturae	c. 100–130	Urban satire; useful for morality, clientele, poverty, and social representation, not as a neutral mirror.
Fronto	Epistulae / speeches	mid-second century	Latin rhetoric and the Antonine circle; Christian tradition also preserves the memory of pagan criticisms associated with his name.
Aulus Gellius	Noctes Atticae	c. 160–180	Scholarly culture, reading, schools, and literary memory.

Apuleius	Metamorphoses; Apologia	c. 150–180	Religion, magic, initiation and social mobility in North Africa.

Second-century Latin literature primarily illuminates the West, Italy, and the imperial administration. In the eastern provinces, intellectual life remained predominantly Greek. The importance of Pliny, Tacitus, and Suetonius for Christian history derives less from the volume of information they provide than from their independence from ecclesiastical memory.

3. The Second Sophistic and Greek literature

The so-called Second Sophistic articulated a culture of rhetorical performance, civic identity, and the recovery of the Hellenic past. Herodes Atticus, Aelius Aristides, Lucian of Samosata, and others show that the second century was a period of intense production of speeches, public display of learning and cultural competition. Christian communities existed within this ecosystem, not in a purely religious vacuum.

Table 46. The Second Sophistic and Greek literature: authors

Author	**Corpus**	**Chronology**	**Contextual value**
Plutarch	Vitae parallelae; Moralia	late first century–first third of the second century	Ethics, religion, biography and philosophy; a useful comparison for the moral culture of elites.
Dio Chrysostom	Orationes	late first century–early second century	The city, kingship, popular philosophy and the mobility of the orator.
Epictetus / Arrian	Discourses; Enchiridion	first third of the second century	Stoic ethics, self-discipline, and oral teaching written down by a disciple.
Arrian	Anabasis Alexandri and other works	second century	Historiographical model and memory of leadership.

(continued)

Author	Corpus	Chronology	Contextual value
Lucian of Samosata	Peregrinus; Alexander; dialogues	c. 160–180	Critique of prophets, charlatans, and religious groups; Peregrinus offers a satirical view of Christians.
Pausanias	Periegesis Hellados	c. 150–180	Religious landscape, sanctuaries and local memory.
Aelius Aristides	Sacred Tales and orations	second century	Religious experience, healing, and the rhetoric of Asclepius.

4. Science, medicine and cosmography: Galen and Ptolemy

Galen and Claudius Ptolemy remind us that the intellectual history of the second century is not limited to philosophy and religion. Galen produced a vast body of medical and philosophical work; his reflections on demonstration, schools, and textual authority provide important context for understanding how the ancients evaluated rival traditions. Ptolemy systematised astronomy, geography, and mathematical astrology. Christian vocabulary concerning cosmos, body, and nature circulated within a world where technical disciplines possessed their own criteria for proof and transmission.

Comparisons must be functional. No direct dependence of a Christian author on Galen or Ptolemy will be asserted here without textual evidence. Their usefulness lies in reconstructing the horizon of specialised literacy and the coexistence of different forms of knowledge.

5. Second-century Judaism: from the catastrophe of 70 to rabbinic reorganisation

The second century in Jewish history was marked by the memory of the destruction of the Temple, the Diaspora rebellions, and the Bar Kokhba revolt. The traditions that would culminate in the Mishnah should not be imagined as a fixed book throughout the century. Rather, they were the product of a process of teaching, discussion, and compilation associated with rabbinic circles whose authority grew unevenly. The redaction of the Mishnah is conventionally placed towards the end of the second or the beginning of the third century under Judah ha-Nasi.

The Septuagint continued to circulate among Greek-speaking communities, while Jewish translations such as those associated with Aquila reflected new needs for precision and exegetical debate. The relationship between Judaism and Christianity remained regionally variable; therefore, textual history must avoid the illusion of two completely separate libraries.

6. Apostolic Fathers: a corpus created retrospectively

The label "Apostolic Fathers" is modern and brings together heterogeneous texts that their authors did not conceive of as a unified collection. Ignatius writes en route to martyrdom; 1 Clement intervenes in a Corinthian conflict; the Didache combines ethical instruction, ritual discipline, and organisation; the Shepherd of Hermas articulates visions, commandments, and parables; Polycarp writes from Smyrna; Papias survives only fragmentarily through later transmission. The value of the label is heuristic, not ontological.

Table 47. Apostolic Fathers: texts

Text	Approximate date	Setting	Main historical problem
1 Clement	c. 90–100	Rome/Corinth	Authority, apostolic memory, community order.
Didache	late first–second century; composition debated	Syria?	Two Ways, baptism, fasting, eucharist, itinerant prophets.

(continued)

Text	Approximate date	Setting	Main historical problem
Ignatius of Antioch	c. 110–113, disputed date	Antioch-Asia Minor-Rome	Episcopate, unity, martyrdom, networks of churches.
Polycarp to the Philippians	first third of the second century	Smyrna/Philippi	Pauline reception and discipline.
Shepherd of Hermas	first half of the second century	Rome	Prophecy, penance, domestic economy, visions.
2 Clement	mid-second century?	disputed origin	Early Christian homily, ethics and eschatology.
Papias	first third of the second century	Hierapolis	Oral memory of Jesus and the Gospels; preserved in fragments.

7. Apologists and negotiation with imperial culture

In the mid-second century, an apologetic literature emerged, adopting forms of petition, philosophical discourse, and religious polemic. Justin Martyr is central because he combines defence before the authorities, exegesis, ritual description, and debate with Judaism. Athenagoras, Tatian, Theophilus of Antioch, and Melito of Sardis show that "apologetics" does not designate a homogeneous school either. Strategies range from appropriation of Greek philosophy and radical critique of pagan culture to petitions for legal recognition.

Justin is particularly important for the history of the book because his "memoirs of the apostles" cannot simply be identified with a closed canon identical to the later one. His testimony belongs to a phase in which certain Gospel narratives possess liturgical authority while the limits of collection remain open.

8. Marcion and the material reorganisation of textual authority

Marcion must be situated within the textual ecology of the second century and not as an external anomaly. His Gospel, Apostolikon, and Antitheses articulate a collection and a reading of apostolic authority. The question of whether he edited Luke or whether his Gospel preserves an earlier form cannot be resolved by the label "heretical"; it requires philological reconstruction based on Tertullian, Epiphanius, and other witnesses, as well as comparison with the Lucan text.

The historical importance of Marcion also lies in the materiality of selecting, ordering, and transmitting a corpus. The second century shows that the canon did not appear all at once: collections, lists, liturgical preferences, and polemics interacted for generations.

9. Irenaeus and the production of a memory of plurality

Adversus haereses is an indispensable and dangerous source. Irenaeus preserves names, fragments, practices, and doctrinal outlines of groups that often do not survive in their own archives, but he does so within a polemical project that constructs genealogies of error and a rule of truth. His defence of the fourfold gospel is a concrete historical intervention, not the neutral description of an original consensus.

Comparison with Nag Hammadi texts has shown that some systems described by heresiologists possessed vocabularies, myths, and practices that were indeed attested, while other categories appear to have been artificially aggregated. Therefore, Irenaeus must be used in two ways: as both witness and constructor.

10. Clement of Alexandria and the end of the second century

Clement of Alexandria stands at the threshold between the second and third centuries. His Protrepticus, Paedagogus, and Stromata reveal a Christian intellectual community engaged in dialogue with philosophy, paideia, exegesis, and asceticism. His work demonstrates that Alexandrian Christianity cannot simply be described as a transition from "Gnosticism" to "orthodoxy": internal boundaries are more porous, and the vocabularies of knowledge, perfection, and allegorical reading are both shared and contested.

11. Non-canonical gospels and revelations: plural literary imagination

The second century produced or transmitted a variety of gospels, acts, apocalypses, and dialogues. The category "apocryphal" is retrospective when used as if the authors knew beforehand that they were writing outside a closed New Testament. The Gospel of Thomas, the Gospel of Peter, the Protoevangelium of James, infancy traditions, the Acts of Paul and Thecla, and Valentinian literature must be studied within a plural literary imagination.

The production of new revelations did not cease when certain collections began to stabilise. Canonisation and creativity are not mutually exclusive processes: they can advance together. This perspective makes it possible to overcome the "illusion of the canon," that is, the modern tendency to order every second-century text according to its final destination within or outside fourth-century lists.

12. Valentinian literature and the limits of "Gnosticism"

Valentinus and authors associated with Valentinian currents share the same world of Christian exegesis as their adversaries. Texts such as the Gospel of Truth, the Tripartite Treatise, or the Gospel of Philip—with distinct problems of authorship and dating—should not be introduced as documents of an already established external religion. In many cases, they reflect intensive reading of Scripture, baptismal language, Christology, and debates on creation and salvation within urban Christian networks.

The critique by Michael A. Williams, Karen King, David Brakke, and Einar Thomassen compels us to abandon overly rigid taxonomies. The category "Gnosticism" can be retained as a historiographical term if it is defined and limited; it should not replace the description of each corpus.

13. Lucian, Peregrinus and Alexander: satire as an external source

Lucian of Samosata is an invaluable external source precisely because he writes with satirical intent. In The Death of Peregrinus, he depicts Christians providing material support to a prisoner and mobilising solidarity; Alexander, or the False Prophet portrays the workings of oracles, credulity, religious competition and the formation of cults. Neither text can be read at face value, but both illuminate how a pagan intellectual could represent new communities and charismatic leaders.

14. Papyri, the codex and the market for copies

The literary history of the second century must come down to the material supports of writing. The growth of the codex among Christians is one of the most debated material features. The earliest surviving Christian papyri are fragmentary and often of broad palaeographical date ranges; they do not allow for precise annual chronologies. P52, P66, P75 and other witnesses must be presented by date ranges and comparison of scribal hands, not as precisely dated fossils.

The production of a codex required materials, time, planning of quires, and scribal work. The graphic quality varied enormously, from relatively competent hands to less formal copies. Rather than inferring the readers' social class directly from this, it is more appropriate to consider material investments and different production contexts. The sociology of the manuscript must distinguish between price, availability, patronage, and scribal skill. The codices themselves are also autonomous evidence: format, nomina sacra and reading aids reveal communal practices that literary texts do not describe (Hurtado 2006).

14.1. Early Christian papyri: content, dating and degree of verification

Table 48. Early Christian papyri: content, dating and degree of verification

Witness	Main content	Usual palaeographic dating	Relevance	Caution
P52 (P.Ryl. III 457)	John 18:31–33, 37–38	first half / mid-second century, range disputed	Early witness to John	Do not set "c. 125" as the exact date.
P46	Pauline Epistles	c. 175–225	Early Pauline collection	It does not prove a universal Pauline canon.
P66	Gospel of John	c. 200, with margin	Copying and correction of the Johannine text	Palaeographic dating is not an absolute year.
P75 (P.Bodmer XIV–XV; now Pap. Hanna 1, Vatican Library)	Luke and John	late second–early third century	Two gospels in one codex	Textual affinity does not imply simple genealogy.
P45	Gospels and Acts	first half of the third century	Collection of Gospels and Acts	Fragmentary state limits reconstruction.

(continued)

Witness	Main content	Usual palaeographic dating	Relevance	Caution
P72	1–2 Peter, Jude and others	third–fourth centuries	Miscellaneous Christian codex	Material coexistence does not equate to formal canon.

15. General overview of the second century

TABLE 49. General overview of the second century

Scope	Authors/texts	Historical function
Latin historiography/ administration	Tacitus, Pliny, Suetonius	Imperial memory, provincial procedure, elites.
Greek rhetoric and philosophy	Plutarch, Dio, Epictetus/ Arrian, Aelius Aristides	Paideia, ethics, performance, civic religion.
Satire and religious criticism	Lucian	Charisma, associations, prophets and external observation of Christians.
Science	Galen, Ptolemy	Demonstration models, body, cosmos, specialisation.
Judaism	Tannaitic traditions, LXX, Aquila	Post-70/135 reorganisation, translation and authority.
Apostolic Fathers	Ignatius, Hermas, Didache, Polycarp, Papias	Local authority, prophecy, ritual, apostolic memory.
Apologists	Justin, Athenagoras, Tatian, Theophilus, Melito	Negotiation with philosophy, power, and pagan opinion.
Collections and controversy	Marcion, Irenaeus	Corpus configuration, fourfold gospel, heresy.
Plural literature	Thomas, Peter, Protoevangelium, Valentinians	Narrative and revelatory imagination beyond future canonical limits.

Conclusion

The second century thus emerges as a densely connected textual ecology. Christian literature did not develop in an isolated chamber, but alongside imperial historiography, rhetoric, medicine, philosophy, Jewish translation, satire, and administration. The consolidation of Christian collections coincided with an extraordinary surge of creativity in gospels, revelations, and commentaries. Recognising this simultaneity dispels two linear narratives: that the canon quickly stifled alternative production, and that Christian identity was constituted outside the cultural practices of the Empire.

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Summary

This chapter reconstructs the textual ecology of the second century in the Roman Empire through Latin historiography, Greek rhetoric and philosophy, science, Jewish traditions, and a wide range of Christian writings. It treats circulation as a social and material process, contextualises the Apostolic Fathers, the apologists, Marcion, Irenaeus, and Valentinian literature, and argues that canon formation

coexisted with continuing literary creativity. Modern commercial categories of authorship, publication, and book distribution cannot simply be mapped onto these ancient conditions of reading and textual circulation.

Annotated Chronology of Christian History (first–fourth centuries)

This chronology does not replace the matrix of synchronisms. It functions as a linear guide to events whose impact significantly altered the memory, organisation, textual production, or material position of Christian communities. Approximate dates are retained as such, and formulations that transform gradual processes into single founding acts are avoided.

First century. Emergence and dispersal

Table 50. First century. Emergence and dispersal

Date	Milestone	Historical significance
c. 30–33	Execution of Jesus of Nazareth	Crucifixion in Jerusalem under the prefect Pontius Pilate. The event constitutes the centre of the passion memory and of the earliest proclamations of resurrection.
c. 30–40	Formation of communities in Jerusalem and Judea	Pauline sources and later narratives allow us to reconstruct an early Jerusalemite core associated with Cephas/Peter, James, and other leaders.
c. 30s	Paul's entry into the movement	Paul describes a revelation or calling that redirected his activity and linked him to the mission among Gentiles; the exact chronology remains approximate.
c. 48–50	Negotiation concerning Gentiles	Galatians 2 and Acts 15 preserve different versions of a real controversy over circumcision, table fellowship, and Gentile membership.

(continued)

Date	Milestone	Historical significance
c. 49	Expulsion of Jews from Rome under Claudius	Suetonius attributes disturbances to "Chrestus"; the specific connection with early Christological disputes is possible, but not certain.
c. 50	1 Thessalonians	Generally considered the oldest surviving Christian letter; it shows the early use of correspondence to maintain translocal communities.
62	Death of James	Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1), links his execution to the actions of the high priest Ananus during a procuratorial interregnum.
64	Neronian repression in Rome	Tacitus links the punishment of Christians to the aftermath of the fire. The evidence shows that the group was identifiable in Rome, not that the entire imperial apparatus already treated it as a legally separate religion.
66–73	First Jewish-Roman War	The war and destruction of the Temple in 70 reshaped multiple Jewish currents and affected groups of followers of Jesus unevenly.

Second century. Authority, collections and differentiation

TABLE 51. Second century. Authority, collections and differentiation

Date	Milestone	Historical significance
c. 96	1 Clement	Rome intervenes in a Corinthian conflict using arguments of order, apostolic memory, and ministerial continuity.
c. 100–120	Didache and Ignatius	Different texts document ritual regulation, itinerant prophecy, local ministries, and a programmatic defence of the episcopate in certain communities.

(continued)

Date	Milestone	Historical significance
c. 110–113	Correspondence between Pliny and Trajan	Earliest surviving administrative dossier on procedure against Christians and external testimony of ritual practices.
132–135	Bar Kokhba Revolt	New political rupture in Judea and reconfiguration of Jerusalem as Aelia Capitolina; its effects on Christian groups must be analysed regionally.
c. 140s	Marcion's activity in Rome	His Evangelion and Apostolikon are early evidence of a delimited collection of Christian writings; it should not be called the "first closed canon" without qualification.
c. 150–165	Justin Martyr	The Apologies and the Dialogue show public reading of "memoirs of the apostles", polemic with Marcion and intellectual negotiation with the Greco-Roman world.
c. 170–180	Celsus	The Alēthēs Logos represents the first major anti-Christian philosophical critique that can be reconstructed in detail.
c. 180	Irenaeus of Lyons	Adversus haereses articulates the rule of truth, episcopal succession and the defence of a fourfold gospel.
late second century	Diversification of Christian literature	Non-canonical gospels, Valentinian works, and other corpora show that circulation and textual delimitation remained open processes.

Third century. Crisis, discipline and material culture

TABLE 52. Third century. Crisis, discipline and material culture

Date	Milestone	Historical significance
c. 200	Earliest surviving major Christian codices	P^{46} and other manuscripts materially show early Christian collections and a preference for the codex.
c. 203	Perpetua and Felicity	The memory of African martyrdom allows us to study gender, status, and visionary authority.
c. 240	Christian building at Dura-Europos	A house adapted with a baptistery and paintings shows community investment in ritual space before Constantine.
249–251	Decius' sacrificial policy	General demand for sacrifice documented by libelli; it provoked a grave crisis among Christians over the lapsi.
257–258	Valerian's measures	Pressure directed more specifically against community leaders and structures.
c. 270–300	Porphyry and anti-Christian criticism	The Porphyrian tradition represents a high level of historical and philological criticism, although the reconstruction of its corpus must be handled with caution.
303–311	Great Persecution	The tetrarchic measures attempt to dismantle institutions, books, and places of worship, with uneven application across regions.
311	Edict of Galerius	It restored toleration and shows that legal change preceded the measures of 313.

Fourth century. Imperial patronage and conciliar normativity

The fourth century should not be read as a linear transition from persecution to a fully formed imperial Church, but as a sequence of legal, material, and doctrinal changes whose intensity varied considerably by region. The Great Persecution begun in 303 left an archive of confiscations, destruction of meeting places, surrender of books, and disputes concerning the lapsi and traditores. Galerius's edict of toleration in 311 and the measures of 313 conventionally associated with "Milan" established a new framework of legality and restitution; they did not amount to the immediate Christianisation of the Empire.

Constantinian patronage nevertheless altered the public scale of particular Christian communities. Restitution of property, clerical privileges, donations, and basilican building programmes created an unprecedented relationship between episcopal institutions and imperial power. Nicaea (325) set an enduring precedent for conciliar deliberation under imperial patronage, although its Christological formula did not end controversy and remained subject to negotiation for decades. Athanasius's Festal Letter 39 (367) is the earliest extant witness to list exactly the twenty-seven books of the present New Testament; its documentary importance does not demonstrate immediate or uniform reception in every church.

Under Theodosius I, Nicene definitions acquired increasing legal support, and several constitutions restricted sacrifice and particular forms of traditional cult. Enforcement, however, was uneven, and non-Christian cults persisted well beyond the fourth century. Laws preserved in the Codex Theodosianus must be cited by the original date of each constitution: the compilation itself dates to 438 and is not a unitary contemporary document of fourth-century events. Key dynamics include imperial patronage, conciliar authority, monumental architecture, the delimitation of scriptural corpora, and the progressive legal regulation of religious identities.

CHAPTER XI

Textual and Intellectual Ecologies of the Third Century: Imperial Crisis, Philology, Controversy, and New Christian Cultures

The third century was not only a time of political and military instability. It was also a period of extraordinary intellectual density in which Christian communities, philosophical schools, Roman jurisprudence, rabbinic tradition, and religious movements of the Eastern Empire developed new forms of knowledge production, classification, and transmission. For the history of Christianity, this century is decisive because it saw the convergence of processes that in the second century were still dispersed: the professionalisation of exegesis, the expansion of libraries, the consolidation of episcopal networks, transregional disciplinary conflicts, and the emergence of authors capable of simultaneously engaging in philology, philosophy, pastoral care, and public debate.

The documentation, however, must be read with particular caution. The so-called "crisis of the third century" did not produce a uniform experience throughout the Empire; the chronologies of civil war, fiscal pressure, epidemics, inflation, and military mobility affected each province differently. Similarly, there is no single Christian culture of the third century. Alexandria, Caesarea, Carthage, Rome, Antioch, and the Syriac communities all exhibit distinct institutional and linguistic profiles. The periodisation that follows uses these differences as an organising principle and avoids turning the century into a teleological prelude to Nicaea.

1. Tertullian and the formation of a Latin Christian vocabulary

Tertullian offers a particularly revealing linguistic laboratory for Latin Christianity. His work, composed between the end of the second century and the first decades of the third, shows how theological, legal, and ritual categories of Greek origin were translated, reformulated and, at times, displaced by the Latin lexicon. Apologeticum, Adversus Marcionem, De praescriptione haereticorum, De baptismo, De oratione, and the disciplinary treatises should not be read as pieces of a homogeneous system. Their chronologies, intended audiences, and shifts in position necessitate the reconstruction of an intellectual and ecclesial trajectory.

His historiographical value lies both in what he affirms and in the adversaries he presupposes. The polemic against Marcion shows that Marcionite communities remained real interlocutors; the discussions on discipline, prophecy, the female veil, marriage, and penance reveal internal disagreements that a retrospective history of "orthodoxy" tends to flatten. Tertullian also offers a privileged case for studying the relationship between forensic rhetoric, categories of private law, and ecclesiastical language, without implying that the Church had already acquired a uniform legal personality.

2. Cyprian of Carthage: episcopate, crisis and correspondence as a social archive

The Cyprianic documentation provides unusually detailed evidence for reconstructing an episcopal network in the Latin West during the mid-third century. His letters, *De lapsis*, and De unitate ecclesiae are situated at the crossroads of persecution, penitential discipline, financial assistance, and the negotiation of authority. The persecution of Decius and the issue of the lapsed generated specific procedures: certificates, intercessions of confessors, synods, letters of recommendation, and disputes over the pace of readmission. It is not merely a matter of penitential theology; it is an archive of community logistics and the administration of people.

Cyprian's correspondence allows for a network analysis of the transmitted dossier. Carthage links African communities, Rome, and other Mediterranean centres, but the frequency of letters does not, in itself, establish institutional primacy. The prosopographical appendix offers a pilot network with sources and reproducible metrics; the direction of exchange and the preservation of each letter are recorded separately from the simplified graph representation.

2.1. Documentary infrastructure and social network analysis (SNA): the Cyprianic epistolary archive as a system of flows

The correspondence attributed to Cyprian of Carthage forms one of the densest epistolary archives of third-century Latin Christianity. Its value lies not only in penitential or ecclesiological theology: letters, delegations, messengers, and synods support reconstruction of a system of information circulation between Africa, Rome, Hispania, and the East. The following model does not transform the preserved correspondence into a complete picture of the historical network; it represents only explicit or strongly documented relationships within the transmitted corpus.

SNA protocol. Node = identifiable person, community, or episcopal see; edge = epistolary link or documented delegation; direction = sending/receiving when it can be established; weight = number of loci selected in the verification dossier, not total volume of historical communication. The metrics express the structure of the modelled corpus and not an actual ecclesiastical hierarchy.

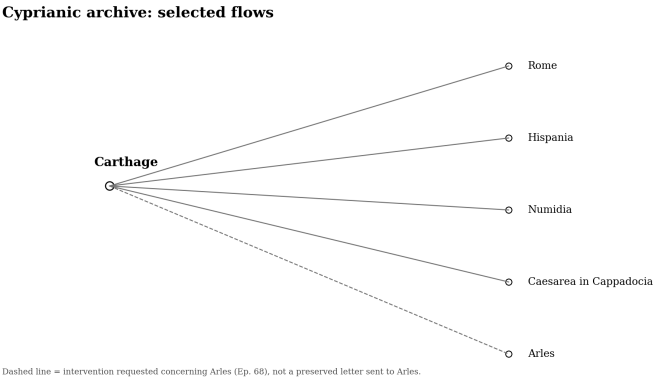


Figure 24 (SNA-2). Selected flows from the Cyprianic archive. Restrained analytical visualisation of documented exchanges; the dashed line to Arles indicates the intervention requested from Stephen of Rome (Ep. 68), not a preserved letter sent to Arles.

The term "Cyprianic archive" here designates the transmitted collection of correspondence associated with Cyprian, not a fully preserved ancient administrative archive. The usual numbering comprises 81 letters dating from approximately 249–258. It contains writings by Cyprian, synodal letters, and letters from other correspondents; the conventional attribution distinguishes 59 letters by him, 6 synodal letters, and 16 by other authors (Letters 1–81, Fathers of the Church 51). Its order and delimitation depend on manuscript transmission and editorial work.

Preservation is asymmetrical. A response may mention an inquiry whose original has been lost. Ep. 67 responds to a Hispanic request; Ep. 75 transmits Firmilian's letter and refers to a communication received through Rogatian. Ep. 62 documents an inquiry and a collection to ransom captives; "Numidia" is a regional aggregation of the identified recipients, not a single administrative interlocutor. For this reason, its metrics are presented solely as a property of the aggregated graph and are not substantively compared with those of episcopal sees or individuals defined at another scale. A bidirectional link in the scheme may include both a preserved letter and the explicit reference to another communication.

Ep. 68 requires a further distinction: Cyprian writes to Stephen of Rome about Marcian of Arles and requests letters of intervention. Arles is the subject of the letter, not its recipient. This is why the scheme differentiates the preserved exchange with Rome from the requested action towards Arles. Visual proximity and metrics describe the documentary selection; they do not establish territorial allegiance, demographics, or uniform legal authority.

Matrix SNA-C1. Selected documentary flows from the Cyprianic archive

Table 53. Selected documentary flows from the Cyprianic archive

Axis	Verification loci	Documentary function	SNA reading and caution
Carthage ↔ Rome	Ep. 20; 30; 36; 49; 50; 59; 68; 72 (selection)	Penance, Cornelius/ Novatian, rebaptism, recognition and contested authority	Axis of greatest density in the dossier; bidirectional and competitive relationship.
Recipients of Ep. 62 (Numidia; regional aggregation) ↔ Carthage	Ep. 62; African conciliar dossiers	Ransoming of captives, collection, regional discipline	Explicit regional aggregation for visualising the dossier; its centrality is not interpreted as equivalent to that of episcopal sees or individuals. Carthage functions as a coordination node, not as an absolute legal capital.
Carthage ↔ Caesarea of Cappadocia	Ep. 75 (Firmilian)	Eastern coalition in the baptismal controversy	Interregional bridge; shows circulation of arguments beyond the African-Roman axis.

(continued)

Axis	Verification loci	Documentary function	SNA reading and caution
Carthage ↔ Hispania	Ep. 67	Query about Basilides and Martial	Supra-regional intervention requested by local actors; it does not equate to stable territorial jurisdiction.
Carthage → Rome; Arles as the subject of the letter	Ep. 68, addressed to Stephen	The Marcian case; request for letters of intervention	Arles appears in the graph as an inferred relationship (E2): no letter sent directly to that see is preserved here.

Methodological result. Carthage emerges as a node with high betweenness centrality because the preserved archive concentrates the sending, receipt, and copying of correspondence there. This documentary centrality does not, in itself, demonstrate an African "primacy" or the existence of a centralised administration. The network serves to visualise dependence on messengers, transit times, coalitions, and competition among episcopal sees.

3. Novatian and the dispute over the purity of the Church

Novatian illustrates the fragility of the later categories of "schism" and "heresy." His *De Trinitate* shares broad doctrinal assumptions with other Latin authors, while the conflict between him and Cornelius centred on episcopal authority and the discipline of reconciliation. The controversy demonstrates that the creation of ecclesial boundaries did not depend solely on Christological differences. It could also arise from rival elections, local legitimacies, and incompatible models of penance.

Sources on Novatian largely come from adversaries or later ecclesiastical narratives. Therefore, any reconstruction must distinguish between the self-understanding of his communities and the labels imposed by rival networks. The persistence of Novatianist communities for centuries confirms that this was not an ephemeral deviation, but an alternative ecclesial structure with its own episcopate, places of worship, and a memory of its own.

4. Origen: library, Hexapla and professionalisation of Christian philology

The work of Origen represents the most important qualitative leap in pre-Constantinian Christian philology. His activity in Alexandria and Caesarea combined biblical commentary, teaching, polemics, comparative editing, and library work. The project known as the Hexapla should not be imagined as a modern "critical Bible," but rather as an extraordinary device for textual comparison: Hebrew, Greek transliteration, and various Greek versions were aligned to expose divergences and translation problems.

Against Celsus, On First Principles, the commentaries, and the homilies reveal an intellectual culture that engages with philosophy, grammar, and literary criticism. The importance of Origen for this book lies not in making him a doctrinal arbiter, but in observing how a Christian community could develop complex philological procedures before imperial patronage. Biblical variants appear as problems of interpretation, not as marginal incidents. At the same time, the subsequent transmission of Origen—including Latin translations, condemnations, and selective extracts—necessitates distinguishing between the original work, its reception, and modern reconstruction.

5. Clement of Alexandria, Gregory Thaumaturgus and intellectual pedagogy

Clement of Alexandria, whose activity extended into the early third century, linked biblical exegesis, ethics, Greek paideia, and social critique. His Protrepticus, Paedagogus, and Stromata do not simply form a systematic "trilogy"; they reveal distinct registers of pedagogical intervention. Read together, they illuminate the social composition of educated urban audiences, debates over wealth, marriage, food and clothing, and the selective use of philosophy as a conceptual repertoire.

Gregory Thaumaturgus, for his part, offers a disciple's memory of Origen's school. His speech of gratitude to Origen combines praise, intellectual autobiography, and the construction of authority. The comparison between the two authors helps to avoid an abstract representation of the "school of Alexandria" and to reconstruct personal trajectories, movements, and teaching networks.

6. Hippolytus and the problem of attributions

The name of Hippolytus of Rome encapsulates one of the classic problems of attribution in early Christian literature. The Refutatio omnium haeresium, exegetical works, and the so-called Traditio Apostolica were long treated as the coherent output

of a single Roman author. Modern scholarship has shown that this simplification is untenable. For historical purposes, each work must be evaluated separately and not used as a transparent window onto a single, third-century "Church of Rome."

The Apostolic Tradition is especially important because its liturgical prescriptions have frequently been used to reconstruct baptism, ordination, and the Eucharist. Its textual and compositional history, however, is complex. It is therefore treated here as a layered ecclesiastical tradition, not as a normative enactment straightforwardly datable to the Roman activity of a historical Hippolytus.

7. Dionysius of Alexandria and episcopal communication

Dionysius of Alexandria is known largely through fragments and letters preserved by Eusebius. This mediation conditions the evidence, but does not diminish its value. His interventions in debates on rebaptism, persecution, discipline, and doctrinal controversies reveal an Eastern network of episcopal correspondence that extends beyond a single city. Eusebius's selection should be treated as an edited archive: it preserves documents while simultaneously rearranging them within a narrative of the Church's past.

8. Methodius of Olympus, virginity and exegetical competition

Methodius's Banquet of the Ten Virgins shows that Christian asceticism could appropriate prestigious classical literary forms. The imitation of Plato's *Symposium* does not constitute an automatic doctrinal continuity with Platonism; it is a literary and rhetorical choice. The text is particularly useful for studying represented female authority, virginity, the body, and exegesis in an environment where ascetic discourse was acquiring increasing centrality.

9. Martyrdom, records and documentation of coercion

The third century produced a martyrdom archive whose reading requires distinguishing between acts with a possible documentary basis, literary compositions, and hagiographic reworkings. The Passio Perpetuae et Felicitatis, dating from the beginning of the century, combines first-person sections, narrative editing, and a theological construction of martyrdom. Its exceptional nature should not be overlooked: precisely for this reason, it is a primary source for studying gender, visionary authority, family, imprisonment, and community memory.

During the persecutions of Decius and Valerian, papyrus and epistolary documentation permits a contrast between martyrial rhetoric and administrative procedure. The sacrificial libelli show formulae, names, witnesses, and local bureaucracy. They do not, in themselves, record "Christian persecution" in every case, but they permit reconstruction of how ritual compliance was verified and how specific civic commissions functioned.

10. Plotinus and Neoplatonism as a documented historical context

Plotinus belongs to the intellectual horizon of the third century and should be treated as such, without turning Neoplatonism into a secret key to explaining Christianity. The Enneads, edited by Porphyry after the master's death, reveal debates about the soul, intellect, unity, and philosophical ascent that circulated in learned circles of the Empire. Certain Christian authors may have shared vocabulary or problems with these schools, but each convergence requires specific textual evidence.

This book maintains a firm methodological separation: the historical presence of Middle and Late Platonisms is indispensable for understanding the intellectual landscape, but it does not justify esoteric genealogies or doctrinal equivalences. Comparison is restricted to concepts, teaching networks, and situations of explicit controversy.

11. Porphyry and the scholarly critique of Christianity

Porphyry is one of the most sophisticated critics of early Christianity. His *Against the Christians* survives only in fragments, and its reconstruction depends on Christian responses and later testimonies. This state of transmission prevents us from quoting it as if we possessed a continuous text. However, the information we have about his arguments—including the Maccabean dating of Daniel—reveals a critique based on philology, chronology, and literary coherence, not solely on religious mockery.

The case of Daniel is especially significant because it shows that issues associated with modern biblical criticism—dating, prophecy ex eventu, textual layers—could already be formulated in antiquity. The comparison between the Masoretic Text, the Greek versions, and the Qumran fragments should be presented as a history of transmission and interpretation, avoiding attributing anachronistic methodological categories to Porphyry.

12. Philostratus and the literary construction of Apollonius of Tyana

The Life of Apollonius of Tyana, written by Philostratus at the beginning of the third century, is a central source for studying the literary construction of the "divine man." Its relationship to Jesus should not be framed as either dependence or equivalence. The comparative interest lies in the narrative techniques: travels, teaching, asceticism, miracles, conflicts with authorities, and posthumous memory. The work was later used in anti-Christian polemics, but its original purpose cannot be reduced to a response to the Gospels.

13. Cassius Dio and the political memory of the Empire

Cassius Dio's Roman History provides a valuable senatorial account of imperial politics, although its social location and chronological perspective differ markedly from those of Christian sources. Here it is used chiefly in political and military contexts, especially where it supplements or corrects chronologies transmitted by ecclesiastical authors. Its evidentiary value depends on comparison with inscriptions, papyri, and other historians, not on any presumption of neutrality.

14. Mani and the formation of a trans-imperial religion

Mani's preaching from the mid-third century onward generated a religious tradition that crossed linguistic and political boundaries. His communities used Syriac, Middle Persian, and other languages, and developed an extraordinarily mobile manuscript culture. Manichaeism interacted with Christian, Iranian, and Mesopotamian vocabulary, but it must be distinguished from the second-century Christian movements that ancient heresiology and modern historiography indiscriminately grouped under labels such as "Gnostics" and "Gnosticism."

The inclusion of Manichaeism in this history is justified by religious competition and by the way fourth-century Christian authors perceived it, not because it constitutes a branch of Christianity. Augustine's biography also reminds us that the boundaries between communities could be crossed by individuals in the course of a lifetime.

15. Mishnah, Tosefta and rabbinic recomposition

The compilation of the Mishnah around the beginning of the third century and the formation of Tannaitic corpora offer an indispensable counterpoint. The history of rabbinic Judaism should not be narrated as a mere inverted mirror of Christian episcopal development. Rabbinic collections respond to their own processes of memory, legal classification, and authority. Their comparison with Christian texts is only valid when chronology, genre, and context of transmission are taken into account.

16. Jurisprudence, rescripts and the language of administration

The third century was also the era of great late classical jurisprudence. Papinian, Ulpian, Paulus, and other jurists formulated categories that encompassed administration, property, associations, and personal status. Christian communities existed within this legal order, even though they did not possess a single, unified legal status. To understand confiscations, restitution of property, or the liability of associations, it is preferable to work with specific legal documents rather than with the anachronistic label of religio licita/illicita as if it were a general statute.

(continued)

Author / corpus	Language	Chronology	Main value	Critical caution

17. Verification table: third-century authors and corpora

TABLE 54. Verification table: authors and corpora of the third century

Author / corpus	Language	Chronology	Main value	Critical caution
Tertullian	Latin	c. 195–220	Apologetics, polemic, discipline	Distinguish phases and genres; do not use him as a uniform spokesperson for Carthage.
Clement of Alexandria	Greek	c. 190–215	Paideia, ethics, exegesis	Activity spanning the second and third centuries; do not treat the "school" as a stable institution without evidence.
Origen	Greek	c. 210–253	Exegesis, philology, controversy	Separate originals, translations, and subsequent reception.
Hippolytus / Hippolytan corpora	Greek	third century	Heresiology, exegesis, discipline	Problems of authorship and stratification.
Cyprian	Latin	248–258	Letters, discipline, episcopacy	An exceptional archive, but situated within specific conflicts.
Novatian	Latin	c. 250	Theology and discipline	Do not reduce his movement to a schismatic caricature.
Dionysius of Alexandria	Greek	mid-third century	Episcopal correspondence	Fragmentary preservation, mainly via Eusebius.
Plotinus	Greek	c. 245–270	Philosophy	Intellectual context, not automatic genealogy of Christianity.
Porphyry	Greek	late third century	Philosophy and religious criticism	Contra Christianos fragmentary; indirect reconstruction.

(continued)

Author / corpus	Language	Chronology	Main value	Critical caution
Philostratus	Greek	c. 220s	Cultural biography	Apollonius as a literary construct; disciplined typological comparison.
Mani and the early Manichaeans	Syriac/Middle Persian	from c. 240	Revelation, transregional mission	Own tradition; interaction with Christianity without identification.
Mishnah / Tannaitic tradition	Hebrew	c. 200 and later	Rabbinic law and memory	Chronology and internal stratification are essential.

18. Conclusion: the third century as a century of archives

The main transformation of the third century cannot be summarised as simply the "consolidation of the Church." What changes is the density of the archives. Episcopal letters, administrative forms, biblical commentaries, polemical treatises, disciplinary manuals, and legal corpora reveal institutions and conflicts with far greater granularity than in the first century. This documentary abundance also produces an illusion of homogeneity: we know certain centres better precisely because they preserved more texts. A critical history must resist this asymmetry and treat the silence of other regions as a limit of evidence, not as proof of absence.

CHAPTER XII

Textual Ecologies of the Fourth Century: Councils, Legislation, Translation and Intellectual Plurality in the Christianised Empire

The fourth century radically transformed the material and political conditions of Christian textual production. Imperial tolerance, patronage, conciliar disputes, and the monumentalisation of cities increased the capacity of certain churches to preserve archives, finance copies, and transform local controversies into imperial debates. However, the century should not be narrated as a linear progression from persecution to "official" status. The coexistence of cults, Christian rivalries, the shifting policies of different emperors, and the persistence of non-Christian philosophical and ritual traditions necessitate the reconstruction of a plural and contested landscape.

The literature of the period reflects this complexity. Eusebius, Athanasius, Basil, the two Gregorys, Hilary, Ambrose, Jerome, Ephrem, Cyril of Jerusalem, Epiphanius, and John Chrysostom do not form a unified voice. Their works reflect different cities, languages, patronages, and conflicts. Alongside them, Ammianus Marcellinus, Libanius, Themistius, Julian, Symmachus, and other authors continue to demonstrate the vitality of non-Christian traditions.

1. Lactantius between apologetics and imperial politics

Lactantius occupies a transitional position between pre-Constantinian apologetics and the new proximity between Christian intellectuals and the imperial court. *Divinae Institutiones* adapts forms of philosophical argumentation and Latin rhetoric to a systematic defence of Christianity. *De mortibus persecutorum*, on the other hand, must be read with particular caution: its account of the persecutors is structured by a retributive theology and does not constitute a neutral chronicle. Precisely for this reason, it is a privileged source for studying how the memory of the persecution was reshaped after Constantine's victory.

2. Eusebius of Caesarea: archive, history and construction of continuity

The Ecclesiastical History is an indispensable source for the study of the first three centuries because it preserves letters, lists, extracts, and information lost through other channels. Its documentary richness, however, does not neutralise its historiographical programme. Eusebius selects, edits, and links materials to construct a history of apostolic continuity, expansion, and victory. In this book, each document transmitted by Eusebius is treated both as an ancient testimony and as an element of a fourth-century narrative edition.

Vita Constantini presents different problems. Imperial praise, the theology of power, and the author's access to certain documents require distinguishing between literary genre, archive, and panegyric. The contrast with legislation, epigraphy, and other sources precludes treating the work as a transparent biography of Constantine.

3. Nicaea and the documentary production of the council

The Council of Nicaea of 325 produced a body of texts whose subsequent transmission was crucial: a creed, canons, letters, and historiographical accounts. The term homoousios acquired retrospective centrality, but its reception was conflicted and variable. The documentary history of Nicaea must trace not only what happened in 325, but also how the actors of the following decades reconstructed the council as a point of reference.

The conciliar activity of the fourth century can be analysed as a technology of imperial communication: convocations, journeys, subscriptions, depositions, restitutions, and the circulation of doctrinal formulas. Without reducing theology to administration, this perspective helps explain why an episcopal controversy could become a problem of territorial governance.

4. Athanasius of Alexandria: controversy, archive and memory of Nicaea

Athanasius was one of the principal architects of Nicene memory. His Discourses Against the Arians, Apologies, and Festal Letters show how a doctrinal position is constructed through exegesis, episcopal networks, and the narratives of adversaries. The label "Arian" must be used with care because it encompasses actors whose positions were not identical. Athanasius's work is an indispensable source, but also an active participant in the production of these categories.

Athanasius's Festal Letter 39 (367) is of particular importance to the history of the canon because it lists the twenty-seven books that would later constitute the New Testament. However, it should not be presented as the universal moment of the "closure of the canon." The letter documents the position of an Alexandrian bishop and his network; other communities preserved different repertoires and textual hierarchies.

5. Life of Antony and the textualisation of asceticism

The Vita Antonii, attributed to Athanasius, shows how desert asceticism was translated into a biographical form capable of widespread circulation. The text is not a snapshot of Egyptian monastic life. It constructs a model of holiness, bodily discipline, demonological combat, and the relationship with episcopal authority. Its dissemination helped transform local practices into transregional repertoires of imitation.

6. The Cappadocians and the precision of the Trinitarian vocabulary

Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nazianzus, and Gregory of Nyssa developed theological vocabularies that allowed for a more precise differentiation between ousia and hypostasis than in the decades immediately following Nicaea. Their historical importance lies not only in "resolving" the controversy but also in demonstrating the linguistic work necessary to stabilise these distinctions. Basil's On the Holy Spirit, Gregory of Nazianzus's Theological Orations, and Gregory of Nyssa's Against Eunomius must be read in relation to specific interlocutors, synods, and episcopal networks.

The Latin reception of these debates introduced new problems of terminological equivalence. Substantia, essentia, and persona do not simply overlap with ousia and hypostasis. The book's institutional glossary incorporates these semantic shifts to prevent modern translation from obliterating the conflicts of the fourth century.

7. Hilary of Poitiers and the western circulation of eastern controversies

De Trinitate and Hilary's historical writings show that the so-called Arian controversy was not exclusively Eastern. Translations, embassies, exiles, and synods transported doctrinal formulas between languages and regions. Hilary thus serves as a witness to a central problem: the imperfect circulation of Greek technical terms in Latin contexts.

8. Ambrose of Milan: episcopate, court and urban culture

Ambrose represents a distinct form of episcopal authority, linked to an imperial capital and conflicts with the court. In *De officiis ministrorum*, he explicitly reworks a Ciceronian title and genre, demonstrating that the Christianisation of Latin culture did not consist in abandoning the classical canon. His hymns, letters, and treatises illuminate liturgy, discipline, assistance, and urban politics without making the bishop the automatic representative of the entire Christian population.

9. Jerome: translation, library and textual authority

Jerome's work is crucial to the history of Latin biblical translation. To speak of the Vulgate as a single, unified work produced all at once by a single author oversimplifies a complex process. Jerome revised and translated various books at different times, worked with Hebrew and Greek, and debated criteria for textual authority. His prologues, letters, and commentaries are primary sources for studying libraries, Jewish scholars, translation practices, and tensions between versions.

De viris illustribus, composed in 392/393, is also an instrument of literary memory. By constructing a genealogy of Christian authors, Jerome participates in the retrospective definition of a canon of writers. This gesture should be compared with bibliographical lists, ecclesiastical catalogues, and citation practices, not confused with a neutral description of the intellectual field.

10. Ephrem the Syrian and a Christian ecology that is neither Greek nor Latin

Ephrem reminds us that fourth-century Christianity cannot be reduced to the Greek-Latin axis. His hymns and commentaries in Syriac develop a poetic theology deeply linked to liturgy, controversy, and biblical memory. The metrical and performative form of his texts modifies the relationship between doctrine and audience. Ephrem also offers an entry point to Christian networks in Mesopotamia and to contact with Persian, Manichaean, and Judeo-Christian communities.

11. Cyril of Jerusalem and catechesis as a ritual archive

The Catecheses attributed to Cyril of Jerusalem support reconstruction of fourth-century baptismal pedagogy, although their problems of transmission and partial authorship must be addressed. The corpus shows how creed, exegesis, architecture, and ritual sequence could be articulated in a programme of initiation. Instead of treating the liturgy as a timeless set of formulas, these homilies situate it within specific spaces, calendars, and audiences.

12. Epiphanius of Salamis and the taxonomy of heresy

The Panarion is one of the great heresiological archives of Late Antiquity and, at the same time, one of the most problematic. Epiphanius preserves valuable materials, quotations from lost works, and local traditions, but organises them within a polemical taxonomy that multiplies groups and genealogies. Its information is therefore used only after quotation, paraphrase, rumour, and classificatory construction have been distinguished from one another.

13. John Chrysostom: preaching, city and social conflict

The activity of John Chrysostom, from the late fourth century onward, offers an exceptional window into the urban audiences of Antioch and Constantinople. His homilies contain references to wealth, theatre, charity, gender, Judaism, festivals, and domestic practices. They should be read as persuasive speeches, not as sociological surveys. Indeed, the preacher's insistence may indicate that the behaviours he condemned were still common among some of his audience.

14. Ammianus Marcellinus and a non-ecclesiastical history of the fourth century

Ammianus Marcellinus's Res Gestae is indispensable for avoiding a history of the fourth century constructed solely from Christian authors. His account of emperors, wars, cities, and religious conflicts offers a distinct perspective, with its own biases and historiographical conventions. Comparing Ammianus's work with ecclesiastical sources reveals discrepancies in scale and causality.

15. Julian: imperial criticism of Christianity

Julian's speeches, letters and Against the Galileans show that intellectual opposition to Christianity continued after Constantine. The text Against the Galileans is preserved primarily through Cyril of Alexandria's refutation, so its reconstruction must acknowledge this mediation. Julian combines exegesis, philosophy, cultic politics, and an educational programme; reducing him to the epithet "Apostate" obscures the content of his project.

16. Libanius, Themistius and the persistence of paideia

Libanius and Themistius demonstrate the vitality of non-Christian rhetoric and philosophy in an empire where Christians were gaining increasing prominence. Their speeches and letters support reconstruction of the history of education, patronage, cities, and relations with emperors. The persistence of this paideia (education) refutes any narrative that the fourth century saw the immediate replacement of classical culture with an exclusively Christian one.

17. Symmachus and the controversy of the Altar of Victory

Symmachus's Relationes, especially the third, and Ambrose's responses document a conflict concerning cultic tradition, senatorial space, and imperial patronage. This episode illuminates how arguments from antiquity, public utility and tolerance were mobilised by different actors. It should not be presented as a simple duel between "paganism" and "Christianity," but rather as a negotiation of resources, symbols, and political legitimacy within an urban elite.

18. Augustine on the threshold of the fifth century

The Confessions, composed around 397–400, stand at the end of the period examined here and form a threshold to the fifth century. Their importance lies in the autobiographical, philosophical, and biblical density with which they reconstruct a trajectory through Manichaeism, rhetorical education, Platonism, and Nicene Christianity. The work is treated not as a mirror of ordinary Christian experience but as an exceptional document of intellectual mobility and retrospective memory.

19. Prudentius, Ausonius and Claudian: poetry in a pluralistic religious world

Late Latin poetry reveals formal continuities that belie any abrupt cultural substitution. Ausonius, Prudentius, and Claudian all employed classical metres, genres, and repertoires from different religious perspectives. Comparison shows how their shared literary education survived transformations in patronage and cult.

20. Imperial constitutions, the Codex Theodosianus and the legal archive

Although the Codex Theodosianus was promulgated in 438, it preserves fourth-century constitutions that are fundamental for studying clerical privileges, property, heresy, cults, and administration. Each law must be cited by date, addressee, and context, avoiding reading the code as a contemporary snapshot of uniform policy. The gap between norm and practice is a central historical question.

The constitutions of Constantine, Constantius II, Valentinian, Valens, Gratian, and Theodosius show changes in orientation and internal conflicts. The so-called Edict of Thessalonica of 380 (CTh 16.1.2) is important, but it does not in itself amount to the instantaneous disappearance of other forms of Christianity or other cults.

21. Constantinople 381 and the incomplete stabilisation

The Council of Constantinople of 381 occupies a central place in subsequent doctrinal memory. Its canons and the history of the reception of the creed must be carefully distinguished. The direct attribution of the so-called "Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed" to the council requires documentary nuance. The historical importance of 381 lies both in episcopal and jurisdictional decisions and in the subsequent use of the council to narrate doctrinal continuity.

21.1. Donatism: persecution, traditio and ecclesial legitimacy

The Donatist conflict belongs to fourth-century Africa and must be explained in terms of the memory of the Great Persecution, accusations of traditio, the legitimacy of ordinations and imperial intervention. It does not constitute an automatic continuation of the "Gnosticisms" of the second century.

21.2. Arius and post-Nicene plurality

Arius was an Alexandrian presbyter whose controversy with Alexander culminated in Nicaea. "Arianism" is a retrospective label useful only with caution: after 325, diverse positions, compromise formulas, and shifting episcopal coalitions coexisted.

21.3. Priscillian and ascetic dissidence in the West

Priscillian, executed in Trier in 385, was a bishop and Christian author. The accusations of Manichaeism, Gnosticism, and magic largely originate from adversaries and must be compared with the surviving Priscillianist treatises. His case illustrates the intersection of ascetic discipline, competition among bishops, and secular jurisdiction.

22. Verification table: fourth-century authors and corpora

Table 55. Verification table: authors and corpora of the fourth century

Author / corpus	Language	Chronology	Main value	Critical caution
Lactantius	Latin	c. 300–325	Apologetics and memory of persecution	De mortibus is a polemical work, not a neutral chronicle.
Eusebius of Caesarea	Greek	c. 300–339	History, archive, Constantine	Distinguish cited documents from historiographical framework.
Athanasius	Greek (Festal Letter 39 partly preserved in Greek excerpts and Coptic fragments)	c. 320–373	Nicene controversy, asceticism	Adversarial categories built in controversy.
Basil of Caesarea	Greek	c. 350–379	Pneumatology, discipline, asceticism	Read in conjunction with synods and correspondence.
Gregory of Nazianzus	Greek	c. 360–390	Oratory and theology	Situated discourses, not an abstract compendium.
Gregory of Nyssa	Greek	c. 370–395	Exegesis, anthropology, controversy	Distinguish between genres and interlocutors.
Hilary of Poitiers	Latin	c. 350–367	Trinity and Western reception	Problems of translation of the Greek lexicon.
Ambrose	Latin	374–397	Episcopate, liturgy, urban politics	Imperial capital and patronage conflict.

(continued)

Author / corpus	Language	Chronology	Main value	Critical caution
Jerome	Latin	c. 370–420	Translation, commentary, literary memory	"Vulgate" = plural process, not an instantaneous unitary work.
Ephrem	Syriac	c. 306–373	Hymnography and exegesis	Syriac ecology; liturgical performance.
Cyril of Jerusalem	Greek	mid-fourth century	Catechesis and initiation	Corpus with authorship/ transmission problems.
Epiphanius	Greek	c. 374–377	Heresiology	Polemical taxonomy; verify the underlying sources.
John Chrysostom	Greek	late fourth century	Urban preaching	Exhortative rhetoric, not social statistics.
Ammianus Marcellinus	Latin	c. 380s	Imperial history	Non-ecclesiastical perspective; inherent biases.
Julian	Greek	361–363	Philosophy, religious politics	Contra Galilaeos survives fragmentarily through hostile transmission.
Libanius / Themistius	Greek	fourth century	Rhetoric and public philosophy	Persistence of non-Christian paideia.
Augustine	Latin	late fourth century	Autobiography, exegesis, polemic	Confessions as a singular case, not a typical experience.

23. Conclusion: from late Roman pluralism to new forms of normativity

The fourth century does not mark the end of pluralism but rather a shift in its institutional conditions. Controversies begin to generate more legislation, councils, archives, and sanctions; certain churches gain privileged access to imperial resources; and translation between Greek, Latin, and Syriac transforms theological and institutional vocabularies. The convergence towards more normative structures was real, but uneven and reversible. The coexistence of Christian authors with non-Christian philosophers, rhetors and administrators demonstrates that the cultural transformation of the Empire was a protracted process.

In documentary terms, the fourth century requires us to separate three levels: normative formulation, local reception, and subsequent memory. A law does not demonstrate universal compliance; a conciliar canon does not imply immediate consensus; a list of books does not automatically preclude the circulation of other texts. This principle summarises the work's general method: reconstructing historical convergences without replacing the complexity of the archives with a linear narrative of institutionalisation.

CHAPTER XIII

Disease, Epidemics, Medicine and Healing Practices in Early Christianity (First–Fourth Centuries)

This chapter studies illness not as a biological backdrop, but as a central dimension of the social history of early Christianity. The problem requires distinguishing four archives that are often conflated: religious narratives of healing, Greco-Roman medicine, the material experience of epidemics and endemic diseases, and community care practices. The New Testament is not a medical treatise; however, it preserves vocabulary, substances, and gestures that belong to the therapeutic horizon of the Roman Mediterranean. In turn, the great epidemics of the second and third centuries shaped domestic economies, mobility, mortality, and discourses on providence, martyrdom, and assistance.

1. Sources and method: between miracle story, therapeutic practice and retrospective diagnosis

The history of ancient medicine compels us to work with heterogeneous levels of documentation. The Gospels and Acts narrate healings within theological frameworks; James and 1 Timothy contain community or domestic instructions; Dioscorides, Celsus, Soranus, and Galen represent technical traditions with distinct purposes; inscriptions, papyri, and osteoarchaeological remains document practices and pathologies in varying degrees. The method of this chapter avoids two opposing reductionisms: reducing all religious healing to covert medicine or, conversely, denying that ritual gestures could coexist with ordinary material procedures. A single community could resort to prayer, oil, diet, physicians, family networks, and domestic care without perceiving these practices as incompatible categories.

2. Medical ecology of the Roman Empire

Imperial cities offered favourable conditions for the transmission of infections: high population density, constant movement of people, uneven water supply, waste, animals, markets, and continuous contact with ports and military camps. The mobility that fostered the expansion of religious networks could also accelerate the spread of diseases. Added to this urban vulnerability were rural and regional endemics. Malaria was particularly prevalent in several humid areas of Italy and the Mediterranean; tuberculosis, dysentery, respiratory infections, parasitic diseases, and eye diseases were part of a high-mortality regime long before any pandemic. Demographic history must therefore distinguish between endemic mortality and extraordinary epidemic episodes.

3. The New Testament and material remedies: limits of the dossier

The New Testament dossier is brief but significant. Oil and wine appear as therapeutic substances; myrrh and aloes are primarily associated with funerary preparations; saliva and mud are part of healing scenes; the laying on of hands and prayer link the therapeutic act to charismatic authority. The presence of a substance known to ancient medicine does not automatically transform a narrative into a medical prescription. One must ask what function it serves in each literary genre, who acts, what expectation of efficacy the text expresses, and how that practice relates to contemporary repertoires.

3.1. Olive oil: anointing, wounds and ritual polysemy

Mark 6:13 states that the apostles anointed many sick people with oil and healed them; James 5:14 prescribes that the elders pray over the sick person and anoint them with oil in the name of the Lord; Luke 10:34 places oil and wine on the wounds of the assaulted man. Oil was an everyday product with culinary, cosmetic, athletic, and medicinal uses. In Christian texts, therefore, oil carries no single meaning. In James, the verb ἀλείφω refers to an ordinary bodily anointing that takes on a ritual function within communal prayer; it should not simply be equated with χρίω and its vocabulary of consecration. The Lucan scene, on the other hand, belongs to a parable and depicts plausible wound care, not a systematic clinical prescription.

3.2. Wine: wound cleansing and dietary use

In Luke 10:34, wine appears alongside oil in the treatment of wounds. Its alcoholic content could produce a limited cleansing effect, although the modern category of "antiseptic" should not be applied without nuance. 1 Timothy 5:23 recommends "a little wine" for Timothy's stomach and frequent ailments. This testimony belongs to the Pastoral Epistles, not to the seven Pauline letters generally accepted as authentic, and must be situated within a dietary culture where wine, water, and diet were part of the daily management of the body.

3.3. Myrrh, aloes and incense: ancient pharmacy and literary function

John 19:39–40 mentions a large quantity of myrrh and aloes in the funerary preparation of Jesus' body. Although both substances had pharmacological and aromatic uses in the ancient world, the Johannine passage is funerary, not therapeutic. Matthew 2:11 mentions frankincense and myrrh among the gifts of the Magi; there, too, the text does not describe a medical treatment. Comparison with Dioscorides is useful for reconstructing the available material repertoire, but not for attributing to the evangelist a pharmacological intention that his narrative does not express.

3.4. Saliva, mud and touch: therapeutic gestures and narrative meaning

Mark 8:23 and John 9:6 preserve scenes in which saliva, alone or mixed with earth, plays a role in a healing. Saliva possessed therapeutic and magical associations in various Mediterranean cultures, but the Christian narratives must first be interpreted within their literary logic. The use of bodily matter, touch, and performative instructions constructs a scene of presence and authority. The laying on of hands, frequent in the Gospels and Acts, belongs to a broader charismatic repertoire in which gesture, word, and body form a ritual unity.

3.5. Wine with myrrh at the crucifixion: sedation?

Mark 15:23 relates that wine mixed with myrrh was offered to Jesus, but he did not take it. The common interpretation as an analgesic or sedative is plausible, but it should not be elevated to pharmacological certainty. The text does not explain the intention of those who offered it, and the properties of a specific mixture depend on preparation, dosage, and context. This passage serves to illustrate a general principle

of this monograph: knowledge of ancient materia medica can define historical possibilities, but it does not replace the semantics of the text.

4. Philological case study: ἔλαιον, οἶνος, ἀλείφω and θεραπεύω

New Testament vocabulary distinguishes among substances, gestures, and categories of healing. ἔλαιον designates oil; οἶνος, wine. ἀλείφω normally describes the bodily application of oil or ointment and does not automatically coincide with χρίω, a term that can acquire connotations of investiture or consecration. θεραπεύω, for its part, can mean to serve, attend to, or heal depending on the context. This semantic plasticity prevents us from constructing a homogeneous "Christian medicine" from just a few occurrences. What emerges is the appropriation of common linguistic and material resources within specific community narratives and practices.

5. The pharmacological horizon: Dioscorides, Pliny, and Galen

The comparison with the technical medicine of the Roman Empire clarifies the context without postulating literary dependence. Dioscorides, active in the first century, organised hundreds of plant, animal, and mineral substances in De materia medica, including oils, wines, resins, and aromatic drugs. Pliny the Elder compiled medical and natural knowledge in Naturalis historia, while Galen, in the second century, produced an extraordinary body of clinical and pharmacological work. Compared to these corpora, the New Testament offers only isolated uses. The difference in scale and purpose is methodologically decisive: Christian texts reveal social and symbolic practices of healing, not a rival medical school.

6. The Antonine Plague: chronology, symptoms and diagnostic limits

The so-called Antonine Plague began around 165 and recurred in subsequent decades. Galen described an illness with fever, gastrointestinal disturbances, and skin eruptions; therefore, smallpox has been a frequent diagnostic hypothesis. However, there is no direct microbiological identification, and the retrospective diagnosis must be considered a hypothesis. Mortality estimates vary widely and should not be cited as reliable figures for the Empire as a whole. For the debate on its impact, R. P. Duncan-Jones, "The Impact of the Antonine Plague," Journal of Roman Archaeology 9 (1996): 108–136, remains fundamental. The epidemic affected urban centres and armies and coincided with military campaigns, but its regional impact

was uneven. Nor should it be stated without reservation that certain imperial deaths, such as that of Marcus Aurelius, were caused by the same disease.

7. The so-called Plague of Cyprian: Christian archive and epidemiological problem

Between approximately 249 and 270, several sources describe a severe mortality crisis. Cyprian of Carthage, especially in *De mortalitate*, offers a rhetorical and pastoral account of the symptoms and the Christian response; Dionysius of Alexandria, preserved by Eusebius (HE VII.22), links disease, war, and mortality in Egypt. The aetiology remains undetermined; current hypotheses include smallpox, measles, or a viral haemorrhagic fever, but no single cause can be considered proven. Nor do archaeology and papyrology yet allow a uniform imperial mortality curve to be reconstructed. The value of this dossier lies both in the possible epidemiology and in the way communities transformed the crisis into a language of discipline, hope, care, and moral differentiation.

8. Endemic diseases and the daily burden of morbidity

Pandemics feature prominently in the sources, but ordinary life was dominated by recurring illnesses. Malaria, dysentery, enteric fevers, tuberculosis, respiratory infections, eye conditions, and parasitic diseases were frequent threats. Cities and camps created environments particularly vulnerable to gastrointestinal diseases; marshy areas favoured malaria. The "leprosy" of ancient sources requires terminological caution because the Hebrew, Greek, and Latin vocabularies do not correspond simply to modern Hansen's disease. Similarly, the hypothesis of widespread lead poisoning in Roman society remains debated and should not be used as a single-cause explanation for demographic decline.

9. Christian care, charity, and community building

Disease had institutional consequences. Caring for the sick, the poor, widows, orphans, and prisoners appears in various Christian texts as an obligation of the community. In the third century, episcopal correspondence and controversies concerning discipline reveal organisations capable of mobilising people and resources. Plagues may have intensified these functions, but the thesis that Christian charity alone explains the growth of the churches exceeds the available evidence; its most influential formulation, R. Stark, The Rise of Christianity (Princeton: Princeton

University Press, 1996), ch. 4, rests on demographic modelling rather than on local documentation. What is historically demonstrable is that care became a practice of identity: visiting, feeding, burying, and accompanying the sick offered communities a language of belonging and a concrete social infrastructure.

10. Disease, demonology and causality

Ancient Christian texts may link bodily suffering to demons, sin, trial, natural frailty, or providence without organising these explanations into a single system. Identifying possession with modern psychiatric or neurological illness is as anachronistic as claiming that all ailments were understood in demonological terms. The Gospels sometimes distinguish between types of affliction and, in other scenes, overlap them. Historical research must preserve this plural repertoire of causalities and resist the temptation to automatically translate ancient categories into contemporary biomedical diagnoses.

11. Epidemic, persecution and imperial crisis

The Antonine Plague coincided with border wars; the Plague of Cyprian, with the political and military crisis of the third century; the Great Persecution, with the tetrarchic reorganisation. These simultaneous events invite us to study taxation, recruitment, prices, mobility, and legitimacy, but they do not prove a single causality. The sacrifices demanded under Decius were not a public health policy, and Christian narratives about epidemics do not constitute demographic statistics. Integrating disease and persecution means studying how different crises competed for resources, produced social fear, and amplified the visibility of religious networks, not merging them into a single phenomenon.

12. Conclusion: from miracle to care, from plague to social archive

The medical dossier transforms our understanding of early Christianity when integrated into social history. Oil, wine, touch, and prayer demonstrate that material and ritual healing could coexist. The great epidemics reveal the limits of demographic reconstruction and, simultaneously, the capacity of communities to produce meaningful narratives and support networks. The technical medicine of Dioscorides and Galen provides the comparative framework that prevents treating Christian accounts as if they were pharmacology; Christian sources, for their part, preserve information about care, bodies, and vulnerability that rarely appears with

the same density in medical treatises. The result is not a confessional history of "Christian medicine," but rather a history of how disease, therapeutic practice, ritual, and social organisation intersected in the Roman Mediterranean.

13. Documentary table: substances and therapeutic practices in the New Testament

TABLE 56. Documentary table: substances and therapeutic practices in the New Testament

Substance / practice	**Locus**	**Function in the text**	**Historical contextualisation**
Olive oil	Mark 6:13; James 5:14; Luke 10:34	Anointing of the sick; care of wounds	Everyday product with medicinal, cosmetic and ritual uses; it is not equivalent to a standardised drug.
Wine	Luke 10:34; 1 Timothy 5:23	Wounds; dietary-therapeutic recommendation	The pastoral passage belongs to 1 Timothy; avoid automatically attributing it to the historical Paul.
Myrrh and aloes	John 19:39–40	Funeral preparations	They have a pharmacological history, but here the narrative function is funerary.
Frankincense and myrrh	Matt 2:11	Gifts of the Magi	They are not remedies in the passage; any medicinal use is external context.
Saliva / mud	Mark 8:23; John 9:6	Healing gestures	Comparable to ancient therapeutic and magical repertoires without postulating an identity of practice.
Laying on of hands	Gospels and Acts	Charismatic gesture of healing	Ritual practice; should not be classified as a medicine.

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Substance / practice	Locus	Function in the text	Historical contextualisation
Wine with myrrh	Mark 15:23	Drink offered during the crucifixion	The sedative function is a plausible hypothesis, not an explicit description of the text.

14. Critical table: epidemics and diseases of the first–fourth centuries

TABLE 57. Critical table: epidemics and diseases of the first–fourth centuries

Phenomenon	Chronology	Diagnosis / evidence	Critical caution
Endemic urban and rural mortality	First–fourth centuries	Malaria, tuberculosis, dysentery, enteric fevers, respiratory infections, ophthalmia, parasitosis	The regional distribution is uneven, and ancient nomenclature does not match modern diagnoses.
Antonine plague	c. 165–180, with later resurgences	Smallpox is a common hypothesis based on Galen's account	Without direct biomolecular identification; mortality figures and total extent are debated.
Plague of Cyprian	c. 249–270	Aetiology undetermined; hypotheses include smallpox, measles, or a viral haemorrhagic fever	Archaeology and papyrology do not support a uniform mortality rate throughout the Empire.
Local outbreaks of the fourth century	Fourth century	Various epidemic and endemic diseases	There is no well-documented imperial pandemic comparable to the previous ones.

(continued)

Phenomenon	Chronology	Diagnosis / evidence	Critical caution
Plague of Justinian	From 541	Yersinia pestis confirmed by ancient DNA	It falls outside the main chronological framework; useful only as a methodological contrast.

15. Selected bibliography for the chapter

Cyprian of Carthage. De mortalitate and Epistulae. Cite by modern critical edition; distinguish pastoral description, rhetoric and clinical data.

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Summary

This chapter reconstructs disease, the epidemic experience, therapeutic practices, and community care in the Roman world between the first and fourth centuries. It distinguishes New Testament accounts of healing from technical medicine; examines oil, wine, myrrh, aloe, saliva, and bodily gestures within their literary contexts and cautiously compares them with Greco-Roman pharmacology. It then re-evaluates the Antonine Plague and the so-called Plague of Cyprian, highlighting the uncertainty of retrospective diagnosis and mortality estimates. Endemic disease, Christian care practices, and the interplay between epidemic crisis and imperial coercion are treated as components of social history.

CHAPTER XIV

Social History of Christian Communities: Work, Slavery, Patronage and Mutual Aid

This chapter shifts the focus from major authors, councils, and controversies to the human infrastructure that made the daily existence of Christian communities possible. The available sources are uneven: letters, moral exhortations, martyrdom records, inscriptions, documentary papyri, and episcopal accounts primarily preserve situations of conflict or prescription. Therefore, the social history proposed here does not aim to reconstruct a universal "average composition," but rather to identify recurring mechanisms of dependency, labour, mobility, hospitality, and redistribution in specific cities of the Roman Mediterranean.

1. Methodological problems: class, status and documentation

Modern categories of class cannot be applied directly to the Roman Empire. Legal status, wealth, personal freedom, citizenship, profession, gender, geographic origin, and dependence on patrons intersected without forming a single hierarchy. A well-to-do freedman could have more resources than a poor *ingenuus*; an enslaved domestic could occupy a position of trust while remaining legally subject; and membership of an association or household could provide safety nets without erasing inequality. Social research on early communities must therefore focus on profiles and relationships, not on a rigid social pyramid.

Paul's letters reveal artisans, travellers, households able to host meetings, dependants, and people with sufficient resources to offer hospitality or fund journeys. Later, Hermas, Clement of Alexandria, Tertullian, Cyprian, and disciplinary sources bring to light tensions between wealth and poverty, charity and prestige, discipline and dependence. These texts are normative, not censuses; they provide better information about conflicts and expectations than about demographic percentages.

2. Slavery, freedom and community belonging

Slavery was structurally embedded in the Roman economy and domestic life. Christian communities did not exist outside of this system. Philemon provides the most explicit example: Paul intervenes in the relationship between Philemon and Onesimus without proposing a legal abolition of slavery. The language of brotherhood morally reconfigures the relationship, but does not in itself eliminate the legal asymmetry. Similarly, 1 Corinthians 7:21–23 can be read as an eschatological relativisation of status without transforming it into a programme for immediate social emancipation.

The exhortations in Colossians and Ephesians, of debated authorship, and the Pastoral Epistles reveal a distinct phase of domestic regulation. Comparison with the undisputed letters makes it possible to study how communities negotiated the tension between ritual equality and social order. Later documentation confirms that slaves and freedmen could participate in Christian networks, even in positions of trust, but it does not justify describing the churches as socially egalitarian spaces in the modern sense.

3. Manual labour, artisans and mobility

Paul's work, presented in 1 Thessalonians 2:9 and 1 Corinthians 9, offers a privileged entry into the mission economy. The word σκηνοποιός in Acts 18:3, whatever the exact specialisation, situates Paul's memory within the world of artisanal work. Workshop, dwelling, market, and social life could overlap spatially. This configuration helps explain why networks of artisans, merchants, and travellers functioned as channels of transmission without the need to postulate a centralised organisation.

Mobility was not exclusively a missionary trait. Merchants, soldiers, freedmen, relocated slaves, officials, pilgrims, and seasonal workers connected ports and cities. Pre-existing maritime and land routes provided the infrastructure upon which Christian exchanges were superimposed. Religious expansion thus relied upon, and became embedded within, pre-existing Roman economic and social networks.

4. Patronage, hospitality, and meeting houses

The houses associated with Prisca and Aquila, Philemon, Nympha, and other figures in the Pauline tradition show that the domestic space was a crucial unit of gathering. However, "house church" does not necessarily imply a monumental aristocratic dwelling. The range of possibilities extends from modest rooms to houses capable of

hosting relatively large groups. What is historically most significant is that whoever controlled the space could acquire the capacity for social intermediation.

The vocabulary applied to Phoebe in Romans 16:1–2—διάκονος and προστάτις—reveals a combination of service, representation, and support that must be read within the practices of patronage without automatically reducing it to a later "office." The Christian adoption of relationships of benefaction did not eliminate the prestige associated with the gift; it subjected it to new rhetorics of reciprocity, humility, and communal obligation.

5. The poor, widows, orphans, prisoners, and travellers

Assistance gradually became one of the most visible areas of community organisation. Paul's letters already document the collection for Jerusalem as a translocal transfer of resources. The Didache regulates hospitality and aid; Hermas repeatedly addresses wealth and poverty; Justin describes Sunday collections for orphans, widows, the sick, prisoners, and foreigners; and Cyprian's correspondence reveals systems capable of mobilising funds on a regional scale. Christian charity must be studied simultaneously as a practice of care, a mechanism of cohesion, and a means of producing authority.

6. Associations, collegia and disciplined comparison

Greco-Roman voluntary associations offer a useful comparison: they possessed offices, dues, banquets, funeral funds, statutes, and networks of solidarity. But Christian communities were not simply collegia with a different theology. The comparison must operate on features: forms of assembly, administration of funds, meals, discipline, burial, and the commemoration of benefactors. The legal status of a particular community cannot be deduced from its functional resemblance to a recognised association.

7. Funeral economics and cemeteries

The administration of burials, martyr commemoration, and cemeteries provides one of the clearest indicators of material institutionalisation. In Rome, the tradition linking Callistus to a church cemetery (Hippolytus, Refutatio IX.12.14) and the inscriptions in the catacombs show that funerary management became a space of organisation, prestige, and memory. Control of a burial site implied resources, personnel, and institutional continuity; it should not be explained solely as devotion.

8. Selective social prosopography

Table 58. Selective social prosopography

Figure	Place / Date	Documented status or function	Main source
Phoebe	Cenchreae / c. 50s	διάκονος; προστάτις; probable carrier or representative	Rom 16:1–2
Prisca	Corinth-Ephesus-Rome / first century	συνεργός; host of a house church	Rom 16:3–5; 1 Cor 16:19
Aquila	Corinth-Ephesus-Rome / first century	collaborator; craftsman according to Acts	Rom 16:3–5; 1 Cor 16:19; Acts 18
Onesimus	Colossae? / first century	enslaved or dependent linked to Philemon	Phlm
Philemon	Asia Minor? / first century	host and homeowner	Phlm 1–2
Chloe / "Chloe's people"	Corinth / first century	domestic or commercial network that cannot be determined	1 Cor 1:11
Hermas	Rome / second century	author/narrative persona; horizon of houses and wealth	The Shepherd
Cornelius	Rome / 251–253	bishop; clergy and assistance network	Eus., HE VI.43
Cyprian	Carthage / 248–258	bishop; epistolary and financial coordinator	Epistulae

Table 59. Continuation of "Selective social prosopography"

Figure	Historical-social reading	Certainty
Phoebe	Intermediation, patronage and female mobility	A/B
Prisca	Translocal node of home, work and mission	A
Aquila	Artisanal and domestic mobility	A/B

(continued)

Figure	Historical-social reading	Certainty
Onesimus	A case for studying brotherhood and legal asymmetry	A
Philemon	Domestic patronage and local authority	A/B
Chloe / "Chloe's people"	Translocal information channel	B
Hermas	Archive of social mobility, debt and charity	B
Cornelius	Institutional scale of urban redistribution	A/B
Cyprian	Regional centrality and resource mobilisation	A

9. Conclusion

Social history compels us to abandon two opposing simplifications: imagining the early churches as movements exclusively of the poor and slaves, or describing them as associations dominated from the outset by urban elites. The evidence points to mixed and variable compositions, where differences in wealth and dependency coexisted with expressions of fraternity and practices of redistribution. It was precisely this capacity to connect households, workshops, patrons, dependants, widows, travellers, and local authorities that enabled the continuity of communities that, for much of the period, lacked their own public infrastructure.

Abstract. This chapter reconstructs the social infrastructure of early Christian communities through slavery, labour, patronage, domestic space, mutual aid, burial, and voluntary associations. It treats legal status, wealth, mobility, and household dependency as intersecting variables. The evidence points to socially mixed and locally variable communities whose continuity depended both on pre-existing urban networks and on emerging practices of redistribution and reciprocal obligation.

CHAPTER XV

Eastern Christianities and Linguistic Diversity: Egypt, Syria, Edessa, Osroene and Armenia

The documentary predominance of Greek and Latin can produce the misleading impression that early Christianity was, from its origins, an exclusively Greco-Roman phenomenon. This chapter shifts its focus to regions where Greek, Coptic, Aramaic, and Syriac coexisted or competed, and where local forms of memory, translation, and authority profoundly transformed Christian transmission. The category "Eastern Christianity" is used here as a geographical and linguistic tool, not as a retrospective confessional label.

Geographical clarification. In the sequence of Acts 21:7, Ptolemais designates the Ptolemais of Phoenicia (Acre), on the Levantine coast; it should not be confused with Ptolemais Hermiou or with other homonymous cities in Egypt.

1. Egypt beyond Alexandria: from the intellectual port to the chōra

Alexandria occupies a central place because of Philo, Clement, Origen, and the controversies of the third century, but Egyptian Christianity cannot be reduced to its capital. Papyrological documentation from Oxyrhynchus and other locations reveals the copying and circulation of Christian literature in the Nile Valley. The transition to Coptic does not represent a simple break with Greek: for centuries both languages coexisted at different levels of administration, education, liturgy, and textual transmission.

The Nag Hammadi codices, although from the fourth century in their preserved form, contain Coptic translations of works whose composition is, in many cases, earlier. Their material geography requires us to distinguish between the place of copying, the language of preservation, the date of the codex, and the intellectual origin of the treatise. Similarly, the emergence of Egyptian monasticism must be situated within

broader rural and urban networks, not as a phenomenon arising from a culturally isolated desert.

2. Alexandria: school, library and episcopal conflict

The so-called "catechetical school" of Alexandria must be approached with institutional caution: later sources may project continuity where perhaps less formalised teaching circles existed. Pantaenus is a difficult figure to reconstruct; Clement displays a Christian pedagogy deeply intertwined with Greek paideia; Origen takes this practice to an exceptional philological level through teaching, commentary, and textual comparison. With Demetrius, the tensions between episcopal authority and intellectual prestige become visible, allowing us to observe the formation of a more defined structure.

3. Western Syria and Antioch: translation, conflict and city

Antioch was a metropolis where Jewish, Greek, and Christian communities shared a complex urban space. Galatians 2 reveals an early conflict over commensality and identity; Acts preserves a distinct memory of the origin of the name "Christians"; Ignatius, at the beginning of the second century, projects from Antioch a strong theology of episcopal unity. These sources belong to different periods and should not be harmonised as inevitable stages of a single institutional trajectory.

The linguistic diversity of Syria included Greek and various forms of Aramaic. With the development of Syriac literature, translation ceased to be a secondary operation: it created its own theological vocabularies, reorganised metaphors, and facilitated forms of Christianity capable of circulating beyond the Greek-speaking civic framework.

4. Edessa and Osroene: apostolic memory and Syriac culture

Edessa became one of the great centres of Syriac Christian culture. The legend of Abgar, preserved in Eusebius (HE I.13) and later developed in the Doctrine of Addai, cannot be used as a contemporary document of a first-century royal conversion. Its historical importance lies in showing how the city constructed its own apostolic genealogy. Bardesanes and his circle, already at the end of the second and beginning of the third centuries, reveal an intellectual milieu in which Christianity, astrology, philosophy, and local traditions could interact without conforming to later ecclesiastical categories.

5. Tatian and the Diatessaron

Tatian, educated in the Greek-speaking world and associated for a time with Justin Martyr, composed the Diatessaron as a gospel harmony. Its impact in Syria was profound. The text illustrates that the existence of four Gospels did not immediately imply their separate reading in all communities. Harmonisation was a reading technology capable of producing a continuous narrative and adapting textual plurality to liturgical and pedagogical needs. The original language and the phases of transmission remain debated; therefore, it is useful to distinguish between composition, translation, and Syriac reception.

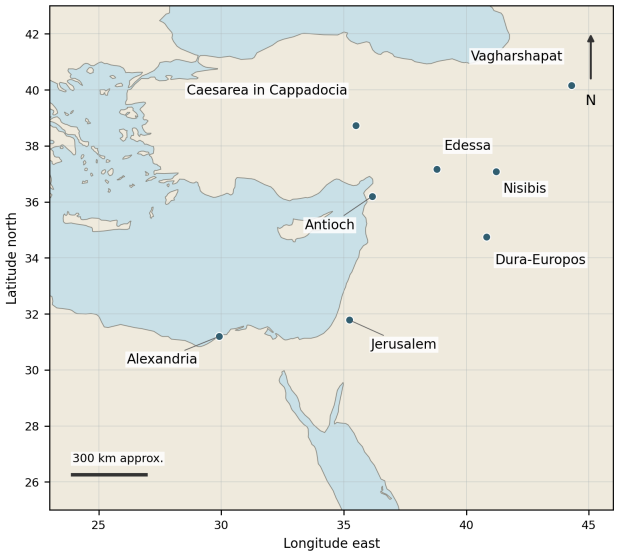


FIGURE 25. Places in the Christian East examined in the work. The points refer to different chronologies, not to simultaneous Christianisation: Dura-Europos, third century; Nisibis and Ephrem, fourth century; Armenia, disputed traditions of reception. Cartography by the author on Natural Earth, public domain.

6. Ephrem and the reception of the Diatessaron

In the fourth century, Ephrem's commentary on the Diatessaron offers an exceptional window into Syriac exegesis. His work demonstrates that the boundary between "biblical text" and "commentary" could be mediated by a gospel form distinct from the four separate Gospels. Ephrem is also fundamental for studying poetic theology, hymnography, and doctrinal controversy outside the dominant Greco-Latin genres.

7. Armenia: Christianisation and caution regarding origins

Armenian traditions attribute very ancient apostolic origins to their communities, but reliable documentation for widespread institutional establishment belongs primarily to Late Antiquity. The conversion of the kingdom under Trdat/Tiridates III and Gregory the Illuminator, usually placed at the beginning of the fourth century, although its chronology is debated, must be studied as part of court politics and inter-imperial competition. The subsequent creation of the Armenian alphabet by Mesrop Mashtots at the beginning of the fifth century falls outside the main focus of this work, but is mentioned only to explain how a distinct literary tradition was consolidated. The decisive narrative source for the memory of the conversion is the History attributed to Agathangelus: it describes the conversion of Tiridates and the mission of Gregory, but the preserved Armenian form belongs to the second half of the fifth century. Its usefulness is therefore twofold: it preserves earlier traditions and, at the same time, documents the retrospective construction of a royal ecclesiastical memory. The chronology of Christianisation should remain open within the early fourth century, without presenting 301 as a definitively established date.

7.1. Early Syriac literature: translation, canon, and theological vocabulary

Early Syriac literature requires an especially careful distinction between date of composition, date of the surviving witness, and language of preservation. The Old Syriac Gospel tradition, known above all from the Sinaitic and Curetonian witnesses preserved in later manuscripts, shows that the reception of the Gospels in Christian Aramaic did not depend on a single act of translation. Alongside the Diatessaron, it documents a milieu in which harmonisation and translation coexisted before the later stabilisation of textual forms that achieved broader circulation. The Peshitta belongs to a later phase of standardisation and should not be projected without qualification onto the second century.

Translation in this setting was not mechanical. Greek terms concerning church, Spirit, body, covenant, salvation, and authority entered Syriac semantic fields with associations of their own. Aphrahat and Ephrem, in the fourth century, reveal an exegetical culture that was not merely a peripheral replica of Alexandria or Antioch: it employed parallelism, biblical symbolism, poetry, and forms of argument adapted to a distinctive linguistic environment. Syriac should therefore be treated as an intellectual archive in its own right, not simply as a vehicle for Greek versions.

7.2. The Christian Caucasus and the limits of fourth-century evidence

Armenia provides earlier and denser documentation than Christian Georgia for the chronological span of this book, yet even there the surviving literary memory postdates many of the events it narrates. Georgian conversion traditions place the process in the fourth century and associate it with Nino, whereas written Georgian evidence becomes securely accessible above all from the fifth century. Armenia and Georgia should therefore not be presented as documentary trajectories of equal density. Comparison remains valuable for the study of courtly conversion, translation, and imperial competition, but it must state the distance between event, tradition, and manuscript witness.

7.3. Persia and Parthia: Christian presence and gradients of evidence

Eastward expansion did not end at Edessa. Literary sources of the late second and third centuries refer to Christians in territories under Parthian and Sasanian rule, while Middle Persian inscriptions associated with Kartir show that "Christians" and

"Nazarenes" belonged to the religious vocabulary of the late third-century Sasanian Empire. This confirms presence and administrative visibility, but it does not justify reconstructing a uniform organisation or projecting onto the second century the structures that become much clearer in the Persian synods of the fifth. Identifiably Christian archaeology within Iran is comparatively sparse, and the imbalance between literary testimony and material remains must be stated explicitly.

These communities also require a move beyond a Roman-centred map. Mesopotamia, Adiabene, Susiana, and the Persian Gulf routes belonged to imperial and commercial systems distinct from, though connected with, the Mediterranean. Syriac became a decisive language of transmission in this zone; relations among communities, local courts, and Sasanian power changed with reigns and with conflict against Rome. "Persian" is used here as a political and geographical frame, not as the name of a homogeneous ecclesiastical identity.

7.4. India and Aksum: routes, apostolic memories, and degrees of certainty

The Thomas tradition is the principal dossier for India. The Acts of Thomas, probably composed in Syriac in the third century, place the apostle within an Indo-Parthian world and preserve the name Gundaphar/Gondophares, a historically attested ruler. That correspondence demonstrates knowledge of an eastern horizon; it does not automatically establish a first-century apostolic mission. Red Sea and Indian Ocean routes made the movement of merchants, languages, and religions possible, yet the evidence for early Christian communities in India must be graded below the level of certainty available for Syria or Mesopotamia.

Aksum presents a different documentary regime. In the fourth century, inscriptions of King Ezana provide epigraphic evidence for the transformation of royal ideology towards explicitly Christian language; traditions concerning Frumentius and his relationship with Alexandria should be checked against fourth-century literary testimony and Aksumite coinage. Here the evidence for a fourth-century royal Christianisation is considerably stronger than any claim of an earlier apostolic foundation. India and Aksum thus exemplify two distinct evidentiary patterns: an early missionary memory of disputed historicity and a later, materially attested royal transformation.

8. Geocultural table of Eastern traditions

TABLE 60. Geocultural table of Eastern traditions

Region	Main languages	Testimonies / authors	Historical problem	Caution
Alexandria	Greek; later Coptic	Clement, Origen, Dionysius	School, episcopate, philology	Do not project a stable school institution from the beginning
Egypt / chōra	Greek and Coptic	Oxyrhynchus Papyri; Nag Hammadi	Material circulation and translation	Place of discovery ≠ place of composition
Antioch	Greek and Aramaic/Syriac	Paul, Ignatius, Theophilus	Identity, commensality, episcopate	Sources separated by decades
Edessa / Osroene	Syriac and Greek	Abgar/Addai, Bardesanes	Apostolic memory and local culture	The legend does not prove a royal conversion in the first century
Syria	Syriac	Tatian, Diatessaron, Ephrem	Gospel harmony, liturgy and exegesis	Distinguish between original, translation, and reception
Armenia	Armenian (later); Greek and Syriac through contact	Gregory the Illuminator; Agathangelus, History of the Armenians; later ecclesiastical traditions	Royal Christianisation	The conversion of Trdat/Tiridates III is usually placed at the beginning of the fourth century, but its exact chronology is debated. The History attributed to Agathangelus reached its preserved Armenian form in the fifth century and should be used as a late institutional record, not as a contemporary document.
Persia / Parthia	Syriac; Middle Persian; other Iranian languages	Bardesanes; Kartir inscriptions; later ecclesiastical testimonies	Christian presence under Parthian and Sasanian rule	Literary evidence is denser than archaeology; do not retroject fifth-century organisation

(continued)

Region	Main languages	Testimonies / authors	Historical problem	Caution
India	Syriac and Greek in the literary tradition; local languages in the historical horizon	Acts of Thomas; Indian Ocean trading networks	Apostolic memory and transregional mobility	Probably a third-century text; the name Gondophares does not prove a first-century apostolic mission
Aksum	Geʿez and Greek	Ezana inscriptions; traditions concerning Frumentius; coinage	Fourth-century royal Christianisation	Strong evidence for the fourth century; not evidence for an earlier apostolic origin

9. Conclusion

The eastern expansion shows that early Christianity was not simply the export of a Greek form to passive peripheries. Translation, bilingualism, and regional adaptation produced new configurations of authority and memory. Egypt, Syria, Edessa, Armenia, Persian territories, routes towards India, and the kingdom of Aksum require us to think of a polycentric Christianity whose history is better understood through linguistic ecologies and gradations of evidence than through a map of "sees" retrospectively ordered from Rome. Unequal documentary density across these regions must not be converted into a historical hierarchy of importance.

Abstract. This chapter examines Eastern Christianities through the linguistic and regional ecologies of Egypt, Alexandria, Antioch, Edessa, Osroene, and Armenia, extending the comparative gradient towards Persia/Parthia, India, and Aksum. It distinguishes composition, translation, and manuscript preservation, treats apostolic legends as forms of cultural memory, and explicitly grades the evidence for eastern peripheries while emphasising the creative role of Coptic and Syriac traditions in shaping Christian textual and institutional cultures.

CHAPTER XVI

Liturgy, Initiation and Performative Culture: Baptism, Eucharist and Discipline (First–Fourth Centuries)

Early Christian liturgy did not originate as a uniform system. Sources from the first four centuries reveal repertoires of practices that stabilised unevenly: immersion and washing, fasting, laying on of hands, communal meals, reading, prayer, collections, commemoration of martyrs, penance, and, later, extended catechumenates and complex initiation rituals. The method of this chapter is comparative and stratified: each text is situated within its date, region, and genre before it is used as evidence for ritual.

1. Baptism: from the flexibility of the Didache to late Roman initiation

Didache 7 preserves one of the earliest witnesses to Christian baptism outside the New Testament. It prefers "living water," but allows other types of water and, in case of necessity, the threefold pouring over the head. This flexibility makes it impossible to reconstruct a single, original ritual form. The prescription of fasting for the one being baptised and for other members suggests that the rite was already integrated into a communal preparation.

In the third and fourth centuries, the sources reveal more extensive processes of preparation. The so-called Apostolic Tradition—whose attribution, date, and origin are debated—should not be treated as a universal Roman manual. Compared with Tertullian, Cyprian, Cyril of Jerusalem, and Ambrose, it helps trace the growing articulation among catechesis, renunciations, anointings, immersion, laying on of hands, clothing, and Eucharistic participation.

2. The Lord's Supper and community meals: diversity of forms and development of Eucharistic terminology

The Pauline traditions of 1 Corinthians 10–11 depict a meal where inequalities of access and behaviour could lead to conflict. The Didache preserves Eucharistic prayers with their own vocabulary and sequence. Justin, in the mid-second century, describes a Sunday gathering with reading, exhortation, prayers, the kiss, bread, wine and water, distribution by deacons, and collection. These accounts should not be lumped together to form a single "Mass"; they reveal different phases and regions of ritualisation.

3. Fasting, calendar and differentiation

Didache 8 contrasts its own fasting days with those of "the hypocrites," showing that the calendar could function as an identity marker. The Easter controversy of the second century reveals that the date for commemorating the passion and resurrection was not uniformly fixed. The discussions between Rome and Asia Minor are, therefore, a paradigmatic case of how a temporal practice became a problem of interregional communion.

4. Public reading, homily and performance

The Christian gathering was also a means of giving texts oral expression. Letters intended to be read, apostolic memoirs, prophecies, hymns, and commentaries circulated through performance. Public reading does not presuppose general literacy among the audience. On the contrary, it explains how relatively expensive texts could function in communities where only a minority possessed advanced reading and writing skills.

5. Penance, reconciliation and discipline

Hermas testifies to an early concern with the possibility of repentance after baptism. The persecution of Decius—and, to a lesser extent, that of Valerian—brought this issue to an institutional level: the cases of libellatici, sacrificati and confessors required the definition of conditions for reintegration. The controversy between Cyprian and Novatian shows that penance was not simply a doctrinal problem; it affected episcopal authority, the memory of martyrs, and community cohesion.

6. Ritual ministry and gender

The sources reveal female participation in prophecy, patronage, martyrdom, and, in certain contexts, ministries of assistance and initiation of women. Deaconesses appear more clearly in later Eastern sources. Their study must avoid two anachronisms: projecting a later clerical order onto the first century and, conversely, converting all documented female activity into an "ordained ministry" equivalent to the later one. The history of gender requires tracing functions and vocabulary source by source.

7. Exorcism, healing and baptismal preparation

The expulsion of demons occupies a prominent place in the Gospels and continues to appear in later Christian practice. In Late Antiquity, exorcism was gradually integrated into catechumenal processes. This continuity does not imply ritual identity: the charismatic gesture of a Gospel narrative and an institutionalised practice of baptismal preparation belong to different genres and contexts.

8. Martyrs, memory and local calendar

The cult of martyrs transformed the relationship between space, memory, and time. The celebration of death anniversaries, the preservation of records, and the monumentalisation of tombs created local calendars that could later be integrated into broader repertoires. Polycarp, Perpetua and Felicity, Cyprian, and the Roman martyrs offer distinct examples of this production of memory. The Martyrdom of Polycarp (18.3) already envisages an annual gathering at the burial place to celebrate the martyr's "birthday."

9. Comparative table of ritual practices

Table 61. Comparative table of ritual practices

Source / approximate date	Baptism	Lord's Supper / communal meal / Eucharist (depending on date and source)	Fasting / discipline
1 Corinthians / 50s	Presupposed, without a full description of the rite	Communal meal; social conflict	Community discipline

(continued)

Source / approximate date	Baptism	Lord's Supper / communal meal / Eucharist (depending on date and source)	Fasting / discipline
Didache / late first–early second century	Living water; alternatives; fasting	Distinctive prayers	Fasts as markers of difference
Ignatius / early second century	It does not describe a rite	Eucharist linked to unity	Discipline of communion
Justin, 1 Apol. 61, 65–67 / c. 150	Washing after instruction	Bread, wine and water; distribution	Prayer and ethical life
Tertullian / c. 200	Preparation, water, anointing	Various testimonies	Fasting and penance
Apostolic Tradition / third century?	Catechumenate and complex initiation	Post-baptismal sequence	Examinations and preparation
Cyril of Jerusalem / fourth century	Catechesis and urban initiation	Mystagogical interpretation	Lent and preparation

TABLE 62. Continuation of "Comparative table of ritual practices"

Source / approximate date	Ministries / agents	Interpretive limit
1 Corinthians / 50s	Paul, community	Occasional letter, not liturgical manual
Didache / late first–early second century	Prophets, teachers, episkopoi/ diakonoi	Compilation of layers and debated context
Ignatius / early second century	Bishop, presbytery, deacons	Polemical letters, not a universal panorama
Justin, 1 Apol. 61, 65–67 / c. 150	Presiding minister, deacons	Apologetic description to an external audience
Tertullian / c. 200	Clergy and laity	Specific North African context
Apostolic Tradition / third century?	Bishop, presbyters, deacons	Authorship, date, and origin disputed
Cyril of Jerusalem / fourth century	Catechetical clergy	Jerusalem of the fourth century, not a model of the earliest period

10. Conclusion

Ritual history confirms the general thesis of this monograph: Christian unity was a historical result of convergences, standardisations, and disputes, not a fully developed form from the outset. Baptism, Eucharist, penance, and ministries became progressively more regulated, but retained regional differences for centuries. A comparison of sources avoids both the illusion of a complete and immutable apostolic liturgy and the opposing notion of improvisation without continuity.

Abstract. This chapter reconstructs Christian ritual practices between the first and fourth centuries by comparing baptism, Eucharist, fasting, public reading, penance, exorcism, commemoration of martyrs, and ministry. Ritual uniformity is treated as a historical construction rather than a starting assumption; particular attention is given to regional variation, source genre, and the gradual institutionalisation of initiation and discipline.

CHAPTER XVII

Apostolic Onomastics, Jesus and Christ: Names, Languages and Symbolism of the Twelve

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This chapter brings together in a single philological tool the Greek and Semitic forms of the names associated with Jesus and the apostolic circle. Its purpose is not to reconstruct a uniform "original" nomenclature—something impossible in a multilingual environment—but to distinguish the forms that are actually attested, the ancient transliterations, and the plausible linguistic reconstructions. In Palestine and the diaspora of the first century, a single individual could be known by both a Semitic and a Greek or Latin form of the name; therefore, onomastic variation constitutes historical evidence of mobility, bilingualism, and social adaptation.

1. Philological criterion: attested form, transliteration and reconstruction

This chapter adopts three levels of certainty. [A] designates a form directly attested in a relevant ancient source; [B] a widely accepted linguistic equivalent not preserved for that individual in a contemporary document; [C] a disputed etymology or identification. Hebrew and Aramaic forms are written in square script when the equivalence is certain; Greek retains the spelling of the New Testament textual tradition. For names that are Greek in origin—Ἀνδρέας or Φίλιππος, for example—no hypothetical Hebrew form is invented.

This discipline is especially necessary because Christian sources were transmitted primarily in Greek. The fact that a name has a Semitic etymology does not prove that the person was always called by that name, just as the presence of a Greek name does not in itself determine an ethnic identity.

2. Jesus of Nazareth: Ἰησοῦς, ישוע and the problem of the geographical designation

The Greek form of the name is *Ἰησοῦς*, an adaptation of the late Semitic form ישוע (Yēšūaʿ), related to the longer form יהושע (Yəhōšūaʿ, "YHWH saves / YHWH is salvation"). In Second Temple Judaism, the abbreviated form Yēšūaʿ is abundantly attested; it is neither a unique nor a secret name.

The gospels also use Ναζαρηνός and Ναζωραῖος. Both relate Jesus to Nazareth, but the exact history of their later forms and associations requires caution. The expression "Jesus of Nazareth" is, therefore, a geographical and social identification rather than a theological title. The reading of Ναζωραῖος as a necessary derivation of נָזִיר (nāzîr, "Nazirite") is not philologically obligatory and is not adopted here.

3. Χριστός, משיח and the semantic field of anointing

The title Χριστός comes from the Greek verb *χρίω (*"to smear, to anoint with oil or ointment"). As a verbal adjective, *χριστός* can literally mean "anointed" or "smeared." Religious specialisation occurred decisively in the Greek translations of the Jewish Scriptures, where χριστός *usually* translates the Hebrew מָשִׁיחַ (māšîaḥ, "anointed").

The Hebrew noun did not originally designate a single eschatological figure. It could be applied to kings, priests, and even, in certain prophetic contexts, to political agents invested by God. The shift from "an anointed one" to "the Messiah" was a historical process of semantic concentration, fuelled by distinct royal, priestly, and eschatological expectations.

In non-biblical Greek, χρίω and its lexical family also belong to the ordinary vocabulary of bodily, medical, athletic, and funerary anointing. Therefore, the Christian novelty lies not in inventing the word, but in turning Χριστός into a personal title for Ἰησοῦς that functions almost as a proper name. The Septuagint provides the fundamental linguistic bridge: the religious semantics of the Christian term are understood from its translational use, not from a supposed Greek etymology associated with mystery cults.

4. The Twelve: names, spellings and etymology

TABLE 63. The Twelve: names, spellings and etymologies

Figure	Greek	Hebrew / Aramaic	Etymology or meaning	Certainty
Simon Peter	Σίμων / Πέτρος; Κηφᾶς	שמעון (Šimʿōn); כיפא (Kēpāʾ, Aram.)	Šimʿōn: "has heard" / related to hearing; Kēpāʾ: "rock, stone"	A/B
Andrew	Ἀνδρέας	—	Greek name, from *ἀνήρ/ἀνδρός*: "male, man"; no certain Semitic form for the person	A
James, son of Zebedee	Ἰάκωβος	יעקב (Yaʿaqōb)	Patriarchal name; traditional biblical etymology related to "heel" and to wordplay in Genesis 25	A/B
John, son of Zebedee	Ἰωάννης	יוחנן (Yōḥānān)	"YHWH has been gracious / is merciful"	A/B
Philip	Φίλιππος	—	Greek: "friend/lover of horses"	A
Bartholomew	Βαρθολομαῖος	בר־תלמי (bar-Talmai)	Aramaic patronymic: "son of Talmai"; the identification with Nathanael is a later tradition	A/B
Matthew	Ματθαῖος	מתי / מתתיהו (Mattityāhū / Mattai)	A name in the onomastic family meaning "gift of YHWH"; the individual's exact Hebrew name is not preserved	A/B
Thomas	Θωμᾶς; Δίδυμος	תאומא	from Aramaic *Tʾōmā* / *Tʾōmā*, meaning "twin"; John renders the name's meaning as Δίδυμος	A/B
James, son of Alphaeus	Ἰάκωβος ὁ τοῦ Ἁλφαίου	יעקב; חלפי? (Ḥalfai?)	Yaʿaqōb is a secure equivalent; Alphaeus/Ḥalfai is probable but not absolutely certain	A/C
Jude/Thaddeus	Ἰούδας; Θαδδαῖος	יהודה (Yəhūdāh)	Yəhūdāh: "Judah"; etymology of Θαδδαῖος disputed	A/C

(continued)

Figure	Greek	Hebrew / Aramaic	Etymology or meaning	Certainty
Simon the Zealot	Σίμων ὁ Ζηλωτής / ὁ Καναναῖος	שמעון; קנאי (qannāʾ, Aram./Heb. "zealous")	The epithet indicates "zealous/zealot"; it does not in itself prove affiliation with the later political movement.	A/B
Judas Iscariot	Ἰούδας Ἰσκαριώτης	יהודה; איש־קריות? (ʾîš-Qərîyōt?)	"Judah" is certain; "Iscariot" as "man of Qeriot" is a classical hypothesis, not a certainty	A/C

5. ἀπόστολος, μαθητής and the agency of the envoy

Christian vocabulary distinguishes *μαθητής* ("disciple, apprentice") from *ἀπόστολος* ("sent one, delegate"). The noun ἀπόστολος derives from ἀποστέλλω, "to send." In earlier and contemporary Greek literature, it can designate dispatch, mission, or delegate, although its technical Christian sense developed within the communities of the first century.

The comparison with the late Hebrew שליח (šālîaḥ, "envoy/agent") is useful for thinking about legal and religious representation, but it must be handled with caution: the fully developed rabbinic system is later and does not constitute automatic proof that the apostolic title derives institutionally from an identical Jewish office.

6. Twelve apostles and twelve tribes: an explicit relationship in the gospel tradition

The relationship between the number of the Twelve and the twelve tribes of Israel has a much firmer textual basis than any astrological correlation. The selection of a group of twelve functions as a symbolic gesture of the restoration of Israel. Matthew 19:28 presents the Twelve seated on twelve thrones to judge "the twelve tribes of Israel"; Luke 22:30 preserves a parallel formulation. The replacement of Judas with Matthias in Acts 1:15–26 shows that the numerical integrity of the college has narrative and eschatological significance.

The tribal series, however, is not entirely rigid either. Old Testament lists may include Levi or exclude him, and may count Joseph as a single tribe or replace him

with Ephraim and Manasseh. The symbol "twelve" expresses the totality of Israel rather than a mathematically uniform genealogical scheme.

7. The number twelve in Israel, the calendar and the zodiac: a comparison without equivalence

The ancient Mediterranean was familiar with multiple duodecimal systems: twelve months, twelve zodiac signs, twelve tribes, twelve stones of the priestly breastplate, and, in Christianity, twelve apostles. Mere numerical equality does not demonstrate dependence. There is no Christian source from the first–second centuries that consistently assigns a zodiac sign to each apostle, nor a Jewish source from the Second Temple period that transforms the twelve tribes into a normative astrological table.

Ancient Jewish cosmological interpretations do exist. Philo sometimes interprets cultic objects of twelve elements in a cosmic key, and Josephus relates the twelve loaves of the bread of the Presence to the zodiac and the year (BJ V.217; cf. Ant. III.182). These analogies show that astral symbolism was intelligible within certain Hellenised Jewish circles; they do not, however, authorise identifying Peter with Aries, John with Cancer, or any other apostle with a specific sign.

Archaeology reinforces this chronological caution. Synagogue mosaics from the fourth–sixth centuries, such as Hammath Tiberias and Beth Alpha, incorporate zodiac wheels in unequivocally Jewish contexts. Their existence demonstrates the appropriation and reinterpretation of a Greco-Roman cosmological repertoire; it does not prove that the institution of the Twelve in the first century originated from the zodiac.

8. Comparative matrix of duodecimal series

TABLE 64. Comparative matrix of duodecimal series

Series of twelve	Principal body of evidence	Function	Historical evaluation
Twelve Tribes of Israel	Genesis 29–30; 35; 49; Numbers; variable traditions	Genealogy and totality of Israel	Ancient attestation; lists are not identical
Twelve apostles	Mark 3; Matt 10; Luke 6; Matt 19:28; Luke 22:30	Eschatological restoration and representation of Israel	Relationship with the tribes explicit in gospel tradition

(continued)

Series of twelve	Principal body of evidence	Function	Historical evaluation
Twelve stones of the breastplate	Exod 28	Cultic representation of the tribes	Subsequently susceptible to cosmological interpretations
Twelve months	Mediterranean and Jewish calendars	Annual order	Structural parallel, not religious genealogy
Twelve signs of the zodiac	Babylonian astronomy and Hellenistic tradition	Division of the ecliptic / astral calendar	Astral system prior to Christianity
Synagogue zodiac	Hammath Tiberias, Beth Alpha and other mosaics	Cosmology, calendar, providence; interpretation debated	Fourth–sixth centuries; too late to explain the Twelve on its own
Twelve apostles = twelve signs	Late and variable esoteric correspondences	Subsequent symbolic reception	Not documented as a stable system in Christianity of the first–second centuries; not adopted as a historical explanation

9. Conclusion: Onomastics and symbolism without anachronism

The names of Jesus and the Twelve reveal a multilingual culture in which Semitic names could be adopted into Greek through transliteration, semantic equivalence, or social substitution. The relationship between the Twelve and the tribes belongs to the oldest symbolic core of the movement; the relationship with the zodiac, on the other hand, belongs to the realm of structural comparison and later reception. The criterion of this monograph is to preserve the comparison when it illuminates the context and to discontinue it when the evidence no longer supports a historical genealogy.

Summary

This chapter examines the Greek, Hebrew, and Aramaic forms of the names of Jesus and the Twelve, distinguishing documented forms from plausible linguistic reconstructions. It analyses the semantic development of Χριστός from the Greek χρίω and the Hebrew מָשִׁיחַ, the explicit symbolic relationship between the Twelve and the twelve tribes of Israel, and the wider ancient use of duodecimal systems.

Zodiacal parallels are treated as phenomena of comparison and reception history; they do not, in themselves, prove an astrological origin of the apostolic college.

CHAPTER XVIII

Zoroastrianism and Early Christianity: Eschatology, Evil, Judgement, and Historical Comparison

The comparison between Zoroastrianism and Christianity is one of the oldest and most difficult debates in the comparative history of religions. There are real similarities in the conceptual vocabulary of the struggle between good and evil, judgement, resurrection, and final renewal; there are also profound theological differences and a crucial documentary problem: much of the systematic exposition of Zoroastrian cosmology is preserved in Pahlavi texts from a period well after the rise of Christianity. Therefore, this chapter rigorously distinguishes between typological similarity, the possibility of Iranian mediation through Second Temple Judaism, and demonstrable textual dependence.

1. Sources and chronology: from the Avesta to the Pahlavi texts

The Gāthās, integrated into the Avesta, contain the oldest strata linked to Zarathustra and articulate the moral choice between truth/order and falsehood. The Younger Avesta develops later figures and expectations. The systematic cosmology of Ohrmazd and Ahriman, the cycles of the world, and many details of the end times appear clearly in Pahlavi works written centuries later, even though they may preserve older traditions. This distance obliges us to avoid the circular procedure of using a medieval Iranian text as if it were a direct contemporary source for second-century BCE Judaism or first-century CE Christianity.

Historical contact, however, is undeniable: Jewish communities lived for centuries under Achaemenid, Parthian, and Sasanian rule; Babylon remained a key Jewish centre; and the networks of the Roman East connected Syria, Mesopotamia, and Iran. The question, therefore, is not whether there was contact, but what specific ideas can be shown to have been transferred and in what direction.

2. Ahura Mazdā, Angra Mainyu and the problem of dualism

In Zoroastrian traditions, Ahura Mazdā/Ohrmazd represents wisdom and good order, while Angra Mainyu/Ahriman embodies a destructive and hostile power. The exact configuration of this opposition changed historically and should not be reduced to a symmetrical "good god" and "evil god" across all eras. Iranian eschatology conceives of history as a moral and cosmic conflict whose ultimate outcome is the defeat of evil.

Christianity also develops an opposition between God and Satan, but it does not adopt an equivalent ontological dualism: Satan is a creature and adversary, not an eternal principle comparable to God. This difference is structural. The comparison with Angra Mainyu can illuminate the history of demonology in Second Temple Judaism and Christianity, but it does not justify identifying the two figures.

3. Aša, Druj, truth and falsehood

The Avestan opposition between aša—order, righteousness, truth—and druj—lie, deceit, disorder—has resonances comparable to Jewish and Christian languages of light/darkness, truth/falsehood, and justice/iniquity. The Qumran Community Rule, for example, articulates two spirits and two paths. The Gospel of John constructs a strong antithesis between truth and falsehood. However, binary oppositions are widespread phenomena and do not in themselves prove Iranian dependence.

3.1. Johannine traditions: light, darkness, truth, and falsehood

The Fourth Gospel structures a substantial part of its theological language through oppositions such as light/darkness, truth/falsehood, above/below, and life/death (John 1:4–9; 3:19–21; 8:44–47; 12:35–36). These antitheses allow a long-range comparison with the Iranian opposition between aša and druj, but comparison does not warrant treating Johannine vocabulary as a Christian translation of Zoroastrian categories. Genesis, Isaiah, sapiential traditions, and Jewish apocalyptic literature provide immediate scriptural matrices for much of the symbolism.

A historically closer comparandum appears in 1QS III.13–IV.26, where the Community Rule articulates opposing dominions of light and darkness and the "spirits" of truth and perversity. The similarities with John have long been debated, yet even here they do not require direct literary dependence. The Iranian horizon can serve as a longue-durée comparative background for certain ethical and eschatological dualisms in Second Temple Judaism; Jewish mediation and the distinctive reworking of

Johannine tradition must remain analytically separate from any hypothesis of direct borrowing.

4. The end of time: Fraš̄o.kərəti and renewal of creation

A major comparative parallel is the Zoroastrian expectation of a final renewal of the world, fraš̄o.kərəti (Pahlavi frašegird). In Avestan and later developments, history culminates in a definitive transformation: defeat of evil, resurrection of the dead, judgement, and incorruptible existence. Early Christianity similarly articulates resurrection, judgement, and cosmic renewal, although it does so from its own Jewish frameworks, particularly Daniel, the apocalyptic tradition of the Second Temple, and the interpretation of Jesus' resurrection as an inaugural event.

The hypothesis of Iranian influence on Jewish eschatology is plausible to some historians and disputed by others. The problem lies in mediation and chronology: several ideas known in systematic Zoroastrianism through later sources are already present in pre-Christian Jewish texts. Therefore, the monograph discusses a comparative horizon and possible influence, not a proven borrowing in each motif. The thesis of broad influence was championed above all by Mary Boyce, A History of Zoroastrianism (Leiden, 1975–1991); a more restrictive methodological assessment is James Barr, "The Question of Religious Influence: The Case of Zoroastrianism, Judaism, and Christianity," Journal of the American Academy of Religion 53 (1985).

5. Saošyant and messianism: similarities and limits

The Avestan term saošyant can mean "benefactor" or "the one who will bring benefit" (a future participle), and in later eschatological strata, it designates the final agent of renewal. Tradition developed the figure of the victorious Saošyant who participates in the final defeat of evil and the resurrection. Comparing him to the Jewish Messiah or Christ is legitimate in a history of soteriological types, but not as a genealogical identity: the functions, cosmologies, genealogies, and scriptural frameworks are different.

6. Kingdom of God and "kingdom of heaven"

The proclamation of βασιλεία τοῦ θεοῦ ("kingdom of God") and, in Matthew, βασιλεία τῶν οὐρανῶν ("kingdom of heaven") belongs primarily to the biblical and Jewish realm of divine sovereignty. Daniel, the Psalms, and Jewish apocalyptic literature provide direct antecedents. Zoroastrianism also recognises a culmination of

history under the ultimate triumph of good, which allows for an eschatological comparison. However, there is insufficient basis to derive the gospel expression "kingdom of heaven" from the Iranian lexicon.

7. The temptation of Jesus and the temptation of Zarathustra: Vendīdād 19, the wilderness, and the forty days

The accounts of Jesus' temptation (Mark 1:12–13; Matt 4:1–11; Luke 4:1–13) present Satan as an adversary and place the episode within forty days in the wilderness. The most immediate historical explanation of the number forty is biblical: Israel remains forty years in the wilderness; Moses spends forty days on Sinai; Elijah walks forty days to Horeb. The episode thus reworks Israelite typologies of trial, exodus and faithfulness.

The opposition between a divine messenger and an evil power lends itself to comparison with Zoroastrian cosmic drama, but no ancient Iranian parallel is known that specifically explains a temptation of the saviour during forty days in the desert. To present this detail as a Zoroastrian borrowing would be methodologically unjustified. The influence, if it existed, must be sought in the general transformation of demonology and eschatology, not in an exact narrative equivalence.

Vendīdād 19.1–10 preserves a fragment of the Zarathustra legend in which Angra Mainyu first attempts to destroy the prophet and then to turn him away from the "good religion"; Zarathustra rejects aggression and seduction through ritual formulae and sacred recitation. The tradition therefore provides a genuine comparandum for the broad motif of a prophet or divinely commissioned figure tested by a hostile power. The Vendīdād is, however, a stratified composition whose surviving manuscript transmission is much later; it cannot be treated as a contemporary witness to the Gospels.

The structural similarity does not erase the narrative differences. Vendīdād 19 contains neither a forty-day fast nor a wilderness setting corresponding to the Synoptic accounts, which are saturated with biblical allusions to Israel, Moses, and Elijah. The Iranian parallel is useful for a comparative history of confrontation between a religious agent and a cosmic adversary; the primary exegetical matrix for Mark 1:12–13, Matt 4:1–11, and Luke 4:1–13 remains Jewish and scriptural.

8. Resurrection, judgement and post-mortem destiny

Iranian religion developed ideas of individual judgement, afterlife, and final judgement. The Činvat bridge tradition is one of its best-known motifs. Bodily resurrection, final judgement, reward and punishment appear in Second Temple Judaism and in Christianity. The functional kinship of these systems has fuelled the hypothesis of Persian influence for over a century; direct evidence remains uneven. Jewish literature also offers sufficient internal developments to explain much of the evolution, so Iranian influence, when proposed, must be formulated as one possible factor within a complex history, not as the sole cause.

9. Matthew's μάγοι and the Iranian horizon

Matthew 2 uses the Greek plural *μάγοι* for the visitors from the East. The term had a long history and could designate Persian/Median ritual specialists, but in the Hellenistic world it also acquired broader meanings related to astrology, dream interpretation, and ritual practices. Matthew's text does not identify these μάγοι as Zoroastrian priests, nor does it offer an exposition of Iranian doctrine. Their "Eastern" origin and their astral observation make the cultural association intelligible, but do not justify treating them as official representatives of Zoroastrianism.

10. Critical matrix of Zoroastrian and Christian parallels

TABLE 65. Critical matrix of Zoroastrian and Christian parallels

Issue	Zoroastrianism	Judaism/ Christianity	Assessment	Degree of relationship
Good/evil conflict	Ahura Mazdā / Angra Mainyu; aša / druj	God / Satan; truth / falsehood	Strong structural parallel; different ontology	Comparison; possible mediated influence
Light/darkness; truth/falsehood	aša / druj; long-duration ethical dualisms	John 1; 3; 8; 12; 1QS III.13–IV.26	Phenomenological parallel; Qumran is a closer Jewish comparandum for John	Comparison; direct Iranian dependence not demonstrated
Final renewal	Frašō.kərəti / frašegird	New creation; eschatological consummation	Both bring history to its culmination in the victory of good	Debated influence; direct Jewish matrices
Resurrection	Developed in the Younger Avesta and later tradition	Daniel 12; 1 Corinthians 15; Revelation	Significant parallel	Possible long-term Iranian context, not a simple derivation

(continued)

Issue	Zoroastrianism	Judaism/ Christianity	Assessment	Degree of relationship
Eschatological agent	Saošyant	Messiah / Christ	Final saving function	Comparative typology, not identity
Final judgement	Final judgement and purification	Judgement of God / Christ	Functional parallel	Possible regional diffusion; complex sources and chronology
Adversary	Angra Mainyu/ Ahriman	Satan/διάβολος	A figure hostile to the divine order	Not equivalent; Satan is not a co-eternal principle
Temptation / adversary	Vendīdād 19: Angra Mainyu attempts to destroy and seduce Zarathustra; no wilderness or forty-day period	Mark 1:12–13; Matt 4:1–11; Luke 4:1–13	Genuine structural parallel, but the Synoptic narrative matrix is biblical	Comparison; not evidence of direct borrowing
Final kingdom	A world renewed under the victory of good	βασιλεία τοῦ θεοῦ / τῶν οὐρανῶν	Common eschatological horizon	The gospel expression is Jewish; broad parallel
Magi from the East	Tradition of Iranian Magi	μάγοι of Matt 2	Plausible cultural contact	Do not automatically identify them as Zoroastrian clergy

11. Zoroastrianism, Second Temple Judaism and historical mediation

The most solid historiographical approach to these contacts is not a direct line "Zarathustra → Jesus", but rather the long interaction between Jewish populations and Iranian worlds from the Achaemenid period, followed by the Parthian and Sasanian contexts. Eschatological concepts could circulate, be transformed and combine with Judaism's own biblical traditions. Qumran, apocalyptic literature, and other texts from the period show that Second Temple Judaism was not a passive recipient, but a creative laboratory capable of reworking any external influence within its own Scriptures and categories.

12. Conclusion: similarity, contact, and dependence

The interaction between Jewish and Iranian worlds has a secure historical basis. Judea was a province (Yehud) of the Achaemenid Empire from 539 to 332 BCE; Isaiah calls Cyrus "anointed" (Isa 45:1) and Ezra presents the return under Persian sponsorship; biblical Hebrew and Aramaic preserve Iranian loanwords of administrative, legal and religious vocabulary (pardēs, "park, paradise"; rāz, "secret", in Dan 2 and in the Qumran manuscripts). The Magi, as ritual specialists, appear in Greek sources from Herodotus on and are studied by A. de Jong. This basis allows us to speak of contact; it does not decide which concepts were transmitted or in which direction.

Against that background the symmetries among Zoroastrianism, Second Temple Judaism and first-century Christianity should be graded. (a) Dualism. The "Instruction on the Two Spirits" in the Community Rule (1QS III:13–IV:26), with its Prince of Lights and Angel of Darkness, is the closest parallel to the language of light and darkness, truth and falsehood that reappears in John 3:19–21; but the Qumran text subordinates both spirits to a single creator God, whereas the opposition of Ohrmazd and Ahriman is formulated in terms of two principles, with nuances that scholarship (Shaked) distinguishes between the Gāthās and Pahlavi literature. (b) Resurrection and judgement. Dan 12:2 is the clearest biblical affirmation of bodily resurrection for judgement; the Zoroastrian expectation of a resurrection (tan ī pasēn) is documented in detail only in Pahlavi texts, and the most cited ancient testimony, that of Theopompus transmitted by Diogenes Laertius (1.9), according to which the Magi taught that men would be resurrected, is brief and disputed. (c) Final renewal. The frašō.kərəti, with its definitive defeat of evil, admits typological comparison with the "new heavens and new earth" of Isa 65:17 and Rev 21:1; the comparison does not imply borrowing, because the idea of cosmic renewal has prophetic antecedents of its own. (d) Ordeal by fire. The molten-metal ordeal of the Pahlavi texts recalls the rivers of fire in Dan 7:9–10 and the fire of judgement in 2 Pet 3:7, but the dating of the Iranian texts prevents a direction being fixed. (e) Saving figure. The Saošyant, who renews the world, and the Jewish Messiah or Son of Man fulfil related functions in the structure of the end, but differ in origin and mission; late traditions about a virgin birth of the Saošyant should not be projected onto Matt 1–2.

A synthesis, strictly speaking, can be formulated in four grades. Secure historical contact: Persian rule over Judea, lexical loans, the presence of the Magi in Greek sources. Real conceptual parallels: moral dualism, judgement, resurrection and final renewal. Possible mediation: Enochic and Danielic apocalyptic and the Qumran texts, where material could be reworked within Jewish Scripture. Hypotheses with-

out proof: that Jesus, Paul or the evangelists knew Zoroastrian doctrines directly, that the Magi of Matt 2 are identifiable Zoroastrian priests, or that the Saošyant is a model for Christology. First-century Christianity stands at the end of that chain: it receives the eschatological repertoire already Judaised, not by way of the Avesta. The symmetry is therefore one of form—a history with beginning, conflict, judgement and renewal—and not of social process: what Christianity adds, and what comparative Zoroastrianism does not offer, is the anchoring of that scheme in an executed historical person, a community of shared table and, in the long run, a collection of writings.

This result is consistent with the book's thesis. To show that the vocabulary of the end—kingdom, judgement, resurrection, renewal—was available in a space of exchange stretching from Persia to Judea and Rome reinforces the reading of Christian formation as a convergence of fields of influence, and the Pauline reading of that convergence, because it was Paul who translated that repertoire for a community of Gentiles. Nothing obliges us to explain Christianity by Iranian dependence, and nothing authorises us to exclude contact as one more component of the environment.

Zoroastrianism and Christianity share a keen interest in the moral outcome of history, the defeat of evil, and ultimate justice. The similarities are too significant to ignore, but too general—and the sources too disparate—to automatically translate into direct dependence. The contribution of a critical comparison lies precisely in grading the evidence: certain historical contact, genuine conceptual parallels, possible Jewish mediations, and, finally, a core of claims for which there is no proof of borrowing. This criterion preserves comparative value without restoring esoteric or syncretic genealogies that this edition has excluded from the historical framework.

Summary

This chapter offers a controlled comparison between Zoroastrian eschatology and early Christianity. It examines cosmic opposition between good and evil, resurrection, final judgement, the Saošyant, the final renewal (frašō.kərəti), the kingdom of God, Satan, the forty-day temptation narrative, and the Magi in Matthew. It distinguishes historical contact from typological similarity and foregrounds the chronological difficulty posed by the late Pahlavi sources. Iranian influence on Jewish and Christian eschatologies remains a significant and contested hypothesis; claims of direct derivation require specific evidence.

CHAPTER XIX

Sages, Rabbis and Judaisms (First–Fourth Centuries): Comparison with the Jesus Movement and External Testimonies

This chapter brings together three problems that often appear scattered: the history of Jewish teachers and rabbis between the end of the Second Temple period and Late Antiquity; a disciplined comparison between first-century Judaism and the Jesus movement; and the dossier of Jewish and non-Jewish references to Jesus and the early Christians. The aim is not to construct two fully formed "religions" from the year 30 CE onward, but rather to trace processes of differentiation that shared scriptures, languages, institutions, practices, and conflicts. The use of the term "rabbi" requires caution: for Hillel, Shammai, or Gamaliel I, it is preferable to speak of sages or teachers; the institutionalisation of the rabbinic title belongs primarily to the period after 70 CE.

1. Method and vocabulary: from the sages of the Second Temple to Tannaitic and Amoraic rabbis

The surviving rabbinic literature—Mishnah, Tosefta, Midrashim, and Talmuds—reached written form long after the lifetimes of many of the figures it recalls. Therefore, any doctrinal attribution to Hillel, Shammai, Yohanan ben Zakkai, or Aqiva must distinguish between the possible historical memory of a teaching and its formulation within a collection written or transmitted generations later. The chapter uses the Tannaitic and Amoraic designations as historiographical categories of period, not as evidence of a uniform rabbinic institution from the first century onward.

Three levels are distinguished: [A] person and activity securely located in history by convergence of sources; [B] probable historical figure whose specific teaching depends on later traditions; [C] attribution or biographical detail of uncertain historicity. This scale avoids transforming the Mishnah or the Talmud into contemporary records of the events they narrate.

2. Critical table of relevant sages and rabbis, first–fourth centuries

TABLE 66. Critical table of relevant sages and rabbis, first–fourth centuries

Figure	Chronology	Centre	Main sources
Hillel the Elder (הלל הזקן)	late first century BCE–early first century CE	Jerusalem	Later Mishnaic and Talmudic traditions
Shammai (שמאי)	late first century BCE–early first century CE	Judea/Jerusalem	Mishnah and later traditions
Gamaliel I / Rabban Gamliel ha-Zaqen (רבן גמליאל הזקן)	c. first half of the first century	Jerusalem	Mishnah; Acts 5:34–39 as a narrative Christian testimony
Yohanan ben Zakkai (יוחנן בן זכאי)	c. 1–80	Judea / Yavne	Mishnah, Tosefta, Talmuds
Eliezer ben Hyrcanus (אליעזר בן הורקנוס)	late first century–early second century	Lod/Judea	Mishnah and Tosefta
Joshua ben Hananiah (יהושע בן חנניה)	late first century–early second century	Judea	Mishnah, Tosefta, Talmudic traditions
Tarfon (טרפון)	late first century–first half of the second century	Lod/Judea	Mishnah, Tosefta
Aqiva/Akiva ben Yosef (עקיבא בן יוסף)	c. 50–135	Judea	Mishnah, Tosefta, rabbinic traditions
Ishmael ben Elisha (ישמעאל בן אלישע)	First–second centuries	Judea	Tannaitic and midrashic tradition
Meir (מאיר)	Second century	Galilee/Judea	Mishnah and Tosefta

(continued)

Figure	Chronology	Centre	Main sources
Shimon bar Yohai (שמעון בר יוחאי)	Second century	Galilee	Mishnah, Tosefta; later traditions
Judah ha-Nasi (יהודה הנשיא)	c. 135–217	Galilee	Mishnah; rabbinic tradition
Hiyya Rabbah (Hiyya the Great) (חייא)	late second century–early third century	Galilee/Babylon	Baraitot and Talmudic traditions
Abba Arikha (Rav) (אבא אריכא / רב)	c. 175–247	Babylon	Babylonian Talmud
Samuel of Nehardea (שמואל)	c. 165–254	Babylon	Babylonian Talmud
Yohanan bar Nappaha (יוחנן בר נפחא)	c. 180–279	Tiberias	Palestinian and Babylonian Talmuds
Resh Lakish / Shimon ben Lakish (ריש לקיש / שמעון בן לקיש)	Third century	Galilee	Talmuds
Rav Huna (רב הונא)	c. 216–296	Sura/Babylon	Babylonian Talmud
Rav Nahman bar Yaakov (רב נחמן בר יעקב)	third–fourth centuries	Babylon	Babylonian Talmud
Abaye (אביי)	c. 280–338	Pumbedita/Babylon	Babylonian Talmud
Rava (רבא)	c. 280–352	Mahoza/Babylon	Babylonian Talmud

TABLE 67. Continuation of "Critical table of relevant sages and rabbis, first–fourth centuries"

Figure	Historical-critical relevance	Certainty
Hillel the Elder (הלל הזקן)	Sage associated with a flexible school of interpretation; foundational figure in rabbinic memory.	B
Shammai (שמאי)	Hillel's counterpart in multiple halakhic controversies; the Hillel-Shammai opposition was systematised by tradition.	B
Gamaliel I / Rabban Gamliel ha-Zaqen (רבן גמליאל הזקן)	Pharisee teacher of great prestige in later memory; the exact identification of each tradition requires caution.	B
Yohanan ben Zakkai (יוחנן בן זכאי)	A central figure in the memory of the post-70 reorganisation; Yavne should not be imagined as a "council" with universal jurisdiction.	A/B
Eliezer ben Hyrcanus (אליעזר בן הורקנוס)	Tanna associated with conservative traditions and debates over majority authority.	A/B

(continued)

Figure	Historical-critical relevance	Certainty
Joshua ben Hananiah (יהושע בן חנניה)	Prominent interlocutor in halakhic debates; associated with the Yavne period.	A/B
Tarfon (טרפון)	Tanna of Aqiva's generation; appears in legal and liturgical debates.	A/B
Aqiva/Akiva ben Yosef (עקיבא בן יוסף)	A decisive figure in rabbinic hermeneutics; his relationship with Bar Kosiba is transmitted by later rabbinic sources and must be formulated with caution.	A/B
Ishmael ben Elisha (ישמעאל בן אלישע)	Associated with hermeneutical rules and an exegetical school distinct from that attributed to Aqiva.	B
Meir (מאיר)	Tanna of major importance in the Mishnaic tradition; many anonymous mishnayot were later linked to his school.	A/B
Shimon bar Yohai (שמעון בר יוחאי)	Historical Tanna; the attribution of the Zohar is medieval and falls outside any reconstruction of the second century.	A
Judah ha-Nasi (יהודה הנשיא)	Patriarch associated with the compilation/writing of the Mishnah around 200; key figure in the transition from oral tradition to normative corpus.	A
Hiyya Rabbah (Hiyya the Great) (חייא)	Transitional figure between Tannaim and Amoraim; associated with teaching and transmission of baraitot.	A/B
Abba Arikha (Rav) (אבא אריכא / רב)	Disciple of Judah ha-Nasi according to tradition; founder associated with the Sura academy.	A/B
Samuel of Nehardea (שמואל)	Central Babylonian Amora; his debates with Rav structure large sections of the Talmud.	A/B
Yohanan bar Nappaha (יוחנן בר נפחא)	Palestinian Amora associated with Tiberias and the formation of traditions in the Jerusalem Talmud.	A/B
Resh Lakish / Shimon ben Lakish (שמעון בן לקיש / ריש לקיש)	A frequent interlocutor of Yohanan; his colourful biography contains later literary elements.	B
Rav Huna (רב הונא)	Second-generation Amora; important in the consolidation of Babylonian teaching.	A/B

(continued)

Figure	Historical-critical relevance	Certainty
Rav Nahman bar Yaakov (רב נחמן בר יעקב)	Amoraic jurist associated with Nehardea/Mahoza; chronology and homonymous figures require caution.	B
Abaye (אביי)	Fourth-generation Amora; with Rava, forms one of the great dialectical pairs of the Babylonian tradition.	A
Rava (רבא)	Abaye's main interlocutor; his debate occupies a structuring place in the Babylonian Talmud.	A

3. First-century Judaism and the Jesus movement: a disciplined historical comparison

The Jesus movement emerged within Second Temple Judaism. Therefore, the comparison should not oppose "Judaism" and "Christianity" as already established systems, but rather distinguish a plural Jewish field—Pharisees, Sadducees, priestly groups, apocalyptic movements, Diaspora communities, and other formations—within which a current emerged that proclaimed Jesus as Messiah and Lord. Only gradually, and unevenly according to city and region, did this current acquire increasingly Gentile institutional and demographic characteristics.

Table 68. First-century Judaism and the Jesus movement: problems compared

Problem	First-century Judaisms	Jesus Movement / First Communities	Comparative evaluation
Scriptures	Torah, Prophets and other writings with boundaries and textual forms not identical in all groups; Hebrew, Aramaic and Greek.	The same Scriptures of Israel constitute the basic archive of interpretation; the LXX acquires special importance in Greek communities.	Strong continuity; the divergence lies in the Christological reading and in the authority of new writings.

(continued)

Problem	First-century Judaisms	Jesus Movement / First Communities	Comparative evaluation
Temple	Sacrificial and symbolic centre until 70, with internal criticism and diversity of attitudes.	The first communities of Jerusalem appear linked to the Temple in Acts; the death and resurrection of Jesus reconfigure their interpretation.	The destruction of 70 transforms both fields, but does not produce an instantaneous separation.
Torah / halakha	Circumcision, the Sabbath, food, and purity are debated within a plural Judaism.	Jesus and his first followers are Jewish; the great conflict arises with the incorporation of Gentiles and the question of which obligations apply to them.	It is not equivalent to "Jewish law versus Christian grace"; the historical problem is who should observe what and why.
Messianism	Diverse expectations: royal, priestly, prophetic, apocalyptic, or absence of active expectation.	Jesus is identified as Messiah/Χριστός and his death is reinterpreted in light of resurrection and Scriptures.	The messianic claim is a specific intensification within a broader Jewish field.
Resurrection and eschatology	Accepted by some groups, disputed by others; abundant apocalyptic literature.	The resurrection of Jesus becomes a foundational affirmation and guarantee of the future resurrection.	It shares Jewish apocalyptic imagery, but reorganises it around Jesus.
Kingdom of God	Biblical and apocalyptic language of divine sovereignty.	Central theme of the synoptic preaching; it receives present and future interpretations.	Conceptual continuity with a strong eschatological reinterpretation.
Purity and table	Diverse systems of purity and commensality; importance of food and social boundaries.	Debates about table, food, and Gentiles are visible in Galatians 2, Romans 14, and 1 Corinthians.	The shared table becomes one of the main spaces for identity negotiation.

(continued)

Problem	First-century Judaisms	Jesus Movement / First Communities	Comparative evaluation
Authority	Priests, scribes, elders, teachers, and groups with their own systems of authority.	Apostles, prophets, teachers, elders/ episkopoi and domestic patrons; progressive institutionalisation.	From the outset there is no simple equivalence between synagogue and church, or between rabbi and bishop.
Gentiles	Proselytes, sympathisers, and various forms of relationship with non-Jews.	Paul's mission incorporates Gentiles without requiring them to fully become Jews through circumcision.	This point accelerates a long-term demographic and ritual differentiation.
Languages	Hebrew, Aramaic and Greek; administrative Latin in certain contexts.	Aramaic in the Palestinian environment; Greek dominant in the preserved Christian documentation; Latin grows in the West.	Multilingualism is shared and conditions transmission and interpretation.

4. After 70: Yavne, rabbinisation and Christianisation as asymmetrical processes

The destruction of the Temple in 70 CE forced numerous Jewish groups to reconfigure authority, worship, and memory. Later rabbinic tradition located a series of decisive figures and controversies in Yavne, but current historiography avoids imagining a central academy capable of instantly legislating for all synagogues. Similarly, the communities of Jesus' followers did not immediately transform into a uniform "Church." Both processes were regional, competitive, and uneven. The second century simultaneously reveals continuity, conflict, local separation, appropriation of Scripture, and a redefinition of categories of belonging.

5. Jewish and non-Jewish references to Jesus and the early Christian movement: a synthetic dossier without duplications

The external testimonies already discussed in Chapter I and in the Documentary Appendix are gathered here as a comparative matrix and then expanded upon only where the Jewish archive presents specific problems of transmission, identification, and reception. The complete texts of Josephus, Tacitus, Pliny, and Suetonius are not repeated: their date, relative independence, subject of reference, and principal critical difficulty are recorded. The new material concentrates on Josephus, rabbinic literature, the traditions concerning Yeshu/Miryam, the minim, and the negative controls that prevent Qumran or medieval materials from being converted into first-century testimonies.

TABLE 69. Jewish and non-Jewish references to Jesus: sources

Source	Environment / language	Date	Object
Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64 (18.3.3) (Testimonium Flavianum)	Jewish / Greek	c. 93–94	Jesus
Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1)	Jewish / Greek	c. 93–94	James, "brother of Jesus called Christ"
Tosefta Hullin 2.22–24 and later parallels	Rabbinic / Hebrew-Aramaic	ancient tradition; later redaction	Healing "in the name of Jesus ben Pantera/ Pandera" and boundaries vis-à-vis the minim
b. Sanhedrin 43a	Rabbinic / Aramaic-Hebrew	Late Talmudic redaction	Yeshu and execution on the eve of Passover
Tacitus, Ann. XV.44	Roman / Latin	c. 116	Christus and Christians of Rome under Nero
Pliny the Younger, Ep. X.96–97	Roman / Latin	c. 111–113	Christians in Bithynia
Suetonius, Claud. 25.4	Roman / Latin	c. 120	Jewish riots in Rome "impulsore Chresto"
Suetonius, Ner. 16.2	Roman / Latin	c. 120	Christiani

(continued)

Source	Environment / language	Date	Object
Mara bar Serapion, letter to his son	Syriac / non-Christian context	debated dating: first–third centuries	"wise king" of the Jews
Lucian of Samosata, De morte Peregrini 11–13	Greco-Roman / Greek	c. 165–175	Christians and their "crucified sophist"
Celsus, Alethes Logos, preserved in Origen, Against Celsus	Pagan / Greek	c. 170–180	Jesus and Christians

TABLE 70. Continuation of "Jewish and non-Jewish references to Jesus: sources"

Source	Critical problem	Historiographical value
Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64 (18.3.3) (Testimonium Flavianum)	The transmitted text contains Christian formulations that can scarcely derive in their entirety from Josephus; there is extensive debate about a Josephan core and later interpolations.	Medium-high value for a possible core; transmitted form cannot be used without textual criticism.
Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1)	Incidental reference within the narrative about the high priest Ananus; far less open to suspicion of interpolation than the Testimonium.	One of the most solid external testimonies about the historical existence of Jesus as a reference point for identification.
Tosefta Hullin 2.22–24 and later parallels	The identification and stratification of the traditions are debated; the preserved text is later than the first century.	Important for the history of religious boundaries, not as a contemporary biography of Jesus.
b. Sanhedrin 43a	Late, polemical and complex passage; it does not constitute independent first-generation testimony.	Useful for late Jewish reception and polemical memory, with extreme chronological caution.
Tacitus, Ann. XV.44	Tacitus states that Christus was executed under Pontius Pilate during the reign of Tiberius and calls Pilate procurator; epigraphic evidence, however, identifies his office as praefectus Iudaeae. Tacitus does not reveal his source and writes some eight decades later.	A non-Christian testimony of great importance about the movement and its origin in Judea.
Pliny the Younger, Ep. X.96–97	It describes interrogations, meetings, and singing to Christ "as to a god"; it does not offer biographical information about Jesus.	Early and direct administrative testimony on provincial Christian practices.

(continued)

Source	Critical problem	Historiographical value
Suetonius, Claud. 25.4	Chrestus may be a spelling variant or confusion related to Christus, but also a personal name; the connection with Jesus is uncertain.	It should be preserved as an ambiguous testimony, not as a certain mention of Jesus.
Suetonius, Ner. 16.2	He mentions punishment of Christians as a "new and evil superstition," without explicit reference to Jesus.	It confirms the group's visibility in Rome, not its founding biography.
Mara bar Serapion, letter to his son	It does not name Jesus and the dating is uncertain; the identification is plausible but not demonstrable.	Possible testimony, of limited value due to chronological and nominal indeterminacy.
Lucian of Samosata, De morte Peregrini 11–13	Satirical and hostile; it offers an external description of solidarity and Christian devotion.	Important for social perception of the movement in the second century.
Celsus, Alethes Logos, preserved in Origen, Against Celsus	The original work was lost and must be reconstructed through a Christian refuter; it contains polemics against the birth, miracles, and authority of Jesus.	A crucial dossier for pagan criticism of the second century, always mediated by Origen.

5.1. Evaluation protocol: testimony, reception and controversy

Jewish references to Jesus, his family, and figures associated with his followers do not form a homogeneous archive. The corpus combines Josephus, a first-century Jewish author writing in Greek for an imperial audience, with rabbinic traditions committed to writing several centuries later, and with medieval polemical compositions. This section does not accumulate "proof" of historicity; rather, it classifies testimonies according to date, proximity, independence, transmission, and rhetorical function. The question is not only what each text says, but when it says it, in what genre, for what purpose, and what distance exists between the narrated referent and the preserved literary form.

The scale used is: [A] chronologically proximate and philologically controllable testimony; [B] early testimony whose transmitted form presents significant textual intervention or debate; [C] late tradition which may preserve earlier materials but whose specific historicity cannot be safely isolated; [D] polemical construction or late reception, useful for the history of representations but not as a direct source for the first century. The gradation applies to the passage, not to the person in the abstract.

Rabbinic literature requires additional caution. The Mishnah was compiled around the beginning of the third century; the Tosefta and the Tannaitic midrashim

are products of complex transmission; the Jerusalem Talmud took shape in Late Antiquity, and the Babylonian Talmud reached its redaction long after the events of the first century. A saying attributed to an early Tanna may preserve ancient tradition, but the narrative form that frames it may be Amoraic or post-Amoraic. Therefore, the book distinguishes between internal attribution and preserved date of redaction.

5.2. Josephus: Jesus and James as distinct textual problems

The first section separates two passages from the Antiquitates Judaicae. Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64 (18.3.3), the so-called Testimonium Flavianum, is preserved in Greek manuscripts with unequivocally Christian formulations. Modern scholarship ranges from complete interpolation, through a retouched Josephan core, to substantial authenticity with glosses. This monograph adopts a position of minimal certainty: the received text cannot be cited as if all its content came without modification from Josephus; however, it is methodologically legitimate to discuss the possibility of a non-Christian core prior to the reworking.

Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1) is quite different: here Josephus mentions the execution of "James, brother of Jesus called Christ." The passage is integrated into the narrative of the high priest Ananus and lacks the confessional density of the Testimonium. Although all ancient manuscript traditions must be subjected to criticism, this locus possesses a considerably greater degree of historical acceptability. The expression "called Christ" functions as an identifier and does not imply Josephus's adherence to the Christian confession.

The difference is methodologically decisive: there is no single category of "Josephus's testimony about Jesus." Each locus has its own textual history, narrative function, and probative value.

Table 71. Jewish and Judaeo-Roman testimonies: graded assessment of evidence

Source	Date of preserved form	Subject	Degree	Critical evaluation
Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64 (18.3.3)	c. 93–94 CE	Jesus	[B]	Text transmitted with Christian formulations; debated Josephan core. Do not use the received text as a homogeneous block.

(continued)

Source	Date of preserved form	Subject	Degree	Critical evaluation
Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1)	c. 93–94 CE	James; Jesus "called Christ"	[A/B]	Contextual reference to James within the conflict concerning Ananus; generally considered more secure than Ant. XVIII.
t. Ḥullin 2.22–24 / parallels	Tannaitic tradition, later transmitted form	Yaʿaqov of Kefar Sekhanya; Yeshu ben Pantera	[C]	Polemical material on healing and minim; do not automatically identify Yaʿaqov with James.
b. Sanh. 43a	Late Babylonian redaction	Yeshu; five disciples	[C/D]	Execution on the eve of Passover and a list of disciples within a legal and polemical framework; not equivalent to a first-century court record.
b. Šabb. 104b; b. Sanh. 67a	Late Babylonian redaction	Ben Stada / Ben Pandera; Miriam	[D]	Overlapping and anachronistic traditions; main value for the history of controversy, not for biography.
Toledot Yeshu	Medieval, with diverse layers	Jesus, Miriam, disciples	[D]	Multifaceted Jewish anti-gospel; not an independent source for the first century, although it may preserve older polemical motifs.

5.3. Yeshu in rabbinic literature: identification, chronology and limits

The name ישו (Yeshu) appears in several units of the Babylonian Talmud and in parallel traditions, but the identity of each figure should not be taken for granted. Some narratives place Yeshu in chronological frameworks incompatible with Jesus of Nazareth; others associate him with execution, Passover eve, sorcery, the seduction of Israel, or disciples. The overlapping of motifs indicates polemical memory and

reworking, not a continuous chronicle. The standard study of this dossier is Peter Schäfer, Jesus in the Talmud (Princeton, 2007), which reads these passages as a late Babylonian counter-narrative to the Gospels.

The passage b. Sanh. 43a is the most frequently cited example. It presents the execution of Yeshu on the eve of Passover and adds a scene of prior proclamation and a list of five disciples: Mattai, Naqai, Netser, Buni, and Todah. The structure is interwoven with scriptural wordplay and legal arguments. Its thematic proximity to the passion tradition makes the passage relevant for studying the Jewish reception of Jesus; however, its date of composition and literary form preclude classifying it as a first-century court record.

The traditions concerning disciples of Jesus named Yaʿaqov—of Kefar Sekhanya, in the Tosefta (t. Hul. 2:22–24), and of Kefar Sama, in the Palestinian and Babylonian parallels—are especially useful for studying the boundaries between minim and rabbis. In t. Hul. 2:22–23 (cf. y. AZ 2:2, 40d; b. AZ 27b), Yaʿaqov of Kefar Sama offers to heal Ben Dama "in the name of Yeshua ben Pantera"; the printed editions of the Bavli, affected by censorship, omit the name. The narrative defines a problem of religious authority and healing. There is insufficient basis to identify this Yaʿaqov with James of the New Testament.

5.4. Miriam / Mary: rabbinic tradition and identification problems

The search for "Mary" in rabbinic sources is particularly vulnerable to harmonisation. b. Shabbat 104b and b. Sanhedrin 67a contain a tradition about Ben Stada/Ben Pandera and state that his mother was named מרים (Miryam), described in the passage as a plaiter of women's hair. The scene is embedded in a later discussion, presents contradictory names and family relationships, and does not offer a secure chronological link to Mary, the mother of Jesus.

The coincidence of the name Miriam—very common in the Judaism of the time—is not enough to identify this figure with the Μαριάμ / Μαρία of Christian traditions. The value of the material lies in showing how certain later Jewish polemics reworked motifs about birth, filiation, and magic. This work records the passage as a polemical reception [D], not as an independent biographical account of Mary.

The more developed narratives about Miriam in Toledot Yeshu belong to a multifaceted medieval textual history. They may preserve motifs with late antique antecedents, but they should not be traced back to the first century; they are used solely for the history of Jewish–Christian reception and controversy.

5.4A. Celsus, Panthera and the counter-narratives about the birth of Jesus

The oldest surviving testimony associating the birth of Jesus with a figure named Panthera (Πανθήρα) comes from Celsus, a pagan author of the second half of the second century. His Ἀληθὴς λόγος does not survive independently: it must be reconstructed through Origen's refutation. In Contra Celsum I.28, Celsus's Jewish interlocutor rejects the virgin birth, and in I.32 he identifies the supposed father as a soldier named Panthera.

The status of the passage is polemical and mediated [B/C]. Celsus wrote more than a century and a half after the events, and his formulation is known only through selection, quotation, and paraphrase by a Christian adversary. The text demonstrates the circulation, in the second century, of an anti-Christian counter-narrative concerning the parentage of Jesus; it does not constitute contemporary or independent evidence of his birth.

The nominal similarities with ben Pandera/Pantera in later rabbinic materials warrant comparison, but do not demonstrate a continuous documentary chain from the first century. This edition does not merge Yeshu, ben Stada, and ben Pandera into a single biography, nor does it use those materials as "proof" of historical lineage.

Table 72. Celsus, Panthera and counter-narratives on the birth of Jesus: levels of evidence

Level	Source	Date / Transmission	Legitimate use	Restriction
A	Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1)	c. 93–94	First-century Jewish testimony about James and "Jesus called Christ"	It does not report on birth or Panthera.
B	Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64 (18.3.3)	c. 93–94; problematic received text	Possible Josephan core under textual criticism	Do not cite the received form as entirely authentic.
B/C	Celsus in Origen, Cels. I.28; I.32	c. 170–180; preserved indirectly	History of the pagan controversy of the second century	Not an independent biography of Jesus.
C/D	Yeshu / ben Stada / ben Pandera	Late Antiquity, diverse strata	Reception history and controversy	Do not project to the first century without stratigraphic evidence.
D	Toledot Yeshu	Medieval, multifaceted tradition	Medieval history of the controversy	Not a direct source for the historical Jesus.

5.5. Apostles, disciples and minim: what can and cannot be identified

Rabbinic literature does not offer an independent and early catalogue of the Twelve. The list of five disciples in b. Sanh. 43a does not coincide with the Synoptic lists and is constructed using biblical wordplay. Therefore, it cannot be used to reconstruct the historical circle of the apostles. Similarly, the terms מינים (minim) and נוצרים (noṣrim / Nazarenes, in certain witnesses and contexts) are not transparent labels that always designate Christians.

The Birkat ha-Minim (ברכת המינים) illustrates the problem. Rabbinic sources attribute to Samuel ha-Qatan the formulation or reformulation of a blessing against the minim, but the textual form and historical scope of the petition varied. The presence of noṣrim in late liturgical testimonies does not demonstrate that an identical anti-Christian clause functioned universally in synagogues at the end of the first century. Nor does it establish a coordinated and simultaneous expulsion of all Jewish followers of Jesus. See Reuven Kimelman, "Birkat Ha-Minim and the Lack of Evidence for an Anti-Christian Jewish Prayer in Late Antiquity," in E. P. Sanders (ed.), Jewish and Christian Self-Definition, vol. 2 (Philadelphia, 1981).

For the history of the apostles, later Jewish sources are primarily an archive of reception, classification of otherness, and polemical memory. The principal control remains the undisputed Pauline epistles, the Gospels and Acts subject to literary criticism, Josephus for James, and second-century Christian documentation.

Table 73. Rabbinic figures and labels associated with Jesus: prosopographical assessment

Form	Source	Possible reference	Caution
ישו — Yeshu	b. Sanh. 43a and others	Jesus of Nazareth: possible in some passages, not automatic	The chronology and framework vary between traditions.
ישו הנוצרי — Yeshu ha-Notzri	Some Babylonian witnesses/traditions	More explicit Christian identification	Text form and distribution must be verified against the relevant edition or manuscript.
יעקב איש כפר סכניא — Yaʿaqov of Kefar Sekhanya	t. Ḥullin; b. Avodah Zarah 27b	Follower/min associated with Jesus	Do not identify with James of the NT without additional evidence.

(continued)

Form	Source	Possible reference	Caution
מרים — Miryam	b. Šabb. 104b; b. Sanh. 67a	Woman linked to Ben Stada/Pandera	No secure identification with Mary, mother of Jesus.
מינים — minim	Diverse rabbinic literature	Heretics/sectarians, variable referent	It does not automatically equate to "Christians."
נוצרים — noṣrim	Witnesses and late contexts	Nazarenes/Christians	Its presence in the Birkat cannot be projected backwards without textual verification.

5.6. Negative controls: Qumran, silences, and sources that must not be turned into testimonies

The Dead Sea Scrolls contain no identifiable mention of Jesus, Mary, or the apostles. Similarities between the language of certain Qumran texts and New Testament vocabulary—eschatology, ethical dualisms, community, purity, and prophetic interpretation—belong to the study of the shared Jewish milieu, not to a biographical archive of Jesus. Any identification of the "Teacher of Righteousness" or other Qumran figures with Jesus falls outside the standards of this edition.

The silence of a source does not constitute simple negative evidence either. The absence of Jesus in surviving Jewish authors or corpora may be due to thematic selection, documentary loss, the local scale of the movement in its early decades, or later transmission. This method avoids both the apologetic argument by accumulation and the sceptical argument based exclusively on silence.

Table 74. Hierarchy for the historical use of Jewish sources on Jesus and his environment

Level	Corpus	Primary legitimate use	Restriction
[A]	Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1)	History of the first century / prosopography	It can support historical claims subject to ordinary textual verification.

(continued)

Level	Corpus	Primary legitimate use	Restriction
[B]	Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64 (18.3.3)	Textual history of Josephus / Christian reception	Use only after separating received text and minimal reconstruction.
[C]	Tosefta and Tannaitic traditions transmitted later	Rabbinic boundaries / memory of the minim	Possibly ancient material, but never without distinguishing attributed date and date of redaction.
[C/D]	Babylonian Talmud on Yeshu	Reception and controversy in late antiquity	Do not treat as contemporary documentation of the trial of Jesus.
[D]	Toledot Yeshu	History of medieval controversy	Exclude as a biographical source from the first century.
[Negative control]	Qumran	Context of Second Temple Judaism	It contains no identifiable mention of Jesus, Mary, or the apostles.

6. Avoiding double counting: protocol for internal cross-references

To avoid repetition, this chapter serves as a point of synthesis. The full analysis of Josephus, Tacitus, Pliny, and Suetonius is to be found in Chapter I § 2.1 and in the Documentary Appendix; the discussion of *ἀποσυνάγωγος*, Yavne, and Birkat ha-Minim in Chapter VII and Chapter I § 1.9; and the problem of Paul within Judaism in the review of scholarship and Chapter I § 4.2. Here, these archives are compared only from an institutional and chronological perspective.

7. Conclusion: from plural Judaism to rabbinic and Christian trajectories

Between the first and fourth centuries, there was no simple replacement of "Judaism" by "Christianity," nor were there two blocs that separated all at once. There were diverse forms of Judaism, movements of followers of Jesus, expanding Gentile communities, and, after 70 and 135 CE, parallel processes of textual, ritual, and institutional reorganisation. Rabbinic tradition attained its own normative forms through the Mishnah, the Tosefta, the Midrashim, and the Talmuds; the churches developed canons, episcopates, liturgies, and theological languages. Scholarly comparison is most fruitful when it describes these trajectories as asymmetrical historical processes of selection, memory, and authority, not as predetermined destinies.

Summary

This chapter presents prominent Jewish sages and rabbis from the first–fourth centuries, compares first-century Jewish configurations with the Jesus movement, and brings together Jewish and non-Jewish references to Jesus and the early Christians. It distinguishes the Second Temple sages from later rabbinic institutionalisation, treats Yavne as a complex process after 70 CE, and evaluates Josephus, rabbinic traditions, Tacitus, Pliny, Suetonius, Mara bar Serapion, Lucian, and Celsus according to their chronology, independence, transmission, and polemical context.

CHAPTER XX

Architecture, Surveying and Infrastructure in the Roman Empire (First–Fourth Centuries): Technical Texts and the Transformation of Christian Space

This chapter examines the written sources for reconstructing the architectural and technical culture of the Empire between the first and fourth centuries CE. It does not automatically identify "Christian architecture" with its own treatise tradition: for most of the period, Christian groups inhabited, adapted, and reinterpreted spatial forms produced by Roman, Hellenistic, and provincial architecture. Therefore, three levels of evidence are distinguished: technical and administrative treatises; literary descriptions of buildings; and independent archaeological evidence. Vitruvius is included as a Republican and Augustan antecedent whose work continued to be reused, not as an author of the first century CE.

1. Vitruvius as a technical antecedent received in the imperial era

Marcus Vitruvius Pollio composed De architectura in the first century BCE. Its presence in this chapter reflects the enduring relevance of its technical vocabulary: ordinatio, dispositio, distributio, firmitas, utilitas, and venustas; materials; water supply; public and private buildings; temples; machines; and gnomonics. For the history of Christianity, its significance lies not in postulating a doctrinal transmission between architecture and religion, but in describing part of the technical framework within which cities, houses, basilicas, baths, porticoes, and hydraulic systems were built and later used by Christian communities.

The sequence of the ten books of De architectura is used here solely as the material organisation of a technical treatise and as long-term testimony on the city, building resources, public and private buildings, hydraulics, machines and measurement. It is not credited with a hidden numerological structure or a symbolic architecture that

the text does not document. For the present study, its value lies in offering a technical and typological vocabulary open to historical comparison with later building practices, without turning that terminological continuity into religious dependence.

2. Frontinus and water administration: De aquaeductu urbis Romae

Sextus Julius Frontinus, appointed curator aquarum in 97 CE, wrote De aquaeductu urbis Romae as a technical and administrative record of Rome's water supply system. The text combines the history of aqueducts, flow measurement, pipe sizes, fraud, maintenance, easements, and personnel organisation. For this monograph, its importance is twofold: it documents the infrastructure that made urban concentration possible and shows that the material conditions for gathering, hygiene, water sources, baths, and population density depended on complex public systems. It should not be used to infer that Christian communities controlled these infrastructures; it provides the urban framework within which they operated.

3. Pliny the Elder and Pliny the Younger: materials, monuments and the administration of building

Books XXXIV–XXXVI of Pliny the Elder's Natural History gather information on metals, pigments, stones, marbles, sculpture, and buildings. His encyclopaedic perspective does not amount to a design manual, but it preserves material vocabulary, information on provenances, and monumental records indispensable for understanding the building culture of the High Empire. Pliny the Younger adds another archive: his correspondence with Trajan reveals funding problems, unfinished works, baths, aqueducts, theatres, and provincial oversight. These letters document architecture and public works as an administrative practice rather than merely an aesthetic form.

4. Surveying and territory: the Corpus agrimensorum Romanorum

The literature of the surveyors—Frontinus in his gromatic role, Hyginus Gromaticus, Siculus Flaccus, and other texts transmitted in the Corpus agrimensorum Romanorum—documents boundaries, centuriation, land categories, disputes, and measurement procedures. Roman territory thus appears as a legally constructed space. This corpus is of interest to early Christianity because cities, cemeteries, foundations, rural properties, and roads did not exist on neutral ground: they were subject to regimes of possession, taxation, and delimitation. The date and authorship of each

treatise must be addressed separately; the "corpus" is a later manuscript compilation of diverse materials.

5. Pseudo-Hyginus, De munitionibus castrorum: military architecture and spatial order

De munitionibus castrorum, formerly attributed to Hyginus and now conventionally referred to as Pseudo-Hyginus, describes the layout of a military camp. Its dating within the High Empire remains debated, with proposals ranging from the Trajanic period to later in the second century. The work shows how military space could be organised through measurements, hierarchies, circulation, and functional allocation. It is particularly useful for frontier cities like Dura-Europos, but its principles should not be mechanically applied to the Christian building excavated there: camp, city, and adapted house belong to different scales of evidence.

6. Faventinus and the practical transmission of Vitruvius

Marcus Cetius Faventinus, probably between the third and fourth centuries, composed a compendium of architectural technique known as *Artis architectonicae privatis usibus adbreviatus liber*, also transmitted under titles similar to *De diversis fabricis architectonicae*. The work abbreviates and reorganises Vitruvian material for domestic and private use. Its existence is crucial for the history of Vitruvius's reception: it demonstrates that Vitruvius was not merely an ancient literary monument, but a wellspring that could be summarised and adapted to later needs. Precisely for this reason, its transmission must be studied through specific texts and not through supposed symbolic continuities.

7. Eusebius and the Christian description of the monumental building

With the Constantinian peace, the scale of documentation changed. Eusebius of Caesarea, in his Ecclesiastical History X.4, preserves the panegyric dedicated to the reconstruction of the church of Tyre, and in his Vita Constantini, descriptions of imperial programmes linked to Jerusalem and other centres. These texts are not treatises on architecture: they are theological-political discourses that transform building, patronage, and liturgy into signs of restoration. Therefore, they must be compared with archaeology, topography, and construction phases. Their value lies precisely in showing how monumental architecture began to be narrated as an argument for Christian legitimacy.

8. Mishnah Middot and other Jewish spatial texts

The Mishnah, compiled around the beginning of the third century CE, though preserving earlier traditions, contains in Middot a normative description of the Temple in Jerusalem. It is neither a Roman architectural treatise nor a precise modern archaeological plan. It is, however, a major source for studying the remembered spatial order of the sanctuary, its measurements, access points, courtyards, and hierarchies. Comparison with Josephus and with archaeology reveals how different corpora construct sacred space textually after the destruction of 70 CE.

9. From the domus and the insula to the basilica: typological continuity and change of scale

Documentation from the first to third centuries forces us to resist an overly simplistic genealogy according to which the "house-church" evolved linearly into the basilica. Communities gathered in homes, workshops, and adaptable spaces; Dura-Europos offers an exceptional archaeological case, not a universal model: a private house adapted for worship and sealed by the city's destruction after the Sasanian siege of 256/257, whose chronology derives from stratigraphy rather than from literary tradition. In the fourth century, the basilica provided scale, axiality, visibility, and processional capacity, but its adoption depended on patronage, urban land, and political circumstances. The change is both institutional and material: not the sudden invention of a specifically Christian architectural type.

10. Critical catalogue of architectural and technical texts and corpora, first–fourth centuries

TABLE 75. Critical catalogue of architectural-technical texts and corpora, first–fourth centuries

Work / corpus	Date	Language	Space/Technical Field	Caution in use
Vitruvius, De architectura	first century BCE; imperial reception	Latin	City, buildings, materials, water, machines	Essential background; not a work from the first century CE; exclude unproven numerological readings.

(continued)

Work / corpus	Date	Language	Space/Technical Field	Caution in use
Frontinus, De aquaeductu urbis Romae	c. 97–100	Latin	Aqueducts, administration, hydraulic surveying	Technical-administrative source of Rome; not a general treatise on architecture.
Pliny, Naturalis historia XXXIV–XXXVI	c. 77	Latin	Materials, arts, stones, monuments	Material encyclopaedia; it combines observation, tradition and exempla.
Pliny the Younger, Epistulae X	c. 110–113	Latin	Provincial public works and supervision	Administrative archive; each work must be contextualised locally.
Corpus agrimensorum: Frontinus/ Hyginus/Siculus Flaccus	First–second centuries; various dates	Latin	Gromatic practice: boundaries, centuriation, controversies	Corpus of later transmission; avoid homogenising authors and dates.
Pseudo-Hyginus, De munitionibus castrorum	First–second centuries; disputed dating	Latin	Camp layout and organisation	Anonymous author; attribution to Hyginus abandoned.
Faventinus, Artis architectonicae...	Probably third–fourth centuries	Latin	Compendium of private architecture	Testimony of practical reception of Vitruvius; chronology not absolute.
Mishnah, Middot	Compilation c. 200	Mishnaic Hebrew	Memory and measurements of the Temple	Normative text/ memorial; not a contemporary archaeological survey.
Eusebius, HE X.4	early fourth century	Greek	Church of Tyre and monumentalisation	Panegyric; rhetoric and architecture must be distinguished.
Eusebius, Vita Constantini III–IV	c. 337–339	Greek	Imperial patronage and holy sites	Source of programme and memory; requires archaeological verification.

(continued)

Work / corpus	Date	Language	Space/Technical Field	Caution in use
Vegetius, Epitoma rei militaris	late fourth century, dating debated	Latin	Camps, fortification, logistics	Military text, not an architectural treatise; useful for late technical culture.
Palladius, Opus agriculturae	Turn of the fourth and fifth centuries	Latin	Villas, rural facilities, building economy	It is used only as a late horizon and with an explicit date.

II. *Architecture and Christianity: what can be demonstrated*

The historical result is not a continuous "Christian architecture" from Jesus to Constantine, but a sequence of spatial appropriations within pre-existing imperial infrastructures. Technical texts document materials, measurements, hydraulics, ownership, and typologies; fourth-century Christian sources reveal the new capacity for monumentalisation; archaeology serves as a control on both archives. This method avoids two reductionisms: reading architecture as a mere illustration of theology and, conversely, deducing doctrine directly from a building form.

Conclusion

Between the first and fourth centuries, the Empire's building culture was sustained by technical knowledge circulated in treatises, compendia, regulations, administrative correspondence, and construction practices. Christianity emerged within this material world. The Constantinian transformation did not introduce architecture into Christian history; rather, it changed the economic, legal, and monumental scale of a relationship with space that already depended on houses, streets, ports, necropolises, water, roads, and urban networks. Comparison of Vitruvius, Frontinus, the surveyors, Faventinus, and Eusebius makes it possible to narrate this transition without equating technical continuity with ideological continuity.

CHAPTER XXI

The Canonical Gospels in Comparison: Chronology, Literary Dependence, Divergences, and Christologies

This chapter compares Mark, Matthew, Luke, and John as four related but not interchangeable ancient literary compositions. Its aim is neither to produce a continuous gospel harmony nor to transform every divergence into an insoluble contradiction. The historical-critical comparison begins with a more demanding principle: each Gospel must first be read according to its own narrative architecture, language, sources, community context, and theological programme; only then can the parallel accounts be compared. In a monograph on the first to fourth centuries, this comparison is crucial because the four Gospels were transformed, during the second century, into a normative collection without thereby losing their differences.

The Gospels cannot be dated with absolute years. The proposed dates depend on internal evidence, their relationship to the Jewish-Roman War and the destruction of the Temple, the literary dependence between texts, the history of their reception, and the earliest manuscript evidence. Working ranges and degrees of probability are therefore used. The dates of the surviving manuscripts are also not dates of composition: a papyrus from the second century proves the text was in circulation by that time, but not the exact year the Gospel was written.

1. Probable dates and composition context

Mark is usually placed roughly between 65 and 75 CE, with a concentration of proposals around 70. The prophecy concerning the destruction of the Temple in Mark 13 can be read as an earlier prophetic tradition, as redacted in light of the war, or as a combination of both. The date cannot be mechanically deduced from a single verse. Matthew and Luke-Acts are placed, in most contemporary scholarship, after Mark and usually between 80 and 95, although earlier and later proposals exist. Dependence on Mark, when accepted, establishes a relative terminus: Matthew and Luke must be later than the Markan text they used.

John presents a different problem. The fourth Gospel shares characters, events, and traditions with the Synoptic Gospels, but it organises the ministry differently and presents its own Christological language. A dating to around 90–100 CE remains a common working hypothesis, although the composition history may have been layered and some materials may be earlier. John's presence in second-century papyri rules out excessively late chronologies, but it does not justify converting the palaeography of P52 into an exact date of composition.

TABLE 76. Canonical Gospels: probable dates and context of composition

Gospel	Working range	Key indicators	Methodological caution
Mark	c. 65–75	Jewish War; Mark 13; Markan priority in the two-source hypothesis.	Do not derive an exact date from Mark 13; distinguish between tradition and redaction.
Matthew	c. 80–95	Use of Mark; ecclesial development; intra/inter-Jewish conflict; reworking of legal tradition.	Community location is probabilistic; Antioch is plausible, not proven.
Luke	c. 80–95 (with broader proposals)	Use of Mark; relationship with Acts; post-Pauline horizon and reflection on Israel/Gentiles.	The date of Acts conditions that of Luke, but the argument is not self-sufficient and risks circularity.

(continued)

Gospel	Working range	Key indicators	Methodological caution
John	c. 90–100, with a possible redactional history	High Christology; relationship with synagogue and conflict; Johannine tradition; early circulation in the second century.	Do not automatically identify "expulsion from the synagogue" with a universally datable measure.

2. Mark: narrative priority, messianic secret, and passion

Mark is the shortest of the canonical Gospels and, according to the most widely accepted view today, the primary narrative text used by Matthew and Luke. Its opening lacks an infancy narrative: Jesus appears as an adult in relation to John the Baptist. The narrative moves rapidly from Galilee to Jerusalem. Jesus' identity is revealed gradually and paradoxically. The demons know who he is; the disciples understand incompletely; Peter makes a messianic confession that must immediately be redefined by the announcement of the Passion. The so-called "messianic secret" should not be reduced to a single key, but it aptly describes the tension between manifestation and concealment that structures numerous episodes.

The Passion occupies an extraordinary proportion of the narrative. The centurion at the foot of the cross marks a point of narrative recognition, while the older ending of Mark 16:1–8 concludes with the women's fear and silence. The expansion in 16:9–20 belongs to the later history of transmission and reception. This fact is philologically important: the comparison of the Easter appearances must distinguish the oldest reconstructible Markan text from the secondary endings that harmonise or expand the narrative.

3. Matthew: fulfilment, Torah and community

Matthew reworks much of Mark's Gospel, but reorganises the material through large discursive blocks and a dense network of fulfilment quotations. His Gospel introduces a genealogy tracing back to Abraham and an infancy narrative centred on Joseph, the Magi, Herod, the flight to Egypt, and the return. This sequence situates Jesus within the history of Israel through Mosaic, Davidic, and prophetic motifs. The phrase "so that it might be fulfilled" should not be treated as mere evidence of isolated predictions; it forms part of a scriptural hermeneutic in which events and texts from Israel are reread as shaping the identity of Jesus.

The relationship with the Law is more complex than an opposition between "Judaism" and "Christianity." Matthew 5:17–20 affirms that Jesus did not come to abolish the Law and the Prophets; the antitheses of the Sermon on the Mount intensify or reorient commandments rather than offering an undifferentiated abolition. At the same time, Matthew contains very severe polemics against scribes and Pharisees. Historically, this language may reflect conflicts of proximity between groups that disputed authority over Scripture, practice, and the memory of Israel. One should not project onto the 80s CE a universal institutional separation as though it had already taken place.

4. Luke: salvation history, Spirit and openness to the nations

Luke begins with a historiographical prologue that acknowledges the existence of "many" earlier accounts and declares a plan for ordering them. His Gospel should be read together with Acts as a two-volume work, although the exact conditions of its publication and circulation remain a subject of debate. The infancy narrative focuses alternately on John the Baptist and Jesus, introduces hymns, and situates the events against the backdrop of imperial and priestly history. The genealogy traces back to Adam, not just Abraham, and fosters a universalising perspective.

Luke develops with particular intensity the action of the Spirit, prayer, the reversal of status, wealth and poverty, the inclusion of marginalised figures, and the journey of the word from Galilee to Jerusalem and, in Acts, from Jerusalem to Rome. Lucan theology does not eliminate judgement or eschatology; it integrates them into a narrative that must explain the continuity of the movement over a longer historical period. The question of the "delay of the Parousia" must be formulated carefully: Luke does not abandon future expectation, but rather reconfigures the temporality of the mission.

5. John: pre-existence, signs and a different chronology

John opens with a prologue about the Logos, not with genealogy or baptism. The pre-existence of Christ is formulated in language that connects creation, life, light, and revelation. Throughout the Gospel, miracles are "signs" that point to the identity of Jesus; the "I am" discourses develop a Christology in which the relationship between Father and Son is central. This elevated formulation does not justify describing John as merely a product of external Greek philosophy: his vocabulary is also constructed through Jewish Scripture, festivals, the Temple, Wisdom, Exodus, and messianic traditions.

The Johannine chronology differs from that of the Synoptic Gospels on several substantive points. John mentions multiple Passovers and presents a ministry that may extend over more than two years; the cleansing of the Temple appears at the beginning, not in the final week. Jesus' death is linked to the preparation for Passover in a way that differs from the Synoptic sequence of the Last Supper. These differences cannot be erased by automatic harmonisation. They constitute narrative and chronological choices that require independent evaluation.

6. The synoptic problem: dependence, sources, and limits of reconstruction

Mark, Matthew, and Luke share sequences, vocabulary, and episodes with a degree of overlap that necessitates some kind of literary relationship. The Two-Source Hypothesis explains this relationship through the priority of Mark and a hypothetical source, Q, for material shared by Matthew and Luke but absent from Mark. Q is a critical reconstruction, not a surviving manuscript. Its usefulness depends on whether it better explains the double tradition than the alternatives.

The Farrer hypothesis (Austin Farrer, "On Dispensing with Q", 1955) dispenses with Q and proposes that Luke used Matthew in addition to Mark; other theories posit different patterns of dependence. Q is treated here as a critical hypothesis rather than as a materially attested source, and Luke's use of Matthew is not regarded as established. The comparative apparatus adopts Markan priority as a robust working hypothesis while marking explicitly those loci at which the direction of dependence remains disputed. Source criticism is paired with redaction criticism: where Matthew or Luke systematically recasts a Markan formulation, the alteration may illuminate an evangelist's theological or narrative priorities, although its precise motivation cannot always be recovered.

7. Infancy narratives: genealogies, conception and geographies requiring mediation to be reconciled

Only Matthew and Luke contain birth narratives. Both affirm the virginal conception and birth in Bethlehem, but they differ in characters, sequence, motifs, and geographical movements. Matthew begins with a family apparently linked to Bethlehem, which receives the Magi, flees to Egypt and finally settles in Nazareth for fear of Archelaus. Luke's narrative begins in Nazareth, brings Joseph and Mary to Bethlehem for a census, introduces shepherds and, after the rites in Jerusalem, returns to Nazareth. Attempting to merge both sequences into a single, comprehensive chronology requires introducing events that neither evangelist narrates.

The genealogies also diverge from David to Joseph and attribute different names to Joseph's father. Matthew organises three symbolic groups and traces the Davidic line through Solomon; Luke traces back from Jesus to Adam and follows another line from Nathan. Ancient explanations using legal and natural genealogies belong to reception history but are not explicitly stated in the Gospels. For historical criticism, this divergence shows that genealogies fulfil theological and scriptural functions in addition to any biographical claims.

8. Ministry, geography and chronology

The Synoptic Gospels present a ministry dominated by Galilee, culminating in a final ascent to Jerusalem. John distributes the movement between Galilee and Judea from an early stage and mentions several festival visits to Jerusalem. The chronology of the cleansing of the Temple is the most visible example: at the beginning in John 2, at the end in the Synoptic Gospels. It is possible that John displaced the episode for theological reasons, that the Synoptic Gospels concentrated it within the Passion narrative, or that there were two separate episodes; the last possibility should not be adopted simply to eliminate the divergence, as we lack independent corroboration of two distinct events.

Nor can the duration of the ministry be deduced by a simple addition. The Synoptic Gospels do not explicitly state that it lasted only one year, but their narrative mentions a final Passover; John offers a broader festal framework. Historically, the fourth Gospel can preserve independent chronological data and, at the same time, rearrange them theologically. The appropriate method is locus by locus, not a global preference for one Gospel as if it were a neutral chronicle.

9. Kingdom of God, eschatology and temporality

In Mark and Matthew, the Kingdom is an explicit focus of preaching. Luke retains this language and integrates it with a perspective on the "time of the Church" and of the Spirit. John uses the expression "Kingdom of God" less frequently and emphasises eternal life, judgement, resurrection, and relationship with the Son. This lexical difference does not imply an absence of eschatology in John. In John 5, for example, future resurrection and judgement coexist with the present realisation of life for those who hear and believe.

Different temporal perspectives are crucial for reconstructing the Christian diversity of the late first century. Some formulations maintain an intense expectation of imminent intervention; others explain the historical permanence of the community. It is incorrect to draw a simple line from "early apocalypticism" to "late de-eschatologisation." The same writings can combine present and future, imminence and delay, everyday ethics and final judgement.

10. Comparative Christologies

The four Gospels identify Jesus through overlapping titles and narratives: Messiah / Christ, Son of God, Son of Man, Lord, teacher, and prophet. However, the distribution and weight of each title vary. Mark articulates identity and suffering; Matthew intensifies themes of fulfilment, Emmanuel, and teaching authority; Luke links identity with Spirit, salvation history, and lordship; John formulates pre-existence and functional unity with the Father in a particularly explicit way.

The comparison should not be constructed as a simplistic scale from a "low" to a "high" Christology. Paul's letters, which predate the Gospels, already contain elevated formulations about Christ; Mark can narrate divine authority without employing Johannine vocabulary; John, in turn, preserves humanity, death, and conflict. It is more accurate to describe Christological profiles: different ways of articulating divine agency, sonship, messiahship, pre-existence, death, and vindication.

11. Passion: Last Supper, date and words from the cross

The Passion narrative offers a broad common ground: entry into Jerusalem, conflict, arrest, trial, crucifixion under Pontius Pilate, death, and burial. However, the details present significant divergences. The Synoptic Gospels describe the Last Supper within a Passover context; John situates Jesus' death in relation to the preparation for Passover and constructs his own Passover symbolism. The exact chronology remains

debated. It is not methodologically legitimate to claim that the two sequences say the same thing when the texts organise the feast differently.

The words of Jesus from the cross also vary. Mark and Matthew preserve the cry of abandonment; Luke presents words of forgiveness and trust; John includes the relationship between Jesus, his mother, and the beloved disciple, and culminates with "τετέλεσται". The traditional "seven last words" are a later devotional harmonisation formed by combining the Gospels. As objects of reception, they are historically important; as a reconstruction of a single spoken sequence, they should not be confused with the independent testimony of each source.

12. Resurrection: similarities and differences

All four canonical Gospels place women among the first witnesses of the empty tomb, but they differ in the number of women, messengers, reactions, and appearances. Mark, in its earliest ending, concludes at 16:8 without an appearance of Jesus. Matthew locates a decisive appearance in Galilee; Luke concentrates the first day and the appearances around Jerusalem and culminates in the ascension; John combines Jerusalem and Galilee and offers his own scenes with Mary Magdalene, Thomas, and the miraculous catch of fish in John 21.

These differences are historically productive. They show that the Easter confession was narrated through multiple traditions before its canonical stabilisation. Paul's letters, especially 1 Corinthians 15, predate the Gospels and offer another list of appearances. Critical history must compare the traditions without assuming that one list exhausts all others or that every divergence invalidates the common core: death, burial, conviction of appearance/vindication, and the rapid centrality of the resurrection in the Christian proclamation.

TABLE 77. The canonical Gospels: agreements and divergences by theme

Issue	Mark	Matthew/Luke	John
Infancy narrative	No	Yes, but with different sequences and genealogies	No; Logos prologue
Cleansing of the Temple	Final week	Final week	Beginning of the ministry
Passovers mentioned	One explicit Passover at the end of the ministry	One explicit Passover at the end of the ministry	Several festivals/ Passovers; a longer ministry

(continued)

Issue	Mark	Matthew/Luke	John
Last Supper	Passover setting	Passover setting	Before Passover according to the narrative sequence
Words on the cross	Cry of abandonment	Matthew: cry; Luke: forgiveness/trust	Mother-disciple; thirst; τετέλεσται ("It is finished")
Earliest resurrection ending	16:1–8: fear and silence	Appearances and commission; Luke: Jerusalem/Ascension	Mary, disciples, Thomas; John 21 as an epilogue

13. Law, Israel and Gentiles

The Gospels emerged from a movement born within Judaism and must be interpreted without turning their internal controversies into a later racial or religious map. Matthew can be intensely polemical against Jewish leaders and, at the same time, profoundly scriptural and legal. Luke-Acts establishes continuity with Israel while narrating an expansion to Gentiles. John uses polemical expressions about "the Jews" whose referent shifts from scene to scene and which, read out of context, contributed to later anti-Jewish receptions. A scholarly edition must distinguish ancient narrative conflict from generalisations against Judaism as a whole.

The mission to the Gentiles also does not appear in an identical form. Matthew combines an initial restriction of the mission with a final universal commission; Luke anticipates a light for the nations from infancy and develops the expansion in Acts; John formulates universality through language of world, life, and attraction. The differences correspond both to traditions and to the situations of communities that were negotiating their heritage from Israel, ethnic identity, and Mediterranean expansion.

14. Textual transmission: literary divergence and manuscript variant are not the same

The comparison of the Gospels must distinguish between two phenomena. A divergence between Mark and Matthew pertains to the relationship between different works; a variant among manuscripts of Mark pertains to the transmission of the same work. Modern textual criticism reconstructs the text from papyri, uncials, minuscules, versions, and patristic quotations. Some loci acquired special importance precisely because later scribes harmonised parallel texts, added endings, or made titles explicit.

Mark 16:9–20 and John 7:53–8:11 are classic examples of textual units whose manuscript history requires a critical apparatus. The pericope of the adulteress circulated in different positions and is absent from several early witnesses; its extraordinary importance in Christian reception does not automatically make its Johannine placement part of the earliest reconstructible textual state. A scholarly edition must preserve both textual history and reception history.

15. Why do the Gospels differ?

The divergences do not require a single explanation. Some stem from literary dependence: one evangelist abbreviates, expands, or rearranges a source. Others may derive from different oral or written traditions. Some reflect narrative theology: Matthew organises the material around fulfilment and teaching; Luke integrates episodes into a geography of salvation; John reconfigures feasts and signs. Other differences may reflect distinct historical information, local memory, or the development of community controversies. Finally, manuscript transmission introduced additional variations.

Therefore, the critical question is not "Which gospel tells the truth?" in the singular, but rather what kind of claim each makes, what evidence supports it, and what can be reconstructed through independent comparison. In ancient history, complete agreement is not a condition of documentary value. Partially dependent, biased, and divergent sources are the normal material for historical reconstruction. The historian's discipline lies in neither granting a source a neutrality it lacks nor dismissing its testimony simply because it is theologically constructed.

16. Comparative apparatus of principal loci

TABLE 78. Comparative apparatus of principal loci

Locus / problem	**Witnesses**	**Main difference**	**Assessment**
Genealogies	Matt 1:1–17; Luke 3:23–38	Different lines and structure; different father of Joseph.	Theological and genealogical functions not reducible to a single list without an auxiliary hypothesis.
Infancy	Matt 1–2; Luke 1–2	Magi/flight to Egypt versus shepherds/ census/presentation.	Distinct narrative traditions; total harmonisation not demonstrable.
Temple	Mark 11 par.; John 2	End versus beginning.	Probable editorial shift in at least one tradition; two separate episodes not demonstrated.
Peter's Confession	Mark 8; Matthew 16; Luke 9	Matthew adds a beatitude and a distinctive role for Peter.	A strong example of Matthean redaction on the Synoptic tradition.
Date of passion	Mark 14 par.; John 18–19	Synoptic Passover meal versus Johannine Passover preparation.	Real chronological tension; possible Johannine symbolisation and/or independent memory.
Tomb and appearances	Mark 16; Matthew 28; Luke 24; John 20–21	Divergent locations, messengers and sequences.	Early plurality of Easter traditions.

16.1. Redaction criticism and intertextuality with the Scriptures of Israel

Redaction criticism remains useful provided that it is not made to recover inaccessible authorial psychology with unwarranted confidence. The final form of each Gospel displays observable literary decisions: Matthew reorganises and expands Markan material around scriptural fulfilment, teaching, and communal discipline; Luke relocates episodes within a narrative geography that moves from Galilee to Jerusalem and, in Acts, from Jerusalem into the Mediterranean world; John constructs a sequence of signs and discourses that cannot be reduced to a simple enlargement of the Synoptic scheme. These are textual observations; identifying a specific community behind each decision requires a further degree of inference.

Intertextuality requires the same discipline. Isaiah, the Psalms, Daniel, Zechariah, and other scriptural repertoires provide vocabulary, scenes, and narrative patterns for all four Gospels, but the relationship ranges from explicit quotation to probable allusion and broad thematic resemblance. Mark opens with a composite scriptural citation; Matthew multiplies fulfilment formulae; Luke shapes canticles and prophetic scenes; John rereads signs, festivals, and biblical figures through a Christology of preexistence. Analysis is most precise when it identifies the locus, the relevant Greek or Hebrew textual form, and its literary function rather than accumulating undifferentiated parallels.

17. State of research and reference bibliography

For the Synoptic Problem and redaction, the following works are consulted, among others: Mark Goodacre, *The Synoptic Problem*; John S. Kloppenborg, works on Q; and critical studies on the Farrer and Two-Source Hypotheses. For Mark, Joel Marcus and Adela Yarbro Collins; for Matthew, Ulrich Luz and W.D. Davies/Dale Allison; for Luke-Acts, Joseph Fitzmyer, François Bovon, and C. Kavin Rowe; for John, Raymond E. Brown, C.K. Barrett, J. Louis Martyn, and later works that revise the model of an overly unified "Johannine community." For the historical Jesus, the comparison is made independently of any single criterion of authenticity, taking into account memory, tradition, and context.

Greek text editions should be checked against Nestle-Aland 28 and UBS5, with consultation of specialised critical apparatuses when a locus requires it. A Gospel synopsis should not replace the continuous reading of each Gospel. Papyri such as P52, P66, P75, and P45 are used for transmission history, not as absolute calendars of composition. Patristic quotations from Papias, Irenaeus, Clement of Alexandria, and

Origen belong to reception history and should be dated according to the surviving testimony.

Conclusion

The four Gospels preserved four portraits that Christian communities of the second to fourth centuries did not reduce to a single, harmonised biography. This gradually achieved canonical configuration is a historical fact of major importance: subsequent norms were built upon an internal plurality. Mark, Matthew, Luke, and John share a fundamental plot—Jesus, ministry, conflict, crucifixion, and Easter proclamation—but differ in chronology, selection, language, and Christology. The scholarly task consists of keeping these differences visible and explaining, when the evidence allows, their literary and historical causes. Where a decision cannot be reached, uncertainty must be preserved as part of knowledge. Read alongside Marcion and Tatian, the fourfold Gospel emerges as a third editorial response to the problem of plurality: in contrast to the selection of a single corpus and to harmonisation into one continuous narrative, the solution defended by Irenaeus preserves four distinct compositions within a common normative framework. This synthesis links Chapters II and XXI and avoids treating canon, harmonisation, and synoptic criticism as separate histories.

Summary

This chapter compares the four canonical Gospels as related but distinct ancient compositions. It examines probable dating, the Synoptic Problem, infancy narratives, chronology, geography, Torah and Gentile mission, Christology, passion and resurrection traditions, and textual transmission. Each divergence is assessed in relation to literary dependence, redaction, independent tradition, historical memory, theological construction, and manuscript transmission. The fourfold Gospel canon is therefore treated as preserving, from the second century onward, an internal plurality of narratives rather than erasing it.

CHAPTER XXII

Christian Apocalypses and Eschatological Horizons of the First and Second Centuries: Christ, Empire, Nero Redivivus and Interreligious Comparison

The Book of Revelation is one of the richest witnesses for studying how a Christian current of the late first century imagined Christ, the empire, judgement, and the consummation of history. Its language cannot be reduced to a code of modern predictions. It belongs to the apocalyptic genre, combining prophetic vision, circular letter, liturgy, scriptural exegesis, and symbolic critique of power. This chapter places it alongside Jewish and Christian apocalypses of the first and second centuries and, with greater caution, alongside Iranian eschatological traditions and the politico-religious themes of the Roman world.

Interreligious comparison demands a strict rule. A structural similarity—final judgement, resurrection, saviour, cosmic battle, destruction of evil—does not, in itself, demonstrate textual dependence. Three cases must be distinguished: (a) typological parallels, which can arise in different cultures; (b) historically possible contact, when compatible networks, chronology, and geography exist; and (c) probable or demonstrable dependence, when the transmission of specific forms, vocabulary, or sequences can be identified. This hierarchy, refined into four levels in section 14, avoids both the confessional isolation of the Book of Revelation and indiscriminate comparativism.

1. Date, genre and situation of the seven churches

Revelation is frequently dated towards the end of Domitian's reign, approximately 90–96 CE, partly due to the early reception associated with Irenaeus (Adv. haer. V.30.3, quoted by Eusebius, HE III.18.3). There are proposals for a Neronian or immediately post-Neronian date, especially when the motifs of 666 and Nero redivivus are emphasised. Internal evidence does not establish an unequivocal year. It is more prudent to speak of the end of the first century and to acknowledge that some images may preserve earlier material.

The seven churches of Asia—Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea—form a specific historical geography. The letters in Revelation 2–3 depict conflicts over wealth, suffering, participation in civic-religious practices, prophecy, and authority. They do not necessarily describe a uniform imperial persecution. The pressure may include local hostility, social exclusion, the memory of martyrdom, and tension over the imperial cult. A historically accurate reading must avoid turning every metaphor of violence into evidence of a centralised state policy.

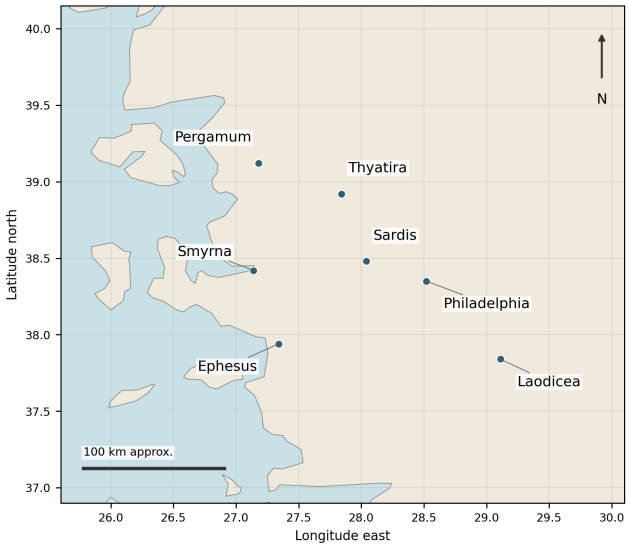


FIGURE 26. The seven churches of Revelation 1:11 and Revelation 2–3 in Asia Minor. The points are approximate city centres; neither a route for John nor confessional boundaries are shown. Cartography by the author on Natural Earth, public domain.

2. The vision of Christ in Revelation 1

Revelation 1:12–18 presents a figure "like a son of man" among seven lampstands. The description combines motifs from Daniel 7 and 10 with priestly imagery, light, fire, a powerful voice, and authority over death and Hades. The result is not a physical portrait of Jesus, but a Christological theophany. Traits that in Daniel belong to the Ancient of Days and heavenly beings are reconfigured around the exalted Christ. This appropriation shows the extent to which apocalyptic Christology engages with the language of divine identity and agency without erasing the narrative distinction between God and the Lamb.

The formula "the first and the last" connects the visionary Christ with language that in Isaiah belongs to the God of Israel. Similarly, the doxologies and worship scenes of Revelation 4–5 place the Lamb within heavenly worship. However, one must avoid translating this observation directly into fourth-century conciliar categories. The text offers material that later contributed to Trinitarian and Christological elaboration, but its own grammar is apocalyptic, liturgical, and scriptural.

3. The Lamb: victim, victor, and sovereign

Revelation 5 constructs one of the central images of early Christianity: the seer hears the announcement of the Lion of Judah and sees, instead, a Lamb standing "as though it had been slain." The paradox redefines victory through death and vindication. The Lamb receives the scroll, shares in the scene of worship, and appears as the agent of judgement and salvation. The image draws on Paschal, sacrificial, Isaian, and Messianic repertoires, but it is not limited to a single source.

Compared to John 1:29, 36, where ἀμνός appears, Revelation predominantly uses ἀρνίον. The lexical difference does not prove two incompatible Christologies; rather, it cautions against automatically identifying all language of the "Lamb" as a fixed formula. In Revelation, the Lamb is simultaneously sacrificed, living, enthroned, and a warrior. This combination explains part of the power of its subsequent artistic and liturgical reception.

4. Son of Man, Messiah and divine titles

The figure of the Son of Man links Revelation with Daniel, the Gospels, and other Jewish traditions. Revelation 14 presents "one like a son of man" with a crown and sickle, associated with the eschatological harvest. The text does not offer a systematic treatise on the natures of Christ; it operates through superimposed images. Davidic

Messiah, Lamb, faithful witness, rider, Word of God, and Son of Man converge in a single narrative figure without eliminating their different symbolic genealogies.

Comparative study must also consider imperial titles. Emperors and benefactors could receive language of salvation, lordship, victory, epiphany, and divine filiation in inscriptions, coins, and ceremonial practices. The existence of this vocabulary creates an environment of political resonance, but it does not mean that every Christian title derives from the imperial cult. "Son of God" has biblical, Davidic, and Jewish roots; the imperial field functions as a competitive context where words of power could acquire an additional polemical edge.

5. Rome as Babylon and the problem of the empire

Revelation 17–18 symbolically identifies a great city with Babylon, a woman drunk with blood, commercial power, and luxury. The association with Rome is historically strong due to the reference to seven hills, dominion over kings, and the memory of violence. "Babylon" allows for a reinterpretation of Rome through the biblical history of oppressive empires. The critique is neither exclusively economic nor exclusively religious: commerce, violence, idolatry, prestige, and domination form a single representation.

The book cannot be reduced to a simple anti-Roman pamphlet. It uses the Empire's own communication infrastructure to circulate among cities in Asia and employs a cosmological language in which Rome is a historical manifestation of a broader struggle. This universalisation makes its subsequent reception possible in very different contexts, but it also compels us to distinguish the initial historical referent from modern applications.

6. 666/616, the beast and Nero redivivus

Revelation 13:18 invites us to calculate the number of the beast. The reading 666 is strongly attested; 616 also has ancient manuscript support (P115 and Codex Ephraemi Rescriptus, C) and is crucial to the history of interpretation. The Hebrew transliteration נרון קסר, "Nero Caesar," totals 666; the form נרו קסר, corresponding to the Latin name Nero without the final nun, totals 616. The calculation is performed using Hebrew letters, not the Latin letters of Nero Caesar. This correspondence is the main argument for the Neronian interpretation, which remains a hypothesis: 616 admits other explanations (for example, Γάιος Καῖσαρ also totals 616 in Greek), and Irenaeus (Haer. V.30) does not name Nero; problems of spelling, reception, and transmission also remain.

The motif of Nero redivivus must be carefully distinguished from the Christological figure. After Nero's death in 68, rumours circulated that he was still alive or would return from the East; impostors appeared, and the Sibylline traditions developed a returning Neronian figure of increasing eschatological significance. In Revelation 13 and 17, the wounded and restored beast and the king who "was, is not, and is to come" may resonate with this complex of expectations. The connection is plausible and, for many interpreters, strong; however, it does not warrant the assertion that the Roman world uniformly believed in a "Nero, the resurrected son of God, who returns as judge."

Imperial titulature could style an emperor divi filius, "son of the deified one," and the imperial cult can bestow upon him superhuman honours. This is distinct from a doctrine of resurrection comparable to the Christian proclamation of Jesus. Nero redivivus functions best as a political and eschatological counter-figure: a returning king, enemy, persecutor, or instrument of catastrophe. It is precisely this difference that allows for a more rigorous comparison between the dead and living Lamb and the imperial parody of a beast that seems to survive its mortal wound.

7. Daniel, 1 Enoch and the Jewish archive of apocalypticism

The immediate horizon of Revelation is the Jewish Scriptures. Daniel provides imperial beasts, thrones, judgement, a time of tribulation, and the figure "like a son of man." Ezekiel contributes visions, scrolls, measurements of the Temple, and Gog/Magog; Isaiah contributes to the new creation and the defeat of powers; Exodus structures plagues and deliverance. Revelation rarely quotes by explicit formula: it rewrites and combines images, so that intertextuality must be analysed by density and function, not just by exact verbal coincidence.

666	**616**
χξς	χιϛ
600 + 60 + 6	600 + 10 + 6

FIGURE 27. Typographical comparison of readings 666 (χξς) and 616 (χιϛ) from Revelation 13:18. The spellings are normalised for reading and the values are made explicit; a papyrus page is not simulated. Irenaeus, Adv. haer. V.30.1, knows variant 616.

1 Enoch, in its various sections, reveals the breadth of Jewish apocalyptic thought: celestial journeys, the judgement of angels and humans, mediators, and eschatological figures. Its relationship to Revelation is not that of a single source. Both belong to a repertoire where heavenly revelation and final justice allow for a reinterpretation of present history. This comparison helps us understand that vision, angels, books, and judgement are not isolated Christian inventions, but rather part of a Jewish culture of revelation in which the early Christians participated.

8. 4 Esdras and 2 Baruch: after 70

4 Esdras and 2 Baruch, usually associated with the trauma of Jerusalem's destruction in 70 CE, offer particularly valuable comparisons. Both reflect on divine justice, Israel's suffering, the fate of the world, and consummation. 4 Esdras presents intense dialogues on the problem of evil and the small number of those who will inherit the world to come; 2 Baruch combines lamentation, instruction, and messianic expectations. The parallel with Revelation lies less in direct dependence than in the way roughly contemporary texts transform historical catastrophe into an eschatological question.

The differences are equally important. Revelation organises the conflict around the testimony of Jesus and the identity of the Lamb; 4 Esdras and 2 Baruch respond from Jewish frameworks that do not share that Christology. Comparison reveals the same historical problem—empire, destruction, justice—and distinct theological responses. This avoids defining apocalyptic literature solely by its spectacular imagery and frames it as a discourse on the legitimacy of God when history appears to be dominated by unjust powers.

9. Christian apocalypses of the first and second centuries

The Ascension of Isaiah, in its complex compositional history, combines martyrdom, celestial journey, and a Christology of descent/ascent. Its stratified structure makes a single date difficult, but Christian elements belong to the early centuries. The Apocalypse of Peter, probably from the second century, develops scenes of post-mortem reward and punishment with a concreteness that would influence later imagery. The Shepherd of Hermas, while not an apocalypse in the same sense as John's, uses visions, angels, symbols, and penitential exhortation to address the moral situation of a Roman community.

These texts show that the Christian apocalyptic genre did not follow a single direction. John articulates empire, martyrdom, and new creation; the Apocalypse of Peter emphasises the destinies of the afterlife; Hermas transforms vision into communal discipline; the Ascension of Isaiah imagines movements through heavens and powers. The comparison shows how revelation could legitimise authority and conduct rather than merely predict the end.

10. Zoroastrianism: Saoshyant, resurrection and renewal

The Iranian tradition offers one of the most illuminating—and methodologically hazardous—comparative dossiers when chronology is neglected. The late Avesta attests the Saoshyant, the final victory over evil, the resurrection of the dead, and the renewal of existence (frašō.kərəti). Yt 19 describes a future world without old age, decay, or death. These motifs predate the medieval Pahlavi treatises, although the more systematic narratives of the final stages, the molten metal, and the sequence of saviours are preserved in later sources and should not be projected wholesale back onto the first century.

The comparison with the Book of Revelation can be organised around five axes: cosmic conflict between good and evil; eschatological agent; resurrection; judgement; and renewal of the world. In both systems, history does not end in mere destruction but in transformation. However, the differences are profound: the Lamb is defined by the death and vindication of Jesus within a Jewish biblical framework; the Saoshyant belongs to an Iranian tradition and remains, in its classical formulation, an eschatological human agent linked to Zarathustra. The similarity of function does not make one a copy of the other.

Long-term contact among the Iranian, Mesopotamian, Jewish, and Hellenistic worlds made the circulation of motifs historically possible. Demonstrating a specific influence on the Apocalypse of John, however, requires a more concrete chain of

transmission than resemblance alone. Zoroastrian traditions therefore serve here as a major comparative horizon and as a possible remote component in the eschatological environment of Second Temple Judaism; they are not presented as evidence of direct dependence by John.

11. Judgement, resurrection and new creation

Revelation 20–22 culminates in the defeat of hostile powers, judgement before the great white throne, resurrection, the lake of fire, and the new Jerusalem. The sequence combines the Jewish tradition of resurrection with an eschatological city in which the Temple disappears because God and the Lamb constitute its sanctuary. The final image is not a simple return to Eden: it is a garden city where the river, the tree of life, nations, and glory reconfigure Genesis, the prophets, and expectations of restoration.

In 4 Esdras and 2 Baruch, final justice responds to the trauma of history; in Iranian traditions, renewal ultimately eliminates corruption and death; in the Apocalypse of Peter, the emphasis is on rewards and punishments. This comparison identifies a shared grammar of deferred justice: the present order does not offer a sufficient correspondence between virtue and destiny, so revelation imagines a judgement that restores justice. The differences lie in who judges, how the cosmos is transformed, and what role the Messiah or Christ plays.

12. The "Son of God" in a world of sovereigns, heroes, and saviours

The title "son of God" must be contextualised within various registers. In Israel, it can be applied to the Davidic king, the people, or celestial beings; in the Greco-Roman world, there are divine genealogies of heroes and rulers, and the imperial prince could be defined as the son of a deified emperor. Christianity reused an available vocabulary but integrated it into a Jewish narrative of creation, messianism, the cross, and resurrection. The comparison must analyse specific functions and not assume that the mere coincidence of an expression establishes historical filiation.

Nero illustrates the problem. His membership in the imperial house and the language of deification in the Principate form part of the political backdrop, but the traditions of his return do not amount to the proclamation of a benevolent resurrected saviour. In Sibylline and Christian sources, he can become a destructive figure. If Revelation plays with a monstrous imitation of death and return, the

contrast with the Lamb is precisely moral and theological: the beast fascinates and dominates; the Lamb triumphs through witness, sacrifice, and faithfulness.

13. Comparative matrix of eschatologies

TABLE 79. Comparative matrix of eschatologies

Tradition	Central agent/figure	Crisis and judgement	Consummation
Apocalypse of John	Christ/Lamb; God; witnesses	Beasts, Babylon, judgement, defeat of death and Hades	New Jerusalem, new creation, life with God and the Lamb
4 Esdras / 2 Baruch	Most High; messianic figure according to passages	Post-70 CE crisis, judgement, explanation of suffering	Future world/ restoration; divine justice
Apocalypse of Peter	Christ the Judge	Post-mortem punishments and rewards	Different fate of the righteous and the wicked
Zoroastrianism	Saoshyant and allies	Final defeat of evil; resurrection; judgement/renewal	Frašō.kərəti: incorruptible existence
Nero redivivus / Sibylline traditions	Nero returns as king/ enemy	Political return and catastrophe; eschatological reworking	It does not, in itself, offer a uniform soteriology; it functions as a crisis figure.

Comparison requires separating composition, transmission, and preservation. The date of a work does not necessarily coincide with the date of the manuscript that preserves it; likewise, an Ethiopic, Syriac, Coptic, Latin, or Slavic version may transmit a much older Greek, Hebrew, or Aramaic original. The following table lists the main apocalyptic and eschatological corpora relevant to the first and second centuries CE and their immediate chronological periphery. It does not lump together texts of different genres into a uniform family: it distinguishes between apocalypses proper, apocalyptic discourses incorporated into larger works, and comparable eschatological traditions.

Dates are expressed as working ranges. When a composition is stratified, this is explicitly stated; when the place of composition is unknown, it is not replaced by the place where a manuscript was found. “Codex or witness” designates the material

support or tradition that allows the work to be traced, not necessarily its place of composition.

13.1. Comparative corpus of apocalypses and eschatological traditions (first and second centuries)

Table 80. Comparative corpus of apocalypses and eschatological traditions (first and second centuries)

Work / corpus	Probable date and original language	Versions / textual status	Codex or witness — collection and provenance
Apocalypse of John	c. 90–100 CE; Greek. Earlier dates are still under discussion.	Greek; then Latin, Syriac, Coptic, Armenian and other versions.	P115, P.Oxy. LXVI 4499 (third–fourth centuries), found in Oxyrhynchus, Egypt; P.Oxy. collection, Oxford. Codex Sinaiticus (fourth century), historically kept at Saint Catherine's, Sinai (Revelation, like the whole NT, now in the British Library, Add. MS 43725); collection distributed among London, Leipzig, Saint Petersburg and Sinai. It does not belong to Nag Hammadi.
1 Enoch	Stratified corpus, approximately third century BCE–first century CE; much of it originally Aramaic.	Fragmentary Aramaic; fragmentary Greek; Ethiopic (Geʿez) preserves the complete corpus.	Aramaic scrolls 4Q201–202 and 4Q204–212 (4Q203 = Book of Giants), Qumran collection, Cave 4, Judean Desert: not codices. Additional Greek witness: Akhmim codex, former P.Cairo 10759, now BAAM 0522, Bibliotheca Alexandrina; palaeographic date disputed, between the sixth–seventh and eighth–ninth centuries. Later Ethiopic tradition.
4 Esdras (2 Esdras 3–14)	c. 90–100 CE; original Semitic, usually reconstructed as Hebrew or Aramaic.	Latin, Syriac, Ethiopic, Arabic, Armenian and Georgian; original lost.	Codex Sangermanensis, Latin Bible of 821–822; Paris, BnF, Latin 11504–11505; 4 Esdras in Latin 11505. Western library provenance, not found at Nag Hammadi. The history of its lacuna requires collation with other witnesses.

(continued)

Work / corpus	Probable date and original language	Versions / textual status	Codex or witness — collection and provenance
2 Baruch (Syriac Apocalypse of Baruch)	c. 90–120 CE; original probably Hebrew or Aramaic.	Primarily Syriac; Greek traces and other versions.	Codex Ambrosianus B.21 inf., Biblioteca Ambrosiana, Milan, sixth–seventh centuries; Syriac Bible. Its present preservation in Milan does not indicate its place of composition. No specific archaeological find-spot is claimed here.
3 Baruch (Greek Apocalypse of Baruch)	Late first–second centuries CE; Greek; dating and strata disputed.	Greek and Slavic.	London, British Library, Add. MS 10073, ff. 173–184, 16th century (Pinakes). Collection of Greek manuscripts; Byzantine transmission. Archaeological provenance undetermined; not from Nag Hammadi.
Apocalypse of Abraham	Late first–early second century; probably of Semitic origin.	Preserved entirely in Slavic; original lost.	Sylvester Codex, medieval Slavic collection, 14th–15th centuries; Moscow, RGADA, fund 381, no. 53. Slavic transmission; archaeological find location undocumented. The codex date does not date the original composition.
Testament of Abraham	First–second centuries; Greek.	Two Greek recensions and later versions.	Long recension: Paris, BnF, grec 770, ff. 225v–241r; paper codex copied in 1315 by the priest George (siglum A in James, 1892, p. 1). Miscellaneous Greek collection; not Nag Hammadi. There is a short recension and oriental versions; no single codex from an archaeological find is common to the entire tradition.

(continued)

Work / corpus	Probable date and original language	Versions / textual status	Codex or witness — collection and provenance
Apocalypse of Zephaniah	Dating is highly debated, between the first century BCE and the second century CE; probably Greek.	Fragmentary Coptic preservation.	Coptic codex of the apocalypses of Zephaniah and Elijah: Berlin P.1862 + Paris, BnF, Copte 135; fourth–fifth centuries according to BerlPap. Commercial provenance from the Akhmim/White Monastery area; exact excavation context not preserved. Collections of Berlin and Paris; not Nag Hammadi. The distribution of the Berlin and Paris leaves between the two works follows the BerlPap record and remains subject to checking against the editio princeps; it is not presented as a settled codicological datum.
Sibylline Oracles IV	Late first century CE in its main form; Greek.	Greek in later manuscript tradition.	Witness to books 1–8: Paris, BnF, grec 2851, ff. 1r–72v, 15th century, family Ψ (siglum R). Other: Wien, ÖNB, hist. gr. 96, ff. 1r–61v, 15th century, family Φ. Collection of oracles in Greek manuscripts; not Nag Hammadi. No documented Egyptian archaeological find. See Geffcken (1902) and NASSCAL. The sigla (R, Ψ, Φ) follow Geffcken's convention and vary in other editions; they are offered as orientation and do not replace consultation of the critical apparatus.
Sibylline Oracles V	Late first–second centuries; stratified composition; Greek.	Greek in later manuscript tradition.	Paris, BnF, grec 2851, 15th century, family Ψ; and Wien, ÖNB, hist. gr. 96, 15th century, family Φ: transmit the collection of books 1–8. The possible composition of this book in Egypt does not equate to the discovery of these codices there. Not Nag Hammadi. Codicological source: NASSCAL and Geffcken edition (1902).

(continued)

Work / corpus	Probable date and original language	Versions / textual status	Codex or witness — collection and provenance
Ascension of Isaiah	Final form c. 100–150, with materials from different dates; Greek as the main language of the preserved Christian form.	Complete Ethiopic version; Greek, Latin, and Slavic fragments.	Ethiopic witnesses: Oxford, Bodleian Library, Aeth. d.13, ff. 95r–115r, 15th century; London, British Library, Or.501, ff. 62r–69v, 15th century. Collections of Ethiopian manuscripts; additional ancient fragments in other languages. Not Nag Hammadi. Archaeological find site not documented for those codices.
Apocalypse of Peter	c. 100–150; Greek.	Greek fragments; Ethiopic version; other indirect testimonies.	Akhmim codex, formerly P.Cairo 10759, now BAAM 0522, Bibliotheca Alexandrina; Greek fragment, palaeographic date disputed (sixth–seventh to eighth–ninth centuries). Found at Akhmim, Egypt. The Ethiopic tradition provides additional evidence. This is distinct from the Coptic Apocalypse of Peter in NHC VII,3, a separate work sharing the same title.
Shepherd of Hermas (Visions)	c. 90–150, composition in stages; Greek.	Greek; ancient Latin versions and others.	Codex Sinaiticus, fourth century; historically preserved at Saint Catherine's Monastery, Sinai, and now part of a distributed collection. It transmits part of the Shepherd along with biblical texts and Barnabas. Additional papyri and versions; not Nag Hammadi.
Didache 16	Late first century to early second century within a composite work; Greek.	Greek; partial Eastern versions and testimonies.	Codex Hierosolymitanus 54, dated 1056, library of the Patriarchate of Jerusalem. Identified by Bryennios in Constantinople in 1873. Collection of Christian texts, with Barnabas and Clement; not an archaeological find nor Nag Hammadi.

(continued)

Work / corpus	Probable date and original language	Versions / textual status	Codex or witness — collection and provenance
Mark 13	c. 65–75 within the Gospel; Greek.	Greek manuscript tradition and ancient versions.	Codex Sinaiticus (fourth century), complete New Testament; historically preserved at Saint Catherine's, Sinai; the New Testament leaves are now in London, British Library, Add. MS 43725. Collection of the Codex Sinaiticus project. The discourse belongs to the Gospel; it is not a materially independent apocalyptic work.
Matthew 24–25	c. 80–95 within the Gospel; Greek.	Greek tradition and ancient versions.	Codex Sinaiticus (fourth century), same collection and provenance. The locus is verified within Matthew; no separate apocalypse in the codex is assumed.
Luke 21	c. 80–95 within the Gospel; Greek.	Greek tradition and ancient versions.	Codex Sinaiticus (fourth century), same collection and provenance. P75 does not preserve Luke 21 (lacuna between Luke 18:18 and 22:4) and cannot be used as a witness to this passage.
1 Thessalonians 4–5	c. 49–52; Greek.	Greek Pauline tradition and ancient versions.	Codex Sinaiticus (fourth century), a biblical collection historically preserved at Saint Catherine's. Of 1 Thess 4–5, P46 preserves only 5:5–9, 23–28 (elsewhere in the letter, 1:1; 1:9–2:3) and should not be used as evidence of the complete passage.
1 Corinthians 15	c. 53–55; Greek.	Greek Pauline tradition and ancient versions.	P46, Beatty-Michigan Codex, c. late second–third century; collection divided between Chester Beatty and Michigan (P.Mich. inv. 6238). Acquired in Egypt, exact location of discovery not documented. Additional witness: Codex Sinaiticus.

(continued)

Work / corpus	Probable date and original language	Versions / textual status	Codex or witness — collection and provenance
2 Thessalonians 2	Date disputed: early Pauline or late first century if the letter is considered deutero-Pauline; Greek.	Greek Pauline tradition and ancient versions.	Codex Sinaiticus (fourth century), same Sinaitic collection and preservation. The passage is not attributed to a preserved leaf of P46. The date and authorship of the letter are discussed separately.

TABLE 81. Continuation of "Comparative corpus of apocalypses and eschatological traditions (first and second centuries)"

Work / corpus	Religious environment	Comparative axes
Apocalypse of John	Christianity of Asia Minor, with a Jewish scriptural matrix and a Roman imperial context.	Christ glorified; Lamb; imperial beasts; Babylon/Rome; martyrdom; judgement; resurrection; new creation.
1 Enoch	Second Temple Judaism.	Watchers; judgement; celestial journeys; mediators; the Son of Man in the Parables; eschatological renewal.
4 Esdras (2 Esdras 3–14)	Post-70 Judaism.	Theodicy after the fall of Jerusalem; Messiah; judgement; future age; destiny of Israel.
2 Baruch (Syriac Apocalypse of Baruch)	Post-70 Judaism.	Temple destroyed; Messiah; resurrection; judgement; restoration; universal history.
3 Baruch (Greek Apocalypse of Baruch)	Hellenistic Judaism with Christian transmission and possible Christian retouching.	Celestial ascent; cosmology; angels; destiny of souls; vision of the cosmos.
Apocalypse of Abraham	Post-70 Judaism.	Ascension; vision of history; idolatry; Temple; judgement; eschatological conflict.
Testament of Abraham	Hellenistic Judaism transmitted by Christian copyists.	Death; celestial journey; individual judgement; balance of souls; angelic mediation.
Apocalypse of Zephaniah	Hellenistic Judaism; Egyptian Christian transmission.	Journey to the afterlife; angels; judgement; punishments; otherworldly topography.
Sibylline Oracles IV	Hellenistic Jewish apocalyptic literature with Christian reception.	Empires; catastrophe; fire; judgement; criticism of idolatry and power.

(continued)

Work / corpus	Religious environment	Comparative axes
Sibylline Oracles V	Jewish and Christian layers in an Eastern imperial setting.	Rome; emperors; Nero's return; destruction; judgement; rereading imperial history.
Ascension of Isaiah	Prophetic Christianity with a strong Jewish matrix.	Martyrdom; heavens; descent/ascent of Christ; Beliar; parousia; cosmic conflict.
Apocalypse of Peter	Christianity of the second century.	Judgement; paradise; post-mortem punishments; retributive ethics; the destiny of the righteous and the sinners.
Shepherd of Hermas (Visions)	Roman Christianity.	Visions; Church personified; penance; tower; judgement; community discipline.
Didache 16	Christianity with a strong Jewish matrix.	Final deception; tribulation; signs; resurrection; coming of the Lord. Apocalyptic discourse, not an independent apocalypse.
Mark 13	Christianity of the first century in the context of the Jewish-Roman war.	Temple; tribulation; false messiahs; Son of Man; vigilance.
Matthew 24–25	Jewish-Christian communities in the process of differentiation.	Parousia; Son of Man; judgement of the nations; vigilance; eschatological ethics.
Luke 21	Mixed Jewish–Gentile Christianity.	Jerusalem; times of the Gentiles; cosmic signs; coming of the Son of Man.
1 Thessalonians 4–5	Early Pauline Christianity.	Parousia; resurrection of the dead in Christ; encounter with the Lord; vigilance.
1 Corinthians 15	Early Pauline Christianity.	Resurrection; transformation; defeat of death; eschatological order.
2 Thessalonians 2	Pauline or post-Pauline Christianity, depending on the scholarly position adopted.	Apostasy; "man of lawlessness"; restraint; coming of the Lord; destruction of the adversary.

Nag Hammadi Codicological Verification Table

Works attributed to the second–third centuries and codices copied in the fourth century are listed separately. "Coptic" designates a language; "Egypt" a territory; "Nag Hammadi" a find collection; and the Coptic Museum designates the repository. Proposed dates of composition remain open, and these codices do not by themselves

prove the circulation of those works in Egypt during the second century. Sources: NASSCAL, NHC V (inv. 10548) and NHC VII (inv. 10546) catalogue records and their codicological editions; Parrott, 1979; Pearson, 1996.

TABLE 82. Nag Hammadi codices: codicological control by work

Work	Codex and pages	Current collection	Find	Copying and composition
Coptic Apocalypse of Paul	NHC V,2; pp. 17–24	Coptic Museum, Cairo, inv. 10548; Nag Hammadi collection	Jabal al-Tarif, near Nag Hammadi, Upper Egypt; discovery reported in 1945	Codex from the fourth century; composition generally placed in the second century, disputed. Not to be confused with the later Visio Pauli.
First Apocalypse of James	NHC V,3; pp. 24–44	Coptic Museum, Cairo, inv. 10548; Nag Hammadi	Same Jabal al-Tarif find	Fourth-century copy; second–third-century composition, debated. Another Coptic witness survives in the Tchacos codex; these are distinct codices.
Second Apocalypse of James	NHC V,4; pp. 44–63	Coptic Museum, Cairo, inv. 10548; Nag Hammadi	Same Jabal al-Tarif find	Fourth-century copy; composition usually placed in the second century, without a demonstrable exact date.
Apocalypse of Adam	NHC V,5; pp. 64–85	Coptic Museum, Cairo, inv. 10548; Nag Hammadi	Same Jabal al-Tarif find	Fourth-century copy; the origin and dating of the composition are disputed. Its character and strata cannot be deduced from the date of discovery.

(continued)

Work	Codex and pages	Current collection	Find	Copying and composition
Coptic Apocalypse of Peter	NHC VII,3; pp. 70–84	Coptic Museum, Cairo, inv. 10546; Nag Hammadi	Jabal al-Tarif, near Nag Hammadi	Fourth-century copy; second–third-century composition, debated. A distinct work from the Greek/Ethiopic Apocalypse of Peter.

13.2. Iranian traditions of comparison: chronology of the source and chronology of the motif

Iranian traditions must be treated in a separate table because they do not constitute Jewish or Christian apocalypses and because a large part of their surviving formulation comes from much later manuscripts. Their comparative value depends on distinguishing the possible antiquity of a motif from the date of composition or of the witness that transmits it.

Table 83. Iranian traditions: chronology of source and of motif

Tradition / Source	Relevant chronology	Preservation	Context
Gāthās / Old Avesta	Iranian strata much earlier than the Roman period.	Avestan; manuscripts preserved much later.	Iranian/Zoroastrian religion.
Yasht 19 and the tradition of the Saoshyant	Avestan material of complex formation; prior to medieval Pahlavi redactions.	Avestan transmitted by Zoroastrian tradition.	Zoroastrianism.
Frašō.kərəti / Frašegird	Motif with Avestan roots and subsequent systematic development.	Avesta and Pahlavi literature.	Iranian Zoroastrianism.
Bundahišn	Middle-Persian compilation preserved in medieval form, with earlier materials.	Pahlavi.	Sasanian and post-Sasanian Zoroastrianism.

(continued)

Tradition / Source	Relevant chronology	Preservation	Context
Zand ī Wahman Yasn	Late Pahlavi text with eschatological materials of disputed chronology.	Pahlavi.	Zoroastrianism.

TABLE 84. Continuation of "Iranian traditions: chronology of source and of motif"

Tradition / Source	Comparable motifs	Historical caution
Gāthās / Old Avesta	Judgement; truth/order versus evil; post-mortem destiny.	Do not use the date of the manuscript as the date of the motif, nor automatically reconstruct a late eschatological system in the Achaemenid period.
Yasht 19 and the tradition of the Saoshyant	Future saviour; defeat of evil; renewal; resurrection in later developments.	Distinguish what is explicit in the Avestan text from Middle Persian systematisations.
Frašō.kərəti / Frašegird	Final renewal; elimination of corruption and death; purification of the cosmos.	Important structural parallel; a direct dependence of Revelation on it requires demonstrating transmission pathways.
Bundahišn	Cosmogony and consummation; resurrection; molten metal; renewal.	Do not project the medieval redaction onto the first century without evidentiary justification.
Zand ī Wahman Yasn	Ages/empires; decline; saviour; restoration.	Useful for the history of Iranian reception, not as a direct contemporary witness of John.

13.3. NERO REDIVIVUS AND IMPERIAL MEMORY: VERIFICATION DOSSIER

TABLE 85. Nero redivivus and imperial memory: verification dossier

Testimony	Date of testimony	Relevant data	Environment / critical value
Tacitus, Histories II.8–9	Beginning of the second century	Account of a false Nero and the political persistence of his memory.	Roman senatorial historiography; proof that the expectation or exploitation of the return had a real political context.
Suetonius, Nero 57	Beginning of the second century	Favourable memory of Nero in certain sectors and reports of expectations after his death.	Imperial biography; it should be read with the conventions of the genre.
Sibylline Oracles IV–V	Late first–second centuries; stratified composition	Neronian figure, fugitive/returning from the East, transformed into an agent of catastrophe.	Jewish and Christian apocalypticism; important for tracing the conversion of political memory into an eschatological figure.
Revelation 13 and 17	End of the first century	Beast, mortal wound, number 666/616, king who "was and is not"; possible convergence with Neronian memory.	Christianity in Asia Minor. The identification with Nero is historically plausible, but it should be formulated as an interpretation, not as an explicit gloss of the text.
Later Christian reception	Second century onwards	Nero is gradually assimilated to the imagery of the Antichrist and the eschatological persecutor.	Reception history; it should not be automatically projected back onto the original composition of Revelation.

13.4. Daniel, Isaiah, and Zechariah as scriptural matrices of Revelation

The scriptural density of Revelation depends less on formal quotations than on a network of allusions. Daniel supplies beasts, horns, thrones, judgement, and the language of sovereignty; Isaiah contributes imagery of new creation, nations, and restoration; Zechariah offers horses, lampstands, and visionary scenes that John reconfigures. Ezekiel, Exodus, and the Psalms complete a repertoire in which Roman imperial language is interpreted through biblical images already charged with political and theological memory.

Intertextuality should therefore not be reduced to a search for linear "sources". John combines, displaces, and superimposes formulations within a new visionary architecture. Philological analysis must distinguish lexical coincidence, shared motif, and structural reuse; historical analysis must also allow for the textual plurality of the Greek Scriptures and that an allusion may depend on liturgical or mnemonic repertoires without implying direct copying from a single scroll.

14. Comparing motifs: similarity does not equal genealogy

Table 86. A comparison of motifs: similarity does not equal genealogy

Motif	John	Parallels	Degree of inference
Resurrection	Rev 20	Daniel 12; 4 Esdras; 2 Baruch; Iranian tradition	Strong direct Jewish root; relevant Iranian comparison, specific dependence not demonstrated.
Eschatological saviour	Lamb/Christ	Jewish Messiah; Saoshyant	Functional parallel; distinct religious genealogies.
Imperial beasts	Rev 13; 17	Daniel 7; ancient political imagery	Literary dependence on Daniel is very strong.
Returning king	Rev 17; Neronian reading	Nero redivivus; Sibylline Oracles	Plausible and probably relevant political-cultural contact.
Cosmic renewal	Rev 21–22	Isa 65–66; Iranian traditions of frašō.kərəti	Explicit Jewish prophetic root; comparative Iranian parallel.

(continued)

Motif	John	Parallels	Degree of inference
Judgement by fire	Rev 20	Biblical tradition; Apocalypse of Peter; metal/fire in Iranian tradition	Widely distributed motif; requires locus and chronology to claim influence.

The comparative method adopted here does not confuse similarity with filiation. Two traditions may share images of judgement, resurrection, cosmic combat, or renewal without either having borrowed the motif from the other. A claim of historical dependence requires more than resemblance: it must also be supported by chronological proximity, a plausible route of transmission, sufficiently specific correspondences, and an account of the significant differences.

Four levels of evaluation are used. [P] Parallel: typological similarity without any claim of contact. [C] Possible contact: geographical or cultural coexistence that makes circulation of the motif conceivable, but without a demonstrable chain. [T] Probable transmission: specific convergence accompanied by identifiable historical mediations. [D] Demonstrable dependence: a textual or documentary relationship sufficiently strong to support a line of transmission. Most ancient interreligious comparisons do not rise above the first two levels.

This scale is especially necessary when comparing with Zoroastrianism. Persian rule over Jewish populations, Mesopotamian networks, and the continuity of Jewish communities in Iranian territories constitute real historical conditions of contact. However, an eschatological system reconstructed from medieval Pahlavi texts cannot be directly transposed to the first century. The analysis therefore separates the motif, source, and date of the witness.

The same principle applies to the Sibylline Oracles and Nero redivivus. Here, the chronological proximity and the imperial context are greater, but the relationship with Revelation remains one of historical reconstruction: John nowhere identifies the beast with Nero by name. The 666/616 dossier, the healed wound, the sequence of kings, and the return traditions constitute a convergent whole, not an explicit inscription of the emperor's name in the text.

Numerological, geometric, or Neoplatonic constructions that cannot be supported by an ancient documentary chain are excluded from the explanatory apparatus. The number of the beast is studied through manuscript tradition, ancient procedures of nominal calculation, the imperial context, and early reception; not through modern correspondences or retrospective symbolic systems.

Table 87. Comparison of motifs: levels of similarity

Level	Criterion	Editorial use
[P] Parallel	Formal or thematic similarity.	Describes an analogy; does not assert contact.
[C] Possible contact	Temporal/geographical coincidence and plausible cultural channel.	Permits questions about circulation, without establishing borrowing.
[T] Probable transmission	Specific features + identifiable historical mediation.	Allows influence to be formulated as a strong, explicitly argued hypothesis.
[D] Demonstrable dependence	Direct textual/documentary relationship or exceptional accumulation of evidence.	Can support a historical relationship of dependence, provided the evidence is identified.

15. Christian reception: from expectation to canon

The status of the Book of Revelation was debated in different regions. It was strongly received by authors such as Justin Martyr (Dial. 81.4) and Irenaeus, especially in relation to millenarian expectations, while other contexts showed reservations. Dionysius of Alexandria, as transmitted by Eusebius (HE VII.25), used stylistic arguments to question the attribution of Revelation to the John who wrote the Gospel. This fact is crucial: Christians of the second and third centuries could accept the text as scripture and, at the same time, discuss its authorship, interpretation, and relationship to other Johannine writings.

Canonisation did not eliminate exegetical diversity. Millenarian, allegorical, historicist, liturgical, and political readings coexisted. For a history of Christianity across the first four centuries, it is less important to decide which later reading is "correct" than to observe how the book offered a vocabulary for thinking about persecution, empire, heresy, martyrdom, Christ's triumph, and consummation. Its plasticity explains both its centrality and its hermeneutical danger when it is disconnected from its ancient context.

16. Critical apparatus and verification sources

Greek text: Nestle-Aland 28/UBS5, with special attention to Revelation 13:18 (666/616), Revelation 1:8, 11, and other loci where tradition presents significant variants. For historical-literary commentary, the works consulted include David E. Aune, *Revelation*; Adela Yarbro Collins, *Crisis and Catharsis*; Craig R. Koester, *Revelation*; Richard Bauckham, *The Climax of Prophecy*; and the works of John J. Collins on Jewish apocalyptic literature. The relationship with the imperial cult should be tested against epigraphy, numismatics, and the provincial history of Asia and not inferred solely from the Christian text.

For 4 Esdras and 2 Baruch, critical editions and studies of post-70 CE apocalyptic literature are used. For the Ascension of Isaiah, Shepherd of Hermas, and Apocalypse of Peter, dates are expressed as ranges, and composition is distinguished from the date of surviving manuscripts. For Nero redivivus, Suetonius, Tacitus, Cassius Dio, the Neronian impostors, and the Sibylline Oracles are considered, distinguishing the date of each stratum. For Iranian eschatology, the Avesta, especially Yt 19, and studies by Mary Boyce, William Malandra, and the Encyclopaedia Iranica are consulted; late Pahlavi texts are cited as sources of reception and systematisation, not as first-century documents.

17. Conclusion: the vision of Christ at the end of the first century

The Book of Revelation testifies to a Christology of the late first century in which Jesus does not appear simply as a remembered teacher. He is the faithful witness, the firstborn from the dead, the slain and enthroned Lamb, the victorious rider, the Word of God, and a figure like a son of man. He shares the roles of judgement and worship within a reconfigured monotheistic vision. This profile should be compared with contemporary gospels and letters to understand the plurality of Christological languages before the councils, not to project Nicene definitions back onto it.

The eschatological horizon of the text is likewise multifaceted. Its primary source is the Jewish Scriptures; its historical enemy is formulated through the language of empire and Babylon; the Neronian motif offers a powerful political key; and comparisons with other Jewish, Christian, and Iranian apocalyptic texts show that the expectation of judgement and renewal was part of a much broader religious context. John's historical originality lies not in having invented each motif, but in the particular arrangement that brings them together around the Lamb and concrete communities in Asia Minor.

Summary

This chapter situates the Apocalypse of John within the apocalyptic cultures of the late first and second centuries. It examines the visionary Christ, the Lamb, the images of the Son of Man, Rome as Babylon, 666/616, and the Nero redivivus complex; it compares the work with Daniel, 1 Enoch, 4 Esdras, 2 Baruch, early Christian apocalypses, and Zoroastrian eschatology. It distinguishes structural parallels, historically plausible contacts, and demonstrable dependencies. Zoroastrian resurrection and renewal provide a relevant comparative horizon, but later Pahlavi systematisations must respect their own chronology. Nero is treated as a returning imperial adversary, without being equated with the resurrected Christ.

CHAPTER XXIII

Asceticism, Continence, and the Formation of Monasticism (First–Fourth Centuries)

Christian asceticism long predates the institutional consolidation of monasticism. Fasting, sexual continence, renunciation of property, consecrated widowhood, and disciplines of the body are already attested in first- and second-century sources, yet they do not amount to a homogeneous monastic institution. The task, therefore, is to distinguish these earlier ascetic practices from the eremitic and cenobitic forms that took more recognisable shape in the course of the third and fourth centuries.

1. Paul, marriage and continence

1 Corinthians 7 provides the earliest substantial documentary point of departure. Paul values continence within an eschatological horizon, while at the same time recognising marriage and articulating reciprocal obligations between spouses. His personal preference for celibacy should not be retrojected as a monastic rule into communities for which no such institution yet existed.

The Pastoral Epistles, whatever their precise dating, reflect a different social configuration, marked by households, widows, and increasingly explicit criteria for ecclesial office. The contrast underscores a central methodological point: asceticism must be studied as a historically situated option rather than treated as an intrinsic essence of earliest Christianity.

2. Widows, virgins, and ascetic continence in the second and third centuries

The Didache, the Shepherd of Hermas, Ignatius, Tertullian, Clement of Alexandria, and Cyprian attest to disciplines of fasting, sexual continence, and widowhood. Yet these categories are not socially or institutionally equivalent across regions: a widow maintained by a community, an ascetic virgin, and an Encratite teacher occupy distinct positions and cannot be collapsed into a single type.

Traditions associated with Tatian and with so-called Encratism show that the renunciation of marriage could acquire explicit doctrinal force. The label "Encratite", however, is largely inherited from classificatory and heresiological authors and should not be assumed to denote a single, coherent organisation.

3. Thecla and the ascetic imagination

The Acts of Paul and Thecla, generally dated to the second century, display with particular clarity the narrative force of female asceticism: Thecla rejects marriage, teaches, confronts martyrdom, and is associated with baptism. The work is therefore an important witness to ideals of continence and female authority, but not an independent biography of a historical collaborator of Paul.

4. Egypt: Antony, Pachomius, and the institutionalisation of monastic life

Athanasius's Life of Antony, composed in the fourth century, was decisive in the wider diffusion of the eremitic ideal. Yet the Antony presented there is also a literary and episcopal construction. Letters, parallel traditions, documentary evidence, and monastic archaeology make it possible to place that influential portrait within a more complex historical field.

Pachomius and the Egyptian cenobitic communities represent a different configuration: rules, labour, common meals, internal hierarchies, and forms of collective ownership organised a durable communal life. Eremitism and cenobitism should not, however, be arranged as successive stages in a single linear evolution.

5. Syria, Cappadocia and monastic diversity

Syrian and Mesopotamian ascetic traditions developed distinctive vocabularies and institutional forms; in Cappadocia, Basil and the networks associated with Macrina bring ascetic discipline into relation with communal life, hospitality, and organised care. Late-antique monasticism is thus best understood as a polycentric history rather than as the simple diffusion of a single Egyptian model.

5.1. Egyptian trajectories before cenobitic codification

The emergence of Egyptian monasticism cannot be reconstructed solely from the biographies of celebrated founders. Papyri, letters, property documents, and archaeological remains reveal a far more varied landscape of withdrawal, labour, and ascetic association. The "desert" itself was crossed by villages, routes, estates, quarries, and links with urban centres; physical distance from the city could therefore operate as an ascetic discipline without entailing complete social isolation.

This evidence requires a careful distinction among anchorites, small ascetic groups, and formally regulated communities. Antony cannot stand for the whole of eremitic life, any more than Pachomius can be treated as the inventor of every form of collective asceticism. Fourth-century sources construct normative genealogies within a more heterogeneous reality, in which bodily discipline, manual labour, reading, patronage, and charismatic authority could be combined in markedly different ways.

5.2. Syria and Mesopotamia: continence, covenant, and non-Egyptian ascetic forms

In Syria and Mesopotamia, ascetic vocabulary followed trajectories of its own. The valuation of continence, the "sons and daughters of the covenant", and other forms of dedicated life show that rigorous asceticism could remain embedded within urban and ecclesial communities without assuming the form of Egyptian desert withdrawal. Fourth-century Syriac sources disclose combinations of celibacy, ecclesial service, hymnody, and communal discipline, and thus caution against writing the history of monasticism as a one-way diffusion from Egypt to passive peripheries.

Table 88. Asceticism and monasticism (first–fourth centuries): dossiers

Dossier	Chronology	Main source	Historical value	Caution
1 Corinthians 7	c. 50s	Pauline letter	Continence and marriage in an eschatological horizon	Do not turn charismatic counsel into a monastic rule

(continued)

Dossier	Chronology	Main source	Historical value	Caution
The Acts of Paul and Thecla	Second century	Apocryphal narrative	Female asceticism and Pauline memory	Literary genre, not biographical record
Antony	Third–fourth centuries	Athanasius, Life of Antony	Eremitism and hagiographic construction	Check with other sources and archaeology
Pachomius	Fourth century	Pachomian rules and traditions	Organised cenobitism	Complex textual history
Basil/Macrina	Fourth century	Letters, rules, Gregory of Nyssa	Cappadocian asceticism and assistance	Do not homogenise different networks

Sources and reference bibliography: 1 Cor 7; Shepherd of Hermas; Tertullian, De virginibus velandis; Cyprian, De habitu virginum; Athanasius, Vita Antonii; Pachomian corpus; Basil of Caesarea. Selected studies: Elizabeth A. Clark, Susanna Elm, David Brakke, and James E. Goehring.

CHAPTER XXIV

Magic, Amulets, Exorcism, and Protective Material Culture in Early Christianity

The category of "magic" is historically unstable. In the Roman world, practices of protection, healing, divination, and ritual coercion could be classified as superstition, magic, medicine, philosophy, or religion depending on the observer, genre, and polemical setting. Analysis should therefore begin with objects, formulae, agents, and contexts of use rather than with a modern boundary between legitimate religion and illegitimate magic.

1. Acts and the polemic against ritual specialists

Acts 8, 13, and 19 construct figures such as Simon, Elymas, and the Ephesian practitioners who burn their books. These episodes disclose competition over ritual authority and thaumaturgical power, but they cannot be read as a neutral catalogue of magical professions or practices.

2. Exorcism and healing

The Gospels place exorcism at the centre of Jesus' public activity, and Christian sources of the second and third centuries continue to present it as a manifestation of divine power. Justin Martyr, Tertullian, and Origen also deploy exorcism apologetically. Historical analysis must therefore distinguish the practice itself from literary representations that may magnify its scope or effectiveness.

3. Papyri, gems and amulets

Egyptian papyri and amulets preserve psalms, divine names, signs, abbreviations, Gospel incipits, and protective formulae. Some objects can be identified as Christian with considerable confidence; others combine Jewish, Greek, Egyptian, and Christian repertoires. Such mixtures of vocabulary do not in themselves demonstrate a stable syncretic identity and may instead reflect the pragmatic logic of the object and its intended efficacy.

The so-called Greek magical papyri are a modern editorial corpus that brings together materials from widely differing dates and contexts. They should not be treated as though they represented a single, unitary "magical religion" existing in parallel with Christianity.

4. Medicine, relics and ritual boundaries

A protective formula, the laying on of hands, oil, a relic, or a medical prescription may all serve therapeutic or apotropaic functions without belonging to the same regime of authority. Comparison becomes historically informative when medium, agent, formula, recipient, and context are specified; it becomes misleading when functional resemblance is allowed to stand as evidence of dependence.

4.1. The amulet as object: medium, inscription, and bodily use

The analysis of an amulet cannot end with the transcription of its formula. Material, dimensions, folding, perforation, container, traces of use, and archaeological context all require documentation, since these features bear directly on the ways in which the inscribed text was intended to operate upon the body and within domestic space. A Gospel fragment worn at the neck, an inscribed lamella deposited in a grave, and an engraved gem may share an apotropaic purpose without belonging to the same chain of production or ritual repertoire.

The presence of nomina sacra, crosses, voces magicae, angelic names, or biblical incipits is likewise insufficient, on its own, to classify an artefact as "orthodox", "magical", or "syncretic". Attribution must rest on the convergence of formula, palaeography, iconography, provenance, and comparanda. This discipline is particularly important for unprovenanced material, since the modern antiquities market may have severed an object from precisely the contextual information required for responsible interpretation.

4.2. Defixiones, cursing, and the limits of attribution

Greco-Roman defixiones provide an indispensable comparandum because they document technologies of ritual writing—names, binding formulae, invocations, and deposition in particular places—that could coexist with other protective uses of text. Yet identifying a curse tablet as Christian requires more than the appearance of a biblical name or a cross. Religious repertoires across the Empire shared signs and names, while formulae could circulate without stable confessional ownership. Attribution should therefore remain graded, explicit, and open to revision.

Table 89. Defixiones and protective practices: objects and attribution

Object / practice	Centuries	Context	Function	Caution
Gospel exorcism	First century	Literary Galilee/ Judea	Liberation and authority	Theological narrative and historical practice are not identical
PGM and ritual papyri	Second–fourth centuries and later	Greco-Roman Egypt	Protection, healing, coercion	Heterogeneous corpus
Christian amulets	Third–fourth centuries and later	Egypt and the Mediterranean	Body/domestic protection	Dating and religious attribution on a case-by-case basis
Inscribed gems	Second–fourth centuries	Eastern Mediterranean	Apotropaic/healing	Shared iconography does not imply shared community
Relics and holy objects	Third–fourth centuries	Late Antique Christianity	Sacred memory and mediation	Do not project medieval forms

Sources and reference bibliography: Acts 8; 13; 19; Justin Martyr, Apol.; Tertullian, Apol.; Origen, Contra Celsum; papyri and amulets published with provenance. Selected studies: Hans Dieter Betz, Roy Kotansky, Theodore de Bruyn, and David Frankfurter.

CHAPTER XXV

Childhood, Family, Marriage and Household in Christian Communities (First–Fourth Centuries)

Early Christianity developed within households, kinship networks, workshops, and relations of dependency. The "Christian family" was never a homogeneous social unit: married couples, widows, enslaved people, freedpeople, patrons, children, ascetics, and religiously mixed households coexisted within the same social world. This chapter reconstructs that domestic sphere without projecting the assumptions of the modern nuclear family onto the Roman Mediterranean.

1. Oikos, domus, and household communities

The Pauline letters attest assemblies meeting in houses and networks of hosts who made such gatherings possible. The household was not merely a private space: it could also be an economic unit, a workshop, a locus of patronage, and a setting for communal meetings. "House church" should therefore be understood primarily as a mode of gathering, not as evidence for a specialised Christian architecture in the first century.

2. Marriage, sexuality and mixed households

1 Corinthians 7 attests marriages between believers and non-believers, separation, continence, and reciprocal obligations. The Deutero-Pauline and Pastoral Epistles reflect other forms of domestic discipline. The so-called Haustafeln should be compared with wider Greco-Roman moral discourse, but not reduced to the direct reproduction of any single philosophical school.

3. Children, birth and baptism

Children appear unevenly across the sources. The infancy narratives of Matthew and Luke are theological compositions concerning Jesus, whereas letters and ecclesial texts permit a different set of social-historical questions. Evidence for infant baptism becomes clearer in the second and third centuries: Tertullian's advice in De baptismo 18 that baptism be delayed in certain cases presupposes that the practice was already known.

Later patristic testimony should not be projected automatically onto Pauline communities. References to the baptism of an entire "household" in Acts and the Pauline corpus do not, by themselves, establish the age of each person baptised.

4. Exposure, adoption and child vulnerability

The exposure of newborns and various forms of fosterage belong to the legal and social world of the Roman Empire, but their incidence is difficult to quantify securely. Christian authors condemn practices they present as homicidal or immoral; such rhetoric must be tested against papyrological evidence, law, and demographic reconstruction before collective behaviour is inferred.

5. Education, memory and transmission

Religious formation in childhood took place through listening, repetition, reading, psalmody, narrative, and domestic discipline. From the fourth century onwards, expanding ecclesiastical infrastructure made formal catechesis and specifically Christian forms of education more visible, although the household remained a decisive setting of transmission.

5.1. Funerary epigraphy, childhood, and family memory

Funerary epigraphy considerably enlarges a literary archive in which children appear only intermittently. Age at death, kinship terms, affective formulae, and, in some cases, explicitly Christian markers allow grief, filiation, and family memory to be studied with greater precision. Epitaphs are not, however, a neutral demographic sample: their survival depends upon economic resources, local commemorative conventions, and material preservation. The frequency of a formula cannot be converted directly into a rate of mortality, literacy, or religious adherence.

Read alongside sarcophagi, catacomb evidence, and legal documentation, these testimonies suggest a gradual Christianisation of domestic memory. Biblical images

and formulae of hope could coexist with wider Roman funerary conventions; Christian distinctiveness must therefore be located in particular combinations of signs and practices rather than in an assumed wholesale rupture with existing repertoires.

5.2. Household economy, slavery, and authority within the household

A household that hosts an assembly is also an economic unit. Enslaved people, freedpeople, clients, artisans, and relatives could inhabit the same space without sharing legal status or equal control over resources and mobility. Networks of "house churches" should therefore be reconstructed through property, patronage, and labour as well as through kinship and religious affiliation. The hospitality that makes an assembly possible may indicate economic capacity, but it does not by itself identify the property-holder as the community's sole leader.

Table 90. Household economy, slavery and authority in the house: themes

Issue	Early source	Historical question	Limit
Meeting house	Rom 16; 1 Cor 16; Phlm	Patronage and sociability	House ≠ specialised church building
Marriage	1 Cor 7	Discipline and eschatology	Do not universalise a Corinthian situation
Children/Baptism	Tert., Bapt. 18	Practice in the second–third centuries	No proof of universal apostolic practice
Slave households	Phlm; domestic codes	Dependence, kinship, and religion	Fraternal language does not eliminate legal status.
Education	catechesis and homily	Intergenerational transmission	Regionally uneven evidence

Sources and selected scholarship: 1 Corinthians 7; Romans 16; Philemon; Ephesians 5–6; Colossians 3–4; Shepherd of Hermas; Tertullian, On Baptism 18; Roman legal and papyrological documentation. Selected studies: Beryl Rawson, Judith Evans Grubbs, Richard Saller, and Carolyn Osiek; on infant baptism, Everett Ferguson, Baptism in the Early Church (2009).

CHAPTER XXVI

The Imperial Cult, Sacrifice, and Political Loyalty: From Augustus to the Tetrarchy

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The imperial cult was not a uniform institution imposed from Rome. Cities, provinces, associations, and local elites articulated their own forms of honouring living and deified emperors through temples, priesthoods, festivals, sacrifices, images, and oaths. Christian conflicts can be understood only by reconstructing this diversity rather than reducing every gesture of civic loyalty to a single "religion of the emperor".

1. Asia Minor and the civic competition for imperial honours

The cities of Asia Minor developed temples, priesthoods, and titles linked to the imperial cult, and competed for prestige as neokoroi. This environment is especially relevant to Revelation because the seven churches are situated within cities where civic religion, benefaction, and imperial power formed a visible network.

2. Images, sacrifice, and tests of loyalty

Pliny's correspondence with Trajan documents a provincial procedure in which invocation of the gods, sacrifice, and reverence before the imperial image could serve to test whether Christian identity had been renounced. The exchange does not constitute a universal code of persecution; it does, however, show the political and juridical weight that ritual gestures could acquire in a particular administrative setting.

3. Revelation: beast, image, and economy

Revelation 13 brings political authority, cult, image, and economic constraint together within a symbolic vision. Comparison with the imperial cult helps reconstruct the text's horizon of intelligibility, but it does not justify treating every apocalyptic detail as a coded transcription of a specific municipal ceremony.

The representation of Rome as Babylon in Revelation 17–18 places commerce, luxury, and violence within a broader theopolitical critique. The text draws simultaneously upon scriptural codes and the experience of imperial power.

4. Decius, libelli, and the empire-wide scale of sacrifice

Decius's policy of 249–251 marks a significant change of scale. The surviving Egyptian libelli document the certification of sacrifice, personal identity, and administrative procedure. The measure should not be described simply as a "persecution of Christians": it required widespread ritual compliance, with particularly serious consequences for those who refused on account of Christian conviction.

5. The Tetrarchy and the transformation of conflict

The Great Persecution initiated under Diocletian and his colleagues combined edicts, the destruction of buildings, the surrender or confiscation of books, and sacrificial demands, all with substantial regional variation. The imperial cult formed part of the language of loyalty, but the conflict must also be understood through administration, military discipline, legal authority, and the wider reorganisation of imperial power.

6. Cults of the Empire and the limits of comparison with early Christianities

The imperial cult belonged to a wider religious landscape in which traditional civic cults, Dionysiac associations, devotion to Isis and Serapis, the cults of Magna Mater, and Mithraic communities coexisted with many other local configurations. Older scholarship sometimes treated "mystery religions" as a homogeneous family from which Christian baptism, ritual meals, salvation, or initiation might be explained by analogy. That model is inadequate: each cult possessed its own chronology, agents, spaces, ritual structures, and degrees of secrecy, and formal resemblance acquires historical significance only where a concrete context of contact can be established.

Mithras offers a particularly instructive comparison. The archaeology of mithraea documents relatively small meeting spaces, communal meals, and specialised iconography, while participation was organised predominantly through male networks and, in some regions, military milieus. The cults of Isis and Serapis, by contrast, could be highly visible in public space, with processions and Mediterranean networks operating on a different scale; Cybele/Magna Mater and Attis possessed still other ritual calendars and institutional settings. Comparison with Christian communities helps reconstruct the competitive religious plurality of the Empire; it does not establish automatic borrowing or a common genealogy.

Chronology is equally decisive. A late literary description of a mystery rite cannot simply be used to explain a first-century Christian practice. Nor does shared vocabulary—salvation, initiation, banquet, purity—establish dependence by itself, since such language could belong to the broader religious lexicon of the Mediterranean. The method adopted here therefore compares institutions and practices within their documented settings and reserves claims of influence for cases in which chronological proximity, plausible contact, and specific correspondences converge.

TABLE 91. Imperial cults and Christianities: contexts of comparison

Context	Date	Evidence	Relationship with Christians	Caution
Imperial civic cult	First–third centuries	inscriptions, coins, temples	Environment of honours and loyalty	It was not uniform
Pliny–Trajan	c. 111–113	Plin. Iun., Ep. X.96–97	Sacrifice and image as proof	Provincial case, not universal law
Revelation	late first century	Revelation 13; 17–18	Symbolic critique of power	Do not interpret each image literally.
Decius	249–251	libelli and Christian sources	Sacrificial certification	Motivation and scope must be distinguished

(continued)

Context	Date	Evidence	Relationship with Christians	Caution
Tetrarchy	303–311	edicts and narratives	Imperial-scale persecution	Uneven regional application

Sources and reference bibliography: provincial inscriptions; imperial coins; Pliny, Ep. X.96–97; Rev 13 and 17–18; Decian libelli; Lactantius and Eusebius for the Tetrarchy, read as authors with particular interests. Selected studies: Simon Price, Duncan Fishwick, Steven Friesen, and Ittai Gradel; on Decius's decree as a general religious requirement, James B. Rives, "The Decree of Decius and the Religion of Empire," Journal of Roman Studies 89 (1999).

CHAPTER XXVII

From House to Basilica: Topography of Worship, Funerary Memory and the Sacralisation of Christian Space (First–Fourth Centuries)

The preceding chapters dealt separately with the house of assembly (V and XXV), liturgy (XVI), martyrdom (IV) and imperial architecture (XX). This chapter brings them together in a question of topography: how and when Christians moved from meeting in houses to having places of their own, from honouring their dead in cemeteries to organising space around sacred memories, and which part of that transformation can rest on the inherited Scriptures and which required new elaborations. The answer is neither rupture nor unaltered continuity. Between the first and fourth centuries there was a progressive territorialisation, materialisation and institutionalisation of Christian memory and of its ritual practices. The chapter offers a timeline of places and spaces of worship (Table 92), an archaeological catalogue by region and century (Table 93) and a separate matrix of exegetical tensions (Table 94), so that it can be established when each practice appears, what evidence there is for it, and how far it is legitimate to relate it to the oldest Christian scriptures.

1. Houses and assemblies in the Pauline letters and in Acts

The Pauline letters offer the oldest evidence. Paul greets the assembly that meets in the house of Prisca and Aquila (Rom 16:5; 1 Cor 16:19), that of Nympha (Col 4:15) and that of Philemon (Phlm 2); in Corinth the Lord's Supper takes place in a gathering that presupposes a domestic space with hierarchies of the table (1 Cor 11:17–34). Acts adds meetings in the house of Mary, mother of John Mark (Acts 12:12), in the upper room at Troas (Acts 20:7–8), in the house of Titius Justus next to the synagogue at Corinth (Acts 18:7) and in the hall of Tyrannus at Ephesus (Acts 19:9), while the Jerusalem community continues to frequent the Temple (Acts 2:46; 3:1) and Paul preaches in the synagogues (Acts 17:1–2; 18:4).

Ἐκκλησία designates in these texts an assembly, not a building, and no specific Christian building of the first century is known. Medium-sized houses allowed a few dozen people to gather in a dining room and an atrium, not a crowd; the composition of the Pauline assemblies, made up of several articulated households, is compatible with that. This phase raises no exegetical tension: the domestic meeting is what the oldest texts describe. Tension appears when the community acquires places of its own.

2. Adapted houses, assembly halls and buildings in the second and third centuries

Between the second century and the middle of the third, the literary sources and archaeology agree on one point: there are recognisable places of worship, but no basilicas. Dura-Europos preserves a house adapted c. 240–256 (Chapter V): two rooms joined together form an assembly hall of about five by thirteen metres, and another room is turned into a baptistery with paintings of the Good Shepherd, Adam and Eve, the healing of the paralytic and the women at the tomb. The name "house church" describes a function, does not prove a stable typological form, and recent revisions of the building's phases counsel against fixing its internal chronology with more precision than the data allow. Kefar ʿOthnay (Megiddo), with its mosaic and the inscription of Akeptous, adds an assembly hall with features of its own around the third century. With an initial date of about 230, it is usually presented as the oldest identified Christian prayer hall in the region, earlier than the house at Dura-Europos; its inscription, which speaks of offering "the table to God Jesus Christ as a memorial", is also one of the earliest mentions of Jesus Christ as "God" in a building. It should be made clear that it is a hall of simple plan, neither a converted house nor a basilica,

part of a complex excavated in the Megiddo prison compound, and that proposals for a later date prevent the chronological priority from being treated as settled.

The literary sources show the same from another angle. The Chronicle of Edessa records the destruction by flood, in 201, of "the temple of the church of the Christians" (Chronicle of Edessa 8); Eusebius states that before the persecution Christians built spacious churches "from the foundations" (Eusebius, HE VIII.1.5); Lactantius describes at Nicomedia the church that overlooked the palace and was razed in 303 (Lactantius, Mort. pers. 12); the edict of Gallienus restores "places of worship" and cemeteries (Eusebius, HE VII.13). The size and form of those buildings can only be inferred. At Rome, the houses beneath the titular churches (San Clemente, Santa Prisca) show that aristocratic residences existed beneath later churches, but their Christian use before the fourth century has not been demonstrated archaeologically: it is a hypothesis that starts from late traditions.

3. Cemeteries, funerary memory and the cult of the martyrs

Funerary memory precedes monumental cultic buildings. The Martyrdom of Polycarp describes, around the middle of the second century, how the community gathered the martyr's bones, "more precious than costly stones", laid them in a suitable place and resolved to celebrate there the day of his birth, that is, of his martyrdom (Martyrdom of Polycarp 18.2–3). The same text distinguishes between Christ, whom we worship, and the martyrs, whom we love as disciples and imitators of the Lord (Martyrdom of Polycarp 17.3). Tertullian alludes to Christian burial "areas" (Tertullian, Ad Scap. 3), and according to Hippolytus the future bishop Callistus was put in charge of the Roman community's cemetery by Zephyrinus (Hippolytus, Ref. IX.12.14), so that around 200 the Church of Rome owned and administered a cemetery.

At Rome, the sites on the Vatican and on the Via Ostiensis, attested by Gaius around 200 (Eusebius, HE II.25.7), and the Memoria Apostolorum at San Sebastiano (Chapter V) show that the memory of Peter and Paul was materialised in monuments and funerary banquets before any basilica. Eusebius documents, in addition, individual journeys to the Holy Land for prayer or inquiry: Melito of Sardis travels to the East to learn about the place where the message was proclaimed and fulfilled (Eusebius, HE IV.26.14), and Alexander of Cappadocia visits Jerusalem "for prayer and to see the places" (Eusebius, HE VI.11.2). Two features emerge: the tomb receives ritual treatment (anniversary, banquet, invocation), and memory becomes attached to specific places.

4. Places of gospel memory: Golgotha, Zion, Capernaum and the Constantinian Holy Land

The traditions about Jerusalem show well the distance between text and place. Acts locates the first community in the Temple and in houses, among them the upper room (Acts 1:13) and the house of Mary, mother of John Mark, to which Peter goes when freed (Acts 12:12). A later tradition, preserved by Epiphanius, claims that when the disciples returned to Jerusalem after 70 they found on Zion a "small church of God" (Epiphanius, Mens. 14), and from the late fourth century the liturgy of Zion is associated with the upper room. Neither Peter's "house" in Jerusalem nor the Cenacle can be verified archaeologically for the first century; they are identifications of local tradition whose antiquity cannot be fixed.

From Constantine on, the system changes scale. According to Eusebius, the emperor ordered a basilica built at Jerusalem over the place identified with Christ's tomb and a complex at Golgotha (Eusebius, VC III.25–40); foundations followed at Bethlehem and on the Mount of Olives (Eusebius, VC III.41–43) and at Mamre (Eusebius, VC III.51–53). The text is an imperial and apologetic narrative, and the identification of the tomb, close to the forum of Hadrianic Aelia Capitolina, is plausible but not verifiable beyond local tradition. Egeria's Itinerarium, of the late fourth century, already shows a stational liturgy organised around those places and recalls at Capernaum the house of the prince of the apostles, turned into a church (Egeria, Itin. 20.5). Joan E. Taylor, in Christians and the Holy Places (1993), criticised the hypothesis of an uninterrupted Christian veneration of the places from the first century and stressed the role of Constantinian reworking; her reading is a methodological warning against using topographical traditions as independent witnesses. Capernaum illustrates the problem: beneath the fifth-century octagonal church lies a first-century dwelling remodelled in later phases; whether it was Peter's house is an identification of local tradition whose early cultic continuity is disputed.

5. From hall to basilica: monumentalisation and sacralisation of space

With Constantine and his successors the basilical form, taken from civic architecture, becomes the model of the public church: the Lateran, an imperial foundation at Rome c. 313–320; the Vatican basilica over the necropolis that guarded the memory of Peter; that of Tyre, dedicated c. 315 and described by Eusebius in a panegyric (Eusebius, HE X.4). Three features separate these buildings from earlier forms: scale (naves able to hold an urban congregation), the fixing of the altar and the clergy in an apse, and the economic endowment of imperial patronage.

Monumentalisation raises tensions that the oldest texts do not resolve by themselves. Acts presents Stephen and Paul as asserting that God "does not dwell in temples made by hands" (Acts 7:48; 17:24), John places worship "in spirit and truth" (John 4:21–24), and the Pauline letters apply temple language to the community (1 Cor 3:16–17; Eph 2:19–22). Around 200 the apologists deny having altars and temples (Minucius Felix, Oct. 10.2; 32.1), and Origen, against Celsus, defends the absence of altars, images and temples (Origen, Cels. VIII.17–20). The patristic solution was to distinguish the temple-community from the house of assembly and, later, to attribute to the building a consecration of its own, so that one language covered two realities. Images offer a parallel case: the baptistery of Dura and the Roman catacombs present biblical scenes, while canon 36 of the Council of Elvira (c. 300–306) forbids paintings in churches; practice coexisted with the objection.

6. Timeline of places and spaces of worship (c. 30–c. 384)

Table 92 orders the known events and spaces from the execution of Jesus to the Constantinian peace and its immediate consequences. It distinguishes three statuses: the attested event or building, the later tradition that locates it, and modern inference. The oldest Jerusalem localisations (upper room, Peter's house, church of Zion) belong to the second category.

Table 92. Timeline of Christian places and spaces of worship, c. 30–c. 384

Date	Event or space	Place	Source	Historiographical status
c. 30–33	Execution and burial of Jesus	Jerusalem: Golgotha and tomb	Mark 15:22–47; John 19:17–42	Execution, high; exact location, later tradition
c. 30–40	Prayer in the Temple and meals in houses; upper room; house of Mary, mother of John Mark	Jerusalem	Acts 1:13; 2:46; 3:1; 12:12	Lukan tradition; later identifications (Peter's house, Cenacle) not verifiable
c. 40–60	Urban domestic assemblies	Antioch, Corinth, Ephesus, Rome	Gal 2:11–14; Rom 16:5; 1 Cor 16:19; Phlm 2	High; no specific buildings
c. 64–67	Death of Peter and Paul at Rome, according to tradition	Rome	1 Clement 5–6; Ignatius, Rom. 4.3	Early tradition; circumstances uncertain

(continued)

Date	Event or space	Place	Source	Historiographical status
70	Destruction of the Temple; end of Christian attendance at the Temple	Jerusalem	Eusebius, HE III.5.3	Destruction, high; move to Pella, tradition
c. 112	Meetings "before dawn" and common meal	Pontus-Bithynia	Pliny, Ep. X.96	High
c. 135	Aelia Capitolina; Gentile-origin community at Jerusalem; tradition of a "small church" on Zion	Jerusalem	Eusebius, HE IV.5.1–4; Epiphanius, Mens. 14	Community, high; church of Zion, late tradition
c. 150–155	Description of the Sunday meeting	Rome	Justin, 1 Apol. 65–67	High; apologetic text
c. 155–160	Gathering of remains and anniversary of Polycarp	Smyrna	Martyrdom of Polycarp 17–18	High
c. 160–170	Aedicula of the "red wall"	Vatican, Rome	Gaius, in Eusebius, HE II.25.7	Apostolic memory, high; contents of the tomb, disputed
201	Church damaged by flood	Edessa	Chronicle of Edessa 8	Literary only
c. 200–220	Community cemetery administered by the Church of Rome	Rome	Hippolytus, Ref. IX.12.14	High
c. 230	Assembly hall with mosaic	Kefar 'Othnay (Megiddo)	Tepper and Di Segni 2006	Date disputed; not a basilica
c. 240–256	Adapted house with assembly hall and baptistery	Dura-Europos	Kraeling 1967	High; phases under revision
257–260	Persecution of Valerian; cult of Peter and Paul at San Sebastiano (tradition); restoration of places under Gallienus	Rome, Empire	Eusebius, HE VII.13	Restoration, high; link with 258, disputed

(continued)

Date	Event or space	Place	Source	Historiographical status
303–311	Destruction of churches in the Great Persecution	Nicomedia, Empire	Lactantius, Mort. pers. 12; Eusebius, HE VIII.2	High
311–313	Edicts of toleration and restitution of places	Empire	Lactantius, Mort. pers. 48; Eusebius, HE X.5.2–14	High
c. 313–320	Basilica of the Lateran	Rome	Liber Pontificalis (late source)	Foundation certain; details late
c. 315	Basilica of Tyre	Tyre	Eusebius, HE X.4	Panegyrical description; no excavation
325–335	Anastasis and Martyrium, Bethlehem, Olivet, Mamre; dedication of 335	Palestine	Eusebius, VC III.25–43, 51–53; IV.43–45	Buildings certain; identification of sites, traditional
first half of the 4th c.	Buildings over the Vatican necropolis and the Via Ostiensis	Rome	Gaius, in Eusebius, HE II.25.7	High at the Vatican; lower at the Ostiensis
c. 381–384	Stational liturgy in Jerusalem; Peter's house at Capernaum turned into a church	Jerusalem, Galilee	Egeria, Itin. 20.5	High as late testimony; does not prove apostolic origin

7. Archaeological catalogue by region and century

Table 93 gathers the sites and testimonies that support or limit what has been said. Each row gives region and century, description, associated literary or epigraphic testimony and the degree of certainty: "certain" where the building or monument has been excavated and its Christian use is secure; "literary only" where only sources attest it; "disputed" where the date or function admits more than one reading.

TABLE 93. Archaeological catalogue by region and century: places of worship, funerary memory and basilicas

Region and century	Site	Date and description	Literary or epigraphic testimony	Function and degree of certainty
Judea and Galilee, 1st–5th c.	Capernaum, "Peter's house"	First-century dwelling remodelled in later phases, covered by a fifth-century octagonal church	Egeria, Itin. 20.5	Dwelling certain; apostolic identification and early cult, disputed
Galilee, 3rd c.	Kefar 'Othnay, Megiddo prison compound	Hall with geometric mosaic and fish; inscription of Akeptous; c. 230, with later proposals	Tepper and Di Segni 2006	Christian prayer hall; date and status disputed
Arabia, c. 300	Aila (Aqaba)	Small basilica-plan building; c. 300 according to the excavators	—	Pre-Constantinian church on that dating; medium certainty
Syria, 240–256	Dura-Europos	Adapted house: assembly hall of about 5 × 13 m and baptistery with paintings	Paintings and graffiti	Christian building certain; phases and functions of rooms under revision
Osrhoene, 201	Edessa	Church damaged by flood	Chronicle of Edessa 8	Literary only
Bithynia, 303	Nicomedia	Church destroyed in the Great Persecution	Lactantius, Mort. pers. 12	Literary only
Rome, c. 160–200	Vatican: aedicula and "red wall"	Funerary monument set into the necropolis wall; graffiti	Gaius, in Eusebius, HE II.25.7	Apostolic memory certain; contents of the tomb and "Petros eni", disputed
Rome, 2nd–3rd c.	Via Ostiensis	Memory of Paul; later Constantinian building	Gaius, in Eusebius, HE II.25.7	Literary memory; pre-Constantinian material remains little known
Rome, 3rd c.	San Sebastiano, Memoria Apostolorum	Hundreds of graffiti and a hall for funerary banquets	Graffiti	Cult of memory certain; link with 258 late and disputed
Rome, 3rd c.	Cemetery of Callistus	Catacomb of the Roman community	Hippolytus, Ref. IX.12.14	Communal ownership and administration; high certainty

(continued)

Region and century	Site	Date and description	Literary or epigraphic testimony	Function and degree of certainty
Rome, 1st–4th c.	Houses beneath San Clemente and Santa Prisca	Residences and mithraea beneath later churches	—	Christian use before the fourth century not demonstrated
Rome, c. 313–320	Lateran	Imperial basilica	Liber Pontificalis (late source)	Constantinian foundation certain; details late
Phoenicia, c. 315	Tyre	Basilica dedicated with a panegyric	Eusebius, HE X.4	Panegyrical description; no excavation
Palestine, 325–335	Jerusalem, Bethlehem, Mount of Olives, Mamre	Constantinian foundations	Eusebius, VC III.25–43, 51–53	Buildings certain; identification of sites, traditional

8. Matrix of exegetical tensions

Table 94 separates the archaeological question from the exegetical one. For each practice it gives the earliest evidence, the support in the oldest scriptures and the tension the practice creates with them, so that the reader can see precisely when each form of worship appears and how far it is legitimate to relate it to the texts Christians inherited.

Table 94. Matrix of exegetical tensions: practices, spaces and the oldest scriptures

Practice or form	Earliest evidence	Basis in the oldest scriptures	Exegetical tension	Certainty
Domestic assembly	50s (Paul)	Rom 16:5; 1 Cor 16:19; Phlm 2	None: continuity	High
Building of its own	Edessa 201; Dura c. 240–256	No mandate; Acts 7:48; 17:24	"God does not dwell in temples"; resolved by 1 Cor 3:16 (the temple is the community)	Medium-high
Table or altar	Inscription at Kefar 'Othnay; Origen, Cels. VIII.17–20	1 Cor 10:21; Heb 13:10	Cultic language against the rejection of sacrifice and the pagan altar	Medium

(continued)

Practice or form	Earliest evidence	Basis in the oldest scriptures	Exegetical tension	Certainty
Tomb and memorial banquet	Martyrdom of Polycarp 18; Vatican c. 160–170; San Sebastiano	Rev 6:9; Matt 23:29–30	Honouring the dead against Matt 8:22 and the critique of the tombs of the prophets	Medium-high
Pilgrimage to places	Melito, Eusebius, HE IV.26.14; Alexander, HE VI.11.2	John 4:21–24	Worship "in spirit and truth" against valuing the place	Medium
Images	Dura c. 240; catacombs; Elvira, can. 36 (c. 300–306)	Exod 20:4	Prohibition of images against narrative painting	Existence, high; function, medium
Monumental basilica	Lateran c. 313–320; Tyre c. 315	Eph 2:19–22; 1 Cor 3:16	Spiritual temple against the building	High as a phenomenon
Consecration of place	Dedication at Jerusalem in 335; Tyre	John 4:21	Holiness of space against the centrality of the assembly	High as a phenomenon

9. Historical-critical conclusion

The findings do not allow us to maintain without qualification that the monumental churches of the fourth century were a betrayal of the teaching of Jesus, nor that they represented an architectural continuation, unaltered, of the apostolic communities. They allow a more precise thesis: between the first and fourth centuries there was a progressive territorialisation, materialisation and institutionalisation of Christian memory and of its ritual practices. That transformation created new forms of relation to places, the dead, images and ecclesiastical authority. Some could be justified by the inherited texts; others generated tensions that required new theological elaborations.

The documentation on Golgotha, Dura-Europos, Megiddo, Capernaum and the Roman apostolic cemeteries offers an exceptional basis for studying that process without reducing it to a simplistic opposition between an "original" and a "later" Christianity. The chapter is, moreover, a case of the book's general thesis: the convergence of memory, text, ritual practice, authority and material representation in a configuration that starts from the domestic assembly fixed in Paul's letters and extends, over four centuries, to a system of places, cemeteries and basilicas.

Sources and control bibliography: Rom 16; 1 Cor 11 and 16; Phlm; Acts 2; 7; 12; 17–20; Justin, 1 Apol. 65–67; Martyrdom of Polycarp 17–18; Tertullian, Apol. 39 and Ad Scap. 3; Hippolytus, Ref. IX.12; Minucius Felix, Oct.; Origen, Cels. VIII; Eusebius, HE II.25, IV.26, VI.11, VII.13, VIII.1, X.4 and VC III–IV; Lactantius, Mort. pers.; Egeria, Itin.; Kraeling, The Christian Building; L. M. White, The Social Origins of Christian Architecture; J. E. Taylor, Christians and the Holy Places; Tepper and Di Segni, A Christian Prayer Hall; Toynbee and Ward-Perkins, The Shrine of St. Peter.

Appendix. Synchronism Matrix in Four Bands (First–Fourth Centuries)

The matrix intersects imperial chronology, the history of Judea and Galilee, Christian literary/community production, and external reception. Its function is to visualise simultaneities, not to assert automatic causal relationships between events close in time.

Documentary comparison 6. Synchronisms in four bands: empire, Judea, communities and documents.

14–37: Tiberius; 37–41: Caligula

Judea and Galilee. 26–36: prefecture of Pontius Pilate; c. 30–33: execution of Jesus

Literature and Christian communities. c. 30s: Jerusalem community; Paul's incorporation into the movement.

External reception / authors. No surviving Roman documentation of the movement from these decades.

41–54: Claudius; c. 49 expulsion of Jews from Rome

Judea and Galilee. 41–44: Herod Agrippa I; famines and social tensions

Literature and Christian communities. c. 48–50: controversy over Gentiles; c. 50: 1 Thess

External reception / authors. Suetonius, writing decades later, mentions disturbances impulsore Chresto.

54–68: Nero; 64: Fire of Rome

Judea and Galilee. 52–60: Felix; activity of the "Egyptian"; 62 death of James

Literature and Christian communities. c. 50s: major Pauline epistles

External reception / authors. Tacitus, writing c. 116, recalls the Neronian repression.

69–96: Flavian dynasty and Domitian

Judea and Galilee. 66–73: war; 70 destruction of the Temple

Literature and Christian communities. c. 70–100: Mark, Matthew, Luke-Acts and John, with disputed chronologies

External reception / authors. Josephus publishes Antiquities c. 93/94.

98–117: Trajan

Judea and Galilee. 115–117: rebellions in the Diaspora

Literature and Christian communities. Didache and Ignatius, approximate dates

External reception / authors. Pliny, Ep. X.96–97, c. 110–113; Tacitus, Ann. XV.44, c. 116.

117–138: Hadrian

Judea and Galilee. 132–135: Bar Kokhba; Jerusalem/Aelia Capitolina

Literature and Christian communities. Regional Christian diversification

External reception / authors. External perceptions remain fragmentary.

138–161: Antoninus Pius

Judea and Galilee. Post-Bar Kokhba Jewish reorganisation

Literature and Christian communities. Marcion and Justin in Rome

External reception / authors. Pagan criticism survives only unsystematically.

161–192: Marcus Aurelius and Commodus

Judea and Galilee. Rabbinic centres in Galilee

Literature and Christian communities. Irenaeus; Valentinian literature; other gospels

External reception / authors. Celsus, c. 175–180.

193–235: Severan dynasty

Judea and Galilee. Galilee and rabbinic diaspora

Literature and Christian communities. Tertullian; Clement; young Origen; P^{46} c. 200

External reception / authors. Pagan-Christian intellectual controversy becomes increasingly visible.

249–260: Decius and Valerian

Judea and Galilee. Late rabbinic transformations

Literature and Christian communities. Cyprian; crises of lapsi; martyrdoms

External reception / authors. Imperial measures and administrative documentation.

293–311: Tetrarchy (Diocletian reigns from 284)

Judea and Galilee. Palestine under Roman administration in the East

Literature and Christian communities. Origen already deceased; consolidated ecclesial networks; 303–311 Great Persecution

External reception / authors. Porphyry in the third century; Hierocles at the beginning of the fourth.

306–337: Constantine

Judea and Galilee. Monumentalisation of Jerusalem from the 320s

Literature and Christian communities. 325 Nicaea; Eusebius; Constantinian basilicas

External reception / authors. Hierocles is refuted by Eusebius; pagan criticism enters a new relationship with imperial power.

337–361: Constantius II, Constans and post-Constantinian recomposition

Judea and Galilee. Continuity of Jewish and Christian communities; Jerusalem and Palestine are integrated into an increasingly monumentalised imperial Christian geography.

Literature and Christian communities. Athanasius, Hilary, Cyril of Jerusalem; synods and controversies on Nicaea; Egyptian and Syrian ascetic development.

External reception / authors. Libanius begins his career; Ammianus Marcellinus later provides a non-Christian account of imperial policy. Fourth-century constitutions preserved in the Codex Theodosianus must be cited by their original date and title, not as though the compilation of 438 were contemporary with each law.

361–363: Julian

Judea and Galilee. Christian and Jewish Palestine under Julian's policy of restoring traditional cults

Literature and Christian communities. Episcopal networks and post-Nicene controversies

External reception / authors. Julian, Against the Galileans.

364–378: Valentinian I and Valens

Judea and Galilee. Persistence of Jewish centres and Christian pilgrimage; regional urban and ecclesiastical changes.

Literature and Christian communities. Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nazianzus, Gregory of Nyssa and Ephrem; episcopal and ascetic networks; pneumatological and post-Nicene controversies.

External reception / authors. Ammianus Marcellinus narrates the fourth century from a non-Christian perspective; Libanius documents rhetoric, education, and relations between pagan and Christian elites. Imperial constitutions provide evidence for measures concerning cults, clergy, and privileges.

379–395: Theodosius I

Judea and Galilee. Consolidated Christian topography in the Holy Land

Literature and Christian communities. 380 Cunctos populos; 381 Constantinople; Cappadocians in reception; Ambrose, Jerome and John Chrysostom; growing institutionalisation of episcopal and monastic networks.

External reception / authors. Symmachus, Libanius, and Ammianus reveal a range of non-Christian positions; late-imperial laws preserved in the Codex Theodosianus document a progressive transformation in the public regulation of cults without implying the immediate disappearance of traditional practices.

General conclusions

The history of early Christianity between the first and fourth centuries cannot be reduced to the linear expansion of a fully formed institution from its origins. Literary, papyrological, epigraphic, archaeological, and iconographic sources show instead a sequence of partial stabilisations: communities negotiating belonging, texts acquiring unequal authority, practices becoming normalised, leaders transforming memory into succession, and symbols making an identity recognisable in ever wider social spaces.

The first result of this investigation is therefore both negative and positive. It is negative because it forces us to abandon teleological explanations that project the institutional forms of the fourth century onto Jerusalem, Paul, or the communities of the second century. It is positive because the absence of a uniform Church at the beginning does not imply an absence of structures: from very early on there were mechanisms of memory, discipline, ritual, and authority whose combination produced verifiable historical effects.

The incorporation of Gentiles offers an early test case for these mechanisms. The Pauline letters show that belonging to the messianic movement of Israel could extend to non-Jews without requiring a complete ethnic conversion. The tension between mission, table fellowship, circumcision, and Law generated different solutions and left a contested memory that Acts later reworked.

During the second century, this diversity did not disappear. Marcion, Justin, Ignatius, the Didache, Hermas, and Irenaeus reveal different ways of constructing legitimacy. Authority could be based on an apostolic calling, a public succession, a rule of truth, a ritual practice, a bishop, a prophet, a collection of texts, or a genealogy of teachers. So-called orthodoxy was not an essence that simply manifested itself, but a historical position that learned to reproduce itself through institutions, archives, and forms of exclusion.

The analysis of the non-canonical gospels reinforces this conclusion. Thomas, the fragmentary Judeo-Christian gospels, the Nag Hammadi texts, the Gospel of Peter, and the infancy narratives do not form a homogeneous "lost canon". They consti-

tute different literary trajectories whose uneven transmission illuminates the process by which some works were copied, read liturgically, and gathered into collections of increasing scope, while others circulated in a more limited way or ceased to be reproduced.

Material culture adds a dimension that doctrinal history alone cannot recover. The codex, the nomina sacra, the staurogram, the graffito of Alexamenos, the catacombs, and Dura-Europos show that Christian identity was written, drawn, buried, and constructed. None of these objects should be interpreted through free symbolism; their value depends on context, dating, medium, and comparison with non-Christian repertoires. In at least one case—the third-century halls of Dura-Europos and Kefar ʻOthnay—the material evidence corrects a generalisation of the literary sources, namely that Christians had no temples or altars; in the others, it complements, qualifies or limits the texts, and must therefore be treated as an autonomous source.

Nor was persecution a continuous backdrop. Between Pliny and the Tetrarchy, there were different policies, varying scales of violence, and multiple local responses. Martyrdom literature transformed this administrative discontinuity into a coherent memory of witness, creating models capable of circulating among communities and generations.

The fourth century finally altered the scale of the process. Galerius, Constantine, Nicaea, architectural patronage, and subsequent legislation did not create a new religion ex nihilo; they provided imperial resources to structures that had been developing for centuries. The result was an unprecedented capacity to convene councils, finance buildings, preserve archives, discipline communities, and transform certain doctrinal definitions into norms backed by imperial power.

The general thesis of this monograph can therefore be formulated in terms of convergence. Early Christianity acquired increasingly stable forms as memory, text, ritual practice, institutional authority, and material representation began to reinforce one another. None of these processes was sufficient on its own, and none progressed at the same pace in all regions. The starting point of the whole process is the continuity of the movement after the execution of Jesus, which is explained by the reinterpretation of his death and by the expectation of his return within a generation; the delay of that return compelled the production of the memory, texts, authority and spaces that this book studies.

This convergence did not occur in a neutral space. It took place at the crossing of diverse fields of influence—the literature and practices of Second Temple Judaism, Greco-Roman rhetorical and associative culture, imperial law and administration

and, on the eastern margins, Syriac and Iranian traditions—and its articulation was, in a precise sense, Pauline. Paul set the problem (Gentile belonging without full ethnic conversion), the medium (letters read in assemblies and copied into collections), the network (urban communities of the shared table) and the vocabulary (ἐκκλησία, Christ, faith, body) that later centuries debated, extended or combated: Marcion built his Apostolikon on Paul; Irenaeus and the formation of the canon reintegrated him against Marcion; P46 and the Pauline codices are the material evidence of that circulation. "Pauline" does not mean that Paul designed the outcome, but that most lines of convergence pass through the question and the texts that he inaugurated. The chapters on prophecy and women, magic, asceticism, the family, apocalyptic, epidemics and architecture are read within this frame as fields of influence or friction in which that convergence was tested, not as thematic appendices.

The integration of the thematic chapters with this thesis can be made explicit. In the chapter on prophecy and women, charismatic authority (the prophetesses of Corinth, Phoebe, Prisca, Junia) appears as a mechanism earlier than episcopal succession, whose later reduction—the disputed transmission of 1 Cor 14:34–35, the Pastoral Epistles, the anti-Montanist polemic—shows that institutional stabilisation had documentable costs. In magic and medicine, the practice of healing, exorcising and blessing was negotiated against external categories of superstition and magic, and Christianity drew boundaries by accusing others of magic and defending itself against the same charge. In asceticism, from Pauline celibacy (1 Cor 7) to the apocryphal Acts and fourth-century monasticism, renunciation worked as a form of distinction and of alternative authority that the institution incorporated only in part. In family and slavery, the household codes (Col 3:18–4:1; Eph 5:21–6:9; 1 Pet 2:18–3:7) and the household as community unit show convergence with Greco-Roman culture rather than radical social novelty. In epidemics, the plagues of the second and mid-third centuries offer a field in which assistance and the interpretation of suffering tested internal cohesion, without a single causality being attributable to them. In apocalyptic and Zoroastrianism, Chapter XVIII compares the cosmic opposition of good and evil, judgement, resurrection, the Saošyant and final renewal (frašō.kərəti), and concludes that the symmetries are real but too general, and the sources too uneven, to prove dependence; if early Christianity received them, it did so through Second Temple Judaism, where Iranian influence is plausible but disputed. Within the frame of this book, Zoroastrianism is a distant and mediated field of influence, not a cause: its value is one of contrast, for it shows how much of the vocabulary of the end—kingdom, judgement, resurrection—was available before the Jesus community used it, and it reinforces the Pauline reading of convergence rather than replacing it.

The question the book raises in comparing the Jesus movement with other movements of its time—why the execution of Jesus did not dissolve the group—can now be given an articulated answer. The first reason is one of content: the followers of Jesus interpreted his death in the light of Scripture and of experiences they took to be appearances of the risen one (1 Cor 15:3–8; Gal 1:15–16), so that the execution ceased to be the refutation of the proclamation of the kingdom and became its decisive moment. The second is one of horizon: the earliest community lived in expectation of the imminent return of Jesus as Messiah or Son of Man. This is shown by the Aramaic preserved in 1 Cor 16:22 (μαραναθά), the consolation of the Thessalonians about "we who are alive" (1 Thess 4:13–18), Paul's counsel about the time that has grown short (1 Cor 7:29–31) and the synoptic sayings about the generation that will not pass away (Mark 9:1; 13:30), whose authenticity is disputed but whose early circulation is not. In that horizon the movement did not need to foresee its own duration in order to persevere: mission was an eschatological duty before the end (Rom 11:25–26; Mark 13:10), and the nearness of the outcome justified rupture with the surrounding world, internal solidarity and the risk of martyrdom. Third, the delay of the parousia, far from dissolving the group, compelled it to produce what this book studies: written memory (the Gospels also respond to the delay; cf. Luke 19:11; John 21:22–23; 2 Pet 3:3–9), succession, discipline, liturgy and a theology of the interim. The Christian movement continued after Jesus because it expected his return, and that expectation, as it lengthened, crystallised the movement into an apocalyptic religion that became institutional by reinterpreting the end rather than abandoning it. Two cautions are in order. The expectation of the parousia explains the group's continuity, not its relative success against other messianic or apocalyptic movements that did dissolve; for that, the inclusion of Gentiles, the Pauline network and the ritual practices treated in the earlier chapters count. And faith in the resurrection and hope for the return are facts that history can record as documented beliefs, not as truths that it is for history to adjudicate.

The expectation of an imminent return of Jesus has explicit and graded support in the sources. In 1 Thess 4:15–17 (c. 50), the oldest surviving Christian document, Paul consoles a community whose members have begun to die and includes himself, with "we who are alive, who remain until the coming of the Lord", among those who will see the event; 1 Cor 15:51 repeats that "we shall not all sleep", and 1 Cor 7:29–31 modifies marital and social practices because "the time has grown short". The Aramaic acclamation μαράνα θά (or μαραναθά) of 1 Cor 16:22, "Our Lord, come!", preserved untranslated in a Greek letter to a Greek community, attests that the invocation came from the oldest Aramaic-speaking communities. The Synoptics set the limit at one

generation: "this generation will not pass away until all these things take place" (Mark 13:30; Matt 24:34; Luke 21:32) and "some standing here will not taste death before they see the kingdom of God come with power" (Mark 9:1); the authenticity of these sayings is disputed, but their circulation and their inclusion in Mark around 70 are not. James 5:8–9, of disputed date, affirms that "the coming of the Lord is near".

In the second century the motif persists, but now with awareness of the delay. Didache 16.1 orders watchfulness because "you do not know the hour"; 1 Clem. 23.5 answers those who doubt with the promise that the Lord "will come quickly and suddenly"; Barnabas 21.3 declares that "the day is near" and, according to Barnabas 15, places the present on the threshold of the last millennium of a cosmic week; and 2 Pet 3:3–9, of disputed date (c. 110–140), answers the "scoffers" who ask "where is the promise of his coming?" by reconfiguring the measure of divine time: "with the Lord one day is like a thousand years". The passage from imminent to prolonged expectation is thus one of the processes this book can document.

For the thesis this has a precise consequence. The Jesus movement did not dissolve with his execution because his followers believed that Jesus would return within a generation, and acted accordingly: they pursued the mission as a task before the end, maintained communal solidarity, accepted the risk of martyrdom and reinterpreted the cross, which ceased to be a public failure and became the prelude to judgement. It is plausible that the sharing of goods described in Acts 2:44–45 and 4:32–35 was also understood within that horizon, although Acts does not say so and both the historicity and the meaning of those summaries are disputed. When the generation passed and the return did not occur, the movement did not die out: it integrated the delay into its theology (2 Pet 3; Luke 19:11; John 21:22–23) and was compelled to produce written memory, succession, discipline, liturgy and spaces of assembly and memory, that is, the mechanisms studied in the earlier chapters. Apocalyptic expectation is therefore a principal factor in the initial continuity and the origin of the pressure that turned a waiting into an institution; by itself it does not explain, as noted, the later success against other movements.

The thesis is falsifiable. It would be weakened if the evidence showed, for the first and second centuries, a uniform and already complete form in every region—a closed list of books, a general monarchical episcopate, a common liturgy—as the linear-development model under criticism supposed; if the stabilisation of a single field (the canon or the episcopate, say) had preceded and by itself explained the others, so that one factor sufficed; if the rhythm were uniform across regions instead of uneven; or if material culture—codices, nomina sacra, inscriptions, buildings—proved independent of the texts and of the authority attributed to it. It would also

be weakened in the opposite direction if early plurality turned out to be an artefact of late sources. These conditions are not rhetorical: the dating of the Pauline papyri, the regional distribution of the nomina sacra, the dates of Dura-Europos and Kefar ʿOthnay, or the earliest testimony to an episcopal triad can move the picture, and the book treats them as data open to revision. "Convergence" here designates a hypothesis of co-occurrence and mutual reinforcement among series that can be measured separately, not an explanatory wild card.

Where the book explains a mechanism by its function, it must be read with a distinction. The causal explanations are local and rest on data from the period: Irenaeus organises his rule of truth and his succession list against Marcion and the Valentinians; the list of Roman bishops is drawn up in a controversy and not as a programme of unity; the cult of the martyrs answers persecution. Those decisions had a unifying effect their authors did not seek, and fourth-century unity is an unintended result of accumulated choices—some retained, others abandoned—not their final cause. The model is one of variation and retention, not of purpose. Where the book links reasons with "because", it signals co-occurrence, and only where the source itself declares it, as in Irenaeus against Marcion, does it assert causality.

The development of places of worship confirms this pattern. In the first century Christians met in private houses and rented spaces (Rom 16:5; 1 Cor 16:19; Phlm 2; Acts 19:9), and no specific building is known. In the second and third centuries there appear, alongside adapted houses (Dura-Europos), assembly halls with features of their own, such as that of Kefar ʿOthnay, and places of funerary memory—the Vatican necropolis, the Via Ostiensis, San Sebastiano on the Via Appia—that are not churches. Only from the fourth century, with imperial patronage, do basilicas become general. None of these forms derives from the synagogue by conversion: they coexist with it and imitate or reject it as the case may be. The book consults almost all this evidence through publications, editions and facsimiles, not by autopsy; the "autonomy" of the material series is therefore methodological, a matter of criterion and not of access, and its results remain open to correction by those who have studied the objects directly.

This perspective makes it possible to explain both early plurality and the subsequent capacity for unification without turning one into an anomaly and the other into an inevitable destiny. Early Christian history thus emerges as a history of selection, transmission, conflict, and materialisation: a succession of documentable human decisions that, accumulated over four centuries, transformed a Jewish movement of the eastern Mediterranean into a religious institution of imperial scope, al-

though that institution never wholly absorbed the regional, linguistic, and doctrinal diversity that had preceded it and continued to accompany it.

Summary

This monograph reconstructs the formation of early Christianity as a historically plural process of stabilisation encompassing memory, texts, ritual practices, institutional authority, and material representation. From the Jesus movement of the first century to the imperial Church of the fourth century, the evidence does not support a linear development from a fully constituted original institution. Successive communities created mechanisms of legitimacy, transmission, discipline, and boundary demarcation whose convergence gradually produced more stable forms of collective identity. The study combines literary criticism, textual criticism, papyrology, epigraphy, archaeology, and iconography, and applies the same evidentiary criteria to canonical, non-canonical, Christian, Jewish, Roman, and anti-Christian sources.

Keywords: early Christianity; historiography; canon; material culture; authority; Roman Empire.

Prosopographical appendix and social network analysis (SNA)

This appendix transforms scattered names and relationships into reference tools. Prosopography is organised by source, attributed function, and degree of certainty. The scale used is: A = person and function directly documented by a chronologically proximate source; B = securely attested person whose function is partly reconstructed; C = identification or function disputed; D = late tradition or uncertain affiliation. The categories do not express historical importance, but rather documentary quality.

1. Leaders, missionaries and mediators (first–third centuries)

Table 95. Prosopography of leaders and mediators

Name	Location	Sources	Function
Paul	Eastern Mediterranean	Undisputed letters; Acts as a narrative point of comparison	Apostle to the Gentiles; founder/ mediator of communities
Peter/Cephas	Jerusalem/Antioch/ Rome?	Gal 1–2; 1 Cor 1; 1 Clem 5; later tradition	Apostle; figure of authority and memory
James, brother of Jesus	Jerusalem	Gal 1–2; Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1); Acts	Leader of the Jerusalem community
Barnabas	Antioch/Jerusalem	Gal 2; 1 Cor 9; Acts	Missionary and mediator
Timothy	Macedonia/Asia	1 Thess; 1–2 Cor; Phil; Rom	Collaborator and envoy
Titus	Galatia/Corinth	Gal; 2 Cor	Collaborator and delegate

(continued)

Name	Location	Sources	Function
Ignatius of Antioch	Antioch/Asia Minor	Ignatian letters	Bishop and letter writer in transit
Polycarp	Smyrna	Letter to the Philippians; Martyrdom of Polycarp; Irenaeus	Bishop and mediator of apostolic memory
Justin	Rome	Apologies; Dialogue	Teacher/apologist
Irenaeus	Lyons	Adv. haer.; Eus. HE V	Bishop, heresiologist and mediator
Tertullian	Carthage	Own work	Author, polemicist, and rhetorical jurist
Cyprian	Carthage	Epistulae; De lapsis; Acta proconsularia	Bishop and epistolary node
Cornelius	Rome	Cyprian; Eus. HE VI.43	Bishop of Rome
Novatian	Rome	De Trinitate; Cyprian; Eus.	Presbyter, episcopal rival, author
Origen	Alexandria/Caesarea	His own works; Eus. HE VI	Exegete, teacher, philologist
Dionysius of Alexandria	Alexandria	Fragments in Eusebius	Bishop and correspondent

TABLE 96. Continuation of "Prosopography of leaders and mediators"

Name	Certainty	Critical note
Paul	A	Separate epistolary autobiography from Lucan biography.
Peter/Cephas	A/B	His presence in Rome and his martyrdom rest on early tradition, though later than the letters.
James, brother of Jesus	A	Do not automatically equate with the later monarchical episcopate.

(continued)

Name	Certainty	Critical note
Barnabas	A	The Barnabas of Acts must be assessed against Paul's testimony.
Timothy	A	Pastorals represent later reception.
Titus	A	The Titus attested in the undisputed letters must be distinguished from the Titus of the Pastoral Epistle attributed to Paul.
Ignatius of Antioch	A/B	Chronology and middle recension must be made explicit.
Polycarp	A/B	The Martyrdom and Irenaeus' recollections belong to distinct strata.
Justin	A	Do not turn his school into a formal church institution without evidence.
Irenaeus	A	His Roman list is a polemical argument, not a contemporary administrative record.
Tertullian	A	Do not identify him as a clergyman with certainty.
Cyprian	A	Exceptional archive, but biased by Carthaginian preservation.
Cornelius	A/B	The figures for clergy and those assisted come from a letter transmitted by Eusebius.
Novatian	A/B	Do not reduce him to a schismatic without reading his own corpus.
Origen	A	The institutional nature of the Alexandrian "school" is debated.
Dionysius of Alexandria	A/B	Preservation mediated by Eusebius.

2. *Women with documented roles*

TABLE 97. Selective female prosopography

Name	Place	Source	Documented role
Phoebe	Cenchreae/Rome	Rom 16:1–2	διάκονος; προστάτις; recommended by Paul
Prisca	Corinth/Ephesus/Rome	Rom 16:3–5; 1 Cor 16:19; Acts	συνεργός; host of an ekklēsia
Junia	Rome	Rom 16:7	Fellow prisoner; ἐπίσημος among/in relation to apostles
Mary	Rome	Rom 16:6	She worked hard for the community
Tryphaena	Rome	Rom 16:12	Labouring in the Lord
Tryphosa	Rome	Rom 16:12	Labouring in the Lord
Persis	Rome	Rom 16:12	"She worked hard in the Lord"
Euodia	Philippi	Phil 4:2–3	*συνήθλησαν* with Paul
Syntyche	Philippi	Phil 4:2–3	*συνήθλησαν* with Paul
Chloe	Corinth/Ephesus?	1 Cor 1:11	Domestic/informational node
Apphia	Colossae?	Phlm 2	Member of house church
Nympha	Laodicea	Col 4:15	House church hostess
Thecla	Asia Minor	Acta Pauli et Theclae	Ascetic heroine and missionary figure of Pauline reception
Perpetua	Carthage	Passio Perpetuae	Martyr; disputed autobiographical voice
Felicity	Carthage	Passio Perpetuae	Enslaved martyr
Priscilla (Montanist)	Phrygia	Eus. HE V.16–18; Epiphanius	Prophetess of the New Prophecy
Maximilla	Phrygia	Eus. HE V.16–18; Epiphanius	Prophetess of the New Prophecy

TABLE 98. Continuation of "Selective female prosopography"

Name	Certainty	Critical note
Phoebe	A	Plausible patronage/representation; do not impose a later office.

(continued)

Name	Certainty	Critical note
Prisca	A	High translocal mobility.
Junia	A/B	Widely accepted feminine name; syntax of ἐπίσημοι debated.
Mary	A	Additional identity unknown.
Tryphaena	A	Precise function not specified.
Tryphosa	A	Precise function not specified.
Persis	A	Language of community work.
Euodia	A	Collaborator in local conflict.
Syntyche	A	Collaborator in local conflict.
Chloe	A/B	"Chloe's people" does not prove her exact location.
Apphia	A	Do not attribute a position that is not stated.
Nympha	B	Depends on a letter of disputed authorship and on a manuscript variant affecting the name's gender.
Thecla	C	Second-century source; not contemporary with Paul.
Perpetua	A/B	Distinguish the diary, redaction and reception.
Felicity	A/B	Key case for the intersection of gender and status.
Priscilla (Montanist)	B	Later, adversarial source.
Maximilla	B	Later, adversarial source.

(continued)

Actors	Region	Sources	Conflict

3. Actors in authority and boundary conflicts

TABLE 99. Conflicts of authority

Actors	Region	Sources	Conflict
Paul / Cephas / "those of James"	Antioch	Gal 2:11–14	Commensality and Gentiles
Marcion / Roman leaders	Rome	Justin; Irenaeus; Tertullian; Epiphanius	Scripture, God the Creator, discipline
Victor / churches of Asia	Rome–Asia	Eus. HE V.23–25	Date of Easter and ecclesial communion
Hippolytus / Callistus	Rome	Refutatio IX	Penance, Christology, discipline
Cornelius / Novatian	Rome	Cyprian; Eus. HE VI.43	Episcopal election and lapsi
Cyprian / Stephen	Carthage–Rome	Cyprian Ep. 69–75	Rebaptism and authority between sees
Dionysius / Nepos	Egypt	Eus. HE VII.24–25	Millenarianism and exegesis of Revelation
Arius / Alexander / Athanasius	Alexandria	Synodal and conciliar documents; Athanasius; Eusebius	Christology and conciliar authority
Donatists / Catholics	Africa	Optatus; Augustine; CTh; records	Traditio, sacraments and episcopal legitimacy

TABLE 100. Continuation of "Conflicts of authority"

Actors	Certainty	Assessment
Paul / Cephas / "those of James"	A	Do not automatically harmonise with Acts 15.
Marcion / Roman leaders	B	Reconstruction depends on adversaries.

(continued)

Actors	Certainty	Assessment
Victor / churches of Asia	B	Roman intervention resisted by Irenaeus and others.
Hippolytus / Callistus	B/C	Strongly adversarial source; authorship of the Hippolytan corpus debated.
Cornelius / Novatian	A/B	Archive biased towards institutional winners.
Cyprian / Stephen	A	It demonstrates collegiality and conflict, not univocal jurisdiction.
Dionysius / Nepos	B	Preservation mediated by Eusebius.
Arius / Alexander / Athanasius	A/B	"Arianism" encompasses diverse positions.
Donatists / Catholics	A/B	Avoid narrating only from the perspective of Catholic adversaries.

4. Prophets, thaumaturges, and messianic pretenders

TABLE 101. Comparison of charismatic and prophetic figures

Figure	Context	Sources	Profile
Honi	Judea, first century BCE	Josephus; Mishnah/ Talmud	Effective prayer and rain
Hanina ben Dosa	Galilee, first century	Rabbinic tradition	Healings and prayer
Judas the Galilean	Galilee/Judea, 6 CE	Josephus	Resistance to the census
Theudas	Judea, c. 44–46	Josephus; Acts	Prophet promising a sign at the Jordan
The Egyptian	Judea, c. 50s	Josephus; Acts	Prophet promising a sign at the Mount of Olives
Jesus ben Ananias	Jerusalem, 62–70	Josephus BJ VI.5.3	Prophet of doom
Simon ben Kosiba / Bar Kokhba	Judea, 132–135	Judean Desert letters; Cassius Dio; rabbinic tradition	Leader of revolt; subsequent messianic interpretation

(continued)

Figure	Context	Sources	Profile
Simon of Samaria	Samaria	Acts 8; Justin; Irenaeus	Magician/charismatic figure
Dositheus	Samaria	Origen; heresiologists; Samaritan tradition	Remembered prophet/restorer
Apollonius of Tyana	Roman East	Philostratus; Hierocles/Eusebius	Philosopher and thaumaturge
Alexander of Abonoteichus	Paphlagonia, second century	Lucian; numismatics	Founder/oracle of Glycon

TABLE 102. Continuation of "Comparison of charismatic and prophetic figures"

Figure	Certainty	Caution
Honi	B	Later rabbinic traditions.
Hanina ben Dosa	B/C	Material redacted later.
Judas the Galilean	A/B	Do not call him the founder of "zealotism" without nuance.
Theudas	A/B	Chronological problem with Acts 5.
The Egyptian	A/B	Numbers of followers vary between sources.
Jesus ben Ananias	A/B	Known from a single narrative source.
Simon ben Kosiba / Bar Kokhba	A/B	Distinguish contemporary documents from rabbinic memory.
Simon of Samaria	B	Later heresiological genealogy.
Dositheus	C	Chronology and relationship with Simon uncertain.
Apollonius of Tyana	B	The Philostratean biography dates from the third century.
Alexander of Abonoteichus	A/B	External satire corroborated by material evidence.

5. Social Network Analysis (SNA): protocol and pilot networks

The SNA is applied as a descriptive tool for preserved relationships. E1 = explicit contemporary or near-contemporary relationship; E2 = declared contextual inference; E3 = subsequent tradition or retrospective association. The metrics for these pilot networks are calculated on simple, undirected, and unweighted graphs, using only E1. CSVs retain the direction of the documented exchanges; E2 is drawn in a distinct style, and E3 is excluded. The number of edges does not measure historical significance, population, or jurisdiction. A second run (E1+E2) is not presented as a calculated result.

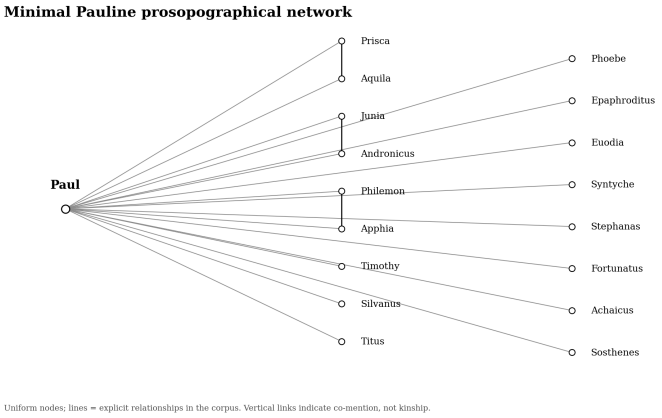


Figure 28 (SNA-1). Minimal Pauline prosopographical network. Analytical visualisation of 18 people and 20 explicit relationships in the corpus; all nodes have equal graphic hierarchy and Paul is not enlarged as a dominant centre. [ED; SNA].

Inclusion threshold and reproducibility

An E1 edge enters the network only if it can be traced back to an identifiable primary locus; E2 requires an explicit and justifiable inference that the reader can accept or reject; purely plausible relationships are not drawn. Each graph must maintain a table of edges with source, direction, and classification. Number of nodes, number of edges, density, degree centrality, betweenness, and components are reported; no metric is interpreted on its own as legal primacy, doctrinal authority, or demographic size.

SNA reproducibility. The edition is accompanied by edge CSVs with origin, destination, direction, locus, class, and relationship type, and a calculation script. Degree centrality is $k/(n-1)$; normalised betweenness follows Brandes's algorithm for simple undirected and unweighted graphs. SNA-1: 18 nodes, 20 edges, density

0.131, and one component. SNA-2: 5 nodes in E1, 4 edges, density 0.400, and one component. Arles belongs to E2 and is excluded from the exchange metrics. The uneven preservation of the texts limits the historical interpretation of the results.

5.1. Controlled extension to second-century networks

The same protocol can be extended into the second century, but not by simply adding names to a single undifferentiated graph. The Ignatian corpus can model senders, recipients, messengers, and communities linked by explicit relationships; Polycarp introduces connections among Smyrna, Philippi, and traditions of martyr memory; Justin requires a different model because the surviving evidence concerns trajectories of teaching, polemical encounters, and Roman location rather than a comparable epistolary network. A combined graph would be legitimate only if edge type, evidentiary status, and chronology remained explicit.

For that reason, the present analysis retains the published metrics for the two pilot networks and frames wider expansion as a reproducible protocol rather than as a fictitious numerical result. Any future corpus should publish its node list, edge table, locus, direction, E1/E2/E3 classification, and aggregation rules before density, centrality, or betweenness is calculated. The methodological priority is reproducibility: a reader should be able to reconstruct the graph directly from the cited evidence.

Table 103. Metrics of the minimal Pauline network

Node	Degree centrality	Betweenness centrality
Paul	1.000	0.978
Prisca	0.118	0.000
Aquila	0.118	0.000
Junia	0.118	0.000
Andronicus	0.118	0.000
Philemon	0.118	0.000
Apphia	0.118	0.000
Timothy	0.059	0.000
Silvanus	0.059	0.000
Titus	0.059	0.000
Phoebe	0.059	0.000
Epaphroditus	0.059	0.000
Euodia	0.059	0.000
Syntyche	0.059	0.000
Stephanas	0.059	0.000
Fortunatus	0.059	0.000
Achaicus	0.059	0.000
Sosthenes	0.059	0.000

Reading. Paul necessarily occupies a central position in a network constructed from his own correspondence. The more informative pattern therefore lies in secondary intermediaries and mobility, even though their betweenness in this graph is zero: Prisca and Aquila connect household, work, and several cities; Phoebe links Cenchreae with the Roman reception of the letter; Timothy and Titus function as envoys. Mathematical centrality must not be converted into ecclesiastical hierarchy. Centralities are rounded to three decimal places: for a node of degree 1 in a network of 18 nodes, 1/(18 − 1) = 0.0588…, which is correctly reported as 0.059 by rounding, not as 0.058 by truncation.

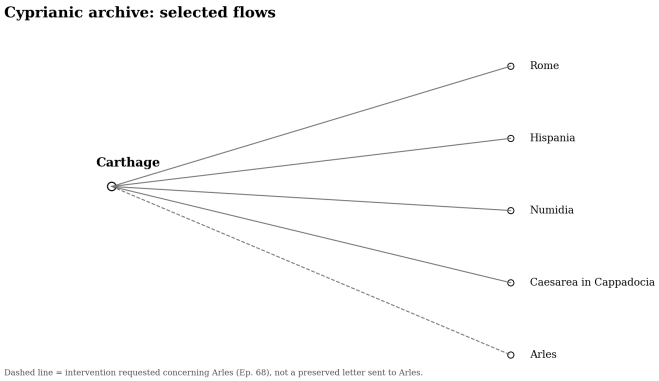


FIGURE 29 (SNA-2). Selected flows from the Cyprianic archive, reproduced in the prosopographical appendix. It repeats Figure 24 with the same graphic and documentary criteria. [ED; SNA].

TABLE 104. Metrics of the minimal Cyprianic network

Node	Degree centrality	Betweenness centrality
Carthage	1.000	1.000
Rome	0.250	0.000
Recipients of Ep. 62 (Numidia; regional aggregation)	0.250	0.000
Hispania	0.250	0.000
Caesarea of Cappadocia	0.250	0.000

Reading. Carthage concentrates betweenness because the selected collection is organised around Cyprian. In this simple graph all peripheral E1 nodes have the same degree centrality; Rome's documentary importance is examined in the letters

and is not deduced from a nonexistent mathematical second position. Hispania, the African recipients aggregated under Numidia, and Firmilian of Caesarea show supra-regional consultations and coalitions. Ep. 68 is addressed to Stephen in Rome and requests his intervention regarding Marcian of Arles. The "Numidia" row represents a regional aggregation of recipients from Ep. 62 and is excluded from any substantive comparison of centrality between sees or persons; its mathematical value only describes this simplified graph.

Bilingual appendix of fundamental loci

The following passages provide brief selections in the original language alongside the author's own English translations as a control. They do not replace the critical editions cited in the bibliography. Only textual units necessary for the argument are reproduced, and transmission problems are noted where relevant.

B1. Romans 16:1–2—Phoebe

Original text: Συνίστημι δὲ ὑμῖν Φοίβην τὴν ἀδελφὴν ἡμῶν, οὖσαν [καὶ] διάκονον τῆς ἐκκλησίας τῆς ἐν Κεγχρεαῖς… καὶ γὰρ αὐτὴ προστάτις πολλῶν ἐγενήθη καὶ ἐμοῦ αὐτοῦ.

Translation: I commend to you Phoebe, our sister, who is also a deacon/servant of the church in Cenchreae… for she herself was a protector or patron of many, and also of me.

Critical note: διάκονος and προστάτις must be analysed historically before being translated by later ecclesiastical offices.

B2. Romans 16:7—Junia

Original text: ἀσπάσασθε Ἀνδρόνικον καὶ Ἰουνίαν… οἵτινές εἰσιν ἐπίσημοι ἐν τοῖς ἀποστόλοις.

Translation: Greet Andronicus and Junia… who are distinguished among/in relation to the apostles.

Critical note: The editorial accentuation Ἰουνίαν corresponds to the widely accepted feminine reading of the name Junia. Ancient manuscripts without accents do not resolve this issue on their own. The syntactic interpretation of ἐπίσημοι ἐν τοῖς ἀποστόλοις and its scope with respect to the term "apostles" require separate discussion.

B3. 1 Corinthians 11:5—women who pray and prophesy

Original text: πᾶσα δὲ γυνὴ προσευχομένη ἢ προφητεύουσα…

Translation: Every woman who prays or prophesies…

Critical note: The passage presupposes the practice; the discussion concerns its bodily and honorific regulation.

B4. Galatians 3:28—belonging and social difference

Original text: οὐκ ἔνι Ἰουδαῖος οὐδὲ Ἕλλην… οὐκ ἔνι ἄρσεν καὶ θῆλυ· πάντες γὰρ ὑμεῖς εἷς ἐστε ἐν Χριστῷ Ἰησοῦ.

Translation: There is neither Jew nor Greek… there is neither male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus.

Critical note: The formula redefines baptismal belonging; it does not in itself demonstrate the immediate abolition of social hierarchies.

B5. 1 Clement 42.4–5—appointment and oversight

Original text: κατὰ χώρας οὖν καὶ πόλεις κηρύσσοντες καθίστανον τὰς ἀπαρχὰς αὐτῶν… εἰς ἐπισκόπους καὶ διακόνους.

Translation: Preaching, then, through regions and cities, they appointed their firstfruits… as overseers and servants.

Critical note: Key text for the Roman memory of ministries; it should not be automatically projected as a monarchical episcopate of the second century.

B6. Ignatius, Smyrnaeans 8.1—bishop and meeting

Original text: πάντες τῷ ἐπισκόπῳ ἀκολουθεῖτε, ὡς Ἰησοῦς Χριστὸς τῷ πατρί…

Translation: Follow the bishop, all of you, as Jesus Christ followed the Father…

Critical note: Strong testimony of an Ignatian episcopal model; its regional scope should not be universalised.

B7. Pliny, Epistulae X.96.7—Christian practice

Original text: carmenque Christo quasi deo dicere secum invicem… seque sacramento non in scelus aliquod obstringere. Morphosyntactic note: dicere, like convenire, is a complementary infinitive of essent soliti, within the quod-clause that spells out what affirmabant reports; secum invicem expresses the reciprocity of the action described.

Translation: And sing among themselves, alternately, a hymn to Christ as to a god… and bind themselves by oath, not to commit any crime.

Critical note: External administrative source; sacramentum here belongs to the Latin language of oath/commitment.

B8. Tertullian, Apologeticum 39.5—common fund

Original text: Modicam unusquisque stipem menstrua die, vel cum velit, et si modo velit, et si modo possit, apponit; nam nemo compellitur, sed sponte confert.

Translation: Each person contributes a small amount on a day of the month, or whenever they want, and only if they want to and can; no one is compelled; each contributes voluntarily.

Critical note: Apologetic testimony about a community fund; it is not evidence of an audited budget.

B9. Cyprian, De mortalitate 14—epidemic crisis

Original text: quod in faucium uulnera conceptus medullitus ignis exaestuat, quod adsiduo uomitu intestina quatiuntur, quod oculi ui sanguinis inardescunt.

Translation: that a fire kindled deep within burns in the sores of the throat, that the intestines are shaken by continuous vomiting, that the eyes are inflamed by the force of the blood.

Critical note: Three clauses from De mortalitate 14 are reproduced according to the text of Hartel, CSEL 3.1 (1868); the spelling of that edition is retained. The passage describes an epidemic experience through pastoral and rhetorical discourse. It does not allow for the reliable identification of an aetiological agent. The text was consulted in a digital edition [ED], without fresh autopsy of the manuscript or a comprehensive collation of the critical apparatus.

B10. Codex Theodosianus XVI.1.2—Cunctos populos

Original text: Cunctos populos, quos clementiae nostrae regit temperamentum, in tali volumus religione versari...

Translation: It is our will that all the peoples ruled by the moderation of our clemency should practise that religion...

Critical note: Legal document from 380; its scope must be read within the process of late Roman coercion and administration.

Documentary and philological appendix

Reading criteria

The following records connect the book's claims to precise primary loci and an identified edition. The historical problem, relevant reading, and scope of the inference are provided. The original words are selective lemmas, not texts established by a new collation. Critical editions are listed in the general bibliography; when the verification performed corresponds to an old or digital reproduction, this is expressly indicated. The complete variant apparatus for each edition should be consulted before defending a decision that depends on a specific witness.

Josephus and the external testimonies

Josephus, Ant. XVIII.63–64 (18.3.3) and Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1)

The *Testimonium Flavianum* is studied in its received form, without imposing a hypothetical restitution as a proven original. The confessional phrase concerning the messianic identity of Jesus is part of the transmission problem; excluding it does not automatically reconstruct the rest of the account. Josephus, Ant. XX.200 (20.9.1) contains a different reference to James, identified by his connection with Jesus. The two accounts should not be given the same textual judgement simply because they belong to the same author. Reference edition: Niese, Flavii *Iosephi opera*. For the history of the Testimonium and its reworkings, see the commentary on Chapter I. An uncollated variant is not attributed here to a medieval manuscript.

Tacitus, Annals XV.44

The lemma *per procuratorem Pontium Pilatum* corresponds to the terminology of the historian, who is writing after Pilate's tenure. The epigraphic evidence from Caesarea uses *praefectus*. The difference can be explained historically without correcting Tacitus's Latin with conjecture. The account of Nero documents the Roman representation of Christians and their punishment, but its rhetoric does not constitute a statistical account of victims. Reference edition: Fisher, Cornelii *Taciti Annalium ab excessu divi Augusti libri*.

Pliny, Letters X.96.7–9 and X.97.1–2

Pliny's report mentions meetings, singing to Christ, and moral obligations; the *sacramentum* described in X.96.7 should not be translated in a way that presupposes the later sacramental meaning. Trajan's reply contains *conquirendi non sunt*: "they should not be sought." This rule refers to the procedure outlined by the governor and is consistent with the punishment of those who persist after being denounced. It expresses neither complete tolerance nor universal persecution. Reference edition: Mynors, C. *Plini Caecili Secundi Epistularum libri decem*.

Conflict, memory and community organisation

Galatians 2:1–10 and 2:11–14

The meeting and conflict at Antioch belong to a first-person epistolary argument. The opposition between Peter and Paul does not justify constructing two static parties throughout the first century. The reference to the poor in Galatians 2:10 and the accusation of inconsistent conduct in 2:13 belong to the argument about membership and table fellowship. The equivalence with Acts 15 is treated as a hypothesis of synchronisation, not as documentary identity. Reference edition for the text: NA28; specific readings require consultation of its apparatus.

Acts 15:1–29

James's speech and the letter narrated by Luke present a communal solution within a later historiographical framework. The distribution of prohibitions and their textual forms requires distinguishing between the text used and the variants of the tradition. This monograph does not reconstruct an original form of the decree through an eclectic selection of translations. Chapter I compares the social problem

in Acts with that in Galatians, highlighting their differences in genre, sequence, and purpose. Reference edition: NA28.

1 Clement 5.1–7; 42.1–5; 44.1–6

Chapter 5 presents Peter and Paul as examples within an exhortation. The expression 'the limit of the West' does not, in itself, establish a journey to Hispania. Chapters 42 and 44 articulate apostolic dispatch, designation of those responsible, and continuity of functions; the terminology should not be transferred without examination to the later monarchical episcopate. The sender is presented as the church residing in Rome, not as an individual letter signed by Clement. Reference editions: Jaubert, SC 167; Holmes, The *Apostolic Fathers*. The older ANF translation is used only as a secondary content check; no new collation from the Greek is claimed.

Didache 7.1–4; 9.1–5; 10.1–7; 15.1–2

Chapter 7 outlines alternatives for water and baptismal procedure according to available conditions; its case-based provisions indicate adaptation, not a complete lack of rules. Chapters 9–10 preserve prayers and an order of the cup and bread that must be explained within their own context. Did. 15 links locally appointed leaders with functions attributed to prophets and teachers. The coexistence of these figures supports a cautious description of a reorganisation of authority without inventing an identical institutional stage for all communities. Reference edition: Rordorf and Tuilier, SC 248, revised edition of 1998; Holmes. The ANF reproduction is used only as a secondary content check.

Ignatius, Smyrnaeans 8.1–2 and Philadelphians 4

The exhortations link bishop, assembly, and Eucharist. Smyrnaeans 8.2 contains the use of ἡ καθολικὴ ἐκκλησία, "the universal church": the adjective is explained in that context and not as a modern, already defined institution. Attribution and recension matter: the middle recension of the seven letters is used as a reference, without automatically including material from the longer recension. The intensity of an exhortation may reveal an ideal that needs to be imposed, rather than a practice accepted without conflict. Reference edition: Holmes; commentary: Schoedel. The ANF translations are used only as a secondary content check.

Writing, reading and delimitation of texts

Justin, First Apology 26 and 58

The passages identify Marcion as *a* known Christian adversary in the second century. They are testimonies predating Tertullian and Epiphanius, but do not provide an edition of the Marcionite Gospel or the *Antitheses*. The charge of wide dissemination belongs to the apologetic argument and should *be* distinguished from an inventory of communities. Critical editions identified: Munier, SC 507; Minns and Parvis, *Justin, Philosopher and Martyr: Apologies*. The book's commentary verifies the loci and chronology, without attributing a new manuscript reading.

Justin, First Apology 65–67

The reading of the "memoirs of the apostles" and the prophets appears within the description of the gathering. The testimony documents a literary and ritual practice in the author's environment; it does not demonstrate that all communities used an identical collection or that the term implies a single codex. In chapter 67, the so-called day of the Sun is mentioned, a relevant detail for distinguishing Sunday worship from the legislation of 321. Reference editions: Munier; Minns and Parvis. The ANF translation is used only as a secondary content check.

Irenaeus, Against Heresies III.3.1–4

Roman succession is used as an argument against teachings considered secret or divergent. In III.3.2, the Latin expression *potentiorem principalitatem* raises a problem of interpretation and transmission from the Greek original: translating it automatically as a universal legal competence can introduce later categories. The enumeration in III.3.3 includes Eleutherius and serves to study the construction of a public memory. It does not, in itself, establish the exact dates of all the leaders. Critical edition of reference: Rousseau and Doutreleau, SC 210–211. The ANF translation is used only as a secondary content check; a complete lexical discussion requires consultation of the text and apparatus of SC.

Irenaeus, Against Heresies III.11.8

The defence of the fourfold gospel uses a symbolic argument about four regions and four winds. The monograph studies this symbolism as documented ancient reasoning; it does not adopt it as historical or mathematical proof. The passage

demonstrates that Irenaeus defended the delimitation of four gospels, but not that all second-century communities already possessed the same complete New Testament canon. Reference edition: SC 210–211. This locus relates to Chapter II and to the distinction between collection, normative reading, and closed canon.

Tertullian, Against Marcion IV.7 and IV.19

The reports concerning the beginning of the Gospel and Lucan episodes are testimonies from an adversary. When Tertullian discusses a reading, it is necessary to separate the text he quotes, the explanation he attributes to Marcion, and his own rebuttal. The matrix in Chapter II does not replace this operation: it classifies loci and degrees of certainty. Reference editions: Kroymann, CCSL 1; Braun, SC 365, 368, 399, 456, and 483; Evans, bilingual edition. Specialist reconstruction: Roth 2015. A complete Greek form is not attributed to the lost Gospel where the testimony is only indirect.

Athanasius, Festal Letter 39.5–7

The letter of 367 lists the twenty-seven writings that comprise the later New Testament and distinguishes this set from other books useful for reading. It is a localised document of episcopal authority, not an act of a universal council that produced the canon in that year. Lists, pastoral use, and regional reception should be distinguished. For the presentation of lists and their texts, see Gallagher and Meade, *The Biblical Canon Lists from Early Christianity. A* supposedly collated pagination from a different edition is not printed.

Objects and signs

Gallio: FD III.4, no. 286; SIG³ 801 D

The photograph records the epigraphic form ΓΑΛΛΙΩΝ; the rest of the chronological argument depends on the edited document and Claudius's title. The coincidence with Acts 18:12–17 connects an administrative figure with the narrative, without turning the imperial letter into a testimony that names Paul. The entry for Chapter I preserves the photographed fragment, the editorial restitutions, and the contextual translation separately. Verification: Plassart's epigraphic edition and Hanson's presentation.

Theodotus: CIJ II 1404

The inscription links the synagogue to the reading of the Law and the teaching of the commandments. The hospitality facilities demonstrate a social function that a strictly cultic definition might obscure. The selective transcription includes editorial brackets and normalised spelling; it is not presented as a line-by-line reproduction of the stone. The document provides a check on reconstructions of the variety of Jewish spaces prior to 70 CE, subject to discussion of its dating. Verification: Frey's corpus and Hanson's presentation.

P^{46} and P^{75}

The abbreviations designate different codices. The first brings together Pauline epistles and Hebrews; the second preserves Luke and John. The physical arrangement of a collection does not, in itself, demonstrate authorship, a closed canon, or the identity of all Christian libraries. Palaeographic dates are expressed as intervals or approximations. The documentary window on P46 reproduces the institutional transcription of a segment from the old page 158 and explains its numbering and abbreviations. The documentary window on P75 remains codicological: a catalogue identification is not converted into a collation of signs. Verification: editions of Kenyon and Sanders for P46 and of Martin and Kasser, Papyrus Bodmer XIV–XV (1961), for P75; Michigan guide and Vatican and CSNTM catalogues.

Abercius and Dura-Europos

The Epitaph of Abercius and the Christian building at Dura require different approaches. The former combines fragmentary epigraphy and literary transmission; the latter preserves spatial relationships and paintings from an excavated context. The words of the epitaph cannot be reconstructed from a partial photograph without prior warning. Architectural drawings are not equivalent to old photographs or newly made surveys. The presentation distinguishes between provenance, medium, interpretation, and reconstruction. References: entry in the Christian Lapidary of the Vatican Museums; Kraeling, 1967 excavation report; Yale Archaeological Collection.

Empire and legal norms

Lactantius, Death of the Persecutors 34, 44 and 48

The three loci correspond to different matters: Galerius's edict, the sign of the Constantinian campaign, and the text on restitution and religious freedom of 313. They should not be combined as a single edict. The author constructs an interpretation of the persecutors' deaths that conditions his narrative, even where he preserves documents. Reference edition: Moreau, SC 39, De *la mort des persécuteurs,* 2 vols., 1954. The ANF translation is used only as a secondary content check. Comparison with Eus., VC I.28–31 preserves the narrative differences regarding the sign.

CJ III.12.2 and CTh II.8.18 (= CTh VIII.8.3; XI.7.13)

The first provision, CJ III.12.2 (7 March 321), uses venerabilis dies solis and contains an agrarian exception; the second regulates litigation and employs dominical vocabulary. The subscription of CTh II.8.18 (= CTh VIII.8.3; XI.7.13) corresponds to 3 November 386. These are two distinct norms and should not be confused chronologically. Legal designations are studied in conjunction with the regulated object, the addressee, and the date, without converting an administrative provision into the origin of a prior religious practice. Reference editions: Krueger for the Justinian Code; Mommsen and Meyer for the Theodosian Code. Verification of the second locus: Latin reproduction of the Grenoble Roman Law Project.

CTh XVI.1.2; XVI.10.10–12

The edict of 380 defines a confessional norm. The provisions of 391–392 belong to a different period and regulate specific cultic practices more broadly. Distinguishing these documents prevents attributing all subsequent consequences to the former. The historical problem includes promulgation, jurisdiction, local application, and reception; a list of laws is not equivalent to a measure of the number of conversions. Reference edition: Mommsen and Meyer, Theodosiani *libri XVI*. The loci are cited by book, title, and constitution.

Movements, controversies and doctrinal delimitation

Revelation 2:6, 14–15, 20–24

Nicolaitans, Balaam and Jezebel: intra-community conflict and the limits of reconstruction.

Ignatius, Smyrnaeans 1–2; Trallians 9–10

The reality of the Passion and polemic against docetic Christologies.

Irenaeus, Against Heresies I.26; III.3–4

Cerinthus, Ebionites and genealogical construction of deviation.

Eusebius, Ecclesiastical History V.16–18

New Prophecy/Montanism and transmission of polemical dossiers.

Tertullian, Against Praxeas 1–3

Divine monarchy, Father-Son distinction and anti-monarchian controversy.

Cyprian, Epistulae 55 and 69–75

Novatianism, lapsi and controversies over reconciliation and baptism.

CTh XVI.5 and African documentation

Imperial intervention in conflicts with Donatists and other dissidents.

Creeds and synodal letters, 325–381

Nicaea and post-Nicene plurality: avoiding a unitary category of "Arianism".

Heresiological source stratification and traceability matrix

This matrix distinguishes attributed quotation, polemical paraphrase, general accusation, argumentative silence, and modern reconstruction. Tertullian, Epiphanius, and Irenaeus are not treated as automatically independent witnesses: literary dependence and rhetorical function are assessed locus by locus.

Locus / witness	Stratum and critical function	Editorial use
Irenaeus, Haer. I.27	General accusation / adversarial summary — Luke-related Gospel; Pauline collection; doctrinal opposition	Doctrinal context, not transcription
Tertullian, Marc. IV.2–7	Paraphrase and polemical argument — Framework for discussing Marcion's Gospel	Primary witness, not facsimile
Epiphanius, Pan. 42	Late polemical inventory — Attributed presences, absences, and variants	Secondary control; dependence assessed

(continued)

Locus / witness	Stratum and critical function	Editorial use
Luke 10:21 / Marc. IV.25	Attributed reading with multiple support — "Lord of heaven" without "and earth"	Modern reconstruction, high confidence
Luke 13:28 / Marc. IV.30	Attributed reading with multiple support — "all the righteous" versus patriarchs/prophets	Modern reconstruction, high confidence
Luke 20:35–36 / Marc. IV.38	Segmentation controversy — Punctuation and syntactic relation	Not reduced to a simple deletion charge
Infancy material	Explicit / inferred absence — Irenaeus: general charge; Tertullian: presupposition; Epiphanius: explicit absence	Witness levels distinguished
Loci without positive data	Argumentative silence — No positive evidence in Tertullian/Epiphanius	Record as "not attested"
Antitheses	Polemical paraphrase — Oppositions attributed by adversaries	Not printed as literal quotation from Marcion

Glossary

Apocalyptic

A modern category for writings and traditions that reveal a hidden order of history, the cosmos, or judgement through supernatural mediation. The literary form "apocalypse" and eschatological expectation are not equivalent. A text may share apocalyptic motifs without belonging to that genre.

Critical apparatus

An organised record of the witnesses, variants and editorial decisions of a textual edition. It is not to be confused with a bibliography or with historical notes. The appendix to this monograph is documentary and philological: it does not publish a new recensio of the cited authors.

Apocryphal

A reception label for writings that were not included in a particular canon. Its use does not establish a late date, a uniform doctrine, or a lack of historical value. Each work and its transmission must be identified.

Apostolicity

A claim to a link with the apostles through authorship, memory, teaching, succession or community origin. Its forms vary. The ancient attribution of a work to an apostle is a datum of reception before it can serve as proof of authorship.

Baptism

Practice of incorporation and purification designated by βάπτισμα (*baptisma*) and related terms. Sources document differences in preparation, water, and procedure. A building with a baptismal installation provides evidence of a local practice; it does not establish an identical universal rite.

Canon

From the Greek κανών (*kanōn*), rule or measure. In textual history, a set of writings recognised as normative by a community. The authority of a book, its liturgical reading, its inclusion in a collection, *and the* closing of a list are related processes that must be distinguished.

Charisma

In the Pauline epistles, χάρισμα (*charisma*) refers to a gift. The modern sociological classification of "charismatic authority" constitutes another conceptual operation. Applying it requires explaining its usefulness without attributing the modern theory to an ancient author.

Catacomb

Common designation for underground burial complexes. Roman examples should be studied in terms of topography, phasing, epigraphy and visual repertoires. Their funerary function does not demonstrate that they were permanent refuges during continuous persecution.

Codex

A book made up of bound sheets, in contrast to a scroll. It may contain one or more works. The codicological form facilitates certain selection and consultation practices, but does not automatically determine the canon or the religion of its readers.

Christology

A modern category for the study of claims about the identity and role of Christ. It does not presuppose that all early texts responded to the questions or vocabulary of the fourth-century councils.

Chrismon

Monogram formed by chi and rho, initial letters of Χριστός (*Christos*). It should be distinguished from the tau–rho staurogram. Its appearance in imperial or funerary contexts requires identification of the support and date of each case.

Diaspora

Distribution of Jewish populations outside of Judea and their relationships with places, practices, and memories of origin. It designates neither a homogeneous culture nor an absolute separation from Jerusalem.

Diplomatic and semi-diplomatic

A diplomatic transcription seeks to reproduce the relevant graphic features of the witness and its layout according to explicit conventions. A semi-diplomatic transcription introduces certain declared standardisations. Copying a continuous editorial text is not equivalent to either unless the procedure is explained.

Domus ecclesiae

A Latin expression used in modern times for domestic buildings adapted for Christian community functions. Its archaeological value depends on material evidence. A community that meets in a house, attested by a letter, does not, by that fact alone, constitute an excavated building of that type.

Ekklēsia

ἐκκλησία (*ekklēsia*) designates an assembly and, in Christian texts, a gathered community or a group of communities. Translating it invariably as "Church", with a capital letter, can introduce a later institutional unity that the context does not require.

Episcopate

Function and organisation associated with ἐπίσκοπος (*episkopos*), supervisor or bishop. The relationship with presbyters and deacons changes between sources and regions. The presence of the word does not demonstrate a fully developed monarchical structure.

Eschatology

The modern study of expectations regarding consummation, judgement, resurrection, and ultimate destiny. Ancient texts articulate these themes in different ways. An expectation of an imminent end does not by itself allow a text to be dated.

Staurogram

The tau–rho ligature used in certain abbreviations of words related to the cross and crucifixion. Its iconographic reading is a historical problem that requires identifying the manuscript and locus. It should not be attributed to P46 merely by generic association with early papyri.

Eucharist

εὐχαριστία (*eucharistia*) means thanksgiving. In Christian sources, it is related to meals, prayers, and liturgical practices whose organisation is not uniform. The descriptions in the Didache and Justin are studied as individual documents.

Gospel

εὐαγγέλιον (*euangelion*) can designate a proclamation and, later, a written work. The use of the term by an author does not guarantee that it names a volume or a collection similar to the current New Testament.

Gentile

In this work, a non-Jewish person. The term describes a historical relationship with Israel and with practices of belonging, without implying a single religious identity shared by all non-Jews in the Empire.

Gnosticism

A debated historiographical category that brings together heterogeneous systems and texts. It is used with an explicit definition, and the names of authors, traditions, and corpora are preferred when the documentation allows for greater precision. A single religion is not postulated as underlying all the Nag Hammadi writings.

Heresiology

Production of classifications and refutations of doctrines considered erroneous. Its lists and genealogies are sources for opposing groups and for the strategies of those who describe them. Reproducing the ancient classification does not make it neutral.

Heresy

αἵρεσις (*hairesis*) was used in the senses of "choice", "current of thought" and "school" before, and alongside, its sense of doctrinal deviation. The book identifies who applies the judgement and from what norm. The category does not replace the historical description of a group.

Homoousios

ὁμοούσιος (*homoousios*), "of the same substance" or "consubstantial." The Nicene usage is studied in the fourth-century conflict. Its incorporation into the creed does not eliminate later disputes about meaning, reception, and alternative formulations.

Iconography

Identification and interpretation of themes and visual repertoires. It requires attention to support, context, date and comparanda. The similarity of two figures does not in itself prove a religious dependence or a chain of transmission.

Jewish Christianity

A modern category for Christian practices, groups, or writings specifically related to Jewish traditions. It should be specified whether it describes affiliation, observance, language, or content. It does not constitute a uniform ancient identity easily separable from others.

Lapsi

Latin designation for those who, according to community criteria, had yielded during a persecution. The forms of compliance and the conditions of readmission gave rise to controversy. A libellus documents administrative certification and does not, by itself, allow one to reconstruct the bearer's inner convictions.

Libellus

A brief document; in the Decian context, a certificate related to the performance of required sacrifices. Each must be recorded with its papyrological identification, date and formula. The document and the martyrdom narratives offer different perspectives on the same horizon.

Locus

An identifiable passage in a work or a precise textual location. The Latin plural is *loci*. The Index locorum records explicit references in the book and its notes; it does not attempt to list every possible literary allusion.

Martyr

μάρτυς (*martys*), witness. The association of the word with death for one's religious confession has its own history. Martyrdom narratives can preserve procedural data and, simultaneously, construct examples, scenes, and community memory.

Nomina sacra

Convention of abbreviating certain names and titles by means of selected letters and a supralinear stroke. The set of abbreviated words and their form vary. Their presence is studied materially and not as a uniform numerical code.

Orthodoxy

A position recognised as correct teaching by specific actors and communities. The historian studies the processes of validation, transmission, and exclusion. The term does not justify projecting all subsequent definitions back to the first century.

Palaeography

The study of scripts and graphic practices. Comparative dating provides margins and probabilities, not absolute years. It must be supplemented with provenance, support, context, and independent data when available.

Patronage

Relationships of support, resources, prestige, and dependence between people or institutions. Households and benefactors could facilitate Christian gatherings, but the analogy with Roman models does not automatically demonstrate the legal status of each participant.

Pseudepigraphy

Attribution of a work to a name other than that of its historical author. It is distinct from anonymity, later editing and traditional attribution. The judgement requires textual and transmission arguments, not merely doctrinal disagreement.

Recension

A textual form resulting from an identifiable process of revision or transmission. In Ignatius, the middle, long and short recensions present distinct problems. In textual criticism, *recensio* also designates the examination and classification of witnesses.

Rule of faith or truth

A formulation of teaching and a criterion of interpretation in certain authors. It can articulate creation, incarnation, and salvation without yet being a universal creed in identical verbal form. Its function must be established in each controversy.

Synagogue

συναγωγή (*synagōgē*) can designate a meeting, community, or building. The Theodotus inscription documents a programme of reading, teaching, *and* hospitality in Jerusalem. It does not imply architectural or institutional uniformity in all cases.

Tradition

Process and content of transmission. The appeal to an apostolic tradition is a historical claim of authority that must be examined through sources. Its declared antiquity and its effective continuity are not automatically equivalent.

Textual variant

Difference between witnesses to a text. The existence of a variant must be separated from its antiquity, distribution, and value for reconstruction. The monograph does not invent manuscript sigla or readings in order to complete an apparatus artificially.

Hebrew and Aramaic glossary of terms and names

This glossary includes only Semitic terms that have a historical, philological, or onomastic function in the monograph. It does not repeat the conceptual entries of the general glossary. Spellings are offered as attested forms or plausible historical equivalents; when a New Testament form is preserved only in Greek transliteration, no attempt is made to reconstruct a supposed "original" phrase with greater certainty than the evidence allows.

אַבָּא / 𐡀𐡁𐡀—ʾABBĀ

Aramaic: "father". Preserved as ἀββᾶ in Mark 14:36; Rom 8:15; Gal 4:6. Transliteration within Greek shows Semitic linguistic memory, but does not by itself allow the reconstruction of the exact oral context.

אָמֵן—ʾĀMĒN

Hebrew, "certainly / so be it", from the root ʾ-m-n associated with firmness and reliability. It passes into Greek as ἀμήν without a direct lexical translation in numerous Jewish and Christian texts.

בַּר אֱנָשׁ—BAR ʾĔNĀŠ

Aramaic, "son of man / human being", especially Dan 7:13. It is a linguistic check for the debate on ὁ υἱὸς τοῦ ἀνθρώπου; it is not assumed that all its gospel uses translate a single fixed Aramaic formula.

כֵּיפָא / 𐡊𐡐𐡀—Kēfā / Kēpā

Aramaic, "rock, stone". It underlies Κηφᾶς, the name of Peter in Paul and John. Πέτρος functions as a Greek onomastic equivalent, not as evidence of an original Hebrew spelling.

גֵּיא־הִנֹּם / גֵּיהִנֹּם—GÊ-HINNŌM

"Valley of Hinnom", base of γέεννα. The semantic history from toponym to eschatological image must be reconstructed through Second Temple and rabbinic Jewish literature, not from isolated etymology.

גָּלִיל—GĀLÎL

Galilee. The Hebrew toponym is related to "district / region". The Greek forms Γαλιλαία and Γαλιλαῖος belong to the linguistically mediated geography of the period.

גֻּלְגֹּלֶת / ARAM. GULGULTĀ—GULGŌLET / GULGULTĀ

"Skull". Related to Γολγοθᾶ in the Gospels. The exact form of the first-century Aramaic place name is treated with caution; the Gospel explains its meaning for Greek readers.

הַלְלוּ־יָהּ—HALLƏLÛ-YĀH

"Praise Yah." Hebrew formula transmitted in the biblical tradition and as ἀλληλουϊά in Greek texts. Its preservation shows liturgical continuity of a Semitic expression.

הוֹשִׁיעָה נָּא—HÔŠÎʿÂ-NNĀ

"Save, please", from Ps 118:25; base of ὡσαννά. In liturgical reception it shifted from petition to acclamation.

יְהוּדִי—YƏHÛDÎ

"Jew / Judean", behind the semantic field of Ἰουδαῖος. The translation depends on the geographical, ethnic, political or religious context; the book avoids resolving all uses with a single English equivalent.

יֵשׁוּעַ—YĒŠÛAʿ

Late Jewish form of the name Joshua, related to the root y-š-ʿ, "to save". Greek Ἰησοῦς. The etymology explains the form of the name, but does not in itself constitute historical proof of a messianic function.

יהוה—YHWH

Tetragrammaton of the divine name. The ancient pronunciation is not restored with absolute certainty. The Septuagint and Jewish manuscripts show different representation strategies; the Christian forms of nomina sacra belong to another graphic history.

מָשִׁיחַ—MĀŠÎAḥ

"Anointed," verbal adjective (qāṭîl form) of the root m-š-ḥ, "to anoint." The LXX usually translates it with *χριστός*. The history of the title encompasses kings, priests, and diverse eschatological expectations; "Messiah" does not designate a single, fixed profile.

מַלְכוּת / Aram. מַלְכוּתָא—MALKÛT / MALKÛTĀ

"Reign, sovereignty, kingdom." Useful to contextualise *βασιλεία τοῦ θεοῦ*. The Greek gospel formula should not be automatically back-translated into a single Aramaic expression without contextual verification.

מִשְׁנָה—MIŠNÂ

"Repetition / teaching", name of the rabbinic Mishnah. Its redaction, c. 200 CE, does not justify projecting all its formulations onto first-century Judaism.

פֶּסַח—PESAḥ

Passover; Greek *πάσχα*. It designates a festival and, depending on the context, a sacrifice/meal. Its calendar was central to the chronology of the Passion and to later Christian controversies.

פְּרוּשִׁים—PƏRÛŠÎM

Hebrew form traditionally related to "separated"; Greek *Φαρισαῖοι*. The etymology does not replace the social history of Pharisaism nor prove a uniform self-designation in all periods.

רַבִּי—RABBÎ

"My teacher / master". Title transmitted as *ῥαββί*. Its use in first-century sources should not be equated without qualification with the fully developed rabbinic institution of later centuries.

רוּחַ—RÛAḥ

"Wind, breath, spirit." The Greek *πνεῦμα* offers a partially comparable field. Biblical equivalences do not eliminate semantic differences between Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek.

שַׁבָּת—ŠABBĀT

Sabbath, "cessation / rest". Greek *σάββατον*. The Christian discussion of the Sabbath must be situated within plural Jewish practices, not as an abstract opposition between "law" and "religion."

שָׂטָן—ŚĀṭĀN

"Adversary/accuser"; Greek Σατανᾶς and διάβολος depending on the context of translation and reception. In biblical Hebrew, שָׂטָן (śāṭān) functions in various passages as a common noun, "adversary/accuser"; in Job 1–2 and Zechariah 3 it appears with the article, הַשָּׂטָן (ha-śāṭān), as the functional designation of the accuser in the heavenly court. Its progressive development into a proper name and personification as a distinct figure belongs to the demonological development of Second Temple Judaism and later apocalyptic traditions. This personal sense should not be projected retrospectively as the sole meaning of all biblical strata.

שְׁמַע—ŠƏMAʿ

"Listen." Conventional name of Deuteronomy 6:4ff. The formula was and is central to the Jewish confession of divine oneness; it constitutes a relevant background for Jewish and Christian Christological debates.

תּוֹרָה—TÔRÂ

"Instruction / teaching", usually "Torah" or "Law". Greek *νόμος* in numerous contexts. In Paul, *νόμος* does not have an identical referent in every passage; Pentateuch, commandment, regime, and scriptural argument must be distinguished.

תּוֹמָא / ܬܐܘܡܐ—TŌMĀ

Aramaic, "twin"; transliterated Θωμᾶς and glossed Δίδυμος in John. Clear example of a Semitic name accompanied by a Greek equivalent.

General Bibliography

The entries are grouped into three categories. Critical editions are identified as textual references; the list does not imply that every volume has been consulted in full. Digital reproductions record the type of verification performed. Secondary works are cited by author and year in the text. Legacy references without title or sufficient publishing information are not included.

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Colophon

This book was typeset for its first bilingual edition (2026) by Sophia Lux Academic Editions, Franklin 2054, 1st Floor, Apt. B, Autonomous City of Buenos Aires. Editorial production, philological revision, textual verification and general direction of the work were the responsibility of Diego Kurilo.

Typesetting. The text is set in EB Garamond—Georg Duffner and Octavio Pardo's revival of Claude Garamont's types after the Egenolff-Berner specimen of 1592—at 11/14.5 pt in the main text and in a smaller size in notes, tables and indexes, with polytonic Greek from the same family. Text block, hyphenation, running heads and pagination follow the conventions of the leading university presses; the pagination of the PDF is canonical for all cross-references and indexes.

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Author: Diego Kurilo. Publisher: Sophia Lux Academic Editions. First bilingual edition, 2026. ISBN 978-631-01-8779-2.